Inside our rotten bones

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/43623090.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Serenia (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Marlena (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Murder Mystery, 80’s, set in 1985, First Love, Friends to Lovers, First Time, Mysteries and clues, Soulmates, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Trigger Warnings, Murder, Attempted Murder, descriptions of violence, Verbal Abuse, mentions of physical abuse, descriptions of bruises and hits, Blood and Injury, Mentions of weapons, Knives, Guns, Homophobia, homophobia according to the time, this is a heavy part of the story, Descriptions of Corpses, Descriptions of deaths, Descriptions of wounds, Character Death, Implied/Referenced Character Death, All characters are 19+ of age, Major character death - Freeform, Minor Character Death, Read until the end, Please be patient and please be nice, I'll make up for the angst, References to Drugs, Fair and happy ending considering the situation

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by StarryNap

Notes

Welcome, foolish mortals…

Interlude

Chapter Notes

I could have written some Scooby Doo shit…

… and then I didn’t

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Interlude

I should tell them that I'm not afraid to die

— *My Body’s Made of Crushed Little Stars* , **Mitski**

Looking at it from a certain angle, it was obvious it was going to happen.

Or at least, that is what the ladies of the neighborhood will gossip tomorrow, during the morning tea, and in the store, or even at the park. They are assholes like that.

It was just bound to happen, of course. *Of course* . This *type* of girl just tends to snap like this. It's actually sad.

"It's always the same thing with orphans" the neighbor in the house next door tells to another, sipping a glass of wine in their pink and luxurious nightgown. "They loose their parents and suddenly they think they can do whatever they want. "

"And honestly, such a disappointment," adds another a few feet away, like vultures feasting in the scene in front of them, "Does she not care about what this makes the neighborhood look like? This is a decent street."

"Is she even getting arrested at all?"

"Whatever it is, is scandalous"

The detective walks out of the house, carrying a black backpack in one hand and guiding the girl's arm with the other. She is not handcuffed, but the way the detective drags her down the steps and inside the back of the car doesn't speak of anything good. And the neighbors aren't sure, of course not, but they could *swear* they see blood stained the front of her sweater.

Scandalous indeed.

And what a way to keep the entire town entertained. First, a murder. Was it a murder? Honestly, nobody would have cared at all if it wasn't for the detective sniffing where she shouldn't. And now this, a straight A student, cheerleader captain and golden girl of the town, wheeled away in the middle of the night.

So, as the girl is taken away in the back of the detective's car, her pretty baby blue eyes swimming in tears, the answer must be obvious, but the question remains.

Then again, the victim wasn't exactly popular in the neighborhood. Or the town. Nobody cared about that dead girl. She was a bad bean from the beginning. Rebellious, volatile, uncontainable from the very start. The things she made her poor mother go through and let's not talk about what was whispered about her. What it was said she liked. A danger for the educated girls of the town of Ethernia. A spawn. A *freak.* But, oh, the gossip is juicy.

So, maybe the question does remain open, after all. And the ladies of the neighborhood just can't wait for it to develop, whispering to each other on that chilling night of November, in their nightgowns and glasses of wine.

Is Adora Grey a murderer?

There isn't much excitement down here, after all.

On the night of Halloween, October 31th 1985, Catrina Weaver is going to die.

Chapter End Notes

So, who killed Catra?

Act I. Clearance

Chapter Summary

"I would go anywhere with you"

Chapter Notes

Do you have pen and paper ready? Here is what you need to know: the who, the where, the when, the how and, most important of them all, the why. Remember clues are everywhere

TRIGGER WARNINGS: Descriptions of dead, descriptions of a dead body, mild homophobia, potential major character dead (won't spoil the journey but take it as a fact/possiblity)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Act I. Clearance

Nothing ever ends poetically.

It ends and we turn it into poetry.

All that blood was never once beautiful.

It was always just red.

— **Kait Rokowski**

November 3th, 1985

If you had told Mara that she would be going back to Eternia after twenty years of escaping that hell, she would have laughed at you. Or tell you to go fuck yourself. Depends on the time of the day.

But here she was, driving through the 55 and 80 intersection to the most fucked up town in Etheria. Mara can tell you about it, she has been in a lot of places.

Eternia is, as most of the towns that got first constructed in the country, a rich town. Pretty white houses with pretty high windows and even prettier soulless gardens. And it's home to exactly the kind of people you would think live in a place like this. Up right, hypocrites and assholes, who enjoy gathering in their private clubs to gossip about their neighbors and rejoice in the luxury of the 'high' society. 'First Ones' as they like to call themselves. Truly, hell on earth.

Mara has nothing but awful memories of this place which is why it comes to no surprise that she is tapping the wheel of the car with anxiety. She truly does not want to be here but alas, mystery calls, and this is definitely a mystery she wants to learn about.

"Are you sure you want to do this?" asks Serenia, Mara's work partner, taking off her round glasses with a huff. She has a paper in her hands, softened after all the times Mara had unfold it and tucked it again to read it. "I mean, this is probably just a joke from high schoolers or something."

Mara sighs, tightening her grip on the wheel. She is probably right but still, there is something very weird about all this.

“Maybe,” Mara says, turning in the street that will lead them to the sheriff's office. There are Halloween decorations still hanging from the houses and the street lamps, the light of the dawn washing over the town in pinks and lilacs. “But just in case, let's make sure it is indeed a joke.”

Mara parks the car in front of the sheriff's office, a tiny building no bigger than the groceries store they just passed by. It's a really calm, muffled laughter of men coming from the inside every once in a while. Dread falls down Mara's back, fumbling with the keys of the car for a few seconds, eyes locked in the building's door, before hopping out of the car.

The morning is chilly so she brings the thick coat closer to herself, stepping over the puddles of water left after yesterday's rain. Serenia follows close behind, carrying a light bag over her shoulder, inspecting the buildings and thick forest around them with clinical eye. If the note that arrived at their office is true or not, it doesn't matter, the investigation begins right now.

The inside of the sheriff's department smells just like it looks. Rancid and old, grease of junk food -the trash dropped somewhere closed to the squeaking door- and bitter coffee. So, exactly like Mara remembers.

There are a total of three men inside, and a secretary almost hidden in the far corner. The men are leaning over the back of their chairs, feet up over the basically empty desks in front of them, laughing and joking between each and barely noticing at all Mara and Serenia's entrance.

Mara walks with decided steps towards the desk, crossing her arms over her chest and clearing her throat after a couple of minutes of no recognition of her presence at all.

"Ahem." The sheriff jumps in surprise, turning around on his chair just enough to look at Mara's face.

"Oh, shit. Sorry, sir… madame?" Sheriff Kurr's eyes focus on Mara's face, widening with disbelief when he sees who she is. "Well, fuck me. If it isn't Mara Greyskull in flesh and bone"

"Kurr" greets Mara between her teeth, tightly. Kurr's eyes travel over all her figure, a wide, mocking smile stretching on his mouth, dirty with bread crumbs and yellowed by cigar.

"It had been what? Ten years?"

"Twenty, actually"

"Of course. It can be seen. The lines in a woman's face can't lie after all, right?" Sheriff Kurr purrs, signaling at Mara's face, deeply

pleased with himself. He doesn't even offer Mara a seat. "The last time I saw you, you were a scrawny rebellious teenager."

Kurr laughs, the other two men behind him laughing too. Mara smirks, biting into the inside of her cheek. "And the last time I saw you were just as you are now. Sitting in your ass"

Sheriff Kurr gapes at her, utterly speechless. The officers behind him chuckle under their breath, obviously amoused. Kurr´s face goes through a few deep shades of red, face going sour immediately. He leans over the desk, taking a much better look at Mara´s face, blatantly ignoring Serenia standing next to her.

“What are you doing here, Greyskull?”

Mara drops her arms to the sides just so she can rest her palms over the desk. “I've actually come for a case”

“A case,” repeats the sheriff, “What are you supposed to be? A writer?”

“I´m a detective, sheriff Kurr,” Mara interrupts him, a dangerous edge starting to show through her voice. She is a woman. She knew how difficult this job would be. For her. By the time she got out of this hell hole she is back in right now, Mara had already lost it all. Everything, *everyone,* she loved. So she is not scared by men like Sheriff Kurr. Not anymore. “And I'm investigating a the disappearance of a person”

Kurr scoffs, crossing his arms over his chest and resting on the back of the chair, the hint of a smirk spreading on his lips,. “Really? Amuse me then, *detective.* Who's gone missing in my town?”

“Catrina Weaver,” Mara spats.

The sheriff's face falls, from mocking to completely blank, the shimmer of something glimmering inside his sick green eyes. “How did you know that?”

This time, it is Mara who smirks at him. *Bingo.* “That's not important right now. I would like to take a look on the folder of the case.”

“There is no folder.”

Mara hesitates, frowning deeply. “What?”

“I said there is no folder,” Kurr repeats as if Mara was stupid, “Because there is no case. Catrina Weaver is a, what's that term young people use now? Well, not our best success, if you understand what I'm saying” he explains with a disgusting wink. Oh, Mara understands, she understands perfectly well. "Given that girl´s antecedents she is probably hiding in some ditch or maybe even thinking she can flee this town.”

Mara blinks, catching the passive aggressive insult. “What an interesting use of words you have for a young girl,” Mara manages to say, grinding her teeth.

“Well, as you may know, nobody *really* leaves Eternia, Greyskull.” Kurr states, crossing his arms behind his neck.

Mara forces a complacent smile, suppressing the want of punching him in the face. As much as she wants too, she may need his connections as sheriff for this. “Still,” Mara drags, biting her tongue, “let's make sure, shall we? Does she have any friends or family I can talk with?”

“Friends,” Kurr repeats, chuckling. “A girl like that doesn´t have any friends.”

“Then who came to report her missing?” Mara pushes. It's clear the sheriff didn't see the question coming because he blinks, suddenly out of excuses, “You asked me how did I know, which means someone must have come asking for her. Someone that doesn't really believe she is hiding somewhere”

Kurr narrows his eyes, chewing in Mara´s questioning for a long moment. “Fine. The captain of our cheerleader team swung by

this morning. Said she hadn't seen her at school or at the Halloween party and was worried for her.”

Mara pulls out a notepad, scribbling quickly on it. “This girl has a name?”

“Adora Grey,” Kurr spurs out, clearly unhappy for the interrogation. “A nice girl. She´s my boy´s girlfriend”

Mara raises her eyes from the pad, looking at his eyes. There is a certain something in the sheriff´s voice when he says that last part. Something nasty. “Is she now?”

Kurr grins, making a shiver run down Mara´s back. “She will. Eventually”

“Hmm,” Mara closes her notepad with a strong swing. “Any family of Catrina I can speak with?”

“Her mother, I guess,” Kurr stretches as little as he can to grab a pen and paper, writing down an address. “Mrs. Sharon Weaver. 14B Horde, next to the creek“ Kurr slides the paper over the desk without a care. “She is a lovely woman, truly educated and honorable in the town. She hasn't shown any worry so, your little investigation will probably end there.”

Mara glances at the paper and saves it quickly in her pocket, clicking her tongue against her teeth, “We´ll see about that.” She turns to leave, her tight braids dingling behind her as she steps across the office.

“One more thing, Grayskull,” Kurr calls after her, still not standing up from his chair. The expression on his eyes is hard as stone, digging holes inside Mara´s. “You can go out there and ask your questions because I'm finding it amusing. But interfere with my job in any way and you´ll be getting out of my town immediately. Do we understand each other?”

Mara knows what he is expecting from her. An affirmation, a word of accordance, maybe even an apology. Mara doesn't give him any

of that. Instead she says, “I´ll be seeing you around, sheriff,” Mara´s voice echoes inside the tiny building, loud. Mara opens the door and lets Serenia walk first, returning Kurr´s angry look with an indifferent one, “Soon.”

Horde Street is huge and disgustingly expensive. The house 14B is old and well taken care of. Clean garden, grass cut almost mathematically straight, red door and windows, white walls. And the inside is almost clinical, like a hospital, not a single plate from the expensive china or table out of place.

It's, by all means, as cold and soulless as its owner.

Serenia shifts on the dark wood chair, scribbling in the notepad the information of the woman. Mara sits next to her, in front of the owner, questioning and observing.

Sharon Weaver slowly, almost on purpose, drops a cube of sugar on her black tea, just one, looking regal and proud. Her hair is long and deeply black, skin thin over her bones, making the red of her silk length floor robe give her a certain greenish color. Her expression has definitely seen better days because she kind of looks- well, awful. Like she was just getting off a huge hangover.

Interesting.

The nails of her left hand are long and carefully manicured, painted in deep burgundy, but the nails of her right are cut short, still red but with the smallest of breaking lines in the pointing finger one, as if it had broken very recently.

Deeply interesting.

"So, what brings you around our lovely neighborhood, detective?" Weaver asks, impassive, calm as a hurricane's eye. Mara's mouth twitches with a polite smile.

"Your daughter actually, Mrs. Weaver"

Weaver's mouth twitches with displeasure, infinitesimally small, the first honest reaction Mara has seen of her in the fifteen minutes they've been here.

"What has that girl done this time?" Weaver asks, the tone of her voice putrid and sour, completely different to the sugar coat voice she had been using merely second ago.

Interesting indeed.

"She's gone missing"

"Has she?" Weaver asks, almost surprised. She looks at Mara with curious eyes, shrugging inside her luxurious robe. "Are you quite certain about that?"

Mara moves finally, leaning over the polished table to look at Weaver better. The house is awfully quiet, not even the tick of a clock echoing anywhere. "Nobody has seen her since Sunday, Mrs. Weaver. Not at the school or around the town."

"Well, that girl tends to wander around, like a wild animal" Weaver says, waving with her hand over the air to take importance to it. "I wouldn't be surprised if she were to pop out of wherever she is hiding any moment now. It's not like she has anywhere else to go." She takes a sip of her tea, completely unbothered by the entire situation.

Mara and Serenia share a swift look, charged with unspoken worlds. Mara drags her eyes quickly around the piano room. There is a piano in the corner, spot cleaned and shining. Not a single photograph or painting is seen around the rooms. The couches are red and velvet, placed almost magazine perfect with the rest of the furniture. On it's all, the inside of the house looks heavy. Claustrophobic.

"Do you know miss Adora Grey, Mrs. Weaver?" Weaver's eyes shine with recognition, a wide smile spreading into her mouth.

"Oh, yes! A lovely girl truly. Responsable, respectful, always walking in the line and obeying the rules The best of us First One's, if I may add," Weaver sips on her tea with satisfaction, giving a dramatically long sigh. "I always tell her how much I'd wanted for her to be my daughter instead of the one I got. But I guess we all have our weights to carry, don't we?"

"Of course," Mara says between a tight smile. She leans back in the chair, smiling. "You have a lovely house, Mrs. Weaver"

"Well, thank you, lady. It's my biggest pride"

"I'm sure it is," Mara stands up, cleaning invisible crumbs from her jacket. Weaver's eyes are focused on her, no doubt silently judging her clothes under all that twisted sweetness. "Do you mind if I look through Catrina's room? Just to get a better idea where she might be"

Weaver's eyes harden just a little but her smile doesn't flatter, waving towards the polished black stairs with a flourish of her hand. "Sure. And an apology of what you might find there, that girl is- quite disturbed if you know what I mean"

Mara kind of wants to scream. "Of course. What room is it?"

"Oh, no. Not room. She sleeps in the attic," Weaver shrugs, throwing her dark hair behind her shoulders. "I figured it would be the best for her. To teach her some limits."

Mara balls her hands into fists inside the pockets of her jacket. Serenia palms her softly in the shoulder guiding her upstairs. "Thank you, Mrs. Weaver," Serenia says, before rushing them up.

It's a big house, there is no question about it. At least five rooms on the second floor and yet there seem to not be a single one worth it for the girl. Mara chews in the woman's words as they approach the attic door, a small square in the roof, the cord that pushes it open worn out.

Serenia pulls from it once, the stairs that lead up unfolding quietly towards the floor. Mara goes first, stopping just enough so she can check the frame of the entrance. There is a small metal ring there, matching another one in the external side of the door, worn out with use. A clear sign that someone used to close this place with a lock.

Different from the house downstairs, the attic is mostly empty but clean, with just the slightest layer of dust covering it. There is a small table with a wonky leg on the corner next to a precariously placed lamp. Several school books are dropped over the floor carelessly. Her clothes hang from a single metal tube in the wall, mostly black and maroon, fabric worn out and second handed, a striking contrast to the rich red of her mother's robe. A mattress is placed in the far end of the attic, below a circular window, several blankets nested over it. No wonder. It's freezing up here.

Serenia leans towards the desk, grasping a few abandoned test results there. They are pretty recent, from last week, the note popping in bright red.

"These are excellent notes," Serenia says, showing the paper to Mara. From maths to literature to history, all maximum notes. Mara furrows her eyebrows, looking around them.

"So, not a bad student." Mara approaches the bed, removing the blankets slightly so she can watch over the window. It has a single inner lock, simple and imposible to open from the other side. Mara slids it to the side, opening the window so she can peek outside. There are dents in the woods of the frame, done for many times of opening and closing it. And when Mara looks outside, she can see the roof tiles, some of them knocked over and worn out, completely different to the pristine rest of the roof, leading to a huge tree on the back of the yard. "An excellent student that gets locked inside her 'room' and escapes through the window. I'm not liking this."

"Do you think she might have actually escaped?" Serenia questions, roaming through the few personal items scattered

around the room. "I mean, did you see that woman? She cares more about the look of her house than her own daughter."

"I don't want to make any assumptions yet," Mara says, closing the window with a thud. "Besides, I don't think she escaped through the window this time. The lock only opens from the inside and it was closed shut."

"Maybe her mother closed it?"

"Dubious but still slightly possible" Mara hops off the bed, scrambling in the clean sheet on her way, letting something peek through under the bed. Is a small square, white corners with something scribbled in the back. Mara leans to pick it up, turning it around.

It's a Polaroid, carefully tucked under the blankets, as if it was supposed to be hidden away. In the photograph there is a young woman, no more than nineteen with curly dark hair and soft brown skin, almost bronze under the light of a sunset. The girl is wearing a baggy red jacket with a wing embroidered in the side and a white t-shirt underneath with her hands tucked inside the pockets. A path of freckles travels over her face and down the skin of her neck, losing themselves in the hem of her shirt, where a delicate chain with a golden heart pendant hangs from her neck. She is facing the camera but her head is tilted to the side, caught in the glimpse of a sudden laughter, the smile stretched on her face almost overpowering the blue and amber of her eyes. She is pretty and she looks happy.

Mara turns the photograph again, reading the bold and straight letters written in dark ink.

Always remember how beautiful you are

– A

"I think we need to pay a visit to Adora Grey," Mara says, putting the photograph inside her bag. "What else did you find?"

"Nothing," Serenia says, frowning deeply. "And I mean nothing. Besides clothes and school work there are no more personal items. Not even an ID"

"Mmm," Mara wonders, walking back towards the opening of the attic. "Let's go, it's almost midday, we need to drive to the school"

Mara and Serenia make their way out of the attic and down the stairs. Weaver is standing next to the piano room window, staring at the woods with a sour expression until she sees them arrive, her face shifting into something sticky, complacent and fake.

"Something useful?" she asks, tilting her hips to the side, another cup held in her left hand.

"We'll see," Mara dodges the question, returning the tight smile with one of her own. "But for now we'll look at the school. Mind walking us to the door?"

"Of course," Weaver accepts between her teeth, walking deliberately slowly across the room and past them, towards the corridor of the door. Mara's eyes focus on the pristine white carpet in the floor and, below it, the smallest of stains. Mara's eyes flash, turning to watch Weaver almost reaching the door.

"That is a beautiful carpet you have, Mrs. Weaver"

Weaver turns back to look at her, eyes narrowed but smile still present, not even blinking or looking at the mentioned carpet at all. "Yes," she says, "it was a kind gift from Sheriff Kurr. We are old friends."

"I see," Mara walks to the door that Weaver has opened with an almost harsh swing. "Luckily you had it.. A stain like that on wood can be hard to take off."

Mara can visibly see Weaver face hardening, pupils blown wide. "Spilled wine," she mutters, "A broken glass and suddenly your floors are never the same again."

Mara smiles, Weaver smiles back, tension hanging thick and heavy between them. Serenia clears her throat softly, hopping down the steps of the door in almost a rush. Mara follows her close behind, slowly, watching up close for the first time the car parked in the entryway. It's a red Camaro, brightly polished and spotless except for a small bump in the front light, slightly scarred and stained by the slightest shade of green.

Mara turns to say something but Weaver is already closing the door, her hair slipping back from where it was falling over her shoulder. The door closes tightly behind Weaver, leaving Serenia and Mara standing outside, the cold and humid air of the fall slipping inside their coats.

Mara looks at the curtains of the door, making sure nobody is peeking outside before she circles the property until she reaches the back of the house, taking a look at the entrance of the forest there. There are no more houses in there, just irregular ground and high trees, deepening into the woods until all Mara can see is thick fog and nothing more.

"What are you thinking?" Serenia asks behind her, shifting in her feet.

"I think that, if we want to find Catrina, we need to find Adora first," Mara says, her fingers brushing the edge of the photograph inside her coat. Out there, in the forest, the broken branch of a tree and the slipped mud and leaves in the mud make a path of their own.

Eternia School is like most highschools. Gloomy, cold and full of teenagers happy to leave it.

Mara leans over the door of her car, watching as the sea of juniors starts to wash out and waiting for the seniors' classes to end. Serenia has gone a different way, traveling towards the town to learn as much as she could about their missing girl. Though, Mara suspects, what they might learn might be of little help at all.

The doors of the school open again and more youngsters walk out. First come the ones that had no more activities and then the extracurricular ones, mostly cheerleaders, hanging from the arms of the members of the basketball team.

A smaller group of the teams separate, waiting over the bikes as they chat excitedly. A short girl is talking at a hundred per hour, her short black hair dyed pink and purple in the end, cheerleader uniform and red pom poms hanging from the side of her equally pink bike as she chats with a taller boy, his tight locks bouncing with the strong wind. He has a kind face and a basketball team varsity with the words co captain embroidery in the back, and smiles at the girl sweetly. Behind them there are four other young people. A tall girl with hay like long hair held in a braid behind her back, flowers sticking from it here and there. A slightly shorter one with beautiful dark hair and a scowl permanently etched in her face. A boy with auburn hair and a red bandana around his neck and a last girl, pretty dark skin and hair held in beautiful braids over her head. Wearing all cheerleader and basketball uniforms respectively.

"We should go to the milkshakes!" the girl with pink hair says, facing the others with a broad smile. "That should cheer Adora right up."

Mara's eyebrows raise, suddenly completely interested. She starts walking towards them, dodging the myriad of people around the backyard as she keeps listening.

"I don't even know why she is making such a drama about it," the girl with black hair says, crossing her arms over her chest and ignoring the embellished faces of the bandana boy.

"She is always like that. Give her a few days and she will forget it," the last girl adds, kicking a loose pebble in the ground. "It's not the end of the world."

"To be honest, I've never been as relaxed at school as these past two days," pink hair says, stretching her arms over her head. "Not

having Catra being a condescendent jerk the entire day has done marvels for my nerves."

"Glimmer," tall guy scolds her softly, shaking his head. "Be nice. Adora is really worried"

"Do you know Adora Grey?" Mara asks, stopping in front of them.

The group fall quiet immediately, eyeing Mara with something that can only be called absolute distrust.

"Sorry, who are you?" asks pink hair, scowling lightly. The guy next to her nudges her softly but she ignores him, waiting for Mara's answer with raised eyebrows. Mara smiles, genuinely, taking a single card from the pocket of her pants and handing it to her.

"I'm Detective Grayskull"

Glimmer eyes the card, scowl falling off her face as she looks back at her, now shifting in her feet. The girl next to her -Mermista, reads the embroidered name on her jacket- takes the card, inspecting it with clinical eye.

"I didn't know women can be detectives," she mutters, but there is no bitterness in her blank tone, except for the faintest glimpse of curiosity. The hay-haired girl rubs her upper arm with her hand, looking at Mara with tense shoulders.

"Umm, what is a detective doing here?" she asks, nervously. Mara doesn't take the card back, choosing to hide her hands back into her jacket with a relaxed pose.

"I'm investigating the disappearance of Catrina Weaver," Mara explains, simple and short. The entire group tenses like a violin's arc, looking at each other with charged faces full of uncertainty. "Do you know her?"

"I mean, everybody in the town knows her," Mermista says, rolling her eyes. She is chewing gum with an uninterested shrug. "She

has quite the reputation."

"Does she?"

"She can be… difficult," tries to explain hay-girl, grimacing at her own words. Glimmer doesn't seem to agree because she kicks the floor with indignation, several shades of red coloring her face.

"She is an asshole." Her words are cut by a quick *Glimmer* , hissed by the tall boy and the blonde girl, but the mentioned ignores it, looking at them with incredulity. "What? It's the truth!"

"Why do you say so?" Mara asks in a calm voice.

" *Because* she always acts like she is better than everybody else, never respects the rules, is a complete jerk *and* she is *awful* with Adora," Glimmer states, clearly upset. "She is always getting Adora into trouble and treats her horrible when she wants to spend time with us or anybody else. I don't even know why Adora insists on trying to be her friend."

Mara ponders over the outburst in silence, tapping with her fingers over the coat as she thinks. "Have they been friends for long?"

" *Friends* is too good of a word" mutters Glimmer under her breath as the tall boy speaks.

"I mean, we know they know each other since they were little, but most of us do. Small town"

Mara turns slightly to him, tilting her head with a smile. "Thank you. What are your names?"

"Oh! I'm Bow," he says, pointing at himself with a bright smile. "This is Glimmer and Mermista. Perfuma here," he points at the blonde girl. "Sea Hawk" the guy with auburn hair, "And Lonnie" the last girl with a sour expression. Mara nods in recognition at each one.

"Nice to meet you everyone. Do you know if there is someone else Catra might have been close to?"

"My mom and her friends say there was a family she used to be close to when she was little," Perfuma says, worrying her lip between her teeth. "Umm, my mom is a hairdresser and people always talk about Catra. But nobody knows who. Maybe the Grey, she was pretty close to them"

"Would Adora's parents be able to testify about that?"

The looks on everyone's faces fall blank, some grimacing others looking at each other with uncomfortable looks. Lonnie crosses her arms over her chest, strong biceps popping under the sleeve of her uniform.

"Adora's parents are dead," she states, frowning. "Last year. Car accident. It's just Adora and her brother now but they were already eighteen when it happened so they were allowed to be left alone in their house."

Mara sighs, an honest apologetic look falling over her face. "My apologies, I did not know."

"Obviously," Lonnie spats harshly. "We don't know what happened with Catra, we are not her friends and she left very clear she didn't want to be ours. Or Adora's, by all means, last week. So whatever happened to her, I'm sure it was what she deserved."

Ouch

The rest of the group looks quite uncomfortable by Lonnie's words but they are nodding anyway, avoiding Mara's look. Mara clicks her tongue against her teeth, exhaling, her breath marking visible puffs of fog with the cold.

"Very well. Thank you kids," she says, throwing a swift look at the progressively empty school behind them. "Do you know if Miss Grey will take long?"

"She is still at the gym, being scolded by the professor," Perfuma explains, shrugging. "She's been really distracted at practice lately."

Mara nods, understanding, turning on her ankles so she can walk back to wait besides her car. There is a shuffle of feet below her and then Glimmer's voice a little bit closer, calling for her.

"Detective?" Mara looks back at her, waiting. "I know we might sound really harsh, but you don't know how it has been for her lately. We don't want her to suffer anymore." Glimmer's sight wanders for a second, lost in a sudden thought before settling again into a firmer expression, talking through her teeth. "I just wish Catra would stop ruining Adora's life"

Mara considers her and nods, watching as the girl straightens her shoulders and hop back to her friends, who have dissolved into easy chattering again.

Mara thinks about her morning, resting her forearms over the roof of the car. Catrina Weaver, a girl nobody seems to care for except for one person whose friends were less than kind with their friendship. With a, if Mara dares -she do dares- to say so, difficult to beyond relationship with a mother that used to lock her in an attic that made her room, making her escape uncontactable times through the high windows and into the woods. But where? Had she just escaped one night and walked into the woods to not come back? No ID, no personal objects. If she had done so, where had she gone? A nineteen year old couldn't just walk out of the town, there were miles and miles until the next one. Unless she was trying to escape something. What could cause a person such a level of desperation?

“Are you the detective?” asks a soft voice behind her. Mara turns around, coming face to face to a pair of bright blue eyes.

The young woman has a cheerleader uniform, golden and white, with even whiter sneakers and pink socks, wrinkled around her ankles. She is wearing a red varsity jacket with a wing

embroidered in the front, big enough that brushes the hem of her short skirt. *Same as the photograph,* Mara thinks. All her hair is pulled into a high ponytail, bronze under the light of the sunset, a light fringe and little baby hairs flying across her face with the cold breeze. She's beautiful and young, but the striking lilac rings under her eyes are unmistakable and, when Mara looks a little bit closer, she can see the girl actually looks exhausted. Devastated.

"You must be Adora Grey"

Adora smiles, tiny and sad, not surprised at all. "I am" she points at her friends a couple feet behind her, who are looking at both of them with disapproval faces. "My friends told me you were looking for me."

"I am," Mara affirms, studying Adora. She looks tired and deflated but there is a certain strength held in her shoulders and the tilt of her chin that tells Mara that she is still alert and observing. Even her gaze, blue eyes soft but smart, studying Mara in the same way she is looking at Adora and Mara understands that this is not only another popular girl faking being nice for someone else's well being. She is smart and she cares. "I want to ask you some questions about your friend Catra."

Adora nods slowly, throwing a quick glance behind and around her. "Can we talk somewhere else? More, um, private?"

Mara holds the keys of her car tight in her hand, making a broad movement with her arm to signal Adora to *lead the way.* Adora starts walking to the side, waving off the soft calls of her friends still next to the bikes as she leads Mara towards an empty set of benches at the edge of the school limits, taking a seat there without caring about the seasonal mud staining her uniform. Mara sits next to her, watching as Adora fumbles with the edge of her white turtleneck, a tingling noise coming softly from the golden chain tucked underneath it.

"What is a detective doing here?" Adora asks before Mara can even mutter a question, her blue eyes locked in the rows of trees

across the pathway. “I really doubt Sheriff Kurr had asked for any kind of help. He certainly didn’t seem to care about Catra when I went to speak with him”

Mara huffs a chuckle, looking at the trees too with a sideways grin. “Yeah, he definitely didn’t call me. I guess you could just say it was good luck that I passed by”

Adora narrows her eyes, crossing her arms over her chest and scowling at Mara with plain indignation. The moment is so honest and out of the picture perfect shape everybody seemed to have Adora into that it almost makes Mara laugh.

“If you want me to trust you saying anything about Catra to you, I need to trust you first,” Adora states, baring her teeth. “I live in this town, I know bullshit when I hear it.”

This time Mara can avoid the laughter ripping from her throat. She shakes her head, running her hand over the braid in her head. “Fair. I actually used to live here, when I was your age. But Eternia hadn’t much to offer me so I moved out to San Diego.”

Adora snaps her head back to the trees, frowning. “Well, you know what they say. No First One ever leaves Eternia alive,” she says, a clear hint of deep irritation and anger shining through her words. “You haven’t answered my question,” she points out.

Mara ponders over it and then takes the folded note Serenianhad been reading on the car from her front pocket, handing it to Adora so she can look at it too. It’s a simple piece of paper, done in black ink with a typewriter. Adora looks at it, her frown dissolving into surprise and then plain anger. “What is this?”

“This letter arrived at my office on Monday with no return address or sender,” Mara explains, tapping over the paper with her finger. “It wouldn’t be the first time I get a prank letter but the fact that it referred to Eternia was too much of a coincidence to let it go so I drove here almost immediately.”

Adora hands the paper back to Mara harshly, snapping her eyes away from it as if the letters were burning her. “Who would send something like this?” she mutters, quiet enough that she might as well be whispering to herself. And then louder she asks, “Is it supposed to be a threat?”

“I don’t know,” Mara confesses, saving the paper again. “I thought you might be able to help me with that. Is there anyone in the town that might want to hurt Catrina?”

The corner of Adora’s still narrowed eyes twitch and soften into something a hundred times sadder, lowering her eyes this time to look at her hands, pulling from the loose thread of her skirt in a grounding motion. She doesn’t answer but her bottom lip wobbles sadly, as if she was trying to bite back something really sad. Mara gives her a sympathetic look, speaking softly.

"I talked a little bit with your friends." Adora tenses, looking briefly to where her friends had been, now gone on their bikes most probably to spend the evening together. “Catrina doesn't seem to be very popular, is she?"

"They don't really like her. They think she is… bad for me" Adora whispers, like an uncomfortable secret, something she obviously doesn’t agree to, something that hurts her. “Catra sometimes says and does things other people don't like. It's not her fault, it's the way she is."

Adora balls her hands over her skirt, unconsciously wei Kalyn the fabric under the tension that swipes over her entire body. Mara exhales, resting on the back of the bench. “How did you two meet?”

Some of the tension slips off Adora’s shoulders and she smiles. “We were six. I used to escape from my parents and explore the entrance of the woods until they would find me. That’s where I met her first”

Fall of 1972

Adora scrunches next to a bunch of dry leaves, carefully covering herself on little sticks and mud. She can hear muffled steps in the near distance and has to press a little hand over her mouth, stiffing a laughter.

"Adora!" chants her mom, close but enough to find her six years old daughter among the woods. "Adora, it's time for your bath! You can hide forever little munchkin"

Adora wants to giggle but she holds it back like a champion, watching as Marlena sighs almost in front of her, running her gaze over the spot Adora is hiding without seeing her. After a few seconds Marlena turns back, calling for Adora's dad to 'look at the other side of the house, Randor' before her muted steps wear off.

Adora peeks out of her hiding spot, making sure her mom is gone as she walks backwards, bouncing lightly on her little feet.

Something solid and warm crashes against the back of her legs and Adora falls backwards with a 'huff'

"Ouch," Adora whispers, scrunching her eyes open just a slid. She is in her back, facing the sky and the grumpy face of the prettiest girl she Adora has ever seen in her short life because this girl had freckles on her nose, her hair looks like a halo and her eyes are two colors!

"Do you mind? Watch where you are going" the pretty girl says, squeaky and highly offended. She has a tooth gape in her bottom canine and Adora sneakers because it matches her own tooth gape on her front teeth. The pretty girl narrows her even prettiers eyes, irritation falling from her in impressive quantities for her short age. "What are you laughing?"

"Whoa," Adora manges to say between giggles, looking at the girl with all the raw honesty of a six year old. "You are so pretty."

The girl's mouth falls open, incredulity and the dust of pink coloring her cheeks before she snaps straight again and turns around, purposely walking away from Adora and deeper into the forest.

"Hey, wait," Adora calls for her, scrambling on her feet, little boots tangling with sticks on the ground and making her trip as she chases after the little girl, who doesn't even glances at her. "Wait for me"

Adora follows the girl inside the forest without even realizing how deep she is actually going but she also doesn't pay too much attention to it or to how is she going to get back home. She just cares about chasing the girl up and down fallen tree trunks and behind hugh orange bushes until the girl stops dead in her tracks and turns around quickly, making Adora jump in surprise at the sudden change.

"Why are you following me?" the girl asks, clearly annoyed but also confusion and curiosity written in her face.

Adora stops her walk too, looking at her. The girl is a little bit shorter than Adora, her dark skin pretty under the warm light of the woods. The jacket she is wearing looks a few sizes too big for her, worn out leather with patches in the back, denim pants stained with dry mud, a red old looking sweater and thick leather gloves, also obviously too big for her, hands cupped towards her chest as if she was trying to hide something.

Adora tilts her head to the side completely, smiling brightly at her, tooth gape and all.

" Hi! What 's your name?" Adora sings songs, wiggling on her feet. The girl's eyes are still suspicious but she answers anyway.

"Catra"

Adora's smile grows in size, waving at Catra excitedly. "Hey Catra! I'm Adora!"

Catra doesn't answer but she also doesn't run away anymore, watching Adora weary. Adora looks at her again and giggles once more, hiding her laughter under her hand.

"What are you laughing about?"

"You have grass in your hair" Adora explains, stepping closer to Catra with all the confidence of someone that has nothing to fear. Adora outstretches a hand towards Catra, grasping a dry piece of yellowed grass from Catra's curls, tossing it aside. Catra flinches when Adora does it, closing her eyes almost as if she was waiting for something completely different to happen. When Catra opens her eyes again Adora is looking at her eyes, studying them with her blue ones.

"You are so pretty." Adora repeats, dabbing softly with the cold pads of her fingers at Catra's freckles. Catra squirms inside her big jacket, facing Adora completely.

"Really?" Catra asks, suddenly shy, though Adora doesn't notice it over the sound of her own loud affirmation.

"Yes!"

Catra shifts on her little boots, also coated in dry mud, looking at the dried leaves on the ground with dropped shoulders. "My mom doesn't say that"

Adora blinks at her and then blinks some more, without understanding. Adora's mom always tells her how pretty she is and it always makes Adora feel better whenever she is having a good day. Catra seems to have deflated a little and that makes Adora sad, so she repeats it. "Well I think you are pretty"

Catra looks back at her and smiles, barely even there but there, making the cords of Adora's heart sing in joy.

That's the first time in Adora's life she promises herself she is going to love Catra always.

Adora approaches Catra, pulling softly from the hem of her jacket. "This is so cool! Where did you get it?"

Catra's tiny smile dissolves but there is still the hint of pride in her tiny shoulders when she shakes them, showing off the tiny silver batches on the shoulders. "It was my dad's!" she announces proudly. "He even had a motorcycle!"

She can't really pronounce the 'r' well yet but Adora thinks she is cute and is truly impressed by the big jacket too. Adora looks around them, on the empty woods besides some foxes running far away, birds and other animals running around.

"Is your dad close?" Adora asks, still looking to all sides. In front of her, Catra's proud expression falls into something clearly sad, though she tries very hard not to show it.

"No. He died," Catra says in a whisper, barely audible over the wind. Adora stops bouncing at one, watching at the side of Catra's profile, speechless.

"Oh," Adora mutters once and only. Catra looks uncomfortable, looking for an opening to run away. Adora cheese on the inside of her cheek and focuses on Catra's cupped hands, brushing the leather with her finger to call Catra's attention. "What do you have there?"

Even at their short age, Catra looks relieved on Adora's thoughtful change of subject. She takes her hands away from her chest, opening just a little so Adora can peek inside to look at the tiny friend there.

"A frog!" Adora exclaims, delighted. "She's so tiny! How did you catch her?"

Adora extends a finger to touch the frog's back but Catra snatches her hands away, not rude but quickly. "Don't touch her! Her skin is very thin and your skin can make her sick!"

Adora takes her fingers away immediately, peeking at the frog from behind Catra's shoulder only. She doesn't feel annoyed by Catra's sudden outburst, quite the contrary, she is impressed.

"How do you know that?" Adora asks, marveled. Catra tilts her head forwards with a renewed proud swing.

"I read it in a book."

"Woah," because that's the main word Adora seems to be able to say around Catra. "You are very smart"

"Of course I am," Catra blinks and smirks sideways, cupping the frog in one of her hands so she can poke Adora right in the middle of the forehead. "And you are a dummy."

Adora beams at Catra's soft face, barely containing the need to wrap her into a hug. "Do you want to put her in the river?" Adora asks instead, wrapping her arm around Catra's.

Catra shifts in her feet, gazing at Adora from under her eyelashes. "Um, no. I don't know. I don't like the river"

"Why not?" Adora asks, curious even when Catra looks away.

"I don't know how to swim"

Adora ponders over it for just a few seconds and then she is pulling from their joined arms towards the direction of the river, ignoring Catra's increasingly alarmed expression.

"Don't be scared! I'll go with you!"

"I'm not scared," Catra mutters under her breath though Adora doesn't even hear her, dragging Catra across the woods as if any of them knew where they were going.

"I'm going to look after you, I promise," Adora says and she means it.

And that, it's the first promise she will make to Catra.

By the time Adora goes back home, Catra has already rushed back to hers -turns out Catra is the best with orientation from both- and it's very late. Adora's parents are deeply relieved and smile at Adora's face and clothes completely stained in mud.

—

Christmas Eve, 1972

"Adora, baby, where are you going?" Marlena leans over the frame of the kitchen door with a smile, her bronze hair sprayed into gentle waves, framing her face in curtains of different lengths. She is wearing a red pleated dress over a white turtleneck and high red boots, a reindeer apron stained in flour laced over her waist.

The house is warm and smells like ginger and cinnamon, the soft echo of ABBA coming from the radio close to the dinner room. Randor, Adora's dad, and Adam, her twin brother, are still out in the town, choosing a tree to place in the living room before they have dinner and camp in front of the chimney. It's an old tradition of theirs, spending the day like this.

Adora stops halfway to the door, wrapped in several layers of wool sweaters and a thick feather jacket, her like face barely visible over the knots and wrap of her two scarfs.

"Umm," Adora says, scrambling in her brain to find anything to say at all. "I'm going to play outside with my friend!"

Well, maybe not that.

Marlena giggles, though, shaking her head fondly. It must be said that, for the entire months Adora has been talking non stop about her forest friend, Marlena has always thought it's some kind of invisible friend. Not an actual little girl. But she doesn't know that yet, or at least for the next fifteen minutes.

"Aren't you a little bit too warm, baby?" Marlena looks through the window as tiny snowflakes start to saunter softly towards the ground. It's going to be a beautiful white Christmas in the morning.

Adora waddles to face her mom, barely able to shake her head with a big, dopey smile. "Nope! Can I go play now?"

"Very well," Marlena accepts, helping Adora open the door. It is cold outside. "On the backyard only and not woods today"

"Okay" Adora sings songs, hopping down the small steps of the door and rushing across the garden, barely even stopping when she slip over the thin snow.

Adora arrives at the limit where the backyard meets the start of the woods, peeking around the frozen sticks and trees.

"Catra," Adora whispers, sniffing as the cold of the morning starts to slip inside her clothes. "I'm here. Where are you?"

There are a few seconds of silence and then a group of sticks at Adora's far left start to move, the unmistakable curls of Catra's head bouncing out of her hidden spot when she walks out. She looks like a little lion. A little soaked lion. Her hair is wet and sticking to her scalp, her face red in the nose and cheeks with the cold and she is sniffing and sneezing a lot. sneezing a lot. Adora rushes by her side, undoing the knots of her second scarf to wrap it around Catra's neck and taking off two of her sweaters so she can put them on Catra's, wrapping her in her dad's jacket right after.

Catra is still trembling from head to toes, her teeth click with each other violently. She looks extremely cold and definitely not up to playing with the dim snow falling from the sky. Adora frowns, worried, wrapping her hands around Catra's shoulders and guiding her softly inside the backyard.

"Let's go inside. Mamma always makes the best cookies"

Catra digs her ankles in the ground and makes them stop, shaking her head from side to side, speechless but with an alarmed look in her eyes.

"Hey, don't worry," Adora cooes at her, holding her hands, "Mamma is really nice, she is going to like you a lot."

It takes Adora a good five minutes to convince Catra but finally they climb the steps to the main door, slipping inside the warm house quickly. Adora is almost jumping with excitement and Catra has quite the apprehensive expression etched in her face, looking at the entire house with quick eyes.

"Mamma! We are back!" chants Adora, helping Catra out of her jacket and soaked boots. "I've brought my friend!"

Marlena chuckles from the kitchen, walking out with a smile already etched on her face. "Have you? Well, how nice- oh heaven above! You really did!"

Marlena's face goes through several expressions until she falls into plain shock and motherly horror at Catra's little form, held tightly to Adora's hand and trembling from head to toes. Marlena lowers in her knees in front of the little girl, frowning deeply when she tries to approach Catra to take her socks off and she flinches in fear, hiding behind Adora with an apprehensive look. Marlena bites on her bottom lip, resting her hands on her lap instead and looking at Catra with the softest look she can.

"Oh, darling. You are trembling like a leaf," Marlena says in a gentle voice, standing up so she can point to the living room, movements quiet and slow so the little girl doesn't get more scared. "It's alright baby, you are safe here. Come here quickly. Adora, sweetie, please help your friend seat next to the chimney"

"Yes, mommy!" Adora nods, pulling from Catra's cold hand across the corridor. "Come Catra! I can show you the decorations too!"

Catra follows her reluctantly, still throwing worried looks at Marlena who follows them in silence. When they reach the

entrance of the living room Catra hesitates, looking at Marlena sideways as she speaks with Adora.

"I can't stay," Catra whispers, teeth clicking together. Adora's excited look falls, squeezing Catra's tiny hand almost sadly.

"Why not?"

"My mother will get angry if she doesn't find me," Catra explains, even lower and the way she says it makes Marlena's heart tighten with dread.

"But-" Adora starts, sadly, though Marlena beats her to it, scrunching next to the girls so she can look at Catra face to face.

"What's your name, baby?"

Catra hesitates but answers, slightly less tense around Adora's mom after the latter reassures her with an encouraging squeeze. "Catrina Weaver"

Marlena smiles at her, nodding. "Alright, let's do this. I'm going to call your mom and tell her you are here, alright? And we'll go from there"

Catra's eyes open, alarmed, stuttering as Marlena stands up and walks back to the kitchen. Quietly, Adora cooes her to sit over the fluffy carpet, dragging a soft blanket from the couch and wrapping Catra on it with a wide smile. Marlena has all the numbers of the town, a small benefit of living in such a private place, and she knows Mrs. Weaver, though she didn't know she had a daughter, just that Weaver was a widow and that she was extremely social inside the uptown circle.

By the time Marlena comes back from talking into the phone, both girls are drowsy next to the warm fire, Catra quiet and Adora whispering next to her, snuggled into Catra's side with a hug. Marlena stands still behind them, just observing, her heart thundering inside her chest as she tries her best to collect all the cheerfulness she can before speaking to them.

"So, wonderful news," Marlena cheered after a while, a bit squeaky and tight but the girls didn't notice that. Marlena walks next to them, holding something soft and folded in her hands as she takes a seat next to them. "I've talked with Catra's mom and she said Catra can stay for Christmas."

Adora cheers, suddenly wide awake, stomping her feet on the carpet as she starts talking about all the things they are going to do. But Catra only looks at Marlena with incredulity, hiding behind her bent knees.

“Really?” she asks very softly and Marlena´s heart constricts in her chest. Marlena lowers in the carpet, next to Catra, softly grasping an errand curl and placing it behind her red ears. Marlena knew Catra´s father very little but she knew he had been a good man, kinder and more honest than any other person in this difficult town, and he was also handsome and soft around the edges. Catra, even so little, it's his living image. She has nothing of the woman that calls herself her mother.

“Yes, really,” Marlena assures in a whisper.

There are certain things parents keep from their children when they are little, most of the time to protect them from things that might hurt them. For example, Marlena doesn´t say that, when Mrs. Weaver picked up the phone, her almost too sweet greeting tone dissolved into the coldest, most uninterested voice when Marlena told her about Catra. Marlena doesn´t say the way Mrs. Weaver scoffed, almost as if she had been interrupted in her evening for something stupid and not because her six year old daughter was almost freezing in the woods, or the way she apologized to Marlena saying ¨that girl is just a problem¨ and ¨don´t worry to sent her back on her own, she should know the way.¨Marlena doesn't say any of that to the girls because they don't need to hear it. She will talk about it with her husband Randor later and they will try to make it a little bit better. Because Marlena and Randor Grey are good people and they care.

"Actually Catra, you can come and stay here any time for as long as you want," Marlena adds, caressing Catra´s cheek in the same way she caresses Adora´s and Adam´s. Catra leans into the touch, almost purring in happiness and it swells Marlena´s heart tenderly. "You will always be welcomed into our home."

Marlena hands Catra the bundle in her arms, a pair of clean jammies she threw in the dryer so they would be warm, cooing both girls upstairs so they can change. Randor and Adam arrive a few hours later, covered in snow and smiling. Marlena speaks to him softly in the kitchen as Adora introduces Catra to her brother, who keeps looking at her reluctantly.

That night, the five of them put the christmas tree together and Catra eats cookies and milk and stew until she physically can't anymore. Adam falls asleep pretty quickly in the living room but Adora and Catra remain awake until well into the night, snuggled behind the soft blankets whispering fairytales to each other.

They go from there.

Present time

"My parents really cared about Catra," Adora says after telling Mara as much as she can remember about their time as little kids. Her eyes are red rimmed and she looks extremely tired, no longer the little kid that used to hide under the blankets while her mother baked cookies. It's clear to speak of them and this is hard for her. "She was there for me after they died."

Mara bites back a sigh, looking at Adora´s sad profile with sympathy but she doesn't let it show fully. It's important she knows the story so she can begin to understand what has happened to this girl.

"What about your brother? Does he hold Catrina in high esteem too?" Adora´s eyes harden ever so slightly at the question, eyebrows furrowed.

“Adam- resents Catra,” Adora says between her teeth, baring them just a little. “He- I guess he has always wanted to protect me, because I´m his sister and whatever. But people in the town say bad things about Catra and sometimes I think Adam believes them. We've fought about it a few times.”

“Because he doesn't want you to be her friend?”

“Adam can't tell me who I'm friends with and who don´t. People in this town are horrible and say horrible things because of that. That's not Catra´s fault,” Adora snaps suddenly, turning to look at Mara with burning eyes. Mara leans back, suddenly surprised by the abrupt burt of sincerity but keeps her face blank and listening, watching as the fury inside Adora burns and dies down with a flop. Adora is carrying something heavy with her and Mara needs to know what because there is where the truth lies.

“What do people say about her?” Mara asks softly. Adora flops into the back of the bench, kicking her feet in the mud, staining her shoes and socks.

“Catra can be really impulsive and she talks back when she knows someone is wrong,” she explains, tired, “Not everyone likes that, you know? She has always been like this and I´ve always admired her for it but it gets her in trouble most of the time.”

August 12th, 1985

Exactly ten minutes after the bell rang, not a single minute earlier or after, the heavy and squeaky door of the quiet classroom opens and closes with a loud bang positively calling everyone's attention to the person that just walked in.

Catra waltz inside the classroom with almost a sprint in her step and a self satisfied smirk in her lips, ignoring the annoyed and disapproving looks of all her classmates as she reaches for her seat, right behind Adora, and flops into it unceremoniously. Adora and Catra had a bit of a struggle at the beginning of the course,

because Adora likes to seat in the first chair of the first row but Catra absolutely despises being nagged all the time by the teachers for her way of sitting -flopped over the desk most of the time- or whatever they want to when she is so close to sight. In the end, they reached for a mutual accord, Adora would sit at the front but in the last row, next to the window so Catra could watch the woods and distract herself.

This time, though, it doesn't help her much. Ms. Darling straightens up in her place standing next to the board, looking at Catra with clear annoyance.

"Miss Weaver, what do you think you are doing?" she asks with that high pitched voice of hers, crossing her arms over her chest. Catra raises her head from where she had been staring through the window, grinning at the teacher deviously.

"Catra, please-" Adora mutters under her breath, holding her pen tightly. Catra royally ignores her.

"Well, taking class. Of course Ms. Darling. I find trigonometry fascinating" Catra answers, mimicking the condescending high pitched tone of the teacher. Adora sighs, defeated, resting her forehead against her palm. Ms. Darling tenses, balling her hands in fists over her forearms.

"You can't just walk into class whenever you want, Ms. Weaver, that's against the rules." Ms. Darling walks towards the door, no doubt ready to kick Catra out. The latter just clicks her tongue against her teeth, resting her chin over the mount of her palm.

"But Ms. Darling, yesterday at the end of the class you told us the bell didn't mark the end of the class and kept going for- " Catra makes a dramatic pause to look at the clock in the wall, making everyone squirm uncomfortably. "-ten minutes, yes, So I just assumed that given the bell doesn't mark the end or start of the class, there wouldn't be a problem with me arriving ten minutes later. You know, to compensate"

A general murmur crosses the classroom at Catra´s words and Adora just buries her head on her hands, barely biting back a loud laughter and making it look like a strangled groan. Catra kicks her in the shin from behind, obviously not fooled by it.

Ms. Darling white face is turning into a myriad of very funny shades of pink and purple, offense written all over her face. She grabs the doorknob and swings the door open with fury, pointing at the corridor violently.

"Out," she says, low and menacing. Catra doesn't move an inch. "Ms. Weaver, out"

"You can't kick me out," Catra says, stretching her legs under Adora's seat, her dark jeans contrasting with the pastel pink of her shirt. Ms. Darling opens her mouth, obviously about to yell at her but Catra beats her to it. "You can't kick me out because besides Adora and I, every single other idiot here is spectacularly failing this class. Which means Adora and I are the only ones holding the grade point average of your class so you don't look terrible in the teachers meeting," Catra pauses again, smiling devilish, already knowing she won. "So, good luck making poor miss Grey holding it up on her own once I'm gone."

The murmur in the class keeps going, now mostly upset and annoyed at Catra blatantly calling them all idiots. Ms. Darling just gapes at Catra, speechless for a long one second as her brain catches up on her words. Slowly, she closes the door again, walking back to the board purposely not looking at Catra. The teacher looks at the rest of the class, throwing her shoulders back and grabbing her chalk again.

"So, class," she says, tightly. "Take your notebooks out and write your extra homework for the weekend. And please thank Ms. Weaver on your way out for it."

The class groans loudly, cursing at Catra's back. Adora squirms, quiet and uncomfortable, and Catra lets her head fall into the desk with a thud.

—

"Why do you always antagonize the teachers?"

They are sitting on a high rock in the forest, throwing little rocks at the tiny pond a few feet away from them. The woods are calm, the natural sounds of life and the run of the river far away around them, drowning the noise of cars and the town between its greenery and trunks.

Adora's head is resting on Catra's shoulder, watching as the flat pebbles hit the surface of the water and sink. Catra is wrapped in Adora's red varsity, always naturally cold especially with the August's breezes, kicking her feet over the soft moss as she scoffs.

"Oh come on, don't tell me you didn't want to get it back to Ms. Darling too. She's an asshole," Catra says, taking a sip of their shared Coke, resting next to their knees. Adora shuffles, raising her head from Catra's shoulder so she can pick a pebble of her own.

"Maybe. But still" Adora throws the little rock, hitting the center of the water. "You are always getting yourself in trouble"

Catra grimaces lightly but Adora does not see it, there is real worry in Adora´s voice and, worse than all, sadness about Catra being treated poorly, for her own actions or for the people being plainly cruel. Catra doesn´t like seeing Adora sad. She nudges Adora in the ribs, getting a surprised squeal in return, "Well, not all of us can be Adora goody-two-shoes Grey"

Catra doesn´t say it with ill meaning or with anger and Adora knows it because she rolls her eyes, tilting her head up in a proud manner. "I like following rules"

Catra gasps, overly reacting and absolutely theatrically dramatic. "No, you don't"

"I do!"

"You are so full of shit." Catra pushes Adora playfully, almost knocking her off their seat. Adora gasps and pushes her right back, both of them dissolving into cheerful and lighthearted laughter on their little spot in the woods.

“I mean it,” Adora says, after a quiet while, “ You are so smart Catra, you are so much smarter than me. I wouldn't even survive most classes without you helping me.”

“I know I´m smart dummy, I never said I wasn't,” Catra chuckles, messing Adora´s perfect ponytail, “I just don´t really care about my school reputation. I'm just there because I know you want to be a primary teacher and you need to graduate for that. And as you said, you wouldn't survive without me”

Catra grins as she points at herself, completely sure of herself. Adora smiles softly at her, heart tender. Adora knows how smart and resilient and brave Catra is and how little she usually cares about gossip. But Adora also sees the way Catra´s shoulders fall after people call her names and insult her, once she is far enough from their sight to see her crumble even just a little. Adora knows.

“Do you still want to open that flower shop you told me about?”

“Uh, fuck yeah,” Catra assures as if it was pretty obvious, throwing her arms to the sides, “That witch makes me keep the grass tiny and spotted clean all the time, I want revenge. I want the most chaotic flower shop ever, stinky flowers and bushes full of sticks and the most crazy cactus. It's going to be awful”

Adora laughs at Catra´s excitement, the way her eyes shine and her mouth stretches into a wild smile is unmistakable. “Yes, it's going to be great.”

Catra turns to look at her with a wide smile, happiness pouring out of her in waves. It makes Adora happy.

"I have something for you" Adora leans behind the rocks to grasp her bag pack, roaming on it until she finds what she is looking

for. "Here"

Adora hands Catra a small bundle, wrapped in soft tissue and held together with a plain red ribbon. Catra looks at it in silence and then at Adora with an arched eyebrow, smirking at her. "My birthday is not until October, princess" Catra can pretend all she wants, but she can´t hide the tremor in her voice when she speaks,

"Just open it" Adora nudges her, pointing at the wrap with her chin, Adora is nervous too. "And stop calling me that"

Catra crosses her eyes to Adora, pulling from the ribbon at the same time. "But you are a princess!"

"Prom nominations don't count. Now shut up and open it"

Catra rolls her eyes but does as she is told, tossing the ribbon aside and fumbling with the tissue until the wrap opens completely. Catra stares and then stares some more, all the sarcasm and jokes leaving her as if she had been hit with a brick wall. Adora shifts next to her, anxious but trying to breathe deep through it, resting her hand over Catra´s trembling one in silent support.

"Adora -" Catra starts but the words die in her throat, staring at the little thing until her eyes sting with even tinier tears. Adora moves then, resting her chin on Catra´s shoulder as she speaks.

"My mother would have liked you to have it. She loved you." Adora stretches her arm, brushing her finger over the surface of the golden heart-shaped locket. When Adora´s mom was younger her husband gave it to her as a gift and a promise to always be with her, by her side. Randor had a twin locket to this, usually held into the chain of his pocket watch. They wore it every single day until the accident after which a nice nurse gave them back to Adora.

"I can't accept this," Catra states, lightly pushing it back to Adora´s hand. "I just can´t"

"You can," Adora insists, struggling with the high neck of her gray sweater until she pulls it down, grasping a delicate chain around her neck and pulling from it, the twin locket shimmering under the light, free of the cover of the fabric. "I have the other one, see? Now you can't get rid of me"

Catra chuckles, wet and heavy, rubbing the back of her hand over her eyes, trying to keep her cool. "You are so sappy. You disgust me "

"I know" Adora smiles, taking the locket from the wrap between her fingers. "Turn around I'll help you"

“And they say gentlemen have died,” Catra murmurs as she turns around, picking up her hair so Adora can close the chain safely around her neck. Catra brushes the surface of the heart gently, smiling very small at it. “Thanks”

“Of course,” Adora accepts the gratitude, dropping the softness of her voice just enough so she can add. “You are so soft, who is the disgusting one now?”

"Oh. Fuck off," Catra punches Adora softly in the shoulder, snickering. Adora gasps, placing a hand in her chest.

"Ouch, I take that personally. Give me back my locket"

"Nope, no take back it's mine now," Catra grasps the little heart in her fingers, jumping off the stone and walking around it as Adora chases her around playfully.

Adora trips with her own backpack, stumbling into the moss abruptly. Catra erupts into squeaky, bright laughter somewhere in front of her, almost bending over herself with the force of it and totally not helping Adora up. Adora grunts, searching in the pockets of her bag until she finds her camera, a pretty thing that her brother had gifted her last Christmas.

"Let me take a photo of you!" Adora calls for Catra as she stands up, preparing the camera with expert fingers. Catra crosses her

arms over her chest, groaning loudly.

"Ugh, Adora, what did I say about photos?"

"Please" Adora pleads, batting her eyelashes to her friend. "For me?"

Catra holds on her pride for a grand total of three seconds and gives up, dropping her arms to the sides. "Fine"

Adora cheers, stepping back just enough so she can focus Catra inside the frame of the camera. Catra puts her hands inside the pockets of Adora's jacket, regarding the lent of the camera with the most serious expression she can muster. Adora hums, happily, looking up at Catra with a mischievous face.

"Great. Now say 'Fuck off, Ms. Darling!' "

Catra laughs and Adora snaps the camera.

Present time

Adora doesn't tell everything to Mara. She tells her about the stuff at school and their usual hikes around the woods, where nobody would bother them. But she doesn't tell her about the locket or their plans for the future, that's theirs. Mara knows Adora is holding back things but she also understands the need to keep something dear, private and safe especially in a place like this. Mara knows this first hand and better than anyone else.

"Catra is my best friend" Adora grimaces, biting back a knot on her throat. "It doesn't matter what everyone thinks or believes about Catra. She is good and kind, and she is my friend."

Mara looks at her gripping the fabric of her cheerleader skirt, her fists trembling, skin pale scattered in errand freckles.

"Miss Grey, do you think Miss Weaver could have run away?"

Adora shakes her head vehemently. "No. Catra can be impulsive and stubborn, but she is not stupid, she would have told me something" something dark crosses her eyes, making her close them tight, as if chasing something away, as if trying to convince herself of her own words "She would have."

Mara lets the words hang between them until the school behind them is completely empty, the last cars, bikes and curious eyes of teachers and classmates gone completely, leaving only the gray clouds of rain above them and the whistle of wind against the trees.

"When was the last time you saw Ms. Weaver?" Mara´s questions must hit a nerve because Adora flinches as if she was physically in pain, hugging herself.

"I-" Adora struggles with her words, watching at the woods almost as if expecting for Catra to walk out and into the road any second now. "We had a fight"

October 30th, 1985

Midday

"Catra" Adora follows her out of the heavy school door and into the main yard, the freezing wind of October hitting her in the face harshly. Adora´s breathing is speeding up, heart almost breaking out of her chest and pouring into the cold ground belows as she watches Catra walk away from her. "Catra, please"

"Will you fuck off already?!" Catra turns towards Adora harshly, almost screaming, her face grim and furious under the daylight. Her colorful eyes, usually always so full of life and brightness, are dim, clouded over by a kind of fog that Adora can only call disappointment and that it stabs into her heart more painful than any curse or rage Catra could ever direct towards her. "You just never know when to quit, do you Adora?"

“Please, just please listen to me alright?” Adora pleads, outstretching her hand, trying to wrap her hand around Catra´s wrist. Catra snaps her arm away, anger escalating alarmingly quick.

“Don´t touch me,” Catra hisses, baring her teeth at Adora. “What are you even doing here? I thought you prefered to stay with them”

“That is not what I meant,” Adora interrupts her, voice edging desperation. “You know that's not what I meant, I made a promise to you.”

“It doesn't look like you did,” Catra says, low, menacing, “If you had, you wouldn't hide-”

“Catra,” Adora cuts her, alarmed, looking around them to be sure nobody is listening to them. Class is about to end for the day, people won´t be long to start coming out. “Please don´t do this here.”

Catra´s face is devastating when Adora says that and she know immediatly that she has completely, absolutely, fucked up. Catra gives a step back, then another, her black backpack covered in band patches hanging sadly from her shoulder.

"What do you want, Adora?" Catra asks in a whisper, hugging herself tightly. "What do you really want?"

Adora opens her mouth, wants to talk, wants to say it, scream it right there and then, in the middle of the school yard. But she can't. Adora closes her mouth and stares at Catra, trying to speak to her with her eyes, telling her everything she wants with one of those shared gazes they've been giving to each other for years now.

Catra's expression falls and she looks away, dropping her arms to the sides. She looks so sad, it's breaking Adora's heart into pieces. "I knew it."

"Catra," Adora whispers, softly, tender, reaching for her again, but Catra walks away from her again, like precious sand slipping between her fingers. Catra shakes her head from side to side, all fight and anger leaving her completely, giving away to simple sadness.

Catra doesn´t say more as she turns from Adora and crosses the school yard, walking away.

Adora doesn´t follow.

Present time

"I always thought I could protect Catra, by walking inside the line when she wouldn´t," Adora explains, hugging her knees into her chest, "But I never did, not really. I never spoke up when people were saying things about her. No one was protecting Catra then. I was always just too much of a coward and I hurt Catra because of it."

Mara eyes her, dropping the tense pose of the detective into something more organic, more honest. She knows what Adora is saying, she has lived it. Mara also disappointed someone she cared about and lost them in the way.

"I made a promise to Catra," Adora says, determination renewing in her voice and the tension of her shoulders. "And I'm not going to give up on her, never." Adora turns to look at Mara´s face, narrowing her eyes. "So please, help me find her."

Mara rests her hand over Adora´s arm, giving her a reassuring smile. "Of course I will miss Grey"

A car turns around the corner of the school and stops in the road opposite where they are sitting, the low rumbling of the motor dying down quickly. It´s a nice car of a strange color, lilac with silver details and very clean. The door of the passenger's seat opens and Serenia hops off it, focusing on Mara and waving her arm at her.

“Mara! Here, I´ve come with someone you should meet”

Mara stands up from the bench as the pilot and copilot doors open too, two people walking out of the car. The first is a tall woman, with soft ginger hair that almost looks pink under the autumn sun, she is wearing a white lab coat and high waisted denim pants, walking with confidence next to Serenia. The second person is a man, shorter than the woman with black hair and a thick beard peppered in white strikes. He is wearing slightly more casual clothes, with a colorful bomb jacket of the same color as the car, and his expression is friendly but worried, square glasses slipping down his nose every once in a while.

“Doctor Brightmoon?” Adora stands up too, rushing towards them too. The couple's face brightens a little at Adora´s presence, regarding her with a kind smile.

“Hello, Adora,” the tall woman says as the man nods, walking towards Adora and wrapping her into a familiar hug.

“Hey kiddo, how are you doing?” he asks, palming Adora´s back gently. Adora returns the embrace swiftly, stepping back so she can look at him in the face.

“Hanging in there,” she answers, clearly tense, “Thanks Micah”

“Mara, these are Doctor Angella Brightmoon and her husband Micah,” Serenia presents them. Mara nods at them, offering her hand for them to shake.

“Detective Grayskull,” Mara introduces herself, looking at Adora as she points at Serenia. “Miss Grey, this is my detective partner, Serenia Alvarez”

Adora smiles at her, though like most of her smiles, it doesn´t last long. Angella steps forward. “Detective Alvarez crossed with us at Razz´s Dinner, she told us you are investigating Catrina´s missing” her pale eyebrows furrow, worry etched in all the lines of her face. “We didn´t know the sheriff had ruled it as one”

“He didn´t, Detective Alvarez and I are making the investigation on our own,” Mara explains.”Do you know Miss Weaver?”

Angella smiles, a little apologetic but sure of herself. “I´m the only doctor in Eternia, detective, I know every single kid that has ever crossed through my clinic.”

Mara looks over Micah, who is wearing the same worried expression. “Do you work in the clinic too, Mr. Brightmoon?”

“Oh no, no. I work in the mayor's office, chief of administration. Lots of paperwork and documents but that's all. My lovely wife is the one with all the fun” he says, honest, gazing at his life with nothing but clear love. “It was a coincidence we crossed with your partner”

“Yes. Different from the sheriff, I was getting worried about Catrina´s well being,” Angella adds, a shadow crossing over her gentle face.

“Why so?”

“Catrina has asthma” Angella states, taking a paper that her husband hands her and giving it to Mara. It´s a medical record of Catrina Weaver, a recent photograph, school cut looking, followed by a plain document with doctor Angella´s signature signaling Catrina has been diagnosed with asthma since she was eight years old. “i shouldn´t really show you pacient´s documents, but this is important. I´m in charge of provide Catrina of her inhaler´s changes and medication, she is supposed to pass by the clinic every start of the month to pick them up”

“And Miss Weaver hasn´t shown up,” Mara assumes, gaining a solemn nod from the doctor.

“I´m afraid so. I would usually think it could be some kind of carelessness but that's just not normal of Catrina. She has been picking up her medication every first of every month on the spot for the last ten years.”

“Gosh,” Adora murmurs somewhere behind them, looking extra pale and extra sick. Micah rushes by her side, whispering kind reassurances as Angella hovers over her, checking her quickly.

Mara´s mind is already somewhere else, somewhere not so fair away. A bad town. A terrible mother. A fight. No ID, no *backpack,* no vital medicine. Someone just wouldn´t leave like that, with barely nothing.

“Doctor,” Mara calls for Angella again, her brain working at full speed. “Is there a possibility miss Weaver could have spare medicine for the month?”

“I don´t think so, and even if she did, it wouldn´t last very long and she doesn´t have a recipe” Angella answers. Mara looks back at Serenia, frowning.

“Did you find any inhalers in her room?”

Serenia shakes her head.”Nothing at all”

“Catra only has one right now, she always carries it with her” Adora adds, still looking white as a sheet but frowning deeply at both detectives. “What does this have to do with anything?”

“Because, miss Grey and Mrs. and Mr. Brightmoon, I don´t think Catrina Weaver ran away from town.” Mara states, dragging her eyes over the school and into the woods. "Which can only mean she must be still somewhere in the town."

"I've looked everywhere for her, do you think I haven't?" Adora almost snaps, desperation edging her voice dangerously.

A memory makes its way in Mara's mind. Broken branches and dragged mud behind a cold house. The murmur of wildlife and water running somewhere beyond.

"I believe you, miss Grey, but maybe you haven't looked exactly where you should," Mara points at Adora, mind running with

thoughts. "Miss Grey, you said Catrina and you hung around the woods, didn't you."

Adora squirms, throwing a nervous look at the doctor and her husband before nodding. "Yes, we have a treehouse in the woods, my parents helped us build it when we were little. But I already looked there."

"That treehouse, is it close to your house or Miss Weaver's house?"

"Neither," Adora shakes her head, looking nervous, "It's, um, close to the center of the woods"

"But you can reach it either if you walk from your house or hers, correct?" Mara presses further.

"Yes. We both know the way well."

Mara exhales, looking around the group. It's getting late, the sun is very low in the sky. Night won't be long to cover them.

"Very well, I think we must take a stroll through the woods. Serenia" Mara states, handing the car keys to her partner, who nods and rushes to the pilot seat. "Miss Grey?"

"I'm going with you," Adora is already walking to the passenger seat, face serious and determined. Mara likes this girl, she has a lot of strength and a lot of spirit. "My house is in the way, I have a map there and flashlights"

Mara nods, looking back at the couple, who are already marching to their car. "We are also coming," Angella assures, taking off her lab coat and dropping it in her seat. "If she needs medical attention I can help her."

"Very well" Mara climbs into the copilot seat, hooking the seatbelt quickly. "Let's go"

By the time they arrive at the limits of the woods, night has already fallen completely. They have parked down the road, where the trees can hide their cars from gossipy eyes of the neighbors or Mrs. Weaver, though the house of the latter looks tightly closed and empty. Her car wasn't even parked in the house. Nobody even asked if they should let her know they are going to look in the woods, which Mara makes a mental note of

The group is gathering around the car hood, studying the maps Adora had grabbed swiftly from her house. She has changed too, dropping the cheerleader uniform for a white sweater, high waisted jeans and a bomb jacket. Without the cheerful red of her varsity jacket, she looks even paler, lilac circles of the size of thumbs printed under her eyes.

"This is a map of the woods," Adora says, pointing at different circles and colorful lines that have been marked around the plain map. "Nobody has ever marked the paths but Catra and I hike a lot around here so we've marked it."

"Have you looked for her on these points?" Serenia asks, studying the scattered points drawn in red ink.

"Most of them."

"And this treehouse of yours, where is it?" Mara leans over the map, looking as Adora points into a blue circle, a few yards between Adora's house and Catrina's, which are on opposite sides of the woods.

Mara studies the space around the treehouse with clinical eyes. It's mostly surrounded by thick patches of trees colored in green except for one thick line of blue, crossing right between Mrs. Weaver's house and Adora and Catra's spot.

"Is this a river?" Mara asks, running her finger over the line.

"Yes, River Thaymor," exains Micah, leaning over the map to see better. "But it's quite the treacherous pass, we always tell our kids to stay away from it."

Mara nods, fidgeting with her flashlight before turning it on. "Very well, we are starting there."

"Catra doesn't know how to swim," Adora is visible trembling now, cold fog leaving her mouth though Mara supposes her shaking is of a different origin than cold. Mara rests her hand over her shoulder, squeezing softly.

"Let's just make sure then, alright?"

Adora hesitates but nods, taking the lead on the group as they enter the woods. Serenia approaches Mara, whispering so the rest can't hear them.

"What are you thinking?"

Mara presses her lips, running her fingers over a couple of broken branches they cross through. There are clear signs that someone stumbled around here not so long ago. "Nothing good, I'm afraid." Then she looks back, where Micah and Angella are roaming with their flashlights around the trees, "Has it rain lately?"

"Not since over a week," Angella answers.

Mara nods, looking back at Adora's back, making their way through the woods. "Tracks didn't wash away then. We should find something."

It takes them just a couple of minutes to reach the beginning of a creek from which clear but turmoilous water runs down, making its way inside the woods. It's a wide river, with not a bridge or anything at all to cross it. There a sharp rocks and pieces of leaves in the bottom, water darkened under the shadow of the night. Mara kneels carefully next to the mud, dipping her fingers quickly in the water. It's freezing.

When Mara stands up again she sees something close to the river's edge. It's a wide mark with zig zag dents and deep into the dry earth that disappears at the end by the wet mud. *Car tracks.*

"Where does it end?"

"Close to Plumeria Road, at the south limit of the town," Serenia mutters, eyeing the map Adora had handed her at the beginning of their search.

"Alright, we are following the track," Mara looks at all the presents, a serious tone falling in her voice. "If you find anything that may lead to Catrina's presence around the woods, let me know immediately."

This time, Mara is the one taking the lead, followed close behind by Adora. Micah and Angella are a few feet behind them and the Serenia, walking in and out of the tree limits to check up things.

"Catra!" Adora starts calling, running the light of her flashlight everywhere. "Catra, where are you?"

She calls for her for over forty minutes as they makes their way down the river, her calls echoed by Angella and Micah's behind them. Mara remains quiet, scrunching to inspect the ground as she looks for tracks with no more luck.

The moon is considerably high in the sky, clouded by grey clouds and a thick fog that has fallen over the entire woods. Mara walks a little bit further than the rest, stopping near the edge to peek inside it. Here the river is deeper but calmer, surrounded by higher walls of moss and mud, the water still as they start to reach the end of the river. There is a thick tree branch inside the river close to the right side, long ago fallen and whitened by the lick of the water over the wood.

Mara runs the light of the flashlight over it, almost brushing it over if it wasn't by the shadowed figure of something tangled between the smaller branches of the fallen tree. Mara narrows her eyes, walking just a few steps closer and focusing her light directly over the river and tree, making sense of the still figure floating gently in the cold surface of the water.

Mara tries to get closer but slips in the mud, stumbling into the ground, the flashlight scatters a few inches in front of her, illuminating the pale of skin of the figure's hand. Black nailpolish and delicate fingers.

“Oh, shit” Mara whispers under her breath, scrambling to her knees so she can grasp her flashlight again. It is her, there is no doubt. Dread and sadness fall over her chest and shoulder completely, just like every time something like this happens in a case, the heavy feeling of despair and failure. Mara can barely see her, she is too far again inside the still river, but the matted curls tangled in the branches are unmistakable. "Shit, shit. Oh no"

Mara hears the sound of leaves stepped over and tiny branches breaking behind her and her heart gives a spin inside her ribcage, standing and turning around. Adora is standing still a couple inches behind her, frozen in place, her flashlight directed to the same place Mara had just found. She has gone pale, extremely pale, almost so translucent, her chest speeding up with her breath and hands shaking so much the flashlight trembles and falls to the ground unceremoniously, illuminating the river and their faces in melancholic glare. The woods are deadly quiet.

“Catra?” Adora voice breaks around the work, nails against glass, arrows against a heart and from the angle Mara is in, she almost can see Adora's chest ripping open and bleeding out into the merciless cold water at their feet. “Catra”

“Ms. Grey-” Mara stretches her hand towards her but she is too slow.

Adora drops down and jumps inside the deep water of the river, not caring of the tide or the cold or the depth of it, making her way inside the muddy water, fighting desperately against the rocks and water. She is fast but she is already late. Mara knows this.

“No, no, no, no. Catra… Catra!” Adora is repeating again and again, like a whisper, like a prayer, like a heart wrenching scream.

She looks heavy inside the water, limbs like stone drawing her down, breaking between mud and plants slowly, so slowly, sinking inside the water as the pain threatens to drown her as it had already done with her heart. "Please be alive, please, please…"

Adora finally reaches the fallen tree, throwing herself against the water so she can fight the hard branches, breaking them between her hands without even flinching as they cut scratches on her palms. She catches the still figure on her arms as she starts to drift away, wrapping her arms around her waist and resting all her weight over her chest, dragging her off the water and over the muddy edge.

"Doctor Brightmoon!" Mara turns to call for Angella, who is already speeding towards them, followed by her husband and Serenia, attracted by the echo of Adora's screaming.

"Goddess-" Angella mutters, brushing past Mara quickly, the four of them rushing to the edge where Adora has managed to pull herself and the figure out of the water.

Adora kneels into the ground next to the figure with her legs, ripped jeans and sneakers soaked in river water, thrown over Adora's lap. Adora cradles her between her arms, resting the person's head gently over her upper arm, pushing the matted hair away from the person's face and brushing her fingers down a freezing cold cheek and tinted blue lips. Adora's shoulders don't let Mara fully see the face of the person in her arms, but she can see the shape of her arm fallen over the ground, palm open like a still flower, and the pink fabric of a soft sweater stained in mud, wrinkled by Adora's hand, closed into a tight fist around her waist.

"Catra?" Adora asks in a whisper, broken by the tight knot in her throat and the tethering of her teeth crashing against each other. The person in her arms remains still. Adora shakes her softly, almost as if they were just children waking each other up from a horrible nightmare. "Catra. It's alright, you are alright now. I'm here"

Adora cradles Catra into her chest and buries her nose into the damned curls, covering Catra's face and torso with her own body, away from the group's horrified view. Adora is trembling so bad it's making the body in her arms tremble too.

"We are going home, okay? Don't worry, we are going home," Adora keeps whispering sweet reassurances to the body, rocking her tender from side to side. Adora's blue eyes are almost bright under the dim light of the flashlights and the fog of the woods, pupils torn into mere points inside her irises, sight focused in a spot on the river, where the branches of the tree had caught Catra. "You are not done yet. You are not done, do you hear me?" and then in the lowest of voices, so soft Mara is sure it's only meant for Catrina's ears to listen, Adora says, "I love you. I love you so much, do you hear me? I'm so sorry, I've got you now."

Mara is frozen in her place, heart pumping too fast as it always does when anyone sees a person losing someone they love. Catrina is unresponsive inside Adora's hold, Mara knows she is because there would be no way. It's been two days.

Angella brushes Mara's shoulder softly, calling her attention. There are tears gathering in her husband's eyes but her face remains blank and impassive. She is a doctor, after all, and above anything else, she knows how her job goes as hard as it can be.

"I have to check her, I'll need you to help me hold Adora, Detective." She says in a low voice. The tiredness in her shoulders and back can't be hidden away, though, and Mara has to remember these are young people Angella knows since they were kids. Mara nods solemnly. Angels turn once more, towards Serenia, asking her in even a lower whisper. "Detective Alvarez, can you go look for the mortician? His name is Oscar, he is a forensic pathologist and a good friend. We are almost at the end of the river, he lives right across the road past the end, about five minutes away. Tell him what is happening and that I sent you, please"

"Of course," Serenia answers back, throwing a swift nod to Mara before speeding inside the woods. Behind Angella, Micah starts to take off his long coat, looking at both women with sad eyes.

"I'll help you cover her," he whispers to them, walking with them.

Angella approaches first, slowly kneeling in the ground in front of Adora. Mara can barely see anything at all under this light but she can see the way the doctor places a soft hand over Adora's shoulder, who looks up at her with the most heartbreaking expression, blue eyes bloodshot and swimming in frightened tears.

"Doctor Brightmoon," she says, her voice breaking completely. "She is so cold. Why is she so cold?"

Angella's face crumbles in pain, her professional facade slipping off for the split of a second. She leans down slightly, holding Catra's wrist between her long fingers. Angella looks at Mara swiftly, shaking her head in negative once before looking back at Adora, palming her cheek gently.

"Adora," Angella starts, rubbing Adora's fingers, tightly shut around Catra's pink sweater. "Adora, I'm so sorry."

Adora's face stills for an impossible long second and falls like ice breaking, all the muscles of her face going slack and then tensing completely, her teeth connecting with each other together so hard they click loudly.

“No. No, no, no” Adora shakes her head from side to side roughly, bringing Catra's still body closer to her chest, bending over herself so she can guard her from the sight of the people around her, as if the warmth of her own body would be enough to bring Catra back. "No. You are wrong. I can fix this, okay? I can fix it"

"Adora, I need you to let me see her."

"No! I can fix this! Just let me stay with her, please, just let me stay!"

Her voice is frantic now, words clashing against each other, falling down, tripping, clawing off her throat like a thousand knives threatening to tear her open completely. Adora buries her face on the side of Catra's heart, still shaking her head -her hands, her arms, her entire body, shaking like an earthquake-. Her fingers flutter on the side of Catra's neck and press in her pulse point, the movement easy, known, a tell tale that says to Mara that Adora knows this kind of stuff about Catra. Where her pulse is, in the space between her jaw and the three moles like constellations in the column of her neck, knows the smell of her breath and the warmth of her skin. And it tells Mara the exact moment when reality crashes against Adora and the weak, careful dam she had built around herself to keep away the desolation, breaks down and, with it, everything that Adora is.

"Please no. Catra, please, you have to wake up," Adora chokes around a sob, tearing her vocal cords apart. She crumbles over herself, hiding Catra like a lifeline, like a lost ship without an anchor. Mara can almost feel the coldness in Adora when she brings Catra's hand up and presses her lips, wet with tears, on the back. "I'll stay here, don't be afraid, okay? I've got you, I'm not letting go."

Micah kneels next to Adora, prying her frozen fingers open from Catra's body, one by one, pushing her hands away as gently as he can. Adora loses it then, breaking into a gutting wail, weeping her heart out of her throat, baring her teeth at Micah and Angella the same, slapping their hands away when they try to calm her down, cursing and screaming and sobbing so loud and hard her voice fails her, leaving her gasping and out of breath there in the cold ground.

Angella snaps her sight to Mara, pushing Adora back and towards her from the shoulders, kind but firm. "Detective"

Mara moves immediately, snapped out of her frozen state. She leans down, not even thinking about it, Mara's chest against Adora's back, wrapping her arms around Adora's shoulders and upper arms, getting a hold of her wrists and holding them

together firmly against her chest, preventing Adora from slipping out from her grip. Mara has held back grieving people before, she knows about the strength pain can bring. Still, it steals the air from her lungs when Adora slashes against her hold violently. She trashes around and screams like bloody murder as Mara pulls and drags her several feet over the softened earth, away from the body and Angela and Micah hovering quickly over it, hiding away from Adora and Mara's sight. Mara can't even observe them as they work, struggling to keep Adora from running towards them. She is cold too, clothes soaked after she jumped into the river to pull Catra out.

"Miss Grey," Mara tries, holding down Adora with all her force, even as her arms start to feel tired and Adora's voice starts to fail her, lost in the sound of her own sobbing.

"Get off me! Let me go!" Adora wails between the prison of Mara's arms, kicking on the mud and snarling, her lips pulled back and teeth bare, actually clawing at Mara's jacket without mercy. Her hair has gone loose from her ponytail, falling in hazelnut waves around her furious face. "Fuck you! Let me go!"

"Miss Grey, stop!" Mara growls, ignoring Adora's increasingly weak curses. Next to the river's edge, Angella falls back into her ankles, rubbing her fingers heavily over her misted eyes as Micah drapes his long coat over the young woman's body, covering her completely under the thick fabric. "Stop!"

"No, no. Please let me go, please" Adora falls into her fours, freeing her hands from Mara's hold just enough so she can dig her fingers into the soft earth, clawing at the mud and moss like a wounded animal. "Let me go with her. I promised her, I can't fail her. Not her" Adora rests her forehead into the ground, breaking into loud sobs. "She is all I have"

Adora is beyond words now, drowned by her own tears and mourn as the river had drowned who she loved. She wails and screams, reaching among the woods and reaching even the town like a scream pulled out of a nightmare or a horror tale, the kind

that everyone wants to listen and talk about but nobody wants to live. There is nothing Mara can say or do for Adora now but to hold her as she bends over herself and sobs at the top of her lungs, her soul ripped out of her body on that cold spot at the end of the woods.

"I would go anywhere with you" Adora whispers, brushing the tip of her nose with Catra's, covered by the secrecy the night brings with it. Catra smiles, tiny and tired, her eyebrows knitting together in swift hesitation.

"Really?" she asks in an equal whisper, scooting closer to Adora. "You have everything here and I have nothing to give you"

"I don't need any of it," Adora answers, tapping the surface of Catra's locket with her fingers. "I want to do what we said. Know the world, go wherever we want. We'll call the shots"

Catra giggles, good-hearted, heart full. It's cold tonight but she doesn't mind it, neither of them do.

"I'm poor" Catra whispers, a blush tinting her cheeks, but honest. She is nervous, Adora can feel it in the palm of her hand as it runs down the creases of Catra's back.

"I'm poorer," Adora whispers back, smirking. Catra snorts, just as Adora predicted, pocking Adora in the ribs and the forehead.

"Liar," Catra complains, but she laughs anyway. Adora catches her hand between hers, bringing it up so she can rest Catra's palm over her cheek, sighing at the shared warmth of her skins. "I want to hold your hand without anyone talking behind our backs," Adora confesses, locking her eyes with Catra's, bright and smart and just a bit scared. "I just want to be with you."

Catra bites on her bottom lip, hiding her face in the angle between Adora's neck and shoulder, blankets want and rumpled around them. "Promise?"

Adora smiles at her, even though she can not see her, burying her face over the soft curls of Catra's hair, placing a phantom kiss there. The soft tune of Belinda Carlisle's 'Heaven is a place on earth' echoes from the radio somewhere behind their backs, filling the small space with hopeful music.

"I promise"

You want to die for love, you always have

You’re going to die in your best friend’s arms and you play along because it's funny, because it's written down, you've memorized it,

it 's all you know.

– *Crush* , **Richard Siken**

Chapter End Notes

If you are still here, thank you so much for reading. I know this is a very strong subject we are dealing with but that was kind of my goal here.

Still, please have faith in me that there will be justice and the angst will be compensated.

Next chapter is on Dec. 20, see you there :)

Have theories? Let me know in the comments!
Be good ♡

Act II. Playwright

Chapter Summary

"I loved her"

"I know"

Chapter Notes

In the aftermath of a lost, what is but to reveal the truth?

TRIGGER WARNINGS: Descriptions of death, wounds and corpses. Mentions of parental abuse. Homophobia. Slight mentions of drinking. Slight mentions of smoking. Mentions of a major character potential death. Grief.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Act II. Playwright

I don't know what to say to you

except that it tore the heart out of my body

saying goodbye to you.

– **Vita Sackville-West**

Spring, 1963

Mara sprints out of the sheriff's office, chest heavy, breathing hard. The air is unusually cold for spring or maybe it's just Mara and the salt of her tears drying on her cheeks.

There is a mustard colored car already waiting down the road for the girl Mara is chasing after, hurried steps in the cold cement as makes her way to leave this place, and Mara, forever.

"Hope!" Mara yells, out of breath, barely managing to catch up on her. Hope turns towards her but doesn't look at her, gaze lost between the floor and the woods and the sheriff office at Mara's back, a clear statement of what she is feeling. "Hope, please."

"I can't stay, Mara," Hope whispers, fidgeting with her hands. "My parents are already waiting for me, I have to go."

Mara chokes in her words, guilt and shame crippling up her spine and around her chest like an invisible punishing hand self inflicted and painful. "I'm sorry," Mara blurts out, shaken, "For what I did, for what it did to you. I'm sorry."

Hope does look at her then, her dark beautiful eyes swimming in tears but honest, and soft. "Don't be sorry," she whispers, like a secret, "I'm not sorry."

They are young, barely even eighteen, and already broken. Hope stretches her hand and brushes her fingers over the back of Mara's wrist, searching Mara's eyes with a kind of urgency and firmness proper of Hope and Hope only. "I'm going to give you some advice, Mara. Get out of this town as soon and fast as you can and never look back," Hope takes her hand back, starting to walk away again. "This town will kill people like you and me before changing, so please, leave."

Mara stands there, breathless, watching as Hope speeds down the road, hops inside her parents' car and leaves. Mara never sees her again.

That same day, Mara gathers all the things an orphan can have the luxury of calling her own, jumps into her own car and drives until there are no trees around her anymore.

November 4th, 1985

5.15 am

"Mara, wake up"

Serenia shakes Mara from the shoulder, gently but firm, tearing her away from her nightmares. Mara blinks at the cream colored ceiling above her head, breathing deep and slowly, reality falling over her one by one until she fully knows where she is and what is going on.

Mara sits up in the old looking couch, rubbing her hand over her eyes to clean the last webs of sleep away. Serenia hands her a cup filled with dark coffee. It's thick and sour, exactly how Mara remembers it from Razz´s, the muted sounds of the dinner echoing from the first floor below.

“What time is it?” Mara asks, sipping on her coffee.

“A quarter past five,” Serenia answers, fidgeting with a paper in her hands.

“You let me sleep”

“Two hours is barely a nap,” Serenia places the paper on the table in front of Mara, pointing at it with her finger. It´s a newspaper, still damp with dew after being just recently picked up. “You need to see this.”

Mara picks up the newspaper, skimming her eyes over it quickly. An announcement of the incoming highschool basketball game occupies most of the front page, bold dark letters and a white and black picture of the school´s team in the middle. Mara recognizes some of the boys she met yesterday. Bow Coleman is in the middle as co-captain, next to a taller boy with light hair and an incredibly close resemblance to Adora Grey. It must be Adam Grey, her twin brother and captain of the team.

There isn´t much more information in the page besides the weather of the week, a few news from the Private Eternia Club for Residents and, finally, the tiniest square in the far corner of the paper with an even smaller notice:

Local student was found dead in the river. Sheriff Kurr rules it as a careless accident.

Mara slams her empty cup against the table, suddenly incredibly angry. "It hasn't even been eight hours and he already ruled it as an accident."

"I know," Serenia flops in the opposite chair, looking at the ceiling. "Considering he didn't even let us get near last night, I'm not surprised."

Mara leans on the couch, staring at the pale dawn outside the open window.

Serenia and the town's mortician, Oscar, had arrived at the scene barely ten minutes after they had found the body. The man had barely acknowledged the others before he had sprinted to Micah, kneeling next to the covered body with a tense expression on his face. Mara had been working with doctor Angella, trying to calm Adora´s devastated sobs and unstopping fighting. In the end, Angella had ended up slightly sedating her as a police car parked close to them inside the woods, sheriff Kurr and another police officer marching over them with a highly annoyed expression on his paper white face.

"What is the meaning of this?" Kurr asked as Angella gently handed Adora to Micah so she could go and help Oscar with what he was doing. "Mrs. Weaver called me saying people were roaming around her house and I have five other neighbors reporting screaming inside the woods. What are you playing at, Grayskull?"

Mara crossed her arms over her chest, barely holding back a loud curse. "We found Catrina Weaver in the river. But there was nothing to worry about, right?"

Kurr's eyebrows raised to his forehead, looking towards the place Angella, Oscar and the body of Catrina are. He looks mildly impressed but not upset, scoffing. "Well, everybody knows the river is off limits. I can't be blamed for the lack of responsibility of a problematic girl."

Mara gaped at him, dropping her arms to the sides. "Are you serious?"

"Quite serious, actually. Now I'm going to ask you to leave. And stop involving Adora Grey into this."

"Adora Grey offered because she cared about her friend," Mara bited back, looking sideways as Micah gently cooes Adora inside his car, wrapping her in a knitted blanket halfway done he grabbed from the backseat. After everyone was gone, he would drive her home and make sure she was safe. "And I'm not going, I need to see the body first."

"You ain't seeing shit, Grayskull. You have no jurisdiction here," Kurr snapped at her, already halfway inside his car. As they talked, Oscar and Angella had already wrapped and pulled the body inside the wide back of the mortuary's car, speaking in soft, rushed voices.

"Are *you* seeing the body then?"

"Of course not," Kurr snarled, almost as if disgusted by the idea, "That's what the mortician and the doctor are for."

Mara stared at the side of his face, sour anger, frustration and sheet indignation boiling in her throat. She is tired and worn out after holding back Adora for so long. Her ears are still ringing with the sound of her screams. "You are pathetic."

Kurr's face started to get a dangerous shade of plumb, his neck and forehead tensing so much the veins popped. "You and your friend, get out of my sight right *now* ."

It didn't matter how much Mara growled or how much Serenia tried to convince Oscar, Kurr kept them there until the mortician gave them an apologetic tired look and drove away. Angella and Micah, with Adora in the backseat, murmuring quick goodbyes and driving in the opposite direction. Kurr didn't even bother checking the scene or the river, he threw one last threat towards them and drove away mumbling curses. Mara and Serenia had

stayed in the woods until dawn, looking for any other track and taking pictures of the place. As a whole, it wasn't of much help.

And now this.

A soft knock comes from the other side of the door. The door opens and Razz peeks inside, her big earrings and colorful clothes still stuck in the 70s.

"Yohoo, everything alright here?" Razz calls, smiling wide. Mara returns the grin, a little softer, nodding.

"Yes. Thank you for letting us stay here, Razz"

"Of course, of course!" Razz steps inside the room, folding her hands over her chest. She looks tinier than Mara remembers or maybe Mara is just bigger. "I never use this apartment anyway. That's the perks of having lots of places to go."

"Do you have more houses?" Serenia asks from her spot in the chair, genuinely curious.

"A few more here and there. More than I can remember or use, definitely. My grandchild is just recently moving into one of them, so it always comes in hand to have them," Razz sings songs, dusting off the top shelf of the room as she speaks cheerfully.

"I didn't know you had a grandchild, Razz," Mara says with a cheeky smile, finishing her coffee.

"Which grandchild?" Razz asks, absently.

"Um, the one you just mentioned," this time is Serenia the one that speaks, frowning.

"Oh, yes! Well, at my age I do have a few grandchildren under my belt. And I used to travel a lot when I was younger, if you know what I mean," Razz says, wiggling her eyebrows and shaking her hips from side to side, the little jewels of her clothes twinkling against each other. Mara and Serenia laugh with her, shaking their

heads. She is a nice woman. "Oh, but I was forgetting. Would you girls like some pie for breakfast? I just took my berry specialty out of the oven!"

"We would love to, thank you, Razz," Mara stands up, grabbing her jacket from where she dropped it in the ground. "But we'll have to take it on the way. We need to go see Sheriff Kurr."

"Oh that horrid, awful, rancid man," Razz spats, her soft, old face contorting into raw displease. "He is downstairs, at the dinner, with his horrible son."

"Kurr is here?" Mara and Serenia shared a look, already grabbing their essential things.

"Oh yes, he is a pig but loves my pie," Razz starts walking to the door and down the stairs that lead to the dinner's kitchen, followed close by Mara and Serenia.

"Still don't like cops, Razz?" Mara asks with an arched eyebrow and a knowing smile, already knowing the answer.

"Oh, Mara darling, you know cops can go and suck my-" the door of the kitchen closes behind Razz, drowning the rest of her sentence though she doesn't need to finish for Mara and Serenia to blurt into laughter.

"She is nice," Serenia whispers, following Mara through the corridor that leads to the main dinner.

"She is. She was the only person that offered to foster me after my mother died. I was just a teen back then," Mara explains, opening the door to the dinner. "She is a good person, I own her a lot."

The dinner is calm at this hour, the gentle buzzing of the kitchen and the hum from the radio the only loud sounds in the place. The chairs and sofas are the same bright blue Mara remembers and the walls pink and black and white squared floor. It hasn't changed a bit.

There are a few people chatting in the main counter, probably teachers, murmuring between themselves. Sheriff Kurr is sitting in one of the far booths, close to the glass door, talking quickly and slightly angry with the young man in front of him. The boy is his living copy, the same spoiled milk-like face and bright, uneasy green eyes. He has his arms splayed on the back of the seat, looking outside of the window with a visible annoyed expression.

"So, did you see her?" Kurr is asking to his son, tapping on the flat surface of the table again and again and again.

"Her brother said she wasn't home," the son says in a mocking tone, clicking his tongue against his teeth.

"And?"

"And Adam Grey closed the door in my face and told me to fuck off," the boy turns to look at his father fully, green eyes burning in contained rage and frustration. It's pretty clear he has taken whatever had happened very personally. Mara's attention perks up at the mention of the Grey name. "That fucker, one day-"

"But not now," interrupts Kurr, leaning over the table towards his son. His hands are closed in tight fists and his face is red and serious, voice low and dangerous as he speaks to him. "Listen to me well, boy, do not lose that girl."

"I know that-"

"It doesn't seem like you do," Kurr grabs his son by the nape of the neck, locking him in place as he speaks to him, threatening and quietly violent. "Do you want Adora Grey?"

His son's face is grave, tense and blank, but his pupils dilate completely at the mention, making a chill shiver run down Mara's back. Something very bad crawling and sticking inside her ribcage as the young man speaks, voice low and charged. "I do."

"Good. Because I want you to be Mayor one day and for that you need that pretty little princess you've obsessed with. She is this

fucking town's golden girl after all." Kurr lets go of his son, leaning back on the seat. "So you better get going with it."

His son scoffs, crossing his arms over his chest with sly, disgusting smirk. "Don't worry. Without that freak around anymore acting like a fucking guard dog is going to be really easy."

Serenia makes a soft sound next to Mara, both of them interchanging heavy looks. The booth falls quiet so Mara walks towards both men, deciding to pretend she didn't hear the conversation. For now. Instead, Mara approaches in quick strides, slamming the newspaper over the table and leaning over it on her palms.

"What the fuck?!" Kurr exclaims at the same time Mara growls.

"An accident, uh?" She straightens up, crossing her arms over her chest. "You solved it so fast, sheriff, it must be a new record. Even for you."

Kurr's eyes sour at the sight of Mars and the newspaper, pushing the black and white pages to the side carelessly. "You again. Aren't you tired of playing?"

Mara ignores the bite, focusing. "I bet you didn't even dig more into it."

"Why would I even need to?" Kurr establishes, basically spitting the words. "A girl found in a dangerous river, it's not hard to figure out. Mayor Hordak agreed with me, there is no need to attract bad publicity to the town suspecting something that didn't happen."

"Of course he would agree with you. All the propaganda for his reelection would look pretty bad otherwise, wouldn't it?" Mara bares her teeth, barely containing the disgusting in her voice. Kurr doesn't hold his annoyance half as good, slamming his palm over the table.

"You think you are so smart, don't you?"

Mara opens her mouth to answer but it's cut shut by a dry chuckle, lacking all mirth and charged with mockery. Mara turns towards the sheriff's son, who is looking at her with somehow an even more prepotent look.

"You must be the woman my father was talking about," he says, chewing each word like the cat that got the mouse. "The *detective"*

Mara hears Kurr chuckling behind her, amused by his son's condescending tone. She only tilts her head to the side, her braids falling like curtains behind her back. "What's your name?"

"Prime," he announces, obviously proud of himself. ""The *sheriff's* son, of course."

"Of course," Mara repeats, taking in Prime's basketball varsity with a small grin. "My apologies, the newspaper only mentioned the names of the captains of the team, so I had no idea who you were."

It's clearly the wrong thing to say to Prime and the absolute best thing to say for herself because the offended, angry look that falls on his stone like face is priceless. Mara ignores him, looking back at Kurr.

"Let me see the body."

"Why? So you can keep this delirium of yours that you are a detective? I don't think so." Kurr's answers, spitting on the floor. Behind Mara, Serenia wrinkles her nose, disgusted, but Mara doesn't even flinch, repeating her words slowly, like she was telling them to a two years old and not a full grown man.

"Let me see the body. *And* if the mortician and the evidence show it was indeed an accident I'll be off your ass and you'll never have to see me again," Kurr closes his mouth from where he had opened it to protest, narrowing his serpent eyes at her. Mara just smiles. "Do we have a deal?"

"Fine," Kurr accepts, after a long second. "Have fun playing Nancy Drew, sweetheart."

Dread and offense falls over Mara's back but she doesn't say more, straightening up and turning towards Serenia to leave. There is a shuffle in the booth and then Prime's voice raises again, his condescending tone echoing inside the half empty dinner.

"Do you really want to know what that Weaver girl was?" Mara hesitates and looks back just enough to lock eyes with him. He has a self-sufficient smile on his face and his arms are stretched in the seat behind him, but his eyes don't lie and what Mara sees inside then forms a knot in her throat. "She was a freak, a mistake of nature. Everybody knew that. She used to look at our woman instead of men like some kind of aberration," in the dinner, Mara can hear people murmuring, swift looks at them. "And last month, someone caught her forcing herself on someone behind this dinner. Everyone knew what she was after that and no one in their right mind would let their daughter get close to her." Prime smiles, satisfied with himself. "You do your investigation but this town is lucky the rotten seed is finally gone."

Mara digs her nails inside her closed fists, tensing completely. Serenia rests her palm over Mara's back, gently guiding her to the building.

"Let's go Mara," she whispers, throwing a glance at both men's deeply satisfied looks. "Let's go."

Mara pushes the door open, storming off the dinner and towards the car, the sound of the sheriff and his son's cackling laughter following them close behind.

Mara is fuming the entire ride across the town, grabbing the steering wheel with so much force the skin of her knuckles strains against the delicate bones, the mastic of the wheel protesting under the force.

Serenia throws her a few worried looks, unsure of what to say until finally, Mara murmurs under her breath.

"This town has always been like this," tight and angry. The day is cold, the houses start to disappear the more they drive into the south of the town. Here, everything is lonelier, quieter. "It's a fucking hell and nobody ever seems to learn."

Serenia worries her lip with her teeth, knitting her eyebrows together. They are business partners, yes, but they are friends first and it's clear this is bothering Mara deeply. "The world outside is not like that anymore, you know that. It's getting better"

"I know," Mara turns down the road. She can hear the quiet hum of the river inside the woods next to them. "And yet, I have a dead girl and nobody seems to care about it just because she was different to them."

Serenia sighs, placing her hand over Mara's tight knuckles with a small smile. "We care," she whispers and it's true.

Silence falls inside the car until the thick woods open into a large clear, a huge white and brown house rising in the middle. It's full of windows, all closed shut, a clean porch with a few chairs and a small table and black curtains. In the left side, there is a smaller construction, the exterior the same as the house but with the huge tower of some kind of chimney rising from the roof. Black smoke is coming from it, swirling and spiraling in the air and into the morning sky.

Mara parks the car at the edge of the woods, partially hidden under the sad branches of a willow. There is another car parked at the other edge of the woods, an empty white beaten up pick-up, apparently completely empty. Mara frowns, turning off her own car and getting ready to hop out when a strong noise comes from the house.

The door of the smaller construction at the left opens and closes with a slam so harsh all the windows tremble dangerously with the force of it. Adora storms out of the building, walking in long steps across the yard and towards the pickup, her hands closed in tight fists and her face red and contorted in fury. She is wearing a red jacket, black turtleneck sweater and a pair of black jeans torn in the knees. There are strikes of black make-up in her cheeks, made by paths of tears falling from her eyes and smudging her eyeliner everywhere, and her hair is loose and wild falling around her face in a hazelnut curtain, gone are the ponytail and the colorful scrunchies Mara met her with.

Mara and Serenia stare without moving as Adora jumps inside the pickup and turns it on, driving off the property and inside the woods at hellish speed. Mara drums her fingers over the wheel as she sees her go, humming.

"Let's go"

Both detectives make their way through the cold yard, approaching the same building Adora had just stormed off. Mara knocks, quick and loud, three times and it doesn't take long for the sound of wood creaking and keys to come from the other side, the mortuary, Oscar, opening the door with a tired sigh.

"Adora, I already told you I can't - oh, detective Alvarez," he cuts himself short at the sight of Serenia, visibly blushing. He is a handsome man, with dark eyes and a kind face, though he looks deeply tired as the dark rings around his eyes give away. Serenia shifts in her feet, suddenly nervous and pitch higher than Mara has ever heard her before.

"Hello, Oscar, um, doctor" Serenia blushes, looking away and towards Mara, who is looking back at her with an arched brow and a *too much* knowing expression. "Er, this is Detective Grayskull, my partner."

"Yes of course," Oscar shakes himself to reality, offering a hand to Mara, who shakes it back in greeting. "Pleasure. I'm afraid we

didn't get to meet properly last night. Too many things, right?"

"Indeed, but no worries," Mara throws a swift look behind Oscar, peeking inside. A plain, neat and clean corridor, white and sterile looking with nothing else in the walls but a few certificates. As Mara thought, this building must be used for the doctor to do his job. "We saw Miss Grey leaving as we arrived."

"Oh, yes. She wanted to see the body-" Oscar says, voice trailing off as he looks behind him, a swift expression of anguish flashing on his eyes swiftly.

"She looked pretty distressed."

"I couldn't let her pass," Oscar runs a hand through his hair, the white fabric of his lab coat spotless but wrinkled. He's probably been up the entire night. "I've never seen her like this before, though if I'm honest I don't go to the town a lot. I didn't even know they were friends." Oscar grimaces, shrugging as he opens the door wider. "But please, come in. I'm sorry for my clothes, I didn't have time to take a shower."

"That's alright, you look great," Serenia stutters, stumbling as she walks inside the building, followed by Mara. Oscar smiles at her, soft, and doesn't say more, the three of them standing there in awkward silence.

Mara clears her throat quietly, those two jumping in surprise by the sound anyway, stiffing a knowing smirk under a blank look. "I'm afraid we come for the same reason as Miss Grey, we need to see the body," and before Oscar can protest, she adds, "Sheriff Kurr gave us his permission this morning."

Oscar hesitates in his feet, opening and closing his mouth, an apologetic look that doesn't speak of anything god falling over his face.

"I'm sorry, that won't be possible," he says, voice low, "I explained it to Adora too, I tried as much as I could but I couldn't do much."

"What do you mean?"

"Mrs. Weaver came this morning," Oscar explains, exhausted. "She asked me to cremate her daughter's body."

They sit in the office of the mortuary. The rest of the building is too cold and creepy for any of them to endure it right now. Still, it smells strongly like formaldehyde and cleaning products, and through the open window Mara can see the column of dark smoke still coming from what she knows now is the incinerator. She can barely see it at all without her head pulsing in pain.

"Mrs. Weaver came by around four in the morning," Oscar is saying, sipping in the strong coffee he had served to the three of them. There are obvious marks of exhaustion on his face but he keeps as profesional as he can, drumming his fingers over a closed folder over the table. "I thought the sheriff department had told her about Catra and that she was here to recognize the body, but she didn't even wanted to come inside, much less to see her," Oscar's face contorts as if he was thinking something very similar to the way Mara feels about the whole situation right now. "I tried to convince her but she came with Sheriff Kurr and he supported her, gave me an official order. I couldn't do much after that."

"She came with Kurr?" Mara repeats, leaning back.

"Yes, that's why I thought it was strange you said he gave you permission this morning."

Mara growls low in her breath, pinching the bridge of her nose between her fingers. Next to her, Serenia grunts. "He really is an asshole"

"He is but he is not stupid," Mara says, finishing the coffee with a loud clank.

"Do you think he is helping her hide something?"

"I don't know yet," Mara looks at the mortician, who has been following the exchange with heavy eyes. "Is there anything you can tell us about the state body?"

"I couldn't do as much as I would have liked but I did notice some things," he hands the folder to Mara, opening it and signaling the reports and photographs there. They are very simple photographs, close-ups to certain parts taken with an instant camera and slightly blurry. "Blue lips and pale skin. I would say she was in the river for about two days. The cold helped avoid partial decomposition but there are other things that don't match. I didn't find any indicator that she had gulped water or that she had struggled with the river's tide."

"So you don't think she drowned?"

"I can't tell precisely. There are signals of struggle for air," Oscar leans over his seat, rubbing his hand over the back of his neck, "I have a theory though."

Mara and Serenia exchange a look. Serenia nods at him, smiling encouragingly. "Tell us"

"The external signs I found are similar to an anaphylactic attack," Oscar points to a photograph, a close-up to the neck. Mara can't see her face but the column of her neck is clear as are the shallow nail marks in the skin below the jaw. "And signals of desperation. I think she could have had an asthma attack and she panicked."

"Could it be the cause of death?" Serenia presses, narrowing her eyes at the photos.

"It could. I called Doctor Brightmoon, she is in her way. She will be able to tell us more."

"What about these?" Mara interrupts him, pointing at the same photograph, over the skin of the neck, close to the girl's collarbones. There, the skin looks darker, splashes of color slightly spotted in purple and black and that greyish look of hollow skin.

"That's the other thing I wanted to talk to you about," Oscar fumbles among the photographs, taking a few and placing them beside the neck one. There is one of the left thigh, close to the hip bone, a long greenish mark that stretches over the skin. A second photograph of the back, close to the shoulderblades, old thin marks, long ago healed before the dead but unnatural and definitely there. And a last one, of the right hand, delicate bones and worn out nailpolish over blueish nails, chipped and broken at the end, and the unmistakable mark of fingers in the skin of the wrist. "They are bruises. It's hard to tell with the time she spent in water, the ones in the back and tight are old, probably a week or so. But the ones in the neck and wrist are recent."

"From about the time of dead?"

Oscar hesitates, grimacing down at the photos before a sharp, decided expression falls over his face. "Yes. I- I think someone may had tried to choke her"

"So she fought someone," Serenia whispers.

"And someone was hurting her before that too," Mara adds, clenching her teeth. "Anything else?"

"Not really," Oscar leans towards the furniture behind the desk, grasping a small cardboard box and offering it to Mara. "These are the few personal items she had with her. Mrs. Weaver didn't want them so I thought you could take a look at them"

Mara takes the box, fumbling with the things there, all of them packed neatly in evidence bags. A pair of plain keys, a blue hair tie, gum and, lastly, a golden heart-locket smudged in mud but intact. Mara takes Catrina's photograph from her jacket, siding it with the small necklace. It 's the same. Mara also has the feeling she saw the gold of that chain somewhere else.

"I can't believe her own mother didn't even want to look at her," Serenia is murmuring to Oscar, looking at the photos sadly.

"I'm afraid it's not uncommon. Some parents are, well, not what we would expect them to be," he answers back, tight and visibly upset under his professional facade. "At least it is somehow lucky the body was legally reclaimed, many unidentified bodies end up in mortuaries like this because nobody reclaims them. I'm always receiving Jane and John Does. It 's truly sad."

A new set of knocks call at the door, startling them all.

"That must be Doctor Brightmoon," Oscar stands up, fetching the keys from the wall. Serenia and Mara stand too, following him to the door. Before she can leave the room all together, though, Mara grabs the locket and puts it inside her pocket, rushing behind Serenia right after.

Oscar is already talking to Angella, who looks just as tired as everyone else thought she has obviously changed and her hair is as neat as always. The mortician fills her in with what had happened in the morning, explaining the situation with a grim look and handing her the same file they had been reading minutes ago. Angella's eyes are heavy, obviously angry as she goes through the photographs and reports, her lips frunces into a frown.

"I can't believe how easy it is to make a life extinguish and disappear as if she had never been here," Angela mutters under her breath, gripping the papers so hard they wrinkle in the edges. Mara chews on the inside of her cheek, studying the doctor's expression carefully.

"Did Catrina ever talk about bruises or hits?" She asks, already knowing the answer.

"I wouldn't be able to tell that to you even if she did," Angela says quietly, voice tight. Even through the confidentiality she must keep, Mara can see right through it. The way Angella's eyes harden it's enough.

Mara nods, silent understanding passing between the two women. Oscar starts talking again, pointing at the same things he had told them and his theory. Mara's haze drifts into the yard, falling on the doctor's car where a girl is sitting. Dark hair painted pink and bubbling clothes, Mara recognizes her in an instant.

She walks out of the house and down the steps of the door, approaching the copilot's seat with a tight smile on her lips. The girl looks at her approaching, apprehension falling visibly over her as Mara leans on the edge of the open window.

"Hello again Glimmer," Mara greets her. "I should have supposed doctor Bright-Moon was your mother."

Glimmer looks visibly uncomfortable, fumbling with the fabric of her bright purple leggings. "Well, you are the detective after all."

Mara smiles, more candid this time. "I suppose I am," she tilts her head to the side, pointing the obvious at Glimmer's lack of uniform. "You are not in school today."

Glimmer grimaces, looking through the front glass and definitely not at Mara. "Mom wanted to keep me close until she knew what happened," Glimmer's slightly annoyed expression melts into wonder and then plain weariness, looking at Mara sideways, her voice dropping into a mere whisper. "Is Catra really-?"

She doesn't finish the question but her voice trembles all the same. Mara sighs, nodding softly at the girl. "I'm afraid so."

Glimmer looks about to be sick. Her skin pales into a dizzy shade of green and her eyes harden. "I can't believe it," she says, almost to herself. "She always acted so- undefeatable."

Mara gives Glimmer an apologetic nod, digging her hands inside her pockets. "Nobody is indestructible, miss Glimmer, not even the people we dislike."

Glimmer seems to shrink even further in her car seat, playing absently with her seatbelt as they fall into a swift silence. "I…

what I said yesterday," Glimmer finally says, in the thread of a voice, shame and something like guilt crippling in her throat. "I didn't mean it like this. It's just that…Catra was always with Adora. Always. Everyone at the school knew they were glued to the hip. And then Adora became part of the cheerleader team and even then Catra would be at every practice and even every game and didn't seem to care about the things people said about her."

"Hmm," Mara wonders, leaning in the door of Glimmer's side. "Did those things have to do with a rumor of some kind?"

Glimmer turns pale, scrunching in her own shoulder and looking at her folded hands, she doesn't glance at Mara at all. "Adora didn't care about that either. I… I never said anything about Catra, never, but I'm the captain of the team and I hear the things people say. It worried me that Adora could be hurt to an extent but she didn't *care* ." Glimmer scrunches her nose, grinding her teeth together. "I didn't like it because every time Adora would ditch our plans as friends and as a team to be with her. I guess I was just jealous."

Finally, Glimmer looks up, leaning out of the car's window to look at Mara's face fully. "I know what I said. Catra was rude and a dick, but she wasn't a bad person like everyone says and didn't deserve this. I didn't want to admit it, but Adora always smiled the brightest when she was with her." Glimmer seems to think something over, a dark cloud falling over her face. "And, even if what people said was true… it didn't matter in the end. People of this town suck ass, I know because I belonged to them and I… I did nothing. Do you understand, detective? All of us, we did nothing."

Glimmer flops back into her seat, out of breath, the skin of her neck and shoulders flushed. She is clearly upset and the force of it takes Mara aback, staring at the side of the girl's face in stunned silence.

"Mara," Serenia calls for her from the front of the mortuary, signaling with her hand for her to come closer. Mara sighs, heavy

in her chest, looking back at Glimmer one more time. The girls isn't looking at her, instead pricking at her pink nails, mind far away. There are crumbs of dirt under her nails and her nailpolish has come off on some parts.

"Whatever you may have thought about Catrina, I can tell you one, Ms. Bright-Moon and that is that your classmate didn't drown in her own on that river."

Glimmer snaps back with an exhale, turning her eyes to Mara. Her pupils are pinpoints on her irises. She doesn't speak and Mara doesn't elaborate, tilting her head to Glimmer in a silent goodbye before turning back on her steps over the stone path, walking close to the group gathered next to the open door.

Doctor Bright-Moon's eyes are locked with the mortician's file, digging inside the blurry photographs. Even with all her professionalism, Mara can see clear as day the way indignation and anger fight for a place in her features, her eyes hard and even her pale cheeks tinted in dark with emotions.

"Doctor Bright-Moon agrees with a the atshma attack," Serenia tells Mara under her breath. "She can't be sure without an autopsy but given there weren't signs of drowning, it's our best theory so far," Serenia hesitates, eyeing both doctors before whispering in an even lower voice. "But, Doctor Bright-Moon also confirmed that the bruises around her neck matched with a possible try of choking. She's been really quiet since she saw them."

Mara drags her eyes to the Doctor's profile, considering her for a while in silence before speaking. "Doctor Bright-Moon, is there a real possibility that an asthma attack had killed Catrina?"

"Yes," Angela closes the file almost with fury, handing it back to Oscar. "There is a chance her inhaler could have helped her but if she was scared or running it wouldn't have done much. She would have needed an epinephrine shot." Angela crosses her arms over her chest and looks straight back to Mara. "Catra was always

easily propense to these types of attacks, that's why she always was supposed to carry her medicine with her."

"They weren't with her when we found her," Mara tells her, "She had a few personal items but no medicine at all. Bruises in her neck and no missing report" The doctor's eyebrows furrow deeper, teeth clenching together. Mara clicks her tongue against her teeth, opening and closing her hands to her sides. "Doctor Bright-Moon, am I facing a murder?"

Angella's eyes are ice cold against Mara's dark ones. She seems to be fighting something internally, lashing in the shadows of her face until her shoulder drops and she says with one strong, definitive word. "Yes."

The world gets very quiet around them, even the sing of the birds drowning inside the numbing silence that comes with things like this. Angella turns towards Oscar with a frown, eyeing the corridor that leads towards the cold mortuary and the dark incinerator in the back.

"What is going to happen with her ashes?"

"I don't know yet," Oscar rubs his upper arm, grimacing. "Mrs. Weaver didn't want them. I'll look after them until the detectives finish their investigation."

Angella nods along his words, rubbing the side of her temple. "I'll help with any expenses that may come. Is there anything else we can be of help, detectives?" she finishes, turning towards Serenia and Mara. There is obvious honesty in her face, and also, grief, the edge of her eyes red and cheeks hollow. It makes Mara feel just a little bit better that maybe there are actually decent and good people on this town.

"Is there anyone you think may have wanted to hurt Catrina? Anyone holding a grudge against her to this extenze?" Serenia questions them. Angella and Oscar share a tense look.

"We know things are… tense, in the Town about Catrina, but we really need to find the person. Someone hurt this girl and we need to find out why before they hurt someone else."

Angella's eyes dart quickly towards her car, where her daughter is sitting. Oscar's gaze wanders towards the house next to the mortuary, frowning in thought.

"Talk with Prime Kurr," a third voice comes from behind Mara and Serenia. They turn back to look at Glimmer, looking green in the face but firm.

"Why?" Mara asks, already tense. Glimmer scoffs, snapping her gaze away with obvious displeasure.

"There was only one thing I always agreed with Catra and that was the fact that Prime is a fucking asshole"

"Glimmer-" Angella scowls her for the word in a low voice. Glimmer shrugs and keeps going.

"He makes Adora uncomfortable. He is always trying to get close to her during basketball matches or at school, even in the Town," Glimmer makes a face, between something angry and something ashamed, staring at Mara purposely. "She never told us about it but we all saw it. I'm sure she talked to Catra about it because she was always covering for Adora and keeping him away. I know she insulted his guts a few times."

Mara nods, mind already wandering. "Where can I find him?"

"At school. There is basketball practice today, he should be there."

"And Adora Grey?"

"I- I don't know," Glimmer looks at Mara with a pleading stare, fidgeting with the hem of her sweater. "I've called to her house and tried to contact her the entire morning but she doesn't answer. She's not at school either. I- Adora shuts herself a lot,

shuts everyone else out. I've never seen her like this before, I'm really worried about her." Glimmer answers to her as her mother approaches her, reluctantly accepting her encouraging squeeze over her shoulder.

"I'll search for her too," Mara tugs her jacket over her chest, nodding at Serenia who gives one more tiny smile to Oscar before rushing back to the car, starting the engine. "Maybe you should stay at home for now. Sheriff Kurr won't do anything about this but I'm not taking any chances."

"Of course Detective," Angela agrees, face serious.

"Would you like to accompany you back to town, Doctor?"

"Actually," Oscar says, looking at Angella with pleading eyes. "My little sister has a really bad cold, I was wondering if you could give her a look. We could go through the file again and we'd inform the detective if we find anything new."

Angella nods in agreement, gently guiding her daughter with them towards the house. "Of course."

"Be careful," Mara calls after them, already walking down the stairs. Oscar and Angella nod back at her.

The air is very cold and the morning sky is gray. Somewhere, inside the woods, car tracks get erased by rushed, gloved hands.

October 31th, 1985

Halloween

11.18 pm

Catra makes her way inside the woods, furious tears running from her eyes, smudging all over her cheeks even as she tries to tame them down with the back of her hand.

The air is heavy, warm and unusually humid for an October night. The entire woods is bursting with life, crickets, fireflies and other nocturnal animals moving around the forest quietly, unbothered by Catra's ragged breath. She hears a branch snapping in two behind her and looks in time to see that she is being followed even though she screamed not to.

"I told you to piss off and leave me alone!" Catra yells, baring her teeth. Her pink sweater sticks to her skin and all her hair has come undone by her run through the woods.

Catra turns around again, hoping this time the message has come through. The steps behind her stop for long enough that Catra makes it slightly further inside the woods.

Suddenly, the air changes around her, a cold breeze crossing through her entire body and making her shiver. Catra barely has time to hold her breath before a hand wraps around the back of her neck and pushes her forward, slamming her so hard against the trunk of a tree that all the air gets expelled from her lungs.

Catra trips, legs weakened by the hit, and falls face down on the ground painfully. The tree has left scratches over her face, stinging against the suddenly cold breeze. Catra wheezes, trying to incorporate and failing. Her arms are trembling like crazy and her chest is heavy, lungs pressing against her ribcage and heart, making her head spin. Catra grasps at the earth and soft moss, crawling over the ground slowly, too slow, like one would run inside a dream. The grass is damp there and Catra can hear the strong tide of the river close to her.

Arms wrap around her shoulders and turn her over, slapping her square on the face when Catra fights back. Catra growls, grasping hair and pulling strong from it. Kicking, spitting and scratching over until her nails chip in the edges and bleed. She can't scream, her voice gone with the breath of her lungs.

Two hands wrap around her neck and press down, strong, harsh. Catra's eyes widen, panic taking over. She claws at the hands

without much luck, her arms are already tired and her lungs are screaming, looking for air desperately.

The hands shift, keeping the pressure down and pulling, dragging Catra through the mud until all her senses can feel is the river getting closer and the cold water splashing on the rocks and against her face. The pressure in her neck is now gone but she can feel heavy eyes staring down at her, studying her and her desperate gasp. Catra knows she is having an attack, she can feel it, in the pain of her chest and the hammer inside her head and the heartbreak in her throat. She knows she doesn't have her inhaler and that she is alone with this person. Deep inside her, Catra knows she is dying.

Catra looks up, towards the sky, tears falling down her eyes in waterfalls. The moon is shining down at her, bright and pale against the blue of the night sky, sprinkled with stars. It's a beautiful night. It reminds Catra of someone she loves.

She can feel the hands drive away and stand next to her, staring down at Catra, observing as she claws at her own neck, crying and struggling for breath. The hard sole of a shoe presses against Catra's shoulder and pushes. Catra feels the fall and then the merciless hit of freezing water. She feels herself driven away. Even inside the pain it's, somehow, peaceful.

Catra looks at the moon one more time and closes her eyes.

Present time

12.22 am

Love, is a very painful game.

Mara knows this.

By the time she makes it to the school gym, the team is already gone, long finished the practice. They aren't in the classrooms or the school's yards either. It takes Mara and Serenia a couple of

hours of driving in circles around the sterile calm town, gaining the disapproving looks of one too many residents watering their soulless yards or driving in their perfect little cars. It hasn't changed at all, not a single bit since Mara left so long ago.

They finally find the basketball team outside a new looking roller skating rink. The exterior is plain and white as everything in the Town, but colorful lights and cheerful music can be heard and seen coming from the inside. It's early, yet most of the school seniors seem to be here, gathering inside the rink or on the white benches outside. There is a particular group in one of them, a couple of members of the team and cheerleaders gathering around someone in the middle, though none of them are the friends Mara had met yesterday. In the middle, there is a boy sitting with a blank expression on his face, ignoring the chitchat of his friends around him as he stares at some point beyond the line of trees. He is as handsome as Adora is, a clear mirror of his twin with the same blue eyes and the hazelnut hair, short to the chin and messy by the practice and the wind. His chin is set into a tight line, tapping his foot against the concrete of the floor several times. There is a gym bag next to his feet and a half drank soda on his left hand, almost forgotten as he keeps staring at nothing.

Marta stops the car right in front of the group, walking out with purposely authoritarian steps. The group’s voices die down, turning their head towards her with the same judgmental stare Mara is so used to seeing. The boy, however, doesn’t even look surprised, following Mara with his blank gray eyes as she approaches the group.

“Adam Grey,” Mara greets the boy, not even bothering in play presentations. The corner of Adam’s lip twitches into a frail smirk, finally breaking from his still state to give an absent gulp to his Coke, studying Mara from under his light eyelashes. He has a deeply intelligent stare.

“Detective Grayskull,” he greets her in return, plain and simple. “Took you long enough.”

Mara scoffs, actually mildly amused by the boy's impertinent comment. She digs her hands inside the pockets of her jacket, staring at the rest of the classmates. "I need to speak with your Captain alone, if you don't mind."

One of the cheerleaders scowls at Mara, wiping her red hair to the side as she basically drapes herself over Adam's shoulder, who grimaces at the touch. "Uh, you can't tell us what to do," the cheerleader squeaks, high and annoying, "and who are you supposed to be?"

"I think you should listen to the detective," Adam interrupts her, giving another gulp, eyes casted to the ground. The cheerleader, and the rest of the class,ages, looks at him as if he had grown a second head, gasping like a bad soap opera.

"But, But Adam-"

"Dude-" tries another one from the team followed by the others displeased, confused murmurs. Adam frowns, eyes flashing with that same ferocity Mara had seen in Adora's last night.

"I said leave," Adam says again, not bothering on looking up but voice edging into something sharply dangerous. That seems to do the trick because the rest of the people freezes for one second before starting to scramble up the benches and away over the street, picking up backpacks and jackets from the ground and murmuring to each other and throwing horrible looks at Mara on the way. The red haired cheerleader pops the pink gum she had been chewing loudly as she crosses against Mara's side, slightly bumping her shoulder against hers on purpose when she crashes against her.

"Freak," Mara hears her mutter under her breath before joining the rest, leaving only Mara and Adam and the festive music in the background behind them.

"Charming friends," Mara says, arching her eyebrow at him. Adam scoffs, resting his head on the back of the bench. His smirk is

sour, not really reaching his eyes as he looks at the sky. Like most of the people Mara has met, he looks tired.

“They are not my friends."

"Then what are they?"

Adam chuckles, tilting his head to the side as he looks back at Mara. He bends forward, resting his elbows over his legs, dangling the crystal bottle between one hand and the other.

"Just ask me what you've come to question me, detective. We both know why are you here"

Mara hums, unmoving. As much as he is a mirror of his sister, Adam Grey is tighter, closed up around himself like a barrier. There is a kind of tightness on his shoulders that speaks of a heavy weight placed on them and a frown in his dark eyebrows that could be both born from worry or anger. Or both.

"What was your relationship with Catrina Weaver?"

"Inexistent," Adam spats immediately after. His face remains stoic and blank the entire time. "You wouldn't be surprised to find out my sister and I don't always see eye to eye."

"Hm," Mara kicks in the small pebbles of the ground, "The sheriff ruled her death as a drowning, did you know that?"

"I did, everyone in the town knows it," Adam clicks his tongue against his teeth. "But you don't believe that"

"I don't"

"Neither does Adora" Adam's eyes harden, looking at the line of trees past the forest. "I always knew Catra was going to drive my sister mad, I just never thought it would be like this."

Mara walks towards one of the pillars of the building, leaning against it. She doesn't look at Adam, instead looking towards the

empty streets around them. "Adora said your parents liked Catrina"

"My parents were good people," Adam spats, baring his teeth. "They always cared for others and Catra was among them, it wasn't unusual."

Mara chews on the inside of her cheek, wrinkling her nose lightly. "I was sorry to hear about them."

"Yeah well, the world isn't fair is it?" Adam kicks on his gym bag, caring littl for the items that twinkle inside it.

"Is that why you are so angry?"

"What are you trying to get to, Detective?" Adam stands up suddenly, crossing his arms over his chest. He is tall, an inch or two taller than his sister, and clearly worked up because his face is tense all around the edges, and he is clearly strong. Mara doesn't flinch or step back, lifting her eyebrows as she looks at him at his full height for the first time. There are scratches on his legs and knees and his knuckles are slightly bruised, splashes of purple and red strangely scattered around his skin for someone that plays basketball.

"I do believe someone intentionally caused her death," Mara lets through, studying Adam's face as she says the words. There is a flash of mild surprise on the back of his eyes, or maybe even a hit of something *else* , because his pupils blow wide, drowning the blue in them.

He doesn't ask how or what she has found, instead only asking, "Does my sister know about it?"

Mara narrows her eyes. "Not yet"

Adam considers Mara for a second, eyes hardening. It's obvious he knows what she is going to, so he spats, "Just ask, detective"

"Where were you on the night of Halloween?"

"At the Town's party. Not the one of the school gym, the *good* one, on Mermista's House. You can ask any senior, they all saw me there"

"Why do you have bruises on your hands?

"I'm a mechanic, my father taught me and Adora. I'm fixing my parents car," Adam opens his palms for Mara to see them. There are scratches there too and, effectively, grease stains on his wrists and fingers. "It's in the garage, you are welcome to search in our house any time you'd like."

"Don't you think it is a little bit convenient that you have an excellent answer for every question?" Mara questions him with a tight smile that doesn't have real mirth on it.

"You wouldn't be the first person in this town that questions every single thing we do. Especially to us."

"You mean your sister and you?" Adam nods tightly, once. "Why is that?"

"Because for some reason, we seem to be the golden children of this godforsaken town," Adam's lips recoil as if the mere words disgusted him, spitting on the ground next to his feet. "I'm expected to win the basketball scholarship and fuck off to Salineas for some business college and Adora is expected to stay here, marry rich to some asshole and be some of those uptowns gooses like all the old women that live here."

"I'm guessing it's not something you are very happy with"

"Ha," Adam runs one of his hands through his hair, tugging from it until his knuckles turn white. "Things in Eternia aren't about what we want, detective, you know that. Adora told me you lived here."

"I did," Mara digs her nails on her palms, trying to keep her memories at bay. "I imagine being friends with Catrina didn't make it for Adora."

This time it is Adam who closes his hand into a fist, gripping the neck of the bottle so harshly Mara worried for a second it will break.

"I love Adora" Adam says and it´s strangled, the words tangling with his vocal cords and coming tight and trembling. The blank expression he had been keeping the entire time of their conversation beaks in the edges, letting through a hint of profound emotion nestled somewhere inside. "She is my baby sister, even if it is for just a few minutes between us, and I´ll always protect her and will always be ready to do whatever is needed for her to be safe. Is that enough for you, detective Grayskull?"

Mara drops her arms to the sides, looking Adam from head to toe. Besides the emotion on his face there is something else burning up in his eyes, furious and strong like orchestral drums that tell Mara that the emotion may be raw but the intention is set in stone, and that Adam Grey would be ready to do absolutely anything for his sister. Except that Mara does not know where those lengths begin or finish at all, and she doesn´t like not knowing.

"Grey!" a new voice comes from the street, approaching quickly. Mara turns in time to see Prime walking towards them with wide and purposeful steps, staring right back at Mara before stopping right next to Adam who doesn't seem surprised at all. Prime throws his arm harshly over Adam´s shoulders,snapping with the other the Coke from his hand just as Adam is about to drink from it to take a sip of his own, gulping down the entire thing completely. "What are you saying to the nice, nice detective here?"

Adam scowls, shaking Prime´s arm away. "I've told you to stop drinking from my things"

"I *asked,"* Prime repeats as if Adam had not spoken at all, "what are you saying to Mrs. Grayskull, here? Uh?"

“Just I said to you this morning when you went to *my* house, searching for *my* sister, nothing of your fucking business” Adam snaps the empty bottle from Prime´s hands and throws it in the bin near by with sharp aim. Prime´s expression sours immediately at his words, staring at Adam´s face with burning anger before it melts down into something tamed. A slow smirk starts to spread on his thin lips, stretching the faint muscles of his hollow face and casting his pale eyes into shadows.

“Now, don´t be a dick, Grey, It won't make any of us look good,” Prime hisses in a whisper before raising his voice, this time turning fully towards Mara. “Isn't that right, detective? My father asked me to… check up on you. To see if you are getting used to the town as you should.”

There is an obvious meaning behind his words, passive aggressive on his quiet threat that makes Prime feel superior to Mara, straightening tall above her as he steps too close to her face. It´s a tactic Mara has lived through before, of men trying to intimidate her and make her feel less. She is not new to it and much less coming from a nineteen year old like him.

“Yes, I can see you do *everything* your father asks you to do. You are a very obedient boy, aren't you?” Adam actually snorts at that, barely making the effort to hide it. Prime´s cheeks turn even paler and then flare up in red. Mara gives a triumphant little smile, leaning against the pillar casually. “Where were you on the night of Halloween, Prime?”

Prime snaps his shoulders back, very subtly flexing his arms and hands, just enough that he is sure Mara is looking and looking well. He shoots a quick look towards Adam, who avoids his stare, and smiles, regaining all his confidence as he shrugs. “Around”

“Not good enough, Prime. Where were you that night?”

“Did you see her body?” Prime´s words cut Mara like cold ice. Mara gapes, caught off guard which only makes Prime chuckle. “I told you, nobody cared about her”

“Answer my question, Prime, or I´m going to rule you as suspect of murder”

“Actually I don't have to answer anything at all, and last I heard, the police department hadn´t given a prosecution for murder. Remember you don't have jurisdiction here.” Prime digs his hands inside his pockets, swinging on his ankles, the smirk never leaving his face. “But I´ll amuse you, *detective,* just so you stop playing chase the goose. Instead of going to some childish party, I was in a private dinner with my father and Major Hordak, discussing matters for the great future that awaits for our beautiful town” Prime looks at Adam, holding his eyes heavily. The ways his teeth flash with the purple light of the rink makes him look like a serpent about to strike. "A future I'm sure your sister will fit right into perfectly"

Adam's pupils shrink into slits, the blue overtaking his eyes, flaming as fire. Mara has barely time to hold her breath before Adam is moving, shooting forward and grabbing Prime's shirt between his fists, dangling the sheriff's son towards him in a harsh tug. Adam bares his teeth, his entire face contorting and wrinkling with anger. His breathing is fast and ragged, raising clouds of steam from his mouth as he growls at Prime, low and menacing. "You son of a bitch"

"Hey! Hey! Knock it off!" Mara roars, standing next to both men and trying to prey Adam's hands away. Adam ignores her, instead tightening his grip even further over the expensive fabric of Prime's varsity. Prime stares at him, amusement writing all over his face as he throws his head back and laughs out loud.

"Do you want to keep playing the good boy card, Grey? Uh?" Prime gets into Adam's face pitting the words with a maniac smile on his face. Adam grinds his teeth, shaking Prime angrily.

"Shut up"

"Why don't you tell her what you really thought about that whore? What she really wanted to do with your beloved sister, what she

was trying to turn her into. Everybody knows, Grey, don't tell us she didn't do you a favor by dying"

"Shut up!" Adam lets go from one of Prime's shoulders to throw his fist back, ready for a hit. Mara sees the opening and takes it, tugging hard from Adam's arm until the latter trips on his balance and loses his grip, allowing Mara to step between both men, arms extended until they are several feet away.

"I said knock it off!" Mara shouts. A few people from inside the rink have started to peek from the windows, curiously chatting between themselves. It won't take long for the gossip to spread through the town and that's exactly the last thing Mara wants.

Prime raises both of his hands in front of him, playing the innocent as he shrugs and smiles. "Careful, Adam, you've got much more strength than you think"

"Fuck off" Adam spats, tight as a violin cord. Mara gives him a pointing look, her arms still held up to keep them separated.

"Grey" Mara mutters as a warning. Adam Soares her barely a look, frowning deeply. Prime chuckles, fastening his jacket back into place and slicking his hair in perfect place again.

"Listen to the detective, captain. I think it would be for the best for you," Prime walks down the narrow steps back to the street, tilting his head to the side so he can see Mara in the eyes, the perpetual smile etched in his mouth. "Catrina Weaver was a danger and she met an end proper of what she deserved, but I had nothing to do about it. You are welcome to ask Major Hordak about it, though, if he takes the time to see you of course he is a very busy man as we are all in Eternia."

Prime starts to walk back down the street, whistling under his breath. "If you need any more answers, you can find me at the sheriff's office, I'd be glad to be of as much help as I can to solve this mystery, detective." Mara's teeth click together as her jaw sets into a tight line which only gains her another self sufficient

stare. Lastly, Prime gives a military salute to Adam's direction, grinning as the cat that got the fucking mouth. "I'll see you very soon, Grey. Give Adora my love."

Adam looks like he wants to scream profanities but he doesn't, so Prime keeps walking away with the same smirk, whistling the entire way until his figure and the sound disappears, only the funky music replacing the rancid ambient that had fallen outside the rink.

Adam snaps back to reality suddenly, leaning to pick up his gym bag from the ground. He throws it over his shoulder and starts walking away too, harshly stepping over the pavement. Mara rushes behind him, calling after him before he can fuck off away too.

"Wait. Adam, wait." Adam hesitates at her call, tilting his head back just a slit to let her know he is listening. "This is important, Adam."

Adam wrinkles his nose, scanning the empty street a few times and the clear windows of the rink now that the show has ended before speaking, so low and tense that only Mara can hear it.

"Adora and Catra, they had a fight a few days before Halloween. I don't know what it was about but Adora was very upset about it," Adam looks at some point beyond Mara's head, eyes tender and watery. "Adora… She feels guilty. She keeps saying that this is her fault, that she caused it." Adam looks at Mara, sharp and pointing m, making sure his point comes across on his string tone. "But she didn't, alright? And I'm going to tell you one more thing, detective, and it's going to be the last. My sister was being harassed. She was being forced to become something she neither was or wanted and it scared her"

"Are you sure about that?"

"I am," Adam locks eyes with Mara's. "I'm her brother, I know her." Adam fidgets with the strap of his bag, shaking his head

from side to side. "I don't know what happened to Catra but I'm going to ask you to stay away from my sister. She has suffered enough. And it's not a suggestion"

Mara wants to say more but Adam is already turning away, rushing through the street until there is nothing more but cold pavement and the autumn's mist.

3.13 pm

"Do you think he could have be involved in the murder?" Serenia asks, huffing.

They are hiking in the woods, following the treacherous path that leads to the middle. They still have the map Adora had forgotten last night after they found the body, stained in mud and the light drizzle that had fallen at dawn. Now the air is much less humid, the ground and leaves dry, casting a welcomed shadow against the autumn sun.

"I don't think so," Mara jumps over a rock, scanning the ground and trunks around them with clinical gaze. The woods are calm, quiet besides the singing of the birds above their heads and the light drum of the river far away. Adora wasn't lying when she said nobody walked there. “Adam Grey seems very protective of his sister, I don´t think he would have done something to hurt Catrina if he knew they were friends.”

“But he didn't like her after all”

“That´s true too,” Mara stares at the infinite trees around them, covered in darksap and moss. It would be pretty easy to get lost in here if you didn't have a map or knew the way by heart. “You understand why the town hated Catrina, don´t you Serenia?”

“I´m afraid I do,” Serenia holds Mara´s eyes tenderly, understanding. She knows Mara´s story with this place, she understands better than no one else. “Hate can be very dangerous when there is nobody else to defend you.”

Mara clicks her tongue, looking up at the sun pouring from the trees. "This town, it ruins people. It takes away every chance that they could ever be happy" Mara scrunches to the ground, patting the soft surface of the green moss, the humid smell of fungi and dew filling her nose. She can see why the woods would be the perfect place to escape into, to lose themselves from the people of the outside or even to just live a stolen second with someone you love. “I want to find who did this, Serenia. I don't want it to happen again”

“It won´t,” Serenia kneels in front of Mara, taking her hand between hers. She is a good friend, the best friend Mara could have asked after everything that happened. Serenia pulls from their joined hands gently, guiding Mara back up. “Come on, we are almost there.”

They make their way inside the woods, past a thick line of trees that almost seem to separate the small field they walk into from the rest of the woods. In the middle,a tree house rises from the ground, built around the thickest trunks. It's covered in leaves, moss and bindweed, making it look like another part of the woods if you don´t pay enough attention, but maybe that is the whole point of it. Up close, Mara can see the wood has been darkened with the passage of time and rain, but the construction is neat and careful, done by someone that knew exactly what they were doing. There is a makeshift staircase that leads to the house, the steps dug inside the thick trunk, secured by lines of rope tightly knotted with each other. The house isn't that far from the ground, just enough that the branches full of leaves cast a barrier against the view from the exterior, hiding away the pallet that makes a floor of the treehouse and the open round door.

Mara sighs, slightly stretching her muscles before grasping the steps and starts climbing towards the house. The steps are slightly damp by the moss but it's well taken care of and low enough that Mara reaches the pallet pretty quickly, helping Serenia upwards too before turning to the entrance. They have to scrunch down to get in -it had clearly been built for kids height- but they finally managed to make it inside.

The walls are of simple wood but covered in old children's drawings and band posters, from Joan Jett to Annie Lennox down to Cyndi Lauper and Kate Bush, scattered around one of the walls. There are two cut up windows, partially covered by clumsily stitched brown curtains and one last bare wall against which there is a makeshift bed. It's nothing more than a comfortable single mattress that should have cost a kidney and a half to carry up, a handful of cozy blankets, and a halfway made knitted quilt, several pillows thrown around carelessly. In one corner there is a small table and a few closed baskets with unmade bags of popcorn, marshmallows and cookies, a very small pan, an even smaller grill and a dusty radio. As a whole, it looks like a small but cozy and safe space, well loved and quiet.

"Are you sure we shouldn't have asked Adora about this first?" Serenia asks, hesitating on the carpet at the entrance. Mara cleans the mud of her palms over her jeans, carefully stepping over the wood.

"Yes. We need check things first hand, we already lost a lot of time from the moment we found Catrina to now"

"Do you think the murderer could have cleaned their tracks?"

"That's exactly what I want to avoid," Mara looks around the treehouse, carefully starting to roam over the blankets. "Search for Catrina's bagpack or any personal item that we didn't find in her room. Specially that inhaler"

"Alright"

Serenia makes her way towards the table, looking through the few things there as Mara undoes the bed without luck. There is a lost sock behind one of the pillows and an empty bag of potato chips at the foot of the bed but nothing else.

"Hey, come look at this" Serenia calls. She has pulled back one of the curtains revealing a fishing cord hanging from side to side. There are several pictures clipped on it, some manually revealed,

others clearly taken by a Polaroid. Mara approaches behind Serenia, leaning towards the photographs to look closer.

It's like a time capsule, snapshots of a life together since Catra and Adora looked no more than six years old, all the way through primary school, middle school and high school. Festivals, town carnivals, Christmas dinners, strolls to the woods and hang outs on Razz's dinner. A few of them are of both girls through several Halloweens, dressed as ghosts, pumpkins, scarecrows, witches to Ghostbusters and, for a memorable one that looks no more than a few years ago, Michael Myers and Jason Voorhees, all costumes looking handmade and wrinkled with hours of playing around the woods.

There is one of them sitting at a table of what Mara supposes is the Grey's household. The table is full with food from turkey to several desserts, most of them on Catra's side. Adora's arm is thrown over Catra's shoulder, her other hand wrapped on the side of her face to pull her into a forehead smooch. Catra's face is scrunched in face disgust, weakly smudging Adora's cheek as she tries to push her face away. They look happy.

And then there is what looks to be the most recent one, a Polaroid in the far end of the string with a small scribble in the bottom. It's Adora and Catra again, it's always Adora and Catra, sitting on a table with pink linoleum, the back of the seat lined in bright blue. Mara recognizes Razz's Dinner by the yellow roof and the single half eaten pie in front of them. The light that pours from the windows makes it look like dawn time, the dinner looks empty besides them and there is the shadow of a wrinkled finger in the corner of the photo, probably from Razz's finger accidentally covering part of the eye of the camera. Adora and Catra are placed sideways in the seat, facing each other. Adora's hands are cradling Catra's face, keeping her close, the tip of their noses pressing together. Adora's eyes are closed, her smile wide, all teeth and pink lips. Catra's eyes are wide open, her smile is softer, more tender, staring right back at Adora with all her emotions written on her face, her hands cradled over Adora's chest. It's

bright, the photograph, just like the others, bright and honest. Mara looks at it and knows in an instant.

Mara looks at the date scribbled in the bottom of the photograph with a bold, black market.

October 28th, 1985

Just three days before Catrina's death.

"Take a look at this one," Serenia says, unclipping one photo from the string. She hands it back to Mara, pointing at the center of it when Mara raises her eyebrows without understanding.

"I stayed at the school after you went looking for the sheriff's son. The director wasn't happy with me asking questions to the students, probably because their parents would find out, so she let me check up some of the school's files," Serenia roams inside her leather satchel, taking out a yellow folder. "She didn't really care that I looked through Catrina's file. There were tons of excellent notes through high school. She had the highest grade point of the school and extracurricular activities in gardening and arts."

"Anything unusual at all."

"Probably the unusually high amount of professors complains," Serenia takes a single page, filled front and back with bold letters. "Insubordination, rebellious behavior, talking back to professors, arriving late to class. Lots of Saturday's detention too," Serenia frowns down to the paper. "There is a note at the end of this thing that says 'Reported fraternization outside school grounds' after which she was kicked out of extracurricular classes

"Last month, someone caught her forcing herself on someone behind this dinner. Everyone knew what she was after that" Mara hears the voice of Prime from earlier in the day inside her head, making her clench her hands over the photo.

"Anything about the time of this photo?"

"Not about her, it seems she was banned from assisting but some Ms. Darling. But here is what caught my attention," Serenia pulls another paper, the unicorn wings of the school logo printed in the corner in gray instead of the usual bright gold. It looks like a copy, wrinkled slightly in the corners. "I found this tucked somewhere in the school archives, it almost looked like they had tried to get rid of the originals but they forgot this one. There was a small incident in August, at the night of the prom. It seems that Prime Kurr made a bit of a scandal at the dance."

"Why?"

"He was named king of the prom. And guess who was named queen"

"Adora Grey," Mara mutters. Parts of the story start to click into place inside her head.

"Yes, except that when she was called for the coronation she wasn't in the school anymore. The report is very small but looks like Prime got angry when she didn't appear and stormed out of the gym where the prom was taking place" Serenia looks up from the paper, chewing on the inside of her cheek. "The outburst was the talk of the town for a few weeks so the sheriff must have made the school to erase all reports of it from his son's file

Mara frowns, saving the photo in the pocket of her jacket alongside the small plastic bag with the locket, giving one last look at the treehouse around them. "Alright, listen carefully"

August 28th, 1985

Prom Night

9.38 pm

"Adora," Glimmer groans, prolonging the last 'a' with a whine. She laces her arm with Adora's, bumping their hips together. "Could you please stop sulking and have a little fun for once?"

"I'm not sulking," Adora says weakly, letting her head fall against the gym wall she is leaning over.

Cindy Lauper is blasting in the gym, filled to the brim with seniors jumping and dancing with each other. There is glitter and colorful balloons and serpentines everywhere, the light of the disco balls shimmering over every part of the gym bleachers and the stage in the far end where the music is coming from the tall speakers. It's all a swirl of music, laughter and puffy dresses and yet Adora doesn't seems to be able to enjoy a single moment of it.

"You definitely are," Glimmer complains resting her cheek over Adora's shoulders. Usually she has to tiptoe to do this but with her high hot pink stilettos -she definitely wasn't wearing when she walked out of her mom's house-, it's a little bit easier.

Adora opens her mouth but thinks about it and doesn't say anything in the end, shrugging to rest it of importance. She is wearing a flowy pink dress her mother had bought for her before the accident, square earrings and turquoise boots. For once, Adora's hair is down, held tenderly behind her hair with pins, and she had makeup on, the bright blue of her eyeliner a colorful contrast with her eyes.

It's all Glimmer's doing, Adora didn't even want to come. She just wanted to snuggle in her room and watch horror movies with Catra until dawn.

"You shouldn't let it ruin today for you, you know?"

"Glimmer-"

"I'm just saying!" Glimmer raises her hands in surrender, twirling in her own purple dress. Bow, somewhere in the crowd, raises a hand and calls out for them excitedly, eyes bright as the rest of their friends dance in circles around him.

Glimmer waves back, smiling brightly, and starts walking towards him, throwing one last pleading look to Adora.

"I'm going to drink some punch, you go first," Adora murmurs quickly, straightening from the wall and walking towards the long table where snacks and bowls of bright sugary punch are placed.

"Ugh, fine. But don't take too long! The queen and king are about to be announced!"

"Yes, sure"

She hears Glimmer mumbling something behind her but doesn't pay attention to it, absently grabbing one of the plastic cups from the package and serving herself some of the drink. Maybe if she can hold up for just a few more minutes more she will be able to sneak out from the party without her friends making a fuss about it. She knows they want to go to the milkshakes after but, maybe if she is lucky, she can sneak to the treehouse and spend a little bit with Catra there.

Adora is so distracted by her thoughts that she doesn't notice Prime approaching her until she feels a heavy arm placed over her shoulders and a strong breath next to her face.

"Here you are, pretty," Prime slurs, pressing his chest against Adora's back. Adora is tall but he is somehow taller, towering over Adora and covering from the sight of the rest of the gym. Adora's eyes widen and then narrow, her lips pulling back into a scowl. She shrugs Prime's arm from her, trying to step forward without success, she is pressed between him and table.

"Don't touch me, Prime," Adora snaps at him, throwing a quick look at the dance floor. She can see her friends dancing in there, completely unaware of what's going on. Adora looks further for her brother but doesn't find him anywhere, probably already off the gym to escape the noise. Prime makes a disapproving noise, thumbing Adora's drink with one hand and wrapping his other one around her shoulder, harshly pressing over her skin.

"Behave, Adora. We are Eternia's couple, we are an example to the others" he hisses, digging his fingers against the delicate

fabric of her dress. Adora growls, pushing Prime back with her elbow and foot, using all her weight and height to make him stumble backwards, his hands slipping off her with the movement.

"Don't tell me what to do," Adora snaps at him, recoiling at the touch. "And we are not a couple, nothing ever close to that, and we'll never be, so stop it already."

Prime frowns, crossing his arms behind his back. Adora looks at him subtly cleaning his hand on the back of his trousers but gets distracted by the clicking of his tongue against his teeth when he leans on his ankles towards her. His expression shifts in a second, from sour and hateful to self condescending. He eyes Adora from head to toe, dragging his eyes over Adora's arms and torso in a way that makes her shiver with disgust, and smiles from ear to ear, roads of perfect white teeth like a shark about to eat.

"Come on Adora. You are so much more like me than you care to admit. I know you care about what this town thinks, we all do." Prime grasps Adora's chin between his fingers, tilting her head upwards almost sweetly, dishonest. "You have responsibilities with this town, I know you care about them. You are a First One, after all." Prime let's go off her chin, shrugging with a heavy sigh, still smiling widely. His eyes glimmer with something only he knows, making Adora shift uneasy in her feet. "You'll come around it eventually."

"Keep dreaming," Adora says, teeth tight and jaw set, which only earns her a chuckle from him. Prime's words drip down Adora's spine like little curses, tugging at the edges of her brain painfully.

Behind them, the music starts to slower down. Ms. Darling steps into the stage, all white swirls blonde hair, calling for the seniors to lower down their voices as they start to prepare for the king's announcement. Prime glances behind him, smirking as he runs a hand through his hair.

"Looks like that's our call," Prime whispers at Adora, looking from her face to some place near her hands and back. "I'll see you up there, pretty. I'm sure we are going to have a great night tonight."

He gives Adora another all too knowing look and then turns away, disappearing inside the crowd like a ghost.

Adora releases all the air she didn't notice she was holding, leaning over the food table with a stumble that makes the things tremble too. Her hands are shaking and her mouth is dry and she is holding the plastic cup so hard in her hand it's almost a miracle it hasn't folded under the grip. Adora drags a hand through her hair and tries to recover her breath without much luck. Her eyes sting with anxious tears and her heart is hammering inside her chest and yet nobody but her seems to have noticed what just happened, or maybe nobody cares.

Adora really, really doesn't want to be here.

Adora looks at the packet gym and sighs, staring down at her cold drink. Just a few more minutes. Her drink is sizzling a little, like a just opened soda bubbling from the bottom to the surface. Just a few more minutes and she is gone. Adora doesn't remember to have served herself soda, maybe the sticky syrup had it, maybe someone had actually put cheap alcohol in the punch after all. That's alright, she guesses, Adora needs some liquid courage. She just needs to survive this night of her life and she can forget all about it after.

Adora swirls her punch a few times and sighs, slowly raising it to take a long sip from it before joining the rest.

A long, delicate hand shoots out of nowhere from her darkness and covers the mouth of the cup completely before Adora can take a single drop, pushing it away from Adora's face and startling Adora half to death.

"Don't drink that," a voice comes from Adora's side as the owner of the hand steps out of the shadows of the back of the gym.

Adora knows this voice, Adora knows the smell of this hair and the softness of this face. Adora knows this freckled hand that now wraps around the cup, takes it off Adora's grasp, and throws it unceremoniously against the wall of the gym, staining the paint in artificial red. Adora knows this angry scowl when the girl Adora adores repeats her words. "Don't drink that shit."

Adora blinks down at her, barely registering her words or the thrown drink as Adora's face stretches into her first real smile of the entire day, honest and sweet, reaching her eyes like stars.

"Catra"

Present time

4.03 pm

"Let go of me! Let go!"

"Miss Grey, please calm down"

"Why are you so afraid that I tell you exactly what she is?!"

Serenia stops the car on the opposite side of the road, staring at the building across from them. Mara leans against her seat, frowning at the scene. The club house has been there since she was young, a white and sterile building done for the 'higher' families of the town to meet and, most of all, gossip and trash talk among themselves about others. It's a mud pit, a hell, done by rotten people for rotten people.

The usual calm and regal facade of the building is broken by a myriad of people gathered outside the glass door. Two young men are holding Adora Grey by the arms, who pushes them aside with so much force they stumble between themselves. Adora's hair is loose and wild, a hazelnut curtain that falls around her face and down her back in waves. She is wearing the same clothes as in the morning but her face looks even more exhausted, deep bags the side of thumbs below her blue eyes and hollow cheeks.

She spins in her ankles towards the crowd, pointing at someone in specific in the middle of them. The people part just enough for Mara to distinguish the red dress and long black hair of Mrs. Weaver, standing tall and unyielding in front of Adora with the sourest expression in her face.

"Tell them what you are! Tell them what you did to her!" Adora yells at the top of her lungs, marching to Weaver's until they are face to face. Adora's tan skin is red with the outburst, the rim of her eyes red and corneas bloodshot. Weaver doesn't even flinch at Adora's harsh tone, instead, melting her expression into something condescending.

"Adora," Weaver says, voice thick like rotten sugar, "please, we all know you are upset. You are so good Adora, so good. But don't do this to yourself. This is not who you are."

Weaver stretches her hand towards Adora's face, making a movement as if she were to cradle the side of her face between her long fingers. Adora's teeth snap close and she slaps Weaver's hand away so hard it echoes across the street. The people there gasp in surprise, some leaning among themselves to murmur in disapproval until Adora's voice picks up again, high and loud as an explosion.

"You are a monster," Adora accuses her, voice quivering. Her pupils are shrunk so much her eyes almost look white from far away, open, alert and furious. "You hurt her, you never did anything but hurt her."

"Catrina was far from a saint, Adora, everyone knows that," Weaver looks around her with a false look of sadness in her face, the people around them nodding in agreement. Even after everything, for the town, the victim isn't the dead girl but her victimized mother. "Sinful behavior must be corrected somehow."

"She loved you!" Adora exclaims, voice breaking completely. The crowd falls silent again and even Weaver seems slightly thrown aback. Adora's voice is ragged and broken in pieces when she

speaks next, barely even above an echo. "She loved you, you were her *mother."* Adora gulps, gasping for air. "You talk about nothing but how bad she was but that isn't true. She was so much more. She loved sunflowers and cats, she was sweet and kind and loving. You *know* that, why was it never enough for you?"

Next to the crowd, the pick-up from earlier speeds over the pavement of the street and stops in a rush, barely even missing the crowd at all. Adam jumps down the car and rushes through the crowd towards where his sister is as Weaver answers to her, not a sign of sadness or remorse in her voice.

"Love isn't enough to survive this world, Adora. You should know that better than no one by now. Didn't you hurt each other enough in the past?"

Adora recoils in pain, mouth open and closing speechless as her arms fall to the side. Adora's stunned expression crumbles into pieces and is replaced for something nasty, angry yes but also vengeful, full of sticky, rotten and rancorous.

"You are pathetic," Adora spats, so low Mara has to strain her ears to hear her. "You rotted with the fact that the man you wanted loved his daughter so much more than he ever loved you, and you could never live with the knowledge she was so much more and so much more important than you would ever be."

Weaver slaps Adora so hard her face tilts to the side with the force of it. Her cheek starts to color from pink to bright red, skin pulsing and warm with the hit. The crowd gasps loudly, truly surprised by the sudden hit -and probably also because this *is* Adora Grey and as Mara has come to learn, the town has set itself to hold her on impossible high standards among themselves-. Adora straightens up again, staring right back at Weaver, eyes hard. Her nose is dripping slightly with blood, staining the fabric of her sweater in spots of bright red.

"Should we do something?" Serenia whispers, holding the car wheel for the life of her, tense in her seat. Mara shakes her head

in negative, watching as Adam Grey makes it besides his sister. He wraps his hand around her arm, staring at Weaver for a second before pulling from her lightly.

"Adora, let's go," he murmurs between his teeth. When Adora doesn't move, still staring at Weaver menacingly, he pulls with more strength, dragging her with him. "Let's go."

Adam guides Adora through the crowd and down the street towards the car, ignoring the heavy looks and murmurs as they walk by. The people of the club surrender Weaver again, unsurprisingly still comforting her as they step inside.

Adora struggles with her brother, stomping in the ground clearly upset, growling something low enough that Mara can't understand. Adam stops suddenly and faces her, grasping her from the shoulders and shaking her a few times, trying to tame her trembling.

"Stop, 'Dora, stop," Adam huffs, catching her hands between his and holding them over his chest. Like this Mara can see just how much they are alike, from the strong shoulders to the eyes. Adam catches Adora's eyes with his, staring at her firmly. "What the fuck are you doing?"

"I never defended her, Adam," Adora says in a gasp, eyes teary. "Never, in front of anyone, not even at end. Who was defending her then, Adam, who?"

Adora hiccups around a sob, looking away angrily, her face wrinkled. Adam sighs, bringing her into a hug, cradling Adora's face between his hands and pressing a smooch on her forehead, tenderly rocking her from side to side. Adam raises his eyes suddenly, catching Mara's stare through the window of the car. Adam frowns, pressing one more kiss over his sister's temple and guiding her inside the car, throwing one last heavy meaningful look towards Mara.

"I'll take you home, come on," Adam mutters, helping Adora up before circling the car and jumping in two. They speed down the now mostly empty street without look back, the light of their headlights losing between the roads of trees.

"Do I follow them?" Serenia questions, already bringing the car back to life.

"Not yet," Mara straightens in her seat, looking ahead at the opposite direction where the siblings just went. "I just need to talk with Razz one more time. Then we'll go for her."

4.20 pm

The dinner is empty when they arrive. There is soft music coming from the radio, quite different from the cheerful usual tunes and the place smells just clean and warm, new pies being baked in the kitchen at the back. It's a rare occurrence, being the time and the day of the week, but Razz had turned the sign of the dinner to closed and given no other explanation but the 'need of some quiet in this town'.

Serenia excuses herself upstairs to ring Oscar and ask him if he has found something new. Mara tries not to roll her eyes in fond knowledge, taking a seat next to the window. Razz walks out of the kitchen, cleaning her hands over her apron and smiling brightly at Mara.

"Mara, deary, here is a freshly baked berry pie just for you!" Razz sing songs, placing the plate of warm dessert in front of Mara and sitting in the couch in front of her. Mara recognizes the seat from the treehouse's photo, the same blue seats and pink table.

"Thank you, Razz," Mara smiles at the old woman, honest and tender, taking a bite.

It's the calmest she's been the entire day, with the quiet music and Razz sweet hum as she starts knitting something across the table. It reminds Mara of her time living with where, when Razz

was the only one that offered to foster orphan scrawny Mara and supported her even after everything went down, even after Mara decided to leave. Razz is good, knew of the fee good people in town and Mara trusts her completely.

"Razz," Mara starts, leaving her fork to the side. The conversation is heavy so she places her hands in front of her, leaning slightly towards the woman to catch her attention. "Did you know Catrina Weaver?"

Razz looks up from her knitting, blinks a couple of times behind her round glasses as her face splits into a knowing smile. "Well, of course I know Catra! She comes all the time with dear Adora to eat my pies. She says she doesn't but I know her favorite is the cranberry one!"

Mara smiles swiftly at Razz's cheerfulness, shifting sadly on her seat to place a gentle hand over Razz's hands. Mara fights against the knot in her throat, dropping her voice when she speaks next. "Razz, do you know what happened to Catrina?"

Razz looks from their hands to Mara, dropping her knitting over the table slowly. Her eyes turn impossibly gentle and sad, watering in the corners as Mara has never seen her before. "Yes I know," Razz whispers, smiling sadly at some point above Mara's head. "My poor girls. They are the sweetest thing, they didn't deserve any of it."

Mara presses her lips into a thin line, rubbing her temple with her thumb with a headache has made its home. "Razz, people of the town say something happened in the alley of the dinner, something that made the town turn against Catrina. Do you remember about it?"

Razz's eyes return to Mara's face, still holding all the sadness of the world inside them. The old woman rests her wrinkled palm over Mara's cheek, caressing the curve of her cheekbone gently up and down, sinking her own warmth over Mara's colder skin.

"Dear Hope and you come all the time to eat too. I haven't seen her in such a long time though." Razz's eyes flicker with the weight of memories, making Mara feel eighteen again. Razz brushes her finger under Mara's eyelashes, studying her eyes with a wise stare. "You've cried so much already, Adora dearie. Everything will be well, you'll see."

Mara sighs, patting the back of Razz's hand fondly. She was hopeful but Razz was old, far older than anyone in the town knew, and sometimes things got mixed up. Mara leans back but Razz's touch turns tighter, keeping Mara in place with much more urgency.

"I saw what this town did to you, how it almost destroyed you, and Hope. I didn't want it to happen again" Razz says, quickly and alert, her wrinkled cheeks coloring in red with emotion. She looks both worried and sad and upset, dropping her hands down. "I told them to be careful, but you know how love is. And this is an old love, too deep to be kept quiet."

Razz takes her knitting again and continues as if she hadn't said anything at all, humming back under her breath as she gives the halfway done sweater another turn. Mara gulps, holding back her own tears. She hasn't cried in a long, long time but she was afraid this would hit too close to home, and it did.

"Razz?" Mara asks, shaky because she knows the answer but she must ask to do it right, for them. "Catrina was kissing Adora Grey, didn't she? That night? That's what people saw Catrina do, even if they didn't see Adora."

Razz presses her lips into a sad smile, patting Mara's hands gently. "People can be very cruel, Mara dearie, I think you can understand that more than anyone else" Razz’s eyes mist lightly. "They deserve a good ending. A kind one"

"They did," Mara agrees, gulping down the knot in her throat. "I promise I'll do my best for them"

“I know you will, dearie, we all do."

August 18th, 1985

10.02 pm

"Bye, Razz!"

"Bye, bye, Razz!"

"Goodbye dearies, be careful out there"

Catra and Adora walk outside the Dinner, giggling between themselves. Catra gives a few jumps over the puddles the rain left earlier, swirling around them with her eyes closed in a silent dance, humming to herself. Adora tries to follow her but trips on her own feet, barely caught by Catra's hands. They look at each other and erupt into a fit of hushed laughter, giggles and snorts hidden under the darkness of the dinner's alley.

Catra is a little bit drunk. Just a little bit, and so is Adora who is a lightweight from base. They didn't plan it but after ditched their idea of going to the roller skating rink, Adora snuck up a few bottles of pink, sparkling and severely sugary tasting alcohol that Catra had never seen before. Catra teased Adora about being a troublemaker and the last denied it all the way, but they ended it drinking them until the stars were spinning and they decided that a milkshake and pies from Razz were the absolutely best idea in the world.

The air is a little bit colder for Catra's liking, especially with her net thighs and short leather skirt but Adora doesn't seem to mind, wrapping Catra in her own jacket and soaking her sneakers with the puddles even after Catra's complaints.

The alley is darker than usual. The light of the street lantern broke a few weeks ago and nobody has fixed it so the warm light coming from Razz's Dinner is the only thing illuminating the short space. There is a talk wall full of green vines and tiny flowers on

the side of the brick wall, thick enough that if you are not careful you'll get sucked up into the leaves, a metal bench besides it, a few boxes of berries almost creating a fortress and the backdoor of the building that leads to the kitchen, halfway open.

Adora trips again, because her sight is shit in the dark, but Catra sees better on it so she keeps her straight, throwing Adora's arm over her shoulders to keep her from falling in her face.

"Come on, dummy, let's get you to your bed," Catra whispers to Adora, rubbing the low of her back with her other hand. Adora shakes her head, letting it fall against Catra's temple.

"No, I want to stay with you," Adora whines, pouting. Catra huffs, smirking besides herself.

"You can barely walk two steps without tripping, 'Dora, though that's nothing new for you," Catra teases her, rolling her eyes. Adora gives a dramatic gasp, turning in Catra's arms to face her completely.

"Take that back."

"No"

"Take it back," Adora repeats, smiling broadly. She snakes her arms around Catra's waist, cooing Catra's arms to rest over her shoulders. Catra returns her smiling, still shaking her head from side to side.

"Nope," Catra says, popping the 'p'. Adora sighs dramatically heavily, starting to step from side to side guiding them both into a quiet dance.

"You are a brat"

"And you are a troublemaker," Catra bites back, sliding one of her hands off Adora's shoulders to catch their hands together. Adora pokes her tongue out to her but doesn't fight it, letting Catra set the pass.

They swirl into a circle over the rain puddle, staring at each other in silence. Adora smiles tenderly at Catra, resting her nose and chin over Catra's forehead, breathing in the smell of her hair.

"You should be a ballerina," Adora whispers absently, letting her face fall in Catra's neck.

"Sure," Catra mumbles, strained and tender because Adora remembers. Because Adora is the only one that knows that, before life went to shit, Catra wanted to dance. "Maybe in my next life."

"Or this one," states Adora with a feather kiss. Catra smiles but doesn't answer to it, humming an errand tune for both of them as they follow their impromptu dance.

Adora raises her head suddenly, staring down at Catra tenderly. Her hair is loose from it's usual cheerleader ponytail, tucked all inside a pink knitted hat that Razz gifted her last Christmas. It makes the almond shape of her eyes and the blue of her iris to shimmer almost silver under the dinner's light. Catra gulps, naturally nervous as every time that Adora looks at her like this. Adora rests Catra's hands back over her shoulders, moving to cradle Catra's face between her both palms. She leans towards Catra until their noses press against each other's cheeks, her blue eyes closing slowly, stopping just far enough that the crown of their lips barely brush against the other.

" Te adoro, *Catra," Adora whispers against Catra's lips, speaking in the language Catra's father taught his daughter and that then Catra taught Adora, because they were in love.*

"Adora," Catra whispers, slightly out of breath, her heart thundering in her eardrums, swelling tenderly. She can smell the berries and milkshake in Adora's breath and feel the warmth of her parted mouth as Adora breathes her in. "Adora, we are outside."

"I know", Adora answers, just as shaky and soft as her. "It's just us, it's alright"

"But," Catra tries though her own hands betray her, grasping the fabric of Adora's sweater and bringing her close, "Adora-"

"Shh"

Adora kisses her like the first time - thirteen and in the darkness of their treehouse - Out of breath, warm and sweet.

They are older now, they've kissed more times than Catra dares to admit she has count - she has - but it still makes Catra's lungs sing and her heart to tremble with all the emotions of that first day.

Catra tangles her fingers behind Adora's nape, pulling her closer until they are pressed together completely. Adora smiles against Catra's lips, pressing one, two, five, more tiny kisses all over her mouth, the divot of her nose, the freckles in her cheeks, the space below her eyes, back to her open mouth once more. Catra sighs against Adora's tongue, this time following Adora's steps as the latter pushes her softly backwards, towards the wall full of autumn flowers.

Everything people think they know about Adora is wrong. She doesn't like following rules, she doesn't like being their good golden girl and she is definitely not perfect. Adora is a fire burning slowly, flames concentrating into a reduced space until one day they will explode in pieces. Adora is a troublemaker, she likes to break things and break rules, has anger issues, screams and curses and snorts. They didn't know Adora after her parents died, didn't know her fury or her sorrow, Catra did. Catra held her through it when nothing else could have. Catra knows this about Adora better than she knows anything about herself, even knowing that Adora has to spend more and more time with her other friends, Catra is stubborn enough to pride herself that nobody else knows Adora like she does. All of this tamed fire, Catra tastes it every time Adora kisses her, hard and wet and

desperate, pulling from her curls and biting on her lip until she is sure Adora has left lipstick marks smudged all over Catra's face.

For Catra, for whose vulnerability is such a tender spot, sometimes Adora's fire is as exhilarating as it is too much. That's why Adora, even as they burn together, always takes her time to gently distract Catra from her own head. Like now, between open mouthed kisses, when she tickles her in the side cheerfully.

Catra chuckles in the middle of the kiss, slapping Adora's hand away just to dissolve in even more laughter when Adora tickles her again. Catra growls playfully under her breath, grasping Adora's shoulders and turning them over so now Adora is the one pressed against the wall. Adora gasps delighted and suddenly sober up, circling Catra's waist above her skirt. Catra smiles at her and then leans forward, latching her mouth and teeth on Adora's neck, right above her collarbones where she knows the turtle neck of her sweater will cover the lovebites. Adora gasps and sighs, resting her palms over Catra's shoulder blades with a drowsy smile.

If the night hadn't been that quiet, Catra wouldn't have heard them, but she does. Adora's dreamy sighs hide the echo of their laughter for a while but once they are closer to the Dinner, too close, Catra's fine ears catch the sound. It's a group, loud voices and cackles that make the quiet street fill with noise. Catra thinks she recognized them and it's with a sickening shiver that she remembers that there was a basketball game tonight and Razz's dinner is the last open place besides the arcade. Catra's body locks into sudden, frightful, terrible panic and by the time her mind catches to her limbs is already too late.

"Hey, who 's that?!" someone yells, making the steps of the group stop right at the mouth of the alley. Catra's heartbeat stops, fear washing all over her body like cold water.

"Fuck, fuck," Catra mutters, grabbing Adora's shoulders tightly and pressing her face against Adora's cheek to try and hide her

from view. Adora hums a soft questioning sound, still lost in emotions.

"Who's making out there, darlings?!" comes another mocking voice, slightly closer as the group tries to look better who it is. Adora stills suddenly, tensing when realization of what's happening falls over her.

"Catra- " Adora whispers, urgent and scared, cut short by Catra's quick hand over her mouth.

"Shh," Catra hushes her, terrified, still pressed flush against Adora. Catra is trembling from head to toe, facing the wall as she tries to think of a way out. There is warmth on her left side, the familiar smell of Razz's pies coming from the open back door. Catra opens her eyes, holding her breath.

"Come on, children! Share a little!" says a third voice, accompanied by a fit of whistles and finally, by a voice Catra recognizes clearly.

"Forgive my friends," Prime calls, laughing slowly, satisfied. Catra knows he can see the shape of her curls, there is no way Catra is getting out of this. Adora knows too because her hands tighten around Catra's waist, shivering. "It's just, there is something so familiar about you. Why don't you step into the light with your boyfriend and join us in our celebration?"

Catra feels Adora shift into her arms, resolution settling in her muscles, and her mind locks into place.

"Fuck it," Catra thinks or maybe even growls, grabbing Adora and pushing her off the wall and through the open door. Adora trips and falls hard into the tiles of the kitchen, gasping in surprise. Before she can even recover her breath or jump back into her feet, Catra is already closing the door shut, locking it from the outside and silently thanking Razz for the thick material of the doors.

“Hello?” Prime asks again, this time clearly displeased to be repeating himself. Catra barely has time to run a hand over her hair to try and compose herself, walking into the light pouring from the windows.

“Prime,” Catra calls back, crossing her arms over her chest. She gets the swift satisfaction of Prime’s surprised face which gives her just enough confidence to tilt her head impatiently, silently begging for Adora to not do something stupid. “You called?”

Prime’s raised eyebrows drop, studying Catra from head to toe. His upper lip retracts over his gums, tongue running over his teeth as he stares at her, making Catra want to recoil in disgust.

“Weaver,” Prime says, giving a step closer towards Catra. He drags his eyes from her face to the wall behind her, narrowing his eyes at the now closed door. Prime’s friends - more like a couple of Prime’s classmates that follow him everywhere like some shit cult - are not far behind, their mocking whistles and smirks now gone, replaced by blank stares. Catra gulps and steps back, suddenly feeling cornered. “Who was with you?”

Catra bites down her fear, twitching her tongue in annoyance at him. "Not your fucking business, daddy's boy."

Prime's face falls, anger flaring on his green eyes. Catra cheers herself internally for it, she knows how much it stings him that he is only respected for being the son of the sheriff. Prime must know exactly where Catra's mind is going because he opens his mouth again, probably to snap some insult hidden in fake wisdom, when one of his followers beats him to it, narrowing his eyes to Catra as he looks at her better. She doesn't even know his name, they all look the same.

"Fucking hell. Is that a lipstick mark in your neck, you weirdo?" The question takes Catra by surprise, she wants to ignore him but she can't help herself when she immediately raises her hand towards her neck, eyes wide. Prime's pupils shrink, almost turning

into slits. He stares at Catra with renewed sharpness, baring his teeth.

"Damn, was she kissing a fucking woman?" says another one, around a chuckle, with just enough dread that fires up the rest. The group follow him immediately, murmuring between themselves and towards Catra with clear disgust in their faces.

"I always knew she was a freak"

Catra's face flushes in humiliation. She is not a stranger to insults and harsh words, the witch is her mother after all. And she is not ashamed of who she is, Catra had known what she is since the first time she laid eyes on Adora's dumb, pretty face. But this is different, this is so much worse, this is a violation to the fragile privacy Catra had managed to keep safe under layers and layers of rebellion and bite. Catra knew what happened next for her in this town from the moment she heard the laughter near the alley. She had been strained here before but now she had no chance at all to make it out of here alive, the town was going to eat her alive one way or another. But at least, Catra would take the hit alone and not Adora.

Absently, Catra wonders if Adora's hero complex hasn't rub on her way too much - it hasn't, she is doing it for completely different reasons than that -

Prime steps into Catra's space, grasping her chin between his fingers and pulling from her face harshly. Cayta exhales in surprise, struggling against Prime's steel grip, clawing at his arm with increasing alarm. She knows what he is seeing because she saw Adora reapplying her lipstick before walking out of the diner, cheerful and red, perfect like a rose and then smudged like petals all over Catra's mouth. Prime stares at the low of her face and then up, directly into her eyes, shaking her from side to side almost violently.

"Who was with you?" Prime whispers, low and dangerous like a venom snake. Catra's heart is hammering inside her chest, fear

clouding her eyes into tiny, pricking tears. She wraps her hand around Prime's wrist and tugs from it, trying without luck to free herself from his grasp.

"Don't fucking touch me" Catra growls, tugging from him again.

"Who?" Prime snaps, spitting slightly in his anger, wrinkling the collar of Catra's jacket between his fist. Except that the soft, red fabric it's not hers, it's Adora. Adora's jacket.

Catra makes a sound on her throat and pushes Prime back with all her strength, finally freeing herself. Catra leans against the window of the dinner, holding herself to the old brick until it digs into the skin of her palms. She doesn't know if Prime recognizes the jacket, maybe he doesn't at all, but Adora wears the same godforsaken thing all the time.

Prime's group has fallen quiet, following his steps as they surround Catra, cutting her from all her exits. They may insult her again, or scream at her, or beat her, Catra doesn't know,babe doesn't care, she cares only to distract Prime from the jacket and everything that could make him think of Adora at all.

"What are you going to do? Ask your minions to beat me because you are too much of a coward to do it yourself?" Catra is aware she shouldn't be taunting the devil but is the only thing she can think to do. One of the boys, the one that had insulted her first, steps forward and grabs her by the collar of her shirt, slamming her back against the window so hard the glass trembles. Catra winces, exhaling with the wave of sudden pain but still bursts a single, breathe, cackle, ignoring the boy and staring right back at Prime. "I knew it, you are so predictable."

The way he is looking at her it's scaring her a lite bit she holds it, barely even flinching when Prime clicks his tongue and the boy raises his fist towards Catra's face, ready to hit.

"What in hell's name is going on here?!"

The door of the dinner slams open and Razz walks out, apron stained in flour still on and wielding a broom over her head menacingly. Catra looks towards her, alarmed, but for her relief the door closes behind her and nobody else comes out. Razz marches towards the group, all long 70's pink dress and high hair, swinging the stick of the broom like a sword. The group flinches, dropping Catra against the window and retracting on their steps immediately, raising their hand in surrender. Prime doesn't moves though, still looking at Catra as if her could look straight through her.

"Madam Razz," the boy that tried to hit Catra calls, looking from Razz to Catra and back to Razz, "do you even know what kind of people are you letting on your establishment?"

Anger washes back over Catra and she opens her mouth to fight back, but Razz's thin, old hand wraps around her wrist and pulls from her with surprising force, tethering Catra behind her in one swift pull. Catra almost trips with the floor, barely holding herself to the back of Razz's dress.

"The only thing I see are a couple of boys I've seen since diapers raising problems where there is none," Razz says, lowering her broom and raising her chin. Her accent is thicker when she gets angry and she has only gotten this angry on very counted times. The group looks at each other, uncomfortable and clearly taken aback.

"But she is a f-"

"I know you," Razz snaps, pointing at the group with her long finger. Somehow, she looks even more dangerous now than with the broom, even as little as she is in height towering over them completely. The boys recoil, unable to look away from Razz's heavy, disappointing stare. "I know you and I know your parents. I've seen you since you were babies to grow in what? Bullies. Intimidators. Tyrants." This time, she turns towards Prime, standing right in front of him. He has the decency to look taken aback, grimacing down at the old lady. "Especially you, Prime Kurr.

I knew your mother, I expected you to be better than your father ever was with her, but now I see I was wrong."

It must hit something because Prime grinds his teeth, closing his hands into fists at his sides. The group looks at him, waiting for some sign on what to do until he snaps his face to the side, digging his hands inside his jacket and starting to walk away.

"Let's go," he orders them, turning around just enough to look at Catra once more. "We'll deal with 'that' later."

The group starts to follow him towards an expensive looking car Catra hadn't seen, parked across the street. Razz turns around and gently but insistently pushes Catra back until they reach the back door, opening it just a jar and cooing her inside.

"Go back from where you came from, freak!" The group yells to Catra one more time, humiliating further before hopping inside the car. Catra flinches - she can't help it - holding the frame of the door until her knuckles turn pink.

"Come on, dearie, inside. I'll stay here for a while," Razz whispers reassuringly to her, closing the door shut right after Catra steps inside the diner's kitchen.

Adora catches immediately, arms already open to hold her between them. Catra feels it all like in a nightmare, she doesn't even notice how bad she is shaking until Adora hushes her gently, rocking her from side to side softly.

"It's alright, it's alright. You're safe now," Adora's face is flushed and her voice strangled. She is trembling too, she looks completely disheveled. Her eyes are open like a deer in the headlights and she is panting heavily, holding Catra against every part of her body she can physically can, pressing her so hard against her chest that, with a little bit of luck, they may be able to fuse into one. "I'm so sorry, I'm so sorry, sol *. This is all my fault. I tried to go but Razz wouldn't let me, I'm sorry."*

Catra's teeth are still tethering together but it slowly starts to lower down, just enough for her to exhale heavily against Adora's chest. Catra wraps her arms around Adora's waist, counting on her head her breathing. She feels Adora shift around her, roaming in the pockets of Catra's skirt until she finds her inhaler, gently placing it over Catra's lips and helping her press it.

"You are okay, Cat, just feel my chest and breathe, alright? Breath with me." Catra is definitely not okay, she is not going to be okay in a long time. Things will only get worse and she knows Adora knows it too. But just for a little longer, she lets herself be wrapped in the fake safety that is Adora's hold and care as she helps her breath. Adora has done this a thousand times before and she has been sweet on each one of them, even when nobody had taught them before and she didn't really know what she was doing. So Catra follows her, feeling the rise and fall of Adora's breathing under the pad of her fingers.

Absently, she hears the back door open and close again, making her tense until she feels Razz's thin hand over her back. She hears Adora and Raz talk about something but can't quite place the words. Adora is still trembling. Catra is trembling. The world feels like crumbling in the edges and she can still taste the faint shadow of Adora's cherry lipstick on her mouth.

Present time

6.00 pm

The door of the Grey House is blue. It wouldn't be such a big statement if Mara didn't know exactly what kind of neighborhood it was located in. Roads of pretty white houses with pretty yards and red front doors and windows. The Grey House was, by far, the biggest most luxurious one, a three floor thing with green vines hanging from the balcony rails and tinted windows next to the door. It's the furthest away of the rest, right next to the woods, and it somehow looks both like the house with more soul and yet also the saddest one of the road.

Mara knocks on the door a second time, staring at the wood as Serenia looks at the neighborhood around them. She catches the glimpse of curtains pulled back and curious gazes from the neighbors. The gossip won't take long to spread around the town.

Finally, the door opens with a swing, Adora standing on the other side. She is still wearing the sweater with drops of dry blood on them but she has cleaned her face and pulled her hair back with a black diadem, making her eyes look bigger and even more tired. She stares at Mara without saying a word, resting her forehead against the frame of the door.

"Adora," Mara greets her, almost sweetly, trying to not sound too overwhelming. Adora doesn't buy it because her dark eyebrows frunce, looking from Mara to Serenia and back.

"Do you know who did this to her?" Adora asks, not even greeting her back. Her voice is worn and ragged, and the hit on the side of her face is red, slightly scratched by Weaver's nails. For Mara, it looks kind of familiar.

"I can't tell you that yet, Adora," Mara answers softly. Serenia walks inside the house without another word, circling Adora and climbing the white stairs that lead up. Adora's frown just deepens at that, clearly displeased by it,

"Hey, what are you doing?" she calls after Serenia without receiving an answer. She turns back to Mara, shifting uncomfortably on her feet, opening and closing her hands at her sides. Her face is angry now. "What are you doing? What do you mean?"

"I need to speak to you first." Adora grips the frame of the door tightly, looking behind Mara. Mara follows her eyes and realizes most of the neighbors have started to walk outside their houses, standing in their front yards and staring at them accusatory.

"Mara," Serenia calls her softly, turning her attention back. She is standing at the top of the stairs holding something in front of her. "Look"

It's a black backpack, worn out in the seems with patches of rock bands over the front and the straps. It's quite different from the white fabric of the bag next to the open arc that leads to living room with Adora's initials on it. Adora let's go of the door, facing Serenia with an angry scowl. Her hands are backed into fists.

"What are you doing with that?" Adora asks, almost yells, giving one step further. Outside, a few of the neighbors are starting to get closer, getting called to the scene like flies to the rot. "Leave that"

"Adora," Mara murmurs, low and firm, wrapping her hand around Adora's upper arm. Adora snaps her head towards her, pulling without use, Mara doesn't let her go. "I'm gonna need you to come with me."

Adora stares at her until her tan face turns pale, tiny tears burning in the corner of her eyes with fury. "Do you really think I did something to her? Is that what this is?" she yells, her voice high and angry.

The neighbors hear her because they turn to whisper with themselves, some of them walking back inside their houses. *That's not good* , Mara thinks with dread. If any of all of them call the sheriff she would probably lose her chance to speak with Adora and solve all the blank spaces in the story.

"Adora," Mara repeats, tightening her grip when Adora tries to slam her hands away. The girl shakes her head, divided between releasing herself from Mara's grasp and reach Serenia still in the stairs.

"How could you ever think I hurt her?" Adora whimpers, low and almost betrayed, shaking her head from side to side.

"Adora," Mara growls, firmer, holding Adora's both shoulders between her hands. Adora snaps her mouth shut, staring at Mara with wide eyes. "I know, alright? I *know*"

"You don't know anything at all" Adora gasps, baring her teeth.

"I do" Mara snaps, making sure Adora is actually listening to her. Something shifts in Adora's eyes, a spark of some kind of realization, but her entire body remains tense, gazing between the neighbors and Mara's face. "You need to come with me, alright? Come on"

Adora doesn't fight her anymore but she looks clearly unhappy as Mara guides her down the house's porch. Mara knows this doesn't look good at all, with Adora's blood stained sweater and two detectives leading her to the back of their car, but they've already crossed the opportunity to be discreet at all. To be fair, there wasn't a very realistic expectation for that after everything that had happened on the day.

Mara closes the back door behind Adora in silence, eyeing upside. The entire neighborhood is in movement now, windows shining with the inner lights and people walking towards each other's houses, pointing at the car and them. Adora sees them too, staring at the front of the car with her arms crossed above her chest. There are tears running down her eyes and she is sickly pale but she also doesn't look very excited to ask her neighbors for help.

"I'll stay here," Serenia whispers to Mara after leaving the backpack into the copilot's seat, "to tame things a little. Just be quick."

"Alright," Mara stares at one small group of neighbors that had gathered together, already crossing the street towards them. "Be careful"

Mara gets into the car just in time for the group to be intersected by Serenia, who raises her arms to the sides and starts shaking

her head in negative, speaking slowly at them as if they were mere screaming babies. Mara can barely hear them over the sound of the engine turning on but she thinks she can distinguish the faint yells of some women demanding to know where Adora was being taken. She is almost sure she can also hear a few people loudly calling Adora “perfect girl” and “poor thing”. A quick glance at Adora’s sour expression on the rear view mirror tells Mara she hears them too.

Mara steps into the throttle and speeds down the street, avoiding way too many neighbors in sandals and night robes just standing in there. Mara drives in silence through the streets, the radio off, windows pulled up. She knows the paths of this town like the back of her hand - it hasn’t changed a bit in twenty years - so she knows exactly where to go to get some kind of privacy. Mara looks through the mirror at Adora a couple of times, studying her reflection under the darkness of the car, but Adora never speaks, just looking at the woods and houses passing by.

Mara turns around the furthest of the neighborhoods, past the town’s library into the very limits of the town. It was a safe spot for her in her younger years just as the woods were for the girls. It would be enough for now.

Mara stops the car next to the abandoned park behind the library, turning it off. The lights of the car die down and everything falls into a deeper silence. Mara looks through the mirror but Adora doesn't look back, gaze fixed in the door on the side of her seat, eyebrows furrowed and mouth set in a tight line. There are tears lines over her face but the crying has stopped, overcome only by the clear anger in her face.

Mara sighs and gets out of the car, circling the back so she can reach the back door, opening it for Adora.

"Come on" Adora finally raises her face towards her frowning. She looks around them, studying the abandoned park overgrown with trees and grass barely illuminated by the street lights and the quiet street in front of them.

"Aren't you taking me to the sheriff's office?"

"I am not"

"Then why-?"

"Because I need to speak to you" Mara says again, opening the door wider.

Adora is still frowning but she steps out of the car, following Mara with her eyes as the detective takes the black backpack through the window and motions her towards the park. They sit in one of the benches, one in front of the other. The wood is slightly swollen by years of humidity and abandonment but otherwise is intact, the same narrow picnic tables and low benches.

Adora roams with the pockets of her red jacket, fishing a cigarette and a lighter from it. She lights it up, taking a puff and exhaling, smoke crawling on her skin and making her wrinkle her nose. Mara raises her eyebrows, surprised.

"Didn't think you were the kind of person that smokes"

"Why? Because I'm Adora Grey and I'm fucking perfect?" Adora snaps, slamming the lighter against the table. Mara just glares at her so Adora huffs, taking another puff before taking the cigarette off her mouth, glancing down at it as if it were full of mysteries or sins. "To be honest, I fucking hate it." Adora mutters, squeezing the lighted end against the wood, effectively extinguishing it. "But then again, maybe it will kill me faster, so I don't really see the downside on that"

Mara grimaces at the comment but Adora doesn’t seem to care in the slightest, tucking her hands back into her pockets. "You've been smoking for a long time?"

Adora shakes her head, shrugging as she stares at the trees around them. "It's my first in over a year," she says, uninterested. There are moles in her face, scattered like tiny kisses over her

cheek and forehead. "I started out of curiosity, the rest of the cheerleader team does it a lot. It got worse after my parents"

"Then what made you leave it for so long?"

"Catra had asthma" Adora's voice trembles, the corner of her eyes wrinkling when she narrows her eyes in sorrow. "I didn't want it to affect her. And she hated it as a whole. She got so angry at me when she found out I had been smoking in secret, she would always scold me if she saw me smoking with the other cheerleaders"

"I guess not everything was exactly good with the team after all," Mara comments, leaning back on the benchmark trying to relax her limbs into something more approachable for the girl. Adora narrows her eyes at her further, running her tongue over her teeth.

"I don't know if you have noticed but nothing in this town is exactly what it seems to be," Adora says slowly. Mara smiles at her without really reaching her eyes, tilting her head to the side.

"I noticed it after seeing the lack of any kind of empathy," Mara knows Adora understands what she means, she can see it in the drop of her shoulders and the fire of her eyes. Mara sighs, leaning over the table and slightly towards Adora, placing both of her palms over the wood to let her know she means no harm. "I'm sorry you couldn't say goodbye"

Adora holds her eyes just enough to see tears start gathering in her eyes again before averting her gaze.

"Yes, well, life isn't fucking fair" Adora mumbles to her hands, scratching the wood with her bare nails. It must hurt but she does it again, maybe to ground herself, maybe to feel anything at all. Mara sighs, silently and gently pulling the photograph from her jacket and the small plastic bag she brought from the mortuary, taking out the tiny locket from it and warming it inside her palm.

“Where is your brother, Adora?” Adora frowns, looking at Mara unsure.

“In a pre-game party with the rest of the school seniors" Adora says, "I know he talked with you earlier

"He did," Mara agrees, "He asked me to stay away from you."

Adora grimaces, setting her jaw."I-"

"I don't think you killed Catrina"

Adora snaps her mouth shut, eyebrows raised. She stutters, lost of words until she manages to whisper, "Then why-?"

"Catrina had this with her the day she died"

The delicate golden chain is still stained with mud but the tiny heart shines through it when Mara places it in front of her. Adora's hand shoots towards her neck immediately, grasping the start of a matching golden chain around her neck, hidden under the layers of her sweater. The motion is so honest and unconscious it says to Mara everything she needs to know about Adora. "Oh"

"Everyone I've spoken to, they all say the same things. How Catrina Weaver was this bad person for the town's society, how she never followed their rules, how she was a bad influence for your life and your future" Mara repeats the people's words, making sure her disgust and disagreement of them come through in her voice. By the surprised shine in Adora's eyes, she thinks she manages to do it. "But that isn't the truth, is it Miss Grey?"

Mara pulls the photograph from below the table, a tiny square that she slides over the wood next to the locket. Catra is in the middle, smiling brightly at the camera, life and love written over her features as Adora leans next to her on the other side, pressing a surprise kiss in Catra's cheek. Their hairs are disheveled for dancing, Catra's thin red blouse and suit trousers wrinkled, Adora's pink dress ruffled in places and the small bouquet of flowers in her hair long ago ruined. It's prom night, but the

background is wrong, not the gym or the school's makeshift stage, but fairy lights and the wood walls of a treehouse on which two girls used to escape to when they were kids and that it had become that night, as many others before, on their dance floor.

Adora gasps at the photograph, running the pads of her fingers gently over the surface, so gently her skin barely brushes the colors, following the paths of Catra's hair and mouth inside the frozen memory, a frugal fragment of time where Catra lives only now. Fresh tears fall down the wood, barely avoiding the picture at all as they run across Adora's cheeks freely.

"I know what it feels like," Mara starts, dropping her detective posture into something more loose, more like the person she used to be before this town did the same to her than it did to them. Adora looks at her through her eyelashes, silent. "Wanting to be with someone more than anything in the world and having to hide it. Being afraid. I know that is like"

Another wave of tears washes down Adora's face and she doesn't even bother in trying to stop them, pulling from the chain on her heck until the matching lock of Catrina's tickles free from the fabric, warm from being tucked next to Adora's heart for so long.

Adora takes a breath, returning Mara's sad gaze as she whispers slowly.

"Have you ever loved someone madly?"

August 28th, 1985

Prom Night

9.53 pm

"You brought your bike!" Adora exclaims, delighted. Catra grins from ear to ear as she pulls her bike from the bushes behind the gym. It's an old, beaten up thing with the metal painted fire red and a small metal skull on the rear. Catra is very proud of it,

signaling at it with a proud gesture as she makes a deep bow to Adora.

"A carriage fit for a Queen" Catra says, smirking until the dimple of her cheek flourishes like a cheeky secret kiss. Adora rolls her eyes at her, pushing Catra's shoulder playfully as she picks up the skirt of her dress and hops on the back seat of the bike.

"I'm not even sure they are going to name me Queen" Adora mutters, careful not to tangle her dress on the wheels. Catra huffs, resting her hands against either side of her hips, tilting them to the side with an incredulous expression in her face,

"Uh, they totally will. I bet they are already in that ridiculous stage calling your name" Catra establishes, approaching the bike with a sprint in her step. "And I'm *stealing her from them"*

Adora smiles at her, quiet as Catra makes her way to the front seat. She doesn't really want to talk about the slimy, uncomfortable sensations Prime's encounter had left on her, not now that she is finally with Catra in the place she really wants to be. Instead, Adora wraps her arms around Catra's waist, holding her tightly as the girl grabs the handles of the bike.

"Come on, prince charming, take us to the woods in your noble steel" Adora says to Catra's ear, resting her cheek over her shoulder. Catra blushes deeply but still scoffs, shaking her head until her carefully pampered curls bounce against Adora's nose, making her giggle.

"You are such a dork"

The journey to the woods is known and calm, they've done it dozens of times before. Yet this one feels different, freeing, as they leave the packet gym behind them without a word, with its dizzying loud music and flashing lights that make Adora's head hurt and her mind to be everywhere at once and its fake people with their expensive clothes and fake crowns. Adora rather be here, getting the soles of her boots dirty with the mud that

splashes from the ground and her perfectly curated hair messy with the fresh nocturnal breeze.

Catra takes the path through the newer neighborhoods where most of the houses are empty and halfway built and there is nobody that may sneak up on them. After what happened at Razz's dinner, Adora had turned borderline paranoid. She had seen first hand how cruel the town had been after Prime had spread the story, raising lies about what had happened so the town would hate her. How nasty they looked at Catra, what terrible things they said at her back. Adora had made her best, trying to stay with her most of the time, shelter her from them and their glares that only got worse any time Catra was close to Adora. And yet, Adora's best was not enough. She saw the flinch of Catra's shoulders under the weight of the words, the press one her lips at the stares - the flourish of her skin at the hits they didn't talk about but couldn't ignore either as Adora tended them with tears in their eyes - Adora felt guilty, nasty, of had let Catra carry it all, the hate and the rejection, but Catra didn't agree.

"We are almost out, Adora," she would say any time Adora even suggested coming out too, "We are so close. Once the year ends we will be out of here and then we will be free, " and then in a more strangled voice she would add, "I need you well and I need you alive, Adora. We protect each, remember? Let me protect you with this, this time"

They make it most of the way inside the woods with the bike until the roots and stones make it too difficult to move on. After that, Adora helps Catra guide the bike on foot as Catra holds up the hem of her dress, avoiding most of the mud puddles and moss until they reach the limits of their treehouse.

Adora rests the bike on the side of the big trunk, climbing the narrow logs nailed in the wood that serves them as stairs until she is sitting in the pallet. Adora immediately fumbles with her shoes, taking them off and dropping them to the side as Catra makes her way up too, more graceful and quick than Adora ever could. Catra

helps herself out of her shoes too, taking Adora's hand and pulling from her between laughter inside the treehouse.

Adora is about to say something witty and smart when they step inside, all the air ribbed from her lungs suddenly. Catra has hung Christmas lights through the entire roof of the house, hanging low and illuminating the tiny place gently. Little snowflakes, stars and even one or two snowmen all shining in golden light over the place. There are two bottles of lemon mountain dew in the corner, a bowl filled with sour gummies - the kind Adora loves and Catra tolerates - and clear plastic cups next to it. Adora doesn't know where Catra got all this from, but she doesn't really care.

"Wow," Adora marvels in a whisper, smiling broadly as she turns to stare at Catra's flushed face. "I knew you were just as corny as me deep inside."

"Ugh, shut up will you?" Catra groans, rolling her eyes and crossing her arms over her chest, though the perpetual blush on her face gives her away. Adora snickers, shrugging as she steps inside Catra's space, tangling her fingers behind her neck. She smells good, like lavenders and soap.

"Softie," Adora repeats in a whisper, drinking down Catra's annoyed scowl with a kiss. Catra wants to fight it for the first two seconds but gives in, melting around Adora's hands like butter to the flame. Catra always kisses like this, tense at first and then free as water, lips perpetually cold and tongue soft against Adora's teeth. It's been more urgent lately, since the dinner, on those secret, stolen moments at the top of this little spot of the world that is theirs. Adora likes to tangle her fingers in the base of Catra's neck and press her close every time to let her know that she is here and that she is hers.

Catra hiccups against her mouth, parting just enough to recover her breath against Adora's collarbones, blinking out of the drowsy mist in her eyes before huffing and pinching Adora's nose with her fingers swiftly.

"Ouch!"

"Stop trying to distract me, dumbass" Catra complains between her teeth, shrugging out of her suit's jacket to leave it somewhere over the makeshift bed. Adora wrinkles her nose, a little out of words at the sudden sight of Catra's shoulders under the thin streaks of her blouse. Seriously, that suit has no right to fit her the way it does.

"Uh, pretty sure I'm not the one distracted here," Adora says with a smirk at Catra's uncharacteristically clumsiness after the second time she tries and fails to detangle her hoop earrings from her hair.

"I'm going to kick you out of this tree"

"No you won't," Adora chang's sweetly, helping Catra gently out of her mess, smothering the dear curls back into place with a kiss over Catra's temple. "Are you going to tell me what was all that with the drink at the gym?"

Catra grimaces, the shadow of something that calls for nothing good clouding her precious eyes for a second. "Not tonight"

Adora studies her expression for a few seconds, nodding in agreement with one more kiss over her freckled face. "You are right, not tonight. Tonight we are going to dance"

Catra chuckles as Adora turns to the little corner they use as a shelf, swirling in her ankles over the naked wood. "Adora Gray escaped Prom just so she could dance" she says, almost as if it hadn't been her idea in the first place.

"Dance with you" Adora corrects her with a smile, "That's all I want" Catra's upright posture melts behind Adora thought the latter cannot see it, humming and fumbling with the things in the shelf before adding, "We can make out after"

Catra chokes around a snort, completely taken by surprise. "Well, fucking hell"

Adora turns on the dusty radio, trinketing to find a station she likes and pulling from the volume knob until the music echoes across the entire tree house loudly. Catra looks at her with an arched eyebrow, smirking, half mockery half amused.

"Funkytown? Seriously?"

Adora laughs, swinging her hips from side to side without no grace whatsoever. She twirls once and stretches her arm towards Catra

"You know, you can keep that dark, rebellious facade all you want with the rest, but it doesn't work with me. I totally saw you dance to ' Don't go breaking my heart' *at my parents' anniversary dinner."*

"Ugh, I knew you were never going to let me live that down" Catra groans, running a hand down her face. Adora shakes her head, following the rhythm of the music until her hair comes undone, dropping flower petals everywhere.

"Come on, grumpy face. Aren't you the best dancer or the two?" Adora teases her, stretching her hand towards her in defiance.

Catra rolls her eyes but grins widely. Grabbing Adora's hand and pulling her towards her in one swift motion. Adora turns in her hands and laughs, bumping their hips together with the rhythm of the music

It's a ridiculous dance, quite as ridiculous as the music itself. They cross their arms over their shoulders and swing from one side to the other, twirling and tripping with their own feet. Adora shakes her head and her arms like noodles and Catra laughs at how she looks. She wraps her arms around Adora's waist and dips her until her hair brushes the floor, gaining a surprised squeal in return.

They don't think about the school right now, or the gym, or the cruelty of the people. They don't know about simple people giving simple prom prizes or about a man acting like a boy making a

dangerous tantrum in the gym. It doesn't exist for them right now.

Adora straightens and presses a joyful kiss on Catra's mouth, distracting her just enough to this time being the one that dips her into the ground, drinking the happy hiccup from her lips. Their laughter echoing in the trees and they are happy.

Adora is crying, brushing her fingers over the photograph she took after dancing together for hours and then hung in the treehouse as a memory. As a promise.

"I loved her"

"I know"

October 1st, 1985

11.45 pm

This time, the music is slow.

Adora's parents had a pretty and small turntable where they used to play old, soft music all the time. Adora stole it for the night - if it can be called stealing at all, given the turntable is now hers - playing the quiet music of the vinyl discs for both of them.

Adora is not a great dancer but her father taught her enough, just the amount for her to be able to cradle Catra over her chest, swinging them softly from side to side into a tight circle on the treehouse's floor. Catra's face is tucked in the space between Adora's neck and her shoulder, her left hand on Adora's right, Adora's left hand resting on the low of Catra's back.

After hours or just minutes, Adora kisses the side of Catra's temple, searching her eyes with hers. Catra's face is calm, pink with a flush that makes her freckles look like stars. There is a light bruise on her cheekbone, lilac against the dark of her skin. Adora

raises her hand, brushing the pad of her fingers over the tender skin, lightly, so lightly Catra shivers under the touch.

Adora's eyes go hard at the sight of the bruise, eyebrows fruncing together. Catra grunts lightly, tangling her fingers with Adora's, holding her gaze with meaning. They share a heavy look, a silent conversation, the type that only years of knowing and loving each other can create. Adora stares at Catra's mystical eyes and then drops to her lip, wetting her bottom lip with a nervous gulp. Catra's eyebrows rise, knowing, smirking tiny and nervous as she nods. Adora studies her expression, making sure. It's long since they've stopped swinging, changing for a different kind of dance. A sweeter one.

Adora leans in, catching Catra's upper lip against hers in a tender kiss, running her tongue over the edge of her teeth until Catra opens her mouth with a silent gasp, allowing Adora to meet her in the middle. The kiss grows heavier, needier, shared warm breaths and small hiccups as they caress each other's mouths with their tongues.

This is far from the first time they've kissed like this, as if their lives were to end the next day, freely, urgently, digging their fingers on each other's arms, and running their hands over their hairs until they are only messy locks. Yet, this one feels different, meaningful, the last step over the thin line they had been dancing around for so long now.

Adora tugs from Catra's shirt from where it's tucked inside her pleated black skirt, running her hands under the warm fabric, her fingers caressing the creases and depth of Catra's spine with feather like touch, digging stronger as they reach the angles of her shoulder blades, pressing Catra flush against her chest.

Catra exhales, surprised, managing to lean back just enough to murmur an "Adora" before the latter is kissing her again. Catra groans around her tongue, surging forwards until she catches the buttons of Adora's jeans, tugging from them insistently until she

can free Adora's pink sweater from them and slip her hands under it, running her blunt nails over Adora's bare sides.

Adora whimpers at the touch and it's then that reality catches a little up on her. She parts from Catra's mouth but doesn't take her hands away, resting them over her waist. Adora is blushing furiously almost the same shade of her sweater and her voice is low and raspy but she doesn't sound scared. She looks excited, joyful. Happy.

"Um, I know we agreed to do it on your birthday, and there is still a month for that, but-" Adora says in a whisper, looking at Catra from between her eyelashes, playing with the loose hems of her band shirt. She doesn't finish the sentence, laughing once at her own shyness.

Catra slips her hands off Adora's sweater, tangling them instead on Adora's hazelnut hair, smiling at her full of mirth but also honesty. "I think you were the nervous one that established that, dummy"

Adora chuckles, hiding her face against Catra's temple, her nose pressing over her ear, tickling her with her breath. "Play fair"

"Never" Catra says with a soft grin. "Are you trying to woo me, Grey?"

Adora giggles, leaving a soft kiss over the curve of her ear and leaning back to look at Catra's face. She is blushing too, making her freckles pop under the orange light of the fairy lights around them. "I'm just nervous"

"I'm nervous too," Catra admits, cupping the side of Adora's face in her palm. Adora leans against the touch, letting her eyes close and sighing at the tenderness of it. "We don't have to do anything."

"I want to," Adora assures, maybe too fast, her words tripping with each other and making Catra laugh. "I don't know what I'm doing "

"Yeah, neither do I" Catra bites down on her lip, twirling her fingers in Adora's loose hair. "Let's learn together, alright?"

"Okay" Adora murmurs, leaning once more to kiss Catra again.

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This time is slower, with less urgency than before but somehow even more charged. Adora runs her hands down the expanse of Catra's back, her breath hitching when she notices the lack of a bra under her band t-shirt. Catra laughs against her mouth at Adora's surprise, bumping their noses together, her hands tangled close and tight around Adora's hair.

"Take off my shirt, big girl," she whispers, voice hoarse and excited. Adora does so.

Thinking she was blushing before was an understatement, because seeing Catra like this, in front of her, makes Adora go beet red, steam almost going off her ears. She drifts off a little, lost in the expanse of Catra's smooth dark skin and the curve of her breasts. Catra shifts on her feet, nervous, tugging gently from Adora's earlobe to call back her attention.

"All good there, dummy?" she says, trying very hard to sound cheeky and confident though the tremble in her voice gives her away.

"You are so pretty," Adora answers, honest, completely enamoured and in awe. Catra flushes deeply, tinting down her neck and the skin of her collarbones like a rose. She pulls from the knitted wool of Adora's pink sweater, playing with the hem between her fingers.

"I've always liked this sweater"

"Keep it," Adora breathes out, fumbling with Catra's mouth as she pulls up from the mentioned clothes and takes it off in a swing, letting it fall in a mess of pink over the old wood. "It 's yours."

Catra exhales at the sight of Adora's bra, pink too and sweet, tugging from the straps until they fall down Adora's sun kissed shoulder and join the pile of clothes at their feet. Skirt and jeans follow soon after, kicking them out of the way as they make their way blindly to the makeshift bed, falling over the rumpled blankets and pillows in a fit of laughter.

They lay on their sides, looking at each other flushed pink and smiling. Everything is so awkward. Their limbs tangle with each other when they try to scoot closer, they pull accidentally from each other's hair, the blankets wrinkle around them and the floor is slightly too hard. But the night is warm and the forest is quiet, a little bubble around them where they are safe from the rest. So it 's good.

Adora runs the tip of her fingers up and down Catra's side, tickling cheerfully when she reaches her ribs and thumbing on her bellybutton when she goes down, barely brushing the edge of Catra's black underwear.

Catra sighs, cupping Adora's face between her hands and bringing her into a kiss, pulling from her until Adora is hovering over Catra. Adora hooks her thumbs at either side of Catra's underwear, searching for her gaze first.

"Okay?"

"Okay," Catra approves, gulping loudly. Adora smiles leaning down to press a kiss over Catra's pulse point and then down, down, traveling down her body, scattering lingering, loving kisses on each patch of skin she can reach, pulling from the underwear at the same time until it slips off Catra's lean legs and Adora is resting her cheek against the inner face of Catra's warm tight, looking up at her with an enamoured gaze.

"Like that?" Adora asks genuinely, leaving a sweet kiss in Catra's navel, who nods a tad to hard, running her hand over the soft strands of Adora's hair.

"Yes"

"Alright," Adora murmurs, distracted by Catra's sweetest spot, already open like a flower's blossom and damp like dew. Catra is so beautiful, Adora loves her so much.

Adora rests Catra's legs over her shoulders and stretches her arm, looking for Catra's hand. They tangle their fingers together tightly, holding each other.

"Together" Adora reassures her, waiting until Catra is ready and nods back to her, her loopy smirk making a home in her pink face.

"Yeah, together"

It's their first time and it's clumsy, but it's theirs. Adora really, honestly, doesn't know what she is doing, she has to take a breath several times when she runs out of air and she half wonders if everything is maybe a little too wet than it should be but she doesn't care. Adora loves kissing Catra but kissing Catra like 'this', she is sure she has found her happy place. Adora's usually busy, overworking mind has fallen into a numb calm, lulled by the wet sounds of Adora's mouth and Catra's hitched breath against the pillows, her back arched and belly tight, holding herself to Adora's sweaty hair and the damp blankets with all her strength. In fact, Adora is pretty sure she gets so relaxed between Catra's legs that she drowses off a few times, kissing and licking at Catra's soft, pink inner lips almost without thinking, like something natural, something good.

Adora is not sure how long they go like this, Catra shaking in her arms, tightening and loosening several times, whimpering behind the palm of her hand until she pulls from Adora's hair more insistently than before, speechless and out of breath, motioning Adora to 'come up'. Adora almost mourns the loss of that secret, warm place if it wasn't for Catra's welcoming lips, kissing her deeply. The taste in Adora's mouth is heavy and she groans

around the kiss as Catra nestles herself on Adora's side, too loose and lazy to move differently. They'll have time for that. .

Instead, Catra latches her mouth over Adora's neck, her collarbones and the swell of her breast, pushing Adora's pink and soaked underwear with a little bit too much excitement because she accidentally sends it flying to the other side of the treehouse and into the window, hanging in the rough wood there. Adora snorts and Catra laughs with her until neither can breath, bursting into laughter again every time they see the lonely undergarment barely hanging in there.

Adora's laughter melts into a moan when Catra's hand wonders low, caressing her like one would touch a flower, gentle and nervous at first and then faster, more confident as Adora's breath picks up, pressing Adora's petals until her eyes roll back and the wood roof turns into the night sky. Adora rolls to the side at some point curling around Catra as the latter keeps learning her with her hand between her thighs and her mouth against her pulse point. Adora's thigh brushes against Catra's center almost unconsciously, working her up sweetly until they are both tripping over the edge together, eyebrows knitted, whimpering against each other's mouth until the brush of their skins against the other is almost too much.

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Night passes them by like in poetry. Minutes turned into hours, hours turned into endless. They are young and in love and have a lot of stamina but after a while they choose to just curl against each other, a silent agreement wrapped in the spare blankets they have in the treehouse. Adora draws invisible swirls over Catra's shoulders and back, her heart full and content. Catra presses her fingers on the low of Adora's back, almost as if kneading the warm skin there.

Adora sighs, watching as the night twinkles from the window. Soon the starry sky will start to wash into the lilacs and pinks of

the dawn between the branches, for now they still have a little bit of time.

"What kind of house do you want?" Adora asks, her cheek resting over Catra's temple. They've been like this for a little while, asking swift questions to each other. Adora likes to ask Catra about this kind of things. Likes to promise each other the shape of a future together.

"I want a yellow house," Catra answers, smiling to herself. Her voice is hoarse and squeaky and endearing all the same. "With blue windows," and then after a beat of thought, "I'm tired of darkness."

Adora hums, smiling. The air around them is heavy and smells like them and the few candles lit are close to burn out completely. The music from the radio is still echoing softly somewhere.

"What about you?" Catra asks, nuzzling in the angle of Adora's neck, who's smile just grows in size.

"I want a dog." Catra snorts, resting her palm over Adora's bare chest, feeling the fluttering of her heart right under her fingertips.

"Of course you do"

They fall silent for a while until a soft drizzle starts to fall over the woods, splashing against the old wood of the treehouse.

"Thank you," Adora says in the faintest of whispers, nuzzling in Catra's damp hair. She doesn't want to ever be away from her again but she knows she has to, for both their safeties, so for now this has to be enough. "I love you"

Adora feels Catra smile against her naked shoulder, pressing a kiss in the feverish skin there. "I love you more"

Warmth spread through Adora's chest, quickening her heartbeat and making her eyes water. There is so much love inside this little

spot in the world.

"No. I love you more"

"Me"

"Nop, me"

" *Kiss me again, dummy"*

"Alright"

There are things Adora doesn't say, things that are hers and that were Catra's. What is clear for Mara, though, is that what they lived was a love story, kind and honest and short lived like the sun's light.

Adora rests her head on her palms, crying silently over the locket and the photo and the what if. Mara looks at her, her hands resting over the wood, tight until her knuckles turn pink.

"When I was your age… I fell in love with a girl," Mara confesses in a whisper. Adora snaps her eyes at her, clear surprise and weariness in her face.

"You did?"

"Yes," Mara digs her fingers until splinters stab under her nails. This is the first time speaks about this in over ten years but, somehow, Mara feels like she owes it to Adora. "She was my best friend. The world is not kind for people who are alone but she was to me. And I was so, so afraid but, for some incredible reason, she loved me too." Mara looks away swiftly, scrunching in her place with the weight of her memories.

"Someone saw us, once, just once. It was my fault. Hope was always careful but I just loved her so, so much," Mara looks at Adora's eyes, glazed with her own memories, misted over with the same excruciating pain that weighs over Mara. She knows. They

share the same love and they shared the same pain. She knows. "Word spread like fire. They tried to get me arrested, to be sent away, locked for good. Hope's parents didn't press charges, I never knew if it was something Hope did or if they just didn't want the gossip, the trouble. And I guess that saved my fucking ass. But they- they took Hope away."

Mara chokes on air, grasping the bridge of her nose against her fingers, fighting to keep the tears at bay. "The people of the town…they've always been like this. They hate what they cannot understand and that hate destroys so much happiness. But- I guess I wanted you to know that I understand you, that you are not alone," Mara looks at Adora's tearful eyes, dropping like diamonds down her cheeks, full of all the fear and hate and sorrow any person could ever bear. "The world outside is not like here anymore, Adora. It's hard but it's better. You can love there. And you deserve to love and be loved, we all do."

"I don't want to," Adora says, pained, bloody, breateb and death, "I don't want to love anyone else."

Adora presses her lips into a line, staring at Mara in silence, heavy with the words and the memories. After a second, she leans for the bag pack, holding it carefully, lovingly, before pushing it gently towards Mara, her hands trembling.

"You can look if you want," she says, opening the zipper.

Mara doesn't reach for it but sees enough. There are a couple changes of gym clothes, books and Catrina's ID but that's all. No inhaler or medicine at all. It's just an usual school bag. Mara sighs, not disappointed but tired.

"Why was Catra's bag on your room, Adora?"

Adora grimaces, her entire face pale with regret and sadness. "We were going to run away," she says, voice breaking, like a secret breaking as glass. "After graduation, during the holidays break. We always talked about getting out of this awful place and seeing

the world. Travel. Move to San Francisco together" Adora presses her fist against her mouth, as if she was trying to drown a scream. "It was my fault. Nothing would have happen if I hadn't choose this town over her"

The corners of Mara's lips pull down, dread falling over her. "Adora, tell me what happened"

Adora takes a breath, "I broke my promise"

October 30th, 1985

A quarter before midday

The entire team is here, both basketball players and the cheerleaders. Bow is chatting with Adam somewhere in the gym, discussing tactics and plays. Cheerleaders are talking with each other, Glimmer and Mermista already planning the Halloween party for tomorrow, loudly and excitedly talking about food and cheap alcohol and ever cheaper neon lights. They are all on their little worlds, unaware of the storm in Adora's head.

She is wearing a turtleneck shirt below her cheerleader uniform, tight enough that helps her hide away most of her skin, and her hair is up into that godforsaken ponytail Catra so much hated, tugging from the baby hairs on her temples painfully. But Adora doesn't think about that right now. There is a secret love bite in the side of her ribs and the inner face of her thighs and she still smells the faint scent of Catra's hair on her skin. Adora wishes she could be back two days ago, on Razz's dinner celebrating Catra's birthday with special pies - and then in the treehouse with something special in a completely different way - but instead she has to be here.

Things were… hard, lately. It had gotten worse, more aggressive, scarier. Tethering on the edge and about to fall into pieces. The feeling had been chasing Adora for days now, she just couldn't rub it out of her skin. Adora had gotten into way too many

arguments with Catra about this, practically having to beg her for them to lay low for now.

Like today, the morning after the habitual pre-game. The gym was packed with sweaty, smelly teenagers and seniors, all of them going in and around the gym even after the game was long over. Catra would usually go to every game and practice to watch Adora, grumpy faced and annoyed, but there. It was a "them" thing, habitual as going to Razz's dinner or kissing under the candle lights. This time, Adora had begged Catra differently.

An acrid smell gives him away seconds before Prime's arm falls heavily over her shoulders, his mouth hovering too close to the side of Adora's temple.

"Are the gym bleachers interesting, Adora, or are you missing someone?"

Adora grimaces, shifting on her feet. Out of the corner of her eyes she can see the faint shade of green and yellow on Prime's cheekbone, the shadow of an ugly, purposely hit.

"Leave her alone, Prime. She is not here"

"Isn't she?" questions Prime, grabbing Adora by the chin and turning her face towards the entrance of the gym sharply. "Then who's that?"

Adora's heartbeat stops for a moment, watching past the rows of students and players, at the heavy open doors at the end of the gym. Catra is standing there, stretching her neck as she scans the gym, her backpack hanging loose from her left shoulder. She looks beautiful, even under the artificial lights of the gym, but she is always beautiful to Adora. Beautiful and absolutely reckless.

Adora throws a quick look to the side of the field closer to them, where Prime's followers are standing ridiculous and terrifyingly close, arms crossed over their chests, following Prime's sour stare towards Catra, still inadvertently searching for Adora among the people.

Adora's pupils dilate and then shrink, dread falling over her. She turns her eyes back to the side, towards the professors and parents and, tall and dark as a void, Weaver, unaware of her daughter's presence. Adora's heart is thundering inside her chest and she feels about to puke. There are so many people here, way too many people.

Prime tightens his grip over Adora's neck, pressing her face closer to his. It's suffocating, and frightening. From the outside, it probably just looks like a tender embrace for everyone else.

"You know, I didn't press charges against her after her shit show because I know your Catra *is so very important to you," Prime says before his voice drops completely into something raw and threatening, raising the fine hairs of Adora's neck with a goosebump. "But I will hurt her, Adora, I will hurt her so much she will never be able to recover from it, and the only thing you'll be able to do is watch. So be nice with me in front of others and smile, my dear"*

Adora's eyes are burning with unshed tears of humiliation and her entire skin is screaming at his touch, but she doesn't move. People are looking at them, smiling and nodding encouragingly as if they were watching an expected love story and not a horror tale.

Classmates, coaches.

Adam is staring at her above Bow's shoulder, his eyes hard and lips pressed in an angry line. He gives a step forward but Adora shakes her head almost imperceptibly and looks away.

Parents. Professors. Weaver.

Catra

Catra is looking too, her previous expecting expression gone into darkness, the same fire in her eyes that Adora so much love but that won't be able to save them now.

It's kind of funny, actually. Just last night, Adora was pressing kisses on the expanse of Catra's naked back. Today, they are a whole world apart.

"Say you understand, Adora" Prime presses, baring his teeth slightly.

"I do" Adora accepts between her teeth, words burning like acid on her tongue.

"Good. Now, be good *and go fix this," Prime stops just enough to point at a place on the bleachers where his followers are, looking between them and Catra with disgusting stares on their faces. "Or I'll ask those idiots that follow me everywhere to do it for you. I know of good measure they are* dying *to have a talk with her"*

"No," Adora snaps, scared the fuck out. "No. I will do it, just stay away from her"

"I knew you would, precious. Now go, there is a party after this and you are coming with me"

Prime pushes her harshly forward, leaning over the wall with his arms crossed, just looking at her. Adora is aware people are looking at her as she walks across the gym, some of them even talk to her, congratulate her for something she doesn't know and doesn't care, until she finally makes it to the door where Catra is standing, tight like a cord about to sprint.

"Hey," Catra greets her in a whisper, her eyes narrowed in anger and, most of all, worry. The honesty in her eyes makes Adora want to start crying. "Are you alright? What is going on?"

Catra stretches her hand towards Adora's face, catching a loose loop of her hair and curling it on her finger softly. It's a mechanic move but it makes Adora's heart to skyrocket for a very different reason than tenderness. Adora grasps her hand around Catra's and pulls her down a tad too harshly, too busy freaking out to consider Catra's surprised and conflicted face.

"Catra, what are you doing here?" Adora asks in a distressed whisper. Catra grimaces.

"I came to see you, obviously"

"We agreed you wouldn't come, Catra, I asked *you not to," Adora hisses, eyes wild. Catra stares at her, stunned by Adora's change of tone. She's never spoken to her like that, never, not to her.*

"It's alright, Adora, I can take it"

"No, it's not alright" the hand wrapped around Catra's upper arm is tightening making her wrinkle her nose, but Adora doesn't notice it, desperate to get Catra out of here right now. She can feel Prime's green eyes like poison digging on her back. "Your mother is here"

Catra wrinkles her nose, hesitation rolling over her swiftly, but ends up rolling her eyes and shrugging. She had always been the bravest of them.

"I know, but you and I know the witch is going to be a bitch with me anyway, so I don't fucking care anymore." Catra looks around quickly, stretching her hand towards Adora's, searching for her hand to hold. "This is your last game as captain, I know it's important to you. I want *to be here"*

Tenderness floods Adora's entire body, making her stumble in her resolution. For a moment, Prime's threats, the town's judgment, Weaver, all of that doesn't matter for the feeling of Catra's fingers on her palm, softly rubbing calming circles over her skin. "Catra-"

"What's going on with you?" Catra asks in a whisper, frowning around her worry. Her eyes harden at Adora's silence, looking above her shoulder. She must see Prime staring at them because her jaw tightens and her mouth set into a firm line. "Does it have to do with him?"

"No," Adora snaps, angry, all tenderness leaving her body at the reminder of Prime. She doesn't want to be angry - she is *angry,*

but not with Catra - but Catra is stubborn and, most of all, Catra is stubborn with anything that has to do with *Adora.*

"What's wrong then?"

"Nothing is wrong with me, *Catra" Adora sizzles, all the poison Prime had inflicted on her spilling and pouring over Catra. Catra flinches at Adora's voice and the inflection of her words, eyes hurt, and Adora hates herself.*

"What is that supposed to mean?" Catra questions, voice trembling. And still, because Catra can't phantom a world where Adora would be cruel with her on purpose, she asks, "Adora, what the fuck is going on?"

People are looking again, but this time, at them. At Catra. Mumbling between themselves and frowning. Prime and his followers are now together in a group, closer to the center of the gym. Prime's face is displeased. Weaver has noticed too, baring her teeth slightly. Nobody does anything but stare.

"Catra, you need to go" Adora wraps her hands around Catra's arms, pushing her back towards the door with a little more force than she intends. Catra growls and snaps Adora's hands away, digging her ankles to the ground.

"I'm not going to do shit until you tell me what's happening" she all but exclaims, managing to call the rest of the gym's attention. Adam, Bow, Glimmer, the rest of the team. Prime.

"Catra, please"

"Just tell me!"

"I don't want you to be here!" Adora yells at the top of her lungs.

Everything falls quiet around them, or maybe is the buzz inside her ears. Adora pants until she feels she can't breathe, carrying Catra's stunned eyes on hers as slowly, little by little, the sound comes back.

Someone is laughing quietly, not just one person but several, snickering under their breath. The classmates and the rest of the cheerleaders, even some of the older adults, are smirking, gossiping between themselves and pointing at Catra with any kind of decorum. Weaver is smiling, slick and satisfied, mirroring Prime's own.

Adora doesn't see them, she has never been able to see anyone else but Catra and now she is seeing her completely. Catra's face is flushed with shame, her precious eyes shimmering with humiliated tears. She isn't looking at the people either, or her mother, or Prime. She is looking at Adora, *because there is only one person Catra cares about and that's her, and the promise they made to each other to look for each other above the rest. Just the two of them against the world.*

Realization falls over Adora like a freezing waterfall, freezing at Catra's betrayed stare, so sad it makes Adora want to bite in her own tongue and pull her hair out.

Before Adora can say anything else, Catra sets her jaw and snaps her chin away, tugging from the sleeves of her jacket with her nails until it rips holes on the fabric. She straightens her shoulders, never the type to bend herself against others. She looks at Adora right in the eyes, the light trembling in her lip the only thing giving her away.

"I've know what I am since the first time I saw you," she whispers, low enough that even in the chattering silence, only Adora can hear it, "And I've never regret it, not once, because you are worth it, you are worth it more than anything" she looks around them and then back at Adora, mouth set. She is angry, and, worst of all, disappointed and hurt. Adora curls around herself, pain filling every single of her bones. "But if this is what you are going to choose, I'm not going to follow you, Adora, and I'm not going to go with you."

They exchange one last painful look and then Catra is turning on her feet finally doing what Adora so much wanted. Leave.

Adora exhales as the doors close behind Catra, shaking from head to toe. The sound picks up again, the school band starts to play once morez conversation drift in and back to them and then away, dismissed with a sweet as if Adora's whole world hadn't broke into two. Adora looks back, past her friends who are staring at her with eyes full of questions and her her brother and Weaver, and into Prime's eyes, into the low, satisfied smirk on his thin, white lips because this is what he wanted and Adora handed it to him in a silver trail.

Adora carries his green sight for a second more, breathing hard, and then follows Catra through the door.

Present Time

"I was a coward"

"Adora… you did what you thought was the best to protect Catra, that isn't cowardice"

"Maybe I was just protecting myself," Adora snaps, baring her teeth. "I used to tell myself that if I followed all the rules and did everything the town expected from me then maybe it would be easier for us, that they would pay less attention. The truth is… that I did it for myself because it scared me, it scared me so much. But… If- if I had come clean and stood by her side, she wouldn't have had to carry this on her own"

"You don't know what would have happened if you did. Both of your safeties were at risk"

"And what did it matter anyway?" Adora exhales, surrendering in a hoarse sigh, "She still got hurt in the end and she did it alone. I would have rather died with her a thousand times than let her go through it on her own" Adora cleans the tear tracks from her cheeks with the back of her hand, almost violently

Mara waits in silence, collecting her thoughts. Things are as complicated as she thought they were.

"Why didn't you tell me any of this yesterday?"

Adora scoffs, between a chuckle and a sob, shaking her head. "The last time I tried to tell anyone anything about the way Catra was being treated, Sheriff Kurr welcomed me on his office as his 'future daughter in law' " she said, words strangled between her teeth, "I hope you understand why wouldn't I trust this to someone I barely knew."

"I do understand," Mara closes back the bag pack, handing it back to Adora. "Why was Prime Kurr so angry with Catrina?"

Adora scowls. "Catra punched Prime last week" at Mara's stunned expression, she shrugs. "She didn't want to tell me why, but she was furious when it happened. And things just got… so much worse after that. Prime and his followers started a horrible rumor about something that happened at the dinner and the town bought it immediately. The sheriff wanted to lock her no matter what for punching his precious son. I had to beg Madame Razz to help us then. And then Catra's mother, she of course found out and she… she…" Adora stutters with her words, chewing on them and spitting them like a curse. "She *is* a monster."

"Is that why you went to the club house today?"

Adora stares at Mara, not surprised that she knows, wording the next little by little, purposely. "Weaver is friends with the sheriff and the Major. It's *convenient* for her. She has lived her entire life like that, saving appearances with the town, climbing up until she is what she is now, the richest and most *educated* woman of us," she claws to the wood, barely containing her anger at all. "But behind doors, she is none of that. I know you went to see her yesterday, you saw where Catra slept."

"I did. " Mara agrees, grimacing on her own, "What did she do behind doors?"

Adora holds her sight and then looks away, muttering. "Some people are very cruel to a kid when they know there is no one to

protect them, or at least, no one to see the hits"

Mara holds her breath, mind wandering into Oscar's photographs. Blurry old bruises on the wrists, the side of the leg, the back and shoulders, green in the edges over the slightly blue skin of a still body.

"Did Catrina ever tell someone about this?"

Adora chuckles, a dry laugh that tears from her throat, surrendered and exhausted. "Everyone knew, detective, I know they did. Nobody cared, nobody did anything to stop it." Adora runs her hands through her red face, pressing her fists against her sore eyes. "They are the monsters here, not Catra."

They fall into a heavy silence, broken only by the soft natural sounds of the woods around the park. Mara takes a breath, holding it for three exact seconds before letting go, her braid brushing her cheek as she leans forward towards Adora.

"She didn't drown," Mara says, making Adora's eyes bore into hers sharply. Mara knows she shouldn't be sharing confidential information about the case, but this is important. "She had a fatal asthma attack before falling on the river"

Adoras frowns, looking to every side as if she was looking for an answer on the very air. "I- I don't understand. Catra always carried-"

"Her inhaler wasn't with her that night," Mara says softly, "nor any other kind of medication. We've already looked in the forest and there is nothing"

Adora absorbs the words, weighting them inside her heart until her throat closes and her entire face scrunches in comprehension and anger. "Someone took it from her, isn't it?" she asks, louder, holding to the wood until her fingers hurt. "Someone caused this. They- they took her" she chokes on her voice, gasping for air. "They really took her from me"

"Adora," Mara stops her spiraling, wrapping her freezing cold hands with hers. "What happened to you, to both of you, is not fair. And I promise you I'll do everything in my power to make whoever was involved in this to pay for it," she says, firm, all of her words spilling with honesty. She tightens her hold over Adora's trembling hands, rubbing her thumb over the back. She is nineteen but she is still so young. She could be Mara's daughter. And she is alone. "But, I need you to remember that what you are worth isn't measured on how much you could have given to others. You are worth so much more than that and you deserve to find love and to feel love again."

Adora's breath shakes, staring at her joined hands. She is crying openly now, crystal tears running down her cheeks and chin, losing themselves on the hem of her turtleneck, where the golden chain meets skin.

Mara stands up from the seat and circles the table, sitting next to Adora and immediately gathering her inside her arms. Adora breaks inside the embrace, sad hiccups turning into full blown sobs, so loudly the very woods fall quiet with the sadness of it all. Mara feels them against her chest, breaking her own heart just with the trail of their true reach.

"I know I'm worthy of love," Adora whispers next to Mara's head after a little, broken and shaky, her eyes swimming in seas of sorrow, "Catra taught me that."

The travel back to the Grey household is as quiet as the first, but the air is different, less oppressive. Adora is sitting on the copilot seat now, clenching Catra’s bag over her lap and chest, her forehead resting over the cold glass of the closed window. Mara can hear the faint sorb of Adora’s nose every once in a while when the tears get the better of her. Mara takes the longer path back, around the entire town instead of across, so the passage around them are pine trees and empty roads instead of curious neighbors. They’ll have enough of that when they get back.

Closer to the house, Adora speaks again, a little bit strangled, still looking outside.

"I don't care"

Mara looks at her, eyes searching without understanding. "Excuse me?"

"If someone kills me, if the town talks about me. I don't care" Adora explains, turning towards Mara. There is raw honesty in her voice, the kind that is present only when someone has nothing else to lose. A dangerous kind. The lights of her neighborhood are now all around them, making Adora's eyes look gray and void. "I just want to be with her"

The car stops right next to Adora's house, the rum of the engine quieting and immediately being replaced for another kind of sound. The bunch of neighbors are still there, all fainted looking and upset, being for the late hour or the events. Serenia is on the side, right around the three sheriff cars parked on the street, her arms crossed above her chest. She tries to go towards Mara when she sees them arrive but is stopped by an official, who shakes his head and leans inside the car to fetch the radio. Bad signs.

The lights of the house are all on and the door opens immediately as Adora steps down the car. Adam sprints out of the house, quickly, all ruffled hair and wrinkled gym clothes, reaching his sister in just a few seconds.

"Adora!" he calls for her, wrapping her completely into a bear hug.

"Adam" she says, hugging him back tightly. She looks like a mess, loose hair and bloodshot eyes, but she relaxes completely around her brother, sighing against his shoulder.

Adam pulls her back softly, searching on every side of her as to check she isn't harmed. After he is sure, he shakes his sister's shoulder lightly, worry etched on every angle of his face. "Why didn't you call me? I would have come immediately"

Adora’s eyes narrow, shaking herself out of her brother’s grasp. “It’s alright, Adam. Nothing bad happened” she makes a face, punching him on the shoulder hard. "Why did you call the fucking police?"

"I didn't! They were already here when I arrived!" Adam defends himself, raising his hand in surrender as Adora punches him on the shoulder again.

Mara looks to the side, right past the neighbors and sheriff cars, catching the glimpse of another car. Bow is standing next to it too, an anxious stare on his face, followed by Glimmer and who Mara thinks is Perfuma, the daughter of the town's hairdresser, and Mermista. Mrs. Weaver is there too, next to a black expensive looking car, almost blended with the shadows behind her, her face impassible under the dark.

"She just…asked me a few things," Adora is saying to her brother in a murmur, calling back Mara's attention to the siblings. "About Catra"

He stutters, looking from Adora to Mara, his mouth twitching into a grimace. Mara remains beside the car, scanning around them. At least the officials are doing something useful by keeping the neighbors at bay.

Before Adam can question his sister further, a new sheriff car arrives and out walks Prime, flashing an all white smile towards the neighbors and then, like a chill, towards Mara, walking purposely to Adora. He has a can of beer on one of his hands that he swings lightly on his fingers that, by the sly smirk he throws at Adam and the matching gym uniform, Mara supposed it was Adam's at some point. Way to establish dominance over someone else.

"Adora," he greets her, giving one last, long gluo to the beer and tossing it aside over the yard without care. Adora startles at the sound of his voice, facing him as he steps into the path of her house, arms wide open as if he was to embrace her too or maybe

just make his presence very well known. "I'm so glad to see you alright."

Adora opens her mouth but Adam beats her to it, pushing her back and standing between she and Prime. Prime's eyes harden a little but he doesn't loose his smile, crossing his hands behind his back instead.

"Adam"

"What are you doing here?" Adam asks with a hiss, lightly pushing Adora backwards and towards the house.

"I heard there was a problem with Adora and the… detective. I just wanted to make sure that everything was alright," Prime says as a matter of fact, stretching one of his hands to grab Adora's. Adam snaps his hand away, looking from the neighbors to Prime, baring his teeth.

"I told you stay away from my sister" he mutters between his teeth, cooing Adora further over the driveway. "And stay away of our fucking house"

Prime's eyes darken completely. He looks at Adora but when she holds his eyes, her expression is angry, a burning fire bubbling under the surface and barely even being contained at all. She throws a quick look to Mara, charged from the same intensity as when they were talking inside the car, and gives a step forward to the house, absently handing the bag pack to her brother.

Prime doesn't let them go that easily. He wraps his hand around Adam's upper arm, yanking from it without a trace if care but still discretely enought that the rest of the people don't notice it.

"Your sister is going to want me near, golden boy, it's not like she has another choice" Mara hears him hiss at the siblings. Adam grabs his hand and yanks it away, stepping in front of him menacingly. Prime is taller but Adam is obviously stronger, though it doesn't looks like it affects Prime at all.

Adora steps sharply between them, glaring at her brother, to which Prime answers with a satisfied chuckle. Adora turns to him and straightens her back, muttering a "Go fuck yourself" loud enough for most of the street to hear, gaining shocked gasps right and left.

If Mara has learnt something about Prime Kurr in the last hours, is that he doesn't particularly enjoy being publicly humiliated, so when his pale face turns several shades of shamed red, Mara can't help to feel a low spark of satisfaction on her chest,

He opens his mouth several times, no sound coming out until he finally closes it with a click of his teeth, regarding Adora like a viper to a falcon.

"All this drama for someone that the only thing she did was stain your good name and the name of this town" he leans into Adora's space, grasping a lock of hair and placing it behind her ear. "She belonged in that ditch where you found her"

Adora's entire body locks into place. Her pupils shrink until there is almost complete pale gray in her eyes, almost shimmering under the artificial light of the street lamps. Her hands ball against her sides, but somehow she doesn't tremble, standing still in front of Prime, so very still, like a statue. Or a predator.

"What did you say?" she asks, calm, not even blinking. Prime opens his mouth, maybe to repeat himself, maybe to say something even worse, nobody will ever know.

Much like Catra in her time, Adora punches him square in the face.

The hit comes so surprisingly and violently nobody sees it coming until it's done - Mara does but not even she is able to stop it - Prime's nose bends with a satisfied, horrifying *crunch* . He trips with his own feet and falls on his back into the hard pavement of the driveway, wrapping his nose with his palms. There is blood

gushing through his fingers and down his lips, chin and neck, staining the expensive fabric of the uniform for good.

The neighborhood doesn't even gasp, too astonished to make any kind of noise. Is until Adora gives another step towards Prime that Mara sprints into action, raising her hands in a calming manner and standing next to the girl. Adam is right in the other side, the bag pack dangling from his shoulder, a hand wrapped loosely over Adora's upper arm, though he isn't even saying anything, just staring at Prime in the ground with wide, mocking eyes.

Adora gives another step, barely stopped by Mara's ready hand hovering over her chest. The twin lockets, now hanging together off her neck, twinkle with each other when she moves. Adora's fury is cold, the bite of a freezing winter instead of the melting fire of lava, just as lethal and murderous, exploding finally into pieces. Once it is set loose, there is no turning back. Adora's entire body starts to tremble from head to toe with the strength of it, making her eyes fire up in merciless silver. She spits to the ground right next to Prime's bend form, baring her teeth when she speaks, in a sizzle.

"Bastard" she hisses, biting her tongue with each word, spilling all the venom down. "She was better than you, she was so much better than any of you" she ends up yelling, staring right in the eye to every single person gathered around them just to look back down at Prime. He is staring at her as if he couldn't phantom this exact scenario to ever happen, at least not from Adora. She must see this because it fuels her further, snapping both Mara's and Adam's arm away so she can bend towards Prime, grasping the collar of his shirt and pulling from it with surprising strength until he is hovering slightly off the ground as a sad puppet still gushing blood.

"Do you want to know the truth? Is that what you want?" she growls at his face, her entire expression contorted in hate. Her cheeks are red, hair spilling besides her face like a curtain. She is not trembling anymore and she somehow looks bigger now, stronger. Mara sees it coming and panic slightly, too much people

and then there is a new sheriff car parking at the end of the road and the familiar long face of Sheriff Kurr walking out of it.

"Ms. Grey-" Mara calls for Adora softly, but she dismisses her completely, snapping her eyes quickly at her.

"What?! I already told you. I don't care!" Adora yells, returning to Prime's scared, and frankly, pathetic face, exclaiming every single word until her throat goes raw for him and everyone to hear. "I loved her. Did you hear that? I loved her, I *love* her. She was kind and good and loving and brave, and I love with all my heart." She leans further into Prime's space until she is basically spitting the words between his eyes, still loud enough for everyone to hear.

"I let her kiss me, I let her hold me. I let her make love to me until I couldn't breathe and I made love to her too." Adora let's go from his shirt, dropping him back into the ground.

"You are a liar, you lied. Catra wasn't forcing anyone at the dinner," Adora ends with the kind of finality of someone that is already dead. "It was me, that night. It was my lipstick in her neck and my mouth on hers, and my hand on her hand. That's the truth. But you already knew that, didn't you?" she asks mockingly, scowling, this time speaking not only to Prime on the ground but to the entire neighborhood. "Your pretty little game of the perfect girl is over. I'm sick of you."

Adora runs her tongue over her teeth, smearing light red over them. She has bitten on the inner side of her cheek so hard she has bleed herself slightly.

"I'm not *yours,* I never was and never will. And if you did something to her, I'm going to murder you" Adora says at least to Prime.

She looks around her, at the atonished people still standing there, at her friends with matching alarmed faces, before sparring a swift look to Mara before turning in her ankles, marching around the house, not even stepping inside. Adam doesn't try to intercept

her, his expression is unreadable, for anyone else, looking at her back go until she reaches the limit of the woods and looses herself on it. Adam sprints then into movement, throwing one last disgusting at Prime and following after his sister's steps quickly.

Mara tries to follow just as an official helps Prime on his feet - who pushes him away violently, furious, still holding his definetly broken nose with his palm. He looks a bit dizzy in his feet as he stumbles on the road and away from the crowd - but she is stopped by a firm pair of hands on her back, grasping both of her wrists and spinning her painfully towards the closed door of her car.

"Hey!" Mara exclaims, fighting the hold. Sheriff Kurr's cones into view, his upper lip pulled over his gums in anger as he hold Mara down. "Get off me!"

"I told you not to do anything funny, Grayskull, and look what has happened!" he exclaims, loud enough to make Mara's ears rings. She grunts, trying to shake off his hold without much success. Mara tries to look on the crowd for Serenia but she is nowhere to be seen.

"Are you angry that Miss Grey make your son look like an absolute stupid, or that she isn't what you expected her to be?" Mara spits, finally angry enough to say it out loud. Kurr spins her around forcefully, staring at her furiously. He is definitely humiliated and that makes Mara feel almost happy with the situation.

"You people are a plague," Kurr musters, nasty, before dragging Mara towards his car, where Mara can see Serenia already in the back, clearly flustered and angry after flipping off the sheriff earlier. Kurr opens the door and throws Mara forcefully on the back, slamming it back shut and signaling the official to take them away.

Mara looks through the window as the car rolls away. Most neighbors have already started to get back inside their houses,

murmuring among themselves. Mara is sure there will be little sleep and a lot of phone calls tonight.

She tries to look forward but is of no use. Prime is nowhere to be seen anymore and Adora's friends are gone.

Present time

Midnight

November 5th, 1985

Serenia and Mara are locked inside an empty interrogation room. The table is cold as is the room and the plastic chairs are uncomfortable under them.

They just spent a good hour just staring at the official that tried to make them declare what had happened, without success at all. Mara and Serenia were as unyielding as ever.

Sheriff Kurr hadn't appear again so the officers had just locked them inside without another word, leaving them there until they didn't know when. Serena rests her chin over her palms and Mara crosses her arms over her chest, looking at the flickering cheap light.

"What are even the charges, though?" Serenia wonders, exasperated.

"There aren't. We aren't *arrested* per se because it would be illegal, so they just put us here and not in a jail cell," Mara answers with a sighs, popping the joints of her knuckles. Serenia sighs, falling quiet again for a couple more minutes.

"When did you know?" Serenia asks, muffled my her hands. Mara looks at her. "About the girls. I know you figured it out earlier than tonight"

Mara sighs, understanding where her friend is going. "The first day, when I first spoke with Adora."

Serenis turns to look at her, surprised. "Seriously?"

"Yeah," Mara chuckles, rocking in her cheap chair. "Mostly saw Adora's desperation for normal friendship worry, but this was different. Nobody breaks itself into pieces like that unless there is deeper love behind"

Serenia hums, sadly, returning to her palms with a sad flop. At some point, Mara exhales, pinching the bridge of her nose with her fingers.

"When I lost Hope… I thought there would be anything worse in the world but the way it happened," Mara confesses in a whisper to her friend, blinking back newcome tears. "But after this I realized, I- I don't know if I could have survived something like this. Like the way they lost each other."

Serenia considers Mara, bumping her elbow with her softly. "Well, let's make it right for them then"

Mara looks at Serenia and smiles, nodding slowly.

The door of the room opens suddenly, one of the sheriff's minions peeking behind it with a sour expression.

"You two, off now," he says, crossing his arms. Mara raises her eyebrow at him, clicking her tongue.

"Finally?" She asks with a smirk, making the man sneer.

"Just leave already, for fucks sake"

Serena and Mara stand, walking out of the room and into the main office. It's mostly empty except for a few men gathered around the door with their shoulders dropped. As they get closer, Mara can see Razz is in front of them, berating the men with one of her dissapointed looks and knowing words. She keeps going at

it until she catches sight of the detectives, exclaiming in delight at them.

"Razz," Mara greets her, relieved, wrapping Razz into an embrace.

"Oh, dearies," Razz says, turning to hug Serenia too. "Whatever.are you doing here again?"

Mara chuckles, relief spreading in her body as they make their way out of the sheriff apartment, holding back the need of flipping the men off on their way out.

The night is clear, sky scattered with stars. Serenia is chatting happily with Razz about some pay recipe, Mara just walking besides them in silence.

Out of nowhere, there is a sudden swift swirl of turmoil all around them, people running off the the buildings and screaming. A bell starts ringing in the square, waking up the entire town. Mara looks around them, startled, managing to hold someone arm and lowering their run down enough to ask.

"What is going on?!" She yells above the sound of the bells.

"The woods are burning! Someone saw a column of smoke and now it's a full fire!" The person screams back, going back to running as people start yell to each other to call for the other town's firefighters. There are none here.

Mara gasps, standing frozen for a few seconds. She snaps out of it and starts climbing the highest part of the square's fountain, managing to catch sight of the huge column of fire in the south side of the woods. Mara gulps, realizing with a goosebump of dread where do that direction leads to.

She jumps down the fountain, running back to Serenia's and Razz's side, who are holding each other, confused.

"It's the woods!" Mara yells at Serenia, catching midair the keys she tossed her immediately. Serenia pales, holding Razz's hand

with extra strange.

"Do you think it is-?"

"I don't know!" Mara gets inside the car, turning it on immediately. "Stay with Razz! Call doctor Bright-Moon!"

"Alright!"

Mara speeds out like the devil, ignoring the roads and getting straight into the woods's paths, passing through thick trunks and rows of trees, following the thick smoke and the heavy sense of warmth spreading through the trees.

Just as she makes her way closer to the river, a car speeds out besides her, on the opposite direction, almost crashing against her up front. It's a red car but Mara can't see much more beyond the heavy cloud of smoke she drives into once she makes it where she is meant to go.

Mara jumps down the car, barely even hitting the breaks, sprinting inside the woods in an all so familiar path she just walked through a few hours ago.

The treehouse is wrapped into flames, from the roots to the very top of the tall tree, red fire devouring the old woods so quick and easy it's nauseating. The pallet, the circular door, the house and everything inside if it is completely consumed in the red rage, ashes raising to the sky and falling down like dark snow, like an omen. The air is oppressive here, claustrophobic, Mara can barely breathe above it. It's smells like charcoal and swollen wood, humidity burning off and, most terrifying of it all, it smells like burning hair and flesh.

There are a lot of people already crowded around the burning treehouse, shouting and passing buckets full of river water to one another, barely managing to suffocate the fire extending to the damp grass and neighbor trees, and managing nothing on the treehouse. It still burns until the wood steps collapse on themselves.

Someone shoots out of the crowd like a cursed soul from heaven, running towards the fire until another figure crashes against them, tripping them both to the ground harshly. The first person struggles on the ground, fighting off the other with a hoarse shout that rings in Mara's ears.

"Let me go! Beauregard, let me go!" Adam screams, tripping and falling again when Bow throws himself over him, pinning him to the warm grass. "Fuck! Adora!"

"Adam, no!" Bow screams, barely keeping him in place. Bow's gym uniform is slightly burnt in some places and torn in the shoulder after trying to reach the inside of the treehouse. His handsome face and hair are covered in ashes and there are clear tear tracks running down his cheeks, but he looks determinate, holding his friend until there is no more fight inside his body. "She is gone! Listen to me, Adam! She is gone!"

Bow's voice breaks in the middle, dissolving around a sob. Adam stares at him as if he didn't understand what his friend is saying, looking at the treehouse and then back at Bow until realization washes over him again. Adam grasps Bow's shoulder and struggles once more, trying to stand up only to crash back into the floor when his knees give up.

Glimmer runs out off the fire too, just as ashed as her friends, letting herself fall behind Adam and wrapping her arms around him. Her face is terrible too, mascara and eyeliner smudged front the cry and hair blown out it different angles. She had a slight burnt in her hand where she must have tried to climb up too.

They hold each other until reality washes over them and over Mara, the true length of what is really happening right now freezing her completely. She can feel her heart breaking once more, barely waken up by Adam's broken, fatality scream, the three friends tears mirroring Mara's own.

A noise on the woods behind her startles Mara, who turns towards the ruffle in a haze. It's the darkest spot of the forest, opposite to

the fire and the crowd of people. Mara stands still until she hear it again, just a few feet in front of her, the clear sound of footsteps rushing away.

Mara sprints into action, running behind the sound with a single goal on her mind. Make anyone that has been involved on this pay. She doesn't even notice how far she is inside the dark woods until the sound of shouting and wood breaking drowns down. Everything is extremely quiet and calm all of sudden, making Mara's senses to pick up in alert.

She lowers her race and looks carefully, narrowing her eyes at the thick darkness. She think she sees something just in front of her, square and big. The shape of a car barely hidden on the low branches of a tree.

Mara steps forward, teeth clenched and then she feels a sharp pain on the back of her head and everything goes black.

---

i guess this is the end,

i'll have to learn to be somebody else,

it’s been you and me since before i was me,

without you, i don't yet know quite how to live

— **Mitski** , *I guess*

Chapter End Notes

Jebus Chrissus, please don’t hate me and keep your faith in me.

As Sam Samwise once said, even this darkness must pass, and so it will happen here too. I promise

Theories? Favorite parts? Want to cry in the comments? I love reading all of your messages , thank you for staying with me

on this journey, I’ll make it worth it.

See you in Dec. 22. Love ya, be good.

Act III. Curtain call

Chapter Summary

"That's how you honor their memory.
That's how you'll honor their love."

Chapter Notes

Welcome to the big finale

If you are still here, even after everything, thank you so much. Thank you for believing and thank you for letting this story do what it's meant to. Have a meaning.

TRIGGER WARNINGS: Descriptions of a murder, descriptions of dead, descriptions of a corpse. Mentions of knives, guns, gunshots, blood and gore. Mentions of parenteral abuse. Homophobia. Mentions of choking and an atshma attack. Mentions of major characters death

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Act III. Curtain call

How terrible it is to love something that death can touch

– **Anonymous**

November 4th, 1985

11.35 pm

Adora sits on the floor of the treehouse, the bed unmade, the Polaroids on the floor, tear tracks marked on her cheeks and throat sore. She is so tired, exhausted to the bone. She just wants to rest, just for a second. It brings warm tears to her eyes and

pain to her heart, but she just want to rest is Catra's chest and sleep.

So Adora looks through the window, across the trees and towards the starry sky above her. It's a beautiful night, if she focuses for a minute, just for the split of a mad second, Adora thinks she can hear the light steps of the woman she loves, rushing up the stairs of the treehouse, ready to hold and kiss her and never let her go.

But it's not Catra. Catra will never climb up those stairs again or set foot on the wood floor. Her laughter, bubbly and squeaky, won't fill every corner of this place as she spins Adora over their makeshift dance floor. That's part of a life she took with her, all those bright, beautiful things, and to which Adora can't return.

These steps, instead, are slugging, heavier, making their way inside the treehouse like a dark spirit or a bad omen. Adora stands up from the floor and turns around to look at the person entering the last safe space in the world. Her heartbeat shoots up but she is not scared, not anymore.

Adora's upper lip retracts over her teeth when she catches sight of the person standing in front of her, blood rushing on her eardrums.

"You" she says, low and angry.

There is a moment of suspended silence and then the shadow shoots forward quickly, too quickly for Adora to even react. She gasps, falling backwards over the floor, kicking and crawling and spitting. It all happens like in a dream until, suddenly, she feels a sharp, almost pain and the dribble of her own blood slipping through the wood tiles, almost a feather touch against her skin. And, suddenly, after all the pain and the fighting, Adora Grey is no more.

November 5th, 1985

Morning

17 hours to midnight

"You don't have to do this Adam. Not unless you are ready" Oscar says in a whisper, standing on the opposite side of the long, steel table. "Is not- is not good"

"I have to, you know I do Oscar" Adam says, plain, voice blank and void. "She is my sister, I owe her that much"

Oscar sighs, leaning to grasp the hem of the black, plastic blanket and pulling back softly just enough to reveal the face underneath. Adam inhales, once and sharply, holding himself from the table that the material screeches painfully under the hold, nodding once. It's the only signal Oscar needs to pull the blanket back into place gently.

Mara can't see her face, she is too far away, standing behind the glass that separates the mortuary from the corridor, Adam's back between them and the body on the table. He hadn't allowed them to see her, not anyone but Oscar and him, and Mara respects it.

Next to her, a smaller table holds the girl's belongings, or at least, the few that survived the fire. Just a bracelet, the red jacket, several burnt out, and the twin lockets, still held together though slightly smoked by the fire on the surface. Mara thinks it's the least the universe could do for them, keep them together at least like this. At least in death.

"Did she suffer?" Adam asks in a thread of a voice.

"No. I- I believe she was gone before the fire started" Oscar says, hesitating.

"Why?" Adam inquires, tightly. Oscar trips on his words, looking down at the covered body.

"She was stabbed, Adam," he says, painfully. His eyes are sunk with exhaustion and the heavy burden of delivering the sorrowful news. "There are signs of struggle on her hands and knuckles, but the wound was on chest and it was deep, it may have caused her

to pass out. She didn't feel much. And the fire… it may have started after she was gone."

To cover it, Mara thinks the words Oscar doesn't say but that rings loudly inside the room. Adam's shoulders are shaking, by sadness or sorrow or raw anger or a combination of them all.

He snaps his eyes to Mara, still holding tenderly his sister's hand from below the blanket. He has the same eyes as Adora's blue, almost silver under the sickening white lights of the mortuary, red rimmed and full of regret.

"Do you know what happened to Catra?" He asks Mara, voice broken, barely hanging there. Is frightening to see him now, barely a couple of hours when Mara last saw him - tall and proud, sure of himself and protective of his sister - to what he is now, broken and shrunk into himself, barely hanging there on life. First his parents, now his sister. Strong love that met violent ends. It's almost too much to even speak about.

Mara exhales, trying to not look as defeated and angry as she feels. "It's not enough yet"

"Find out" Adam spats, white fire burning behind his eyelids. "And whoever did this to them, make them pay. Or I will"

And what can Mara do, besides close her fists and nod? There is nothing else to lose anymore. The world is burning down and they are already dead.

---

15 hours to midnight

There is nothing left but charred wood and ashes scattered over the once green grass. By the time the firefighters had arrived, the tree and the house built on it was already completely destroyed, logs and branches fallen, blankets burnt, leaves extinguished, the old radio melted with the intensity of the fire. A light rain fell at some point, helping the firefighters to tame the red flames down, just enough for Oscar and Micah to walk in and help recover the

body. Nobody stayed after the fire was gone and she was pulled into the car, nobody offered to help or to even look. In some way, she was surrounded by friends and by her brother.

Mara scatters the remains with careful steps, sharp eyes looking for anything not destroyed by the fire. Her head is still pounding, a pressure on the back of her neck and her eyelids that don't die out even with the analgesics she had chugged down earlier.

She is angry beyond measure, kicking with a drowned yell the darkened logs until they dissolve into even tinier pieces. Serenia looks at her from the side of the woods, her pretty eyes tired. The entire woods feels heavy, as if the very same roots felt the lost that had just happened.

"Fuck!" Mara shouts, kicking the fallen steps that once lead to the treehouse. She tugs from her hair, now loose from her usual braid after doctor Bright-Moon tended to her wound. It wasn't severe, a good bump, a light concussion and a horrible headache but nothing that could keep her from discharging all her rage on the burnt logs.

After a good while, Mara turns to Serenia, breathing hard. Her friend is looking at her softly, all the words she doesn't say clear in her eyes too. But Mara's anger and Serenia's anger don't matter right now.

"Where did they find me?" Mara asks, tightly. Serenia stands from the fallen tree trunk she has sat into.

"This way," she says, leading Mara towards the inside of the woods, over the path Mara followed earlier that very same day before being knocked out by someone she couldn't even see.

They reach the place of the woods where Mara was knocked out. She recognises it by the trees placed as a circle and the slightly broken branches a few feet away. Though it looks different under daylight, less dark and spooky, less mournful.

"Doctor Bright-Moon said your wound had debris of mineral on it, so, you probably got hit with a rock" Serenia provides, studying Mara's profile with her eyes.

"Doesn't matter. Even if we found the godforsaken rock it would be of any use," Mara says between her teeth, scanning the woods. She gives a step forward into the moss and grass but Serenia stops her with a gentle hand, making Mara raise her eyes towards her friend's.

"Mara, tell me how you feel," Serenia asks for, gentle but firm, a tone that lets through that she won't drop the talk until Mara complies.

"Nothing is wrong," Mara tries to dismiss the talk, without success.

"I can't let you compromise the case if your mind is not in the right place," Serenia states, her tone still gentle but clear that she will not doubt on taking Mara away. "Just let it go, Mara. Say it"

Mara chews on the inside of her cheek, huffing, her heart hammering inside her chest. "Two girls got murdered for the simple fact of loving each other" Mara finally manages, rage and sadness making it's way in her voice. "I promised I would protect one and bring justice to the other and no's they are both dead and I have nothing"

"You don't have nothing, Mara, we just need the why and how to prove it," Serenia interrupts her, holding Mara's hand balled in a tight fist. "It's not fair but… I- I guess maybe now, after all the pain and the fear, they are together. And it's on *us* to make it right for them here, alright?"

Mara states at Serenia, gulping down the tight knot inside her throat as she nods. "Alright "

"Are you ready to keep going?"

"Yes" Mara agrees, straightening, "let's get this over with"

They scatter their way through the patch of land, searching around rocks, leaves and branches and anything that may help them find something useful. Mara scrunches next to the spot where she saw the shape of the car, digging her finger on the dry earth. The first few feet look like someone had tried to erase them by hand but the rest of the wheel tracks are undeniably there, frantic and deep as the car possibly sped out at huge velocity.

"Where did you see the shadow?" Serenia asks a few feet away.

"A couple feet behind, at some point I just followed the noise here," Mara points at the ground in front of her. "Whoever it was, they did a poor attempt to hide the tracks."

Mara stands up, cleaning the earth from her tailored pants. "I spoke with the firefighters department from the next town, there were pieces of candles inside the treehouse but they think the fire was fuelled with gasoline"

"So, the killer tried to make it look like an accident?"

"Could have been the first idea, but Adora was stabbed. The truth would've come out sooner or later. Besides, Oscar's report says she didn't breathe the smoke or the fire, which strengthens the fact that she was already dead when the fire started."

Serenia's cheeks are slightly red at the mention of Oscar but she nods, eyes narrowed in thought. "Should we go with the Bright-Moons now?"

"You go," Mara says, throwing the car keys towards Serenia, "I need to see something first"

"Are you sure?"

"Yes. We need to hurry up and use this time now that most of the town is on the clubs or the square. Major Hordak will give a speech at midday and we need to be there."

"Alright. Oh, and Mara?" Serenia calls before they part. Mara holds Serenia's gaze, senses alert. "Whatever you are going to do, be careful and be quick"

Mara smirks sideways, not really reaching her eyes. "I'll do my best"

---

13 hours to midnight

"Thank you, doctor Bright-Moon," Serenia accepts the tea cup Angella hands her.

The Bright-Moon house is cozier than most of the houses here, with tender pink wallpaper on the inside and purple and golden couches with lots of cushions each. The house, as most houses on the town, is deadly quiet except for the errand click of the oven and the warm and delicious smell of cookies being made.

"I like to bake when things are hard," Angella says, sitting in front of Serenia on the wooden chair next to the window. She looks tired too, eyes sunken on their sockets as she sips from her own cup, strongly smelling like black coffee. "It's a calming hobby and good pastries are always in hand to take everywhere."

Serenia smiles gently at her words, accepting the tray of cookies Micah, stirring on the other chair, hands her. They drink and eat in silence for a few minutes until their cups are empty and the house quiet. The entire neighborhood is quiet, frozen in one moment.

"Where is Glimmer?" Serena asks, eyeing the clean living room, empty otherwise.

"At the school, she and her friends were going to meet there. They wanted to make some kind of flower altar for Adora at the square before the Major makes his speech"

"Will the school let them?"

"Classes were canceled after the fire," Micah explains, with a heavy sigh, "Even if there were classes, I don't think anyone would go. The town is a mess, everyone has been talking since last night and the fire just made it a thousand times worse." Micah huffs, sneering, his usually kind face contorted in anger. "There is no empathy in this place. They turned away from Adora as quickly and easily as they did for Catra."

Serenia frunces her lips, pensive and heavy. She turns towards Angella, who is looking through the window with an unreadable expression in her face.

"Have you seen Adam today, Doctor?"

"Just during the fire. I tended to him as soon as I knew. He was having a severe crisis," Angella shakes her head sadly, "that poor boy, he has lost too much already. Nobody should go through something like that."

Serenia exhales, looking at the Bright-Moon's devastated faces mirroring each other. There is no doubt that everything that has happened in the few days has affected them heavily.

"Doctor Bright-Moon, did you look through Oscar's file about Adora?" Serenia asks, softly but to the point.

"I did," Angella answers immediately, leaning to leave her cup over the table and crossing her hands over her lap. "The skin is obviously in terrible damage but Oscar is right about the stab wound, it went from the angle of her left shoulder in diagonal towards her heart. Wouldn't have been too long after that for loss of consciousness. Given there is no darkening of damage for the smoke on her nose, throat and lungs, I could confirm she bled out before the fire reached her."

"You could testify it was a murder then?"

"I can," Angella agrees without waiting a beat, eyes clear and sure. Serenia nods, thoughtful.

Micah leans towards her again, roaming with his portfolio next to his feet as he pulls out a red folder, expensive looking and neat. There is a broken wax seal on the top and golden letters on the bottom.

"There is something else detective, something very important," he hands the heavy file to Serenia, palming it softly before leaning back.

Serenia opens the file carefully, eyeing the documents inside and then eyeing them away, spending some good minutes going through every single words and small sentence and signature until her eyes burn from not blinking at all. With her heart thundering, she raises her head to meet Micah's eyes, a stunned expression in her face that comes as no surprise to him.

"Where did you find this?" Serenia asks, going through every single page again as Micha explains.

"I work in the town hall doing and organizing important files and documents. I remembered last year this package came directly to the Major's office but the secretary, Miss Imp, didn't even let me give it a look outside the address it was supposed to arrive at. She took it and delivered it to the Major himself. I thought it was strange but given his close relationship with the family I didn't think more of it until now and I wanted to be sure. I've seen documents like this before of course," Micah sighs, running his hand through his face but something tells Serenia there isn't a single shred of regret there. "So, yesterday, when the Major went to his usual lunch at the club and his secretary went to her own, I snuck inside the office and looked around. They were in a file with the last name alongside other documents."

"Quite careless, don't you think?" Serenia points out to which Micah agrees.

"To be fair, I don't think he ever thought someone could involve him in anything. When I saw the file I saw the seal was busted and it gave me a very bad feeling. Only the person to which is

addressed the document should be in presence when it's open and should keep the file. It's illegal for the Major to have done it or have it in his possession at all. Now, if you see here," he leans towards the documents, pointing at the numeration in the corner. "This tells me this is the certificated copy of the original, which means-"

"That the person that opened it with Hordak must have the other one," Serenia ends, closing the file. There it is. A *motive.*

"Indeed." There is something burning inside both Micah's and Angella's eyes. Something that looks too much like justice. Maybe even vengeance. "Find that original and there will be no judge that can bat an eye away from it"

"This is… incredible, Micah. Thank you," Serenia admits, holding the file close to her chest before saving it inside her bag. On the wall behind them, an old grandfather clock goes off, marking one hour before midday.

"Oh, I think we need to be going. The square is going to be full with people from the town," Angella says, cleaning her misted eyes with the back of her hand. The three of them stand up, carefully taking the plates and cups towards the kitchen sink and picking up their coats.

Angella hands Serenia a small package of cookies once they reach the door, smiling gently at her. "Would you like us to drive you to the square?"

"Thank you, I appreciate Doctor Bright-Moon. I have the car though but I'll be glad to drive behind you to the square."

"Alright. Do you want us to pick Detective Mara somewhere?"

"There is no need. She'll meet us at the square for the speech" Serenia doesn't elaborate on Mara's whereabouts and neither Angella nor Micah insist on it. Micah picks up a small bouquet of sunflowers enveloped in black paper and the three of them make it outside together.

Midday

12 hours to midnight

As expected, the town's square is buzzing with people. Everyone is here, from students to their parents, adults and young all gathered around the central fountain where a makeshift stage has been built for the Major to speak. There is construction material on the tower bell behind the fountain, taller than any other building in the town, but even that is closed for the day, yellow tape loosely wrapped around the door.

Mara can see the woman of the house club all gathered around Mrs. Weaver who cleans her seemingly tearful eyes with a red handkerchief. Beyond them, the sheriff's department is standing on the limits of the crowd, looking around with bleary, bored eyes. Neither the sheriff or his son are anywhere to be seen. Close to the fountain but opposite to the stage, Glimmer, Bow and the rest of Adora's friends are placing flowers at the white steps. Tulips, freesias and milkweeds, placed in small bouquets one over the other below a photograph clipped on a small cord until they illuminate the entire fountain, inconfundible to see. When she looks closer Mara realizes with a shiver of surprise and a knot on her throat that there are two people in the photograph. It's some kind of sports school event, Adora and Catra in the background, sweaty and disheveled but smiling to each other as they cheer. It's a nice picture. An accidental snap on a moment that otherwise would be lost on time.

"Excuse me," a voice calls next to Mara. She looks down to a young student, no more than a year older than his senior classmate, all nervous hands and hay hair. "Are you the detective?"

"I am," Mara says with a tiny smile. The student nods, pointing to himself. He looks frankly scared beyond his skin or maybe that's just his usual anxious stand.

"I'm Kyle," he says. He is carrying something in his hands, a small dark square inside a yellow box.

"Hello, Kyle" Mara greets, tilting her head, "is there something you want to tell me?"

Kyle looks startled for a second, peeking from side to side around the crowd to make sure there is nobody snooping on them before handing the small box to Mara.

"I have a recording," he says, tripping with his own words. "My-my friends and I sometimes do little films. I have a super 8, well, it was my parents before but they gave it to me after so now I use it though my friends don't like that I say we do film because it's usually of our characters from dungeons and dragons and-"

"Kyle"

"Yes! Well, umm, the other night when we were in the alley next to the milkshakes we recorded something" he hesitates, throwing a swift look to the senior classmates at the front of the crowd. "It's about Catra and, um, Prime Kurr?"

"Alright, Kyle, give it to me" Mara says gently, accepting the box and carefully saving it inside her jacket. Kyle shifts on his feet lightly, as if unsure of what to say next or if to say it all.

"I revealed it already, it's from a few days before Halloween," He chews on the inside of his cheek, considering his words before speaking again, this time a bit louder and sure of himself. "I know what people said about Catra. But, she wasn't like that. She helped me with math, I mean, she did call me an idiot most of the time, but she helped me" his shoulders drop and he looks to the ground slightly defeated. "Catra was kind"

That tears a tender smile from Mara, who rests her hand over his shoulder, squeezing reassuringly. "Thank you, Kyle"

He returns the smile and quickly makes his way back into the crowd, standing next to a taller guy that Mara recognises from the

basketball team.

"Mara!" Serenia calls her from a few feet behind, bumping around annoyed neighbors until she manages her way next to Mara. Doctor Bright-Moon and her husband follow her close behind, regarding her with a nod and a smile before parting ways to look for their daughter. "Finally we found you. How did it go?"

Mara sighs, looking towards the flower altar at the fountain. "Surprisingly good. And you? Did Doctor Bright-Moon confirm Oscar's report?"

"Yes. She is also willing to act as a witness. But that's not all," Serenia pulls a file from her bag, handing it to Mara with a grave expression. "You need to see this"

Mara raises her eyebrows, opening the file and roaming through the pages inside until the words make sense. She snaps her eyes back to Serenia who just smirks, almost evil. Something satisfactory washes over Mara as she looks back at the crowd, past dozens of heads and to the tiny altar of flowers.

"Do you want to do it now?" Serenia asks at the same moment the crowd quiets and Major Hordak climbs towards the stage, all golden teeth and expensive suits.

"Not yet, we still have loose ends to close."

"Good morning, people of Eternia," Hordak starts gripping the microphone. Unlike Sheriff Kurr, Major Hordak has always been leaning more to the pathetic stance, with bursts of anger and tantrums when things don't go his way. Still, he is heir to a long and rich line of families of Eternia and the town will bow to his feet as long as they don't have an excuse to throw him out. "I know many of you have questions about the recent event in out beloved town but I can assure you everything will be cleared out"

The town dissolves in quick murmurs with each other, gossiping until Hordak grunts loudly, quieting them down. Angella and Micah

make it back to Mara and Serenia's place, Glimmer nowhere to be seen. Hordak cleans his throat and pulls a long typed paper.

"Today, at the start of the day, a senior student know as Adora Salome Grey, daughter of the beloved and late Randor and Marlena Grey, died in a self caused fire on an illegal construction inside the woods"

"What?!" Mara exclaims, drowned but the loud exclamation of Angella and Micah, full of indignation, and the even louder murmur of the town, some of them confused, others surprised, other ones nods in affirmation, their voices carrying low, nasty murmurs. *A deserved,* they say, mirroring the day after finding Catra's own body and Mara has never wanted to punch a group of people so much in her entire life.

"Adora Grey was known for spend her time with also late, Catrina Maria Weaver, a well known town student once pointed for offensive behavior," Hordak makes a purposeful pause, wetting his thing lips and looking up slightly, enough for Mara to think he throws her a swift, cold smirk. He ignores Mara's murderous stare and keeps going. "Adora Grey made what the town considers an alarming statement last night about the nature of her relationship with Catrina Weaver before running to the woods. It's of the Town Hall believings that the alleged disturbed 'relationship' was what ultimately caused for them to meet such end-"

"No, she didn't!" someone yells, climbing towards the stage is a ruffle of fury. Glimmer looks furious, her usually spiky hair flat, her face misted with anger and sorrow, eyes bloodshot and body trembling, barely containing her anger inside her body. She is much shorter than the Major but she still manages to tower over him completely, throwing him off his posture.

Bow is behind Glimmer, resting his hands over her shoulders, his peaceful, calm face gone completely, replaced by a stare so angry even Mara feels the full weight of it from so far away. The rest of their friends are also there, on the very front row of the crowd.

Mara can't see their faces but she can see the tightness of the line of their shoulders.

Glimmer walks directly towards Hordak's face, hushing him away from the microphone. There is a bit of a struggle in there and far away Mara can see the sheriff's department start to make their way to the stage only to be stopped by seriously annoyed Mermista and her boyfriend. Finally Hordak steps down off the stage, fuming as he complains loudly to one of his office workers.

Glimmer stands on the makeshift stage, cheeks pale, gripping the talk microphone tightly inside her hands. She looks at the expanse of people in front of them, all the town's people she must know and that know them. Behind Mara, Micah and Angella tense too, holding each other's hands as they look at their daughter speak.

Glimmer sighs, sniffing her nose once before shaking her shoulders, he posture straight.

"Adora- Adora loved Catra," Glimmer states, loud and clear, her voice breaking just at the end. The chattering of the town picks up again to which Glimmer clocks her tongue against her teeth, stomping her feet on the stage once with so much force it positively silences everyone back down.

"She did! The world doesn't revolve in the way you want it anymore. They loved each other and we - we knew something was going on and we saw how happy they looked when they were on their own even if we didn't want to see it or address it and *we* still did *nothing* when all of you mistreated Catra for being who she was, when you gave your back to her and then to Adora just for being… human beings. And we got angry at them and spoke horrible of Catra too because not only because we were so deep into your shit, but because we were *cowards* and didn't want to stop and understand. Catra wasn't bad for Adora, she wasn't converting her or harassing her. It was just them against the world. They were good people and-" Glimmer chokes around a sob, "And none of us are better than what they were, none. We- we are the monsters here and I'm sorry. I'm so sorry." Glimmer

runs out of air for a moment, barely holding herself and her tears.

Next to Mara, Angella whispers a tiny and sad, "Oh, Glimmer"

Bow squeezes Glimmer's shoulder gently, taking a step closer to the microphone as Glimmer tilts her head away, cleaning running tears from her cheeks. The loss has weighted heavily on him too, eyes haunted as if he hadn't slept in days.

"Catra didn't drown and Adora didn't cause her own death. They weren't *disturbed* or wrong or freaks. Someone murdered them because they refused to stop loving each other even when everyone told them they should." Bow says, as a matter of fact, not wavering or even stopping to breath. Somehow he also looks bigger than anyone else on the square, braver, full of regret. "In a way, we are all their killers"

Bow presses her lips tightly and walks back, holding Glimmer's hand before starting to walk down the stage. Hordak rushes back to the microphone but his words have gotten stuck inside his throat, failing to even try to restart his speech. It's of no use anyway, a sense of dread has fallen over the crowd, the kind that is sticky and uncomfortable and clings to one's skin for days to come.

Most of the crowd starts to dilute away in groups, staring at the students out of the corners of their eyes as they make their way towards Mara and Serenia.

Just as the first day, Glimmer, Bow, Perfuma, Mermista, Sean Hawk and Lonnie come together, but this time, there are no red pom poms or talks of milkshakes. Their faces are grave and grim, their bodies sore and worn out with the weight of it all. They stop in front of the detectives, shifting on their feet. Mara feels Angella and Micah shift, but they don't approach Glimmer, instead leaning to the other side.

"We'll do a bit of damage control with the Major while you speak," Micah says softly, giving the young lads an encouraging smile before he and Angela walk towards where the Major is beet red with anger.

Mara smiles swiftly at the group, a knowing glint in her eyes that only years of knowledge and pain has been able to give them. "Are you ready to talk now?" she asks them.

They are looking at their hands, their shoulders dropped, but nod. Glimmer frowns, opening and closing her mouth a few times, searching for her words. She still has that straight up stance that characterizes her but her eyes are rimmed red and the corners of her mouth are pulled down.

"When I met Adora… she was this scrawny, funny new kid in school," Glimmer starts, fidgeting with her hands. "All of us had known each other since diapers, either for our parents being close or because there is only one school in the town, but not Adora. Her mom was an elementary teacher and she taught her at home until Adora turned twelve and it was time for middle school. She was always nice with everyone, from the very beginning."

"We used to take a theater club together and Adora couldn't act for the life of her, but it was nice knowing her," Lonnie adds, chewing on her lip, "Except that, when she arrived at school, so did Catra. Marlena Grey had taught her at home too and then sent them both to middle school. She paid for all of it."

"It was like seeing a little fuzzy lion club glued to Adora's hip," Bow says with the hint of a smile on his voice, eyes tired. "She was always very protective of Adora but, um, we took it the wrong way. We used to talk about her being possessive of Adora but we didn't really stop to think that the only thing they'd ever had was each other. That it was just them protecting each other"

"We weren't as good at welcoming Catra as with Adora," Glimmer admits, lowering her eyes in shame, " *I* wasn't. I always made an excuse about Catra being difficult and a brat, lash out first and

talk later, but- the reality is that we were much more similar than I wanted to admit. And I never stopped to think that maybe Catra was hurting for something else." Glimmer bites on her lip so hard she draws out a slight shine of blood, "By the time high school started Adora started to bloom into herself. She became the rising star of Eternia, smart, pretty, of a good family, all the things the town values above anything else until Adora was less of a person and more of a token."

"Catra's attitude just got worse after that," Glimmer continues, "She got fiercely protective of Adora. Snapped at people trying to convince her to do things she didn't want, went with her everywhere, after school parties, team meetings, classes even if she arrived late at her own class. She got herself to carry the badge of rebel and rude to keep assholes at bay from them. We- we had a horrible fight when Adora joined the cheerleaders. She said horrible things and I said horrible things in return, Adora had to intervene."

"Adora didn't want to join the cheerleader team," Bow explains in a low voice, "She wanted to join the track team, it was us that convinced her that it was the best for her because Adam was on the basketball team and all of us were going to join too."

"I never asked Adora what she wanted," Glimmer laments, voice breaking, her eyes watering with tears. "I thought Catra was ruining Adora's life but never thought she was only trying to defend Adora's right to make a choice."

The group falls quiet, looking at Mara from below their eyelashes and then looking away. Mara sighs, running her hand over her pounding head.

"Does this also apply to what happened with Prime?" Mara asks, straight to the point. The group looks deeply uncomfortable but they nod, anger flaring on their eyes.

"Prime has always gotten everything he wanted, and at some point in high school, he started to want Adora," Perfuma says,

grimacing. She's visibly uncomfortable, fidgeting with her hands. She smells strongly like bleach and her hair is slightly more blonde than usual, framing her tanned face and making her freckles pop. "Adam made him stop most of his tries but Catra was the one that kept him away from Adora."

"I heard there was an incident during Prom," Mara asks, tilting her head. Mermista clocks her tongue, crossing her arms over her chest, truly annoyed.

"Incident. Tantrum. Whatever you want to call it," she says, rolling her eyes. "Prime and Adora got named King and Queen of Prom, and he definitely bought that one, but when they called for Adora she had left already. We didn't know where she was, she didn't say anything to us, and Prime lost his shit when he realized. He stomped off the stage and made a mess on the food tables. He kept screaming to his 'followers' something about a drink and Adora, he even had a plastic cup fisted on his hand. He even screamed at us, demanded to know where Adora had gone. He looked like a maniac, the school's director didn't want to because of the sheriff but she had to intervene."

Mara's heart gives a turn on her chest. "He was angry at the drinks?"

Glimmer and her friends share a heavy look, charged with something cold. "The night of Prom, when we were all going home, I saw Prime and his father at the gym's parking lot, they seemed to be having a discussion about something. The sheriff slapped Prime on the face several times, provoking him as he dangled something in front of his face. I couldn't see it well or hear them, but the sheriff was furious, I thought he was going to beat Prime there."

Mara blinks, frowning deeply. "Does the Sheriff have outbursts like those frequently?"

"Not in public," Perfuma shakes her head. "My mom says people talk all the time at the beauty shop. The sheriff used to be very

violent against his wife and they were both violent to Prime. When Prime was in middle school his mom left town without a word. It was a huge thing in town and Prime ended up being just as his father at the end. But the sheriff has a lot of weight here so the gossip died down quickly."

"Yes. Sheriff Kurr would do anything to maintain his status and good name." Lonnie agrees.

Mara's mind is raising, thoughts going miles per hour as she starts to understand. She can feel the warm weight of the super 8 film saved on the inner side of her jacket and the smooth, cold surface of the matching lockets she had taken from the mortuary, nestled inside her pocket, and then another metal small box, carefully saved on the pocket of her shirt.

"Thank you, everyone," Mara says, gentle and sincere. The group murmurs back a singular deflated agreement. Mara points at the now mostly empty stage, Major Hordak and his secretary long gone. There are a few people eyeing the flowers at the fountain, mostly young students and other seniors. "It was very brave what you did up there. Confronting the town"

Glimmer grunts, rubbing her upper arm with her hand. "Catra was much braver first, and then Adora. We were supposed to be her friends, it's the last thing we could do. For both" She shares a look with her friends, charged with meaning. She looks unsure for a second, studying Mara's face carefully. "Even if we didn't want to admit it, we- we aren't as different, after all."

Mara exhales, looking at all these young people for the very first time. They are just young students after all, barely even starting their lives, just as scared and hidden as those girls now gone somewhere better.

Micah and Angella reach the group again. Micah rests his hands over Glimmer's shoulders gently. "You okay, kiddo?"

"Yeah, dad"

Mara turns towards Micah, pulling out the super 8 film and handing it to him. "Mr. Bright-Moon, do you by any chance have a projector?"

---

8 hours to midnight

The picture is granulated and a little bit off at first but it quickly stabilizes, letting through the image completely. It doesn't show on the screen but Kyle had sticked a note with the date on the side of the film, October 27th, just four days before Halloween night.

On the video, it's night time, the town's streets dark, illuminated by the light of the shops around the main square. At the opposite side of the camara, the front of the milkshake's shop is in clear view, as it is the small group of students there, drinking definitely not milkshakes and laughing loudly around someone, all of the dresses in bright white. There are few drowned voice on the background and the film shakes a little, as if the person holding the camera had tripped or almost dropped it, a nervous laugh barely held back.

" *Stop toying with that, Kyle* ," someone says somewhere behind the camera, a little too faraway for Mara to recognize. Someone else grunts in approval to which Kyle almost drops the camera again.

" *I just want one more take for tonight! I want to show this to the rest of the D&D club!"*

"Seriously, Kyle?"

" *Prime!"* Someone yells beyond their voice, loud enough and furious enough that rings across the entire square.

Catra stomps into frame, all loose curled hair and leather jacket, her lips drawn over her teeth into a deep scowl, dropping her backpack in the ground as she approaches the group in wide steps. She looks furious.

The group in front of the milkshakes opens and Prime steps forward, dangling his drink on his hang as he swirls it from side to side. He looks at Catra comming at him from head to toe, smirking with confidence.

" *Oh, but if it is the little freak-"*

Catra punches him square in the face.

Prime falls on his ass over the hard concrete, grasping his cheek where Catra's knuckles connected with his cheekbone. His followers gasp in surprise, frozen in place by the sudden hit.

" *You are fucking pig* !" Catra shouts, baring her teeth. She grabs something from the back pocket of her jeans and throws it at Prime's bruised up face, small green beads scattering all over the floor around them. " *I know what you tried to do, stay away from her!"*

Catra leans and spits directly on his face, snarling one more time before turning around and grabbing her bag back up. Prime shots to his feet immediately, snapping violently at the hands of his still frozen mates when they try to help him..

" *I'm going to fuckin kill you, Weaver! Mark my words! You are dead* !" Prime shouts, pointing a finger to Catra.

Catra turns around and flips him off, walking out of the film's frame. The camera shakes a little more and turns off.

Mara exhales, dread falling over her. She turns towards Angella, whose expression is even more grave as she roams with her medical bag, cursing under her breath until she fishes a small box, untouched and sealed, handing it to Mara with a terrible look on her face. Mara takes it, looks at the box and around it, holding back the need of squeezing it inside her fist until the small beads inside it are nothing but dust.

"Should we go?" Micah asks, softly, shaken, nose clotted with unshed sadness.

"I don't know where they are," Mara admits, angry with herself. Behind them, perched on the rail of the stairs, Glimmer clicks her teeth, venom dripping off her face. Mara hadn’t even seen her sitting there.

"Well, then we need to hunt them"

One hour to midnight

"Are you sure he is here? We haven't found them the entire day"

"No doubt, the entire town seems to be calling to the sheriff's office to either complain or freak out about it, it's on every police radio station of the town" Serenia says, tightly.

A shout comes from inside the square, the turmoil of people gathered around the fountain gasping loudly. Mara and Serenia walk off the car, approaching the crowd quickly but carefully. Mara brushes her hand swiftly with the handle of the gun held to the back of her pants, praying to not have to use it.

They make it through the people gathered quickly, slightly having to push some of them to reach the square until it finally parts and Mara can see the full view of the fountain. Prime is a the steps, shouting and hollering, absolutely trashing the flowers altar Glimmer and the rest had put there, the little candles gathered around the floor and steps knocked over and extinguished as Prime stomps over them in rage. His face is terrible, busted and purple on the broken nose and cheekbones where Adora has beaten him up the prior night, pale green eyes bloodshot, almost obscured by it. Unlike his usual stance, his clothes are a mess, ruffled and untucked, stained with sweat on the collar, back and armpits, uncaring of any kind of public appearance.

Before Mara or Serenia can say or do anything, sheriff Kurr shoots off the crowd in a swirl of rage, approaching his son. For the split of a second, by the way Kurr's arms raise, Mara thinks he will grasp him by the shoulders, shake him, even drag him away.

Instead, he slaps Prime across the face so hard his son stumbles back, opening the skin of his upper lip and making it bleed, red spilling into Prime's white teeth like wine upon the snow. Mara flinches at the slam, her heartbeat hammering inside her eardrums, absently, she brushes the gun on her back, standing still.

"What are you doing boy? Uh?! What the fuck are you doing?!" Kurr growls, grabbing Prime by the back of the neck and yanking it back harshly, making Prime's neck to tense completely, the veins of his forehead popping green and blue against his skin. "I told you to stay in the fucking office, boy, did you not listen? Are you fucking stupid, uh?" he says, digging his finger on the side of Prime's temple, seemingly completely unaware of the crowd of people around them. "Is there some actual intelligence inside there? Eh? Hello?! Answer to me!"

"Kurr!" Mara yells, stepping closer towards them, furious. "Step away from your son, Kurr"

Kurr clicks his tongue against his teeth, turning his neck to the side to look at Mara sideways, uncontrolled fire burning in his eyes. Prime is looking too, not at Mara or the crowd, but to his father, something cold and firm washing over his pale eyes.

"Stay the fuck away from this, woman" Kurr shouts back to Mara, baring his teeth like a rabid animal, "Don't mess with men's matters"

"I said, step away," Mara repeats, bringing her hand back without really taking out the gun. Kurr catches the movement though because his eyes darken completely, finally letting go of his son, tossing him aside over the fountain's steps and the destroyed bits of flowers like a broken toy, no longer useful.

"Are you going to shoot me, Grayskull? Is that it?" Kurr taunts her, spitting into the ground, "I'm going to make you rot in jail, you know that? I know you are just a disturbed piece of shit as those

two whores. You are going to be sorry for it, and this time, that fucking old woman won't be able to cover for you"

"Like you covered for Adora's murder?!" Mara yells back, firm and unwavering. She is almost able to ignore the collective yells of the town around her as she finally says the words out loud. Even the few officers from the sheriff's department gathered there eye Kurr in apparent shock. Kurr's face is almost hilarious, staring at Mara as if he could tear her apart with his eyes alone. But he can't, not anymore.

"I was thinking how strange it was that during the fire the sheriff himself didn't show up at all," Mara continues, chewing on every word, "So I asked around, but nobody saw you then or the entire day, except that I did, didn't I?" Mara gives a dry chuckle, not reaching her eyes, "at first, I must admit, I thought it could be someone else, but that pearly white of the sheriff's car is unmistakable, isn't it? Such an expensive luxury given by Major himself to you after helping him corrupt the elections. Tell me, where is your car now, Kurr?"

"I'm going to-"

"What? Kill me? You can't kill me. I'm going to help you out and give an assumption. If I go to the sheriff's office I'm going to find your car covered in mud and tree debris, is that right officers?" Mara asks to the wind, looking swiftly at the mentioned standing to the side, who just share a tense look between themselves. "I saw your car that night so you could risk it. Are those scratches on your palms clean, by the way? I would think the rock you hit me with is dirty and sharp enough to give you a nasty infection if not taken care for properly."

Kurr snaps his scratched up hands close into tight fists. He opens his mouth but Prime let's out a loud cackle, bedding back as laughter rips off his throat is maniac shakes. Kurr looks at his son as if he had grown a second hand and wanted to slap it too but Prime doesn't even address it, running a hand down his face with a sideways smirk, rolling his pale and red eyes to Mara instead.

"Oh detective, you are giving him way more merit. My father is not nearly as intelligent to plan a mourder like that," Prime says, back to his condescending, self satisfied tone of always, edging though in something much more dangerous and frightening than all the times before.

Mara stares at him, returning the fake smile even though she can feel her blood pressure pounding in her head and ears.

“Did your father arrived before or after you started the fire to drag your sorry ass out of the scene?” Mara finally asks Prime, calm even if she is grinding her teeth. Prime smiles, now fully at her, almost as if her were proud of her, it's just a perturbed stare that Mara feels Serenia and the rest of the people tense, uncomfortable. Scared.

"You are delusional. You can't prove any of that shit you are saying," Kurr spats, obviously ragged, voice tight and tripping. Even through his entire career has been based in lies and abuse, Kurr slips right here. Mara ignores him, still staring at Prime.

"What was it Prime? Did it disappointed you you couldn't have her? That she wasn't what you wanted her to be? That she was Catrina's, the very same girl you had taken as a goal to diminish and vilify, and not yours?" Mara digs her nails inside her palms painfully, "Or was it that she repudiated you like your mother did?"

"Mara," she hears Serenia snap in warning. Prime's smile dies down, drowned like tar to the fungus.

"Adora didn't even know what she wanted," he says, slow and steady but sharp.

"Is that why you tried to drug her at Prom?" Mara reaches for her jacket's left pocket, the twin lockets twinkle together as she pulls out the medicine box, shaking it purposefully in front of her. By the way Kurr's shoulder's line tenses completely, Mara knows he recognises it. "Adora slipped right through your fingers at Prom

and didn't even bother to take the Rohypnol you so smartly dropped into her drink. Who got it for you? One of those brainless boys that follow you everywhere?"

People are *talking* now, murmuring among themselves so loud is a buzzing across the square, loud like wasps as Mara's words start to echo from mouth to ear and so, and so. That, oh so important reputation crumbling into ashes in mere seconds. Suddenly, from one second to the next, Prime stops being the town's golden boy and next major and turns into a predator.

"Catrina was the one that saved her that night, did you know that?" Mara taunts Prime, throwing the green pills to the ground and slamming her feet against them, gridding them into pieces with the heel of her boot. "Maybe she saw you, maybe she heard you brag about it, but she knew. She hunted you, didn't she? Until she knew exactly what you were planning to do that night with the person she loved. That's why she beated your sorry ass before Halloween."

"You don't have proof of anything!" Kurr yowls, stomping his heavy boot on the ground. He looks violent towards Mara, barely contained anger, face beet red and spit drilling off his lips when he screams. Prime remains quiet, regarding Mara with a blank stare on his face, void of any kind of expression or movement at all, a metal clone just standing there.

"But I do. You know why? Because even if you *knew* what your son was doing, and you *covered* for it, they were good people, and they were loved, and their deaths weren't in vain," Mara pulls from her inner pocket the small metal box, the recorder she carries with her, turning it on. Adora's voice slips out of it slowly, ringing on the entire square. "And because Adora Grey gave me permission to record her statement yesterday where she explains the harassment of your son to her and Catrina, which you purposely ignored when she sought help."

My name is Adora Salome Grey, I'm nineteen years old, twenty In January and I give my full consent to this statement-

Prime never got said no except for Catra-

He hated her because she was protecting me. That's what we did-

I tried to speak with the sheriff, he addressed me as daughter in law and sent me home-

I knew something was wrong. I knew there was a reason why Catra pulled me out of Prom like that-

She was brave-

Catra was furious with him but she didn't want to tell me why. She almost breaks his bone cheek-

Prime threatened me with hurting her if I didn't comply with what he wanted. I know he would-

I just wanted to be with her-

If you are not beaten up or dead, nobody will do anything to protect you.

"And, because you are so fucking stupid, and you feel so fucking untouchable, when I go looking on the sheriff's office trash, I will find the hunting knife, *your* hunting knife *your* son used to stab her and that you just threw away to cover for him." Mara finishes, fury burning in her chest.

The mumbling now turns into even loud voices, shouted towards the sheriff and his son from every corner of the square. Even the officers are talking among themselves now, spitting on the ground and standing on a moral ground. Mara hates them all.

Kurr yells one more time, cursing and screaming at the town people, commanding them to shut up with no success at all. He 's done. Even if the town doesn't really care for these girls, he is done and Prime is too.

Kurr gives a drowned yowl, pulling from the thin roots of his hair, violence rolling out of him in waves. He grabs Prime from the jaw and yanks him aside harshly, almost making him trip over the cold marble of the fountain. "Listen to me, you bitch. He is the son of a fucking whore, but he is *not* a murderer"

"No, she is right," Prime says, calm and collected, reaching to the back of his pants, "I am"

Prime pulls out the hunting knife and stabs his father on the heart.

*****

The attack is so sudden and violent, the entire town, even Mara, remains frozen in shock as it happens.

Prime drags the knife out and then digs it inside his father's chest again, this time more to the left spraying a rush of blood all over his face and clothes. In and out, in and out. In, in, in. The knife makes a wet sound every time it breaks through clothes and skin, no resistance at all before the lethal sharpness of the blade and the blind violence of the murderer's grip.

Kurr holds himself from Prime's forearms, staring at his son with wide eyes, almost as if he couldn't believe what was happening right now. He gurgles, choking around his own blood as it spills from his open mouth, a mirror of the bloody hit he had just given to his son, growing on size until his entire chin and chest are drenched with the red liquid and he loses his grip, knees and body and life failing as he falls into the ground of the fountain, red spilling over the errand flower petals.

*****

That's the moment the screaming starts.

The town comes back to life suddenly at the sight of Kurr dead on the floor, screaming and shouting everywhere as they turn around and start to run away from the square, crashing and stumbling

with one another, tripping with their own feet and expensive clothes and horrified yells.

Mara and Serenia get pushed back by the heavy wave of people, unable to go against the flow of dozens of First Ones running in terror. Someone crashes against Mara's left side so hard it makes her fall alongside other people against the ground painfully. She barely manages to avoid getting stomped over, feeling feet all around her and tugs on her jacket. The smells against her are crazy. Metal, electricity, blood, bleach, perfumes and colognes of all kinds, chemicals from the fountain, earth moved around by the run, petrichor from the incoming rain, all of them moving together amidst the chaos.

Mara struggles to her feet as quickly as she can, reaching for her gun and getting it read, finger off the trigger as she avoids the people, making her way to the fountain.

"Get everyone out of here, now!" She screams to Serenia, not even turning look if she has heard her at all before marching quickly towards the scene.

Prime is standing in from of his father's body, tilting the corpse's face to the side with his feet, shoes drenched in blood. The expression on his face is the most terrifying thing Mara has ever seen, void of any kind of empathic emotion, of regret or even shock. Not at all. No, he looks almost *amused* by the entire thing, giggling under his breath as her stares and stares at the blood dripping down the marble and staining the fountain's water in red.

"Ah, I always wanted to do that," Prime says when Mara gets close enough, as if they were having a calm, normal conversation and weren't standing in front of this.

He smiles, all white teeth and thing lips, looking from the floor to Mara with a loops sided smirk. He scratches the side of his face with the sharp tip of the knife, already stained with Adora's blood

and now with the freshly red of Kurr's, not even noticing or not even caring that is draw a painful, bloody wound on his temple.

Prime catches Mara's stare towards the knife. He chuckles, taking it away from his bloodied head to inspect the stained blade with a manic stare.

"I told you, detective, my father is not nearly smart enough to do think on all of that," he shrugs, dangling the knife from side to side, "Oh well, *was* smart."

"Drop the knife, Prime," Mara warns him, pointing at him. Prime looks at her almost bored, shrugging again. He leans down quickly and stabs the knife on Kurr's still head, right through the right eye. Mara flinches and that's her first mistake because Prime uses the split of a second as a distraction. He shoots forwards again and grabs Kurr's weapon quickly straightening up and pointing at Mara too.

Mara raises her gun closer to the level of her eyes, chewing each word in serious warning. "Put that down!"

"Do you want to know what's the funniest thing?" He says with a dry chuckle, ignoring her completely. "I was so fucking drunk, I didn't even enjoyed killing her. Guess the whore wasn't worth it after all"

"That's enough!" Mara shouts.

"I should have known the things those two were doing. Touching. *Fucking* ," Prime says, blood and spit flying from his mouth as he chews in the words. His skin is covered in sweat, pale and slick like a serpent. He chuckles, loud, maniac, eyes out of orbit and bloodshot, looking at Mara and everywhere and nowhere in particular at the same time. "Eternia should rejoice for this! The impure ones are dead! Only the superiors should be allowed to live in this world, make it a mirror of our image! Perfect as it should be!"

Prime shoots, the bullet barely missing Mara at all when she throws herself to the ground quickly and painfully to avoid it. The sky above their heads rumbles and pours open, rain falling heavily over them and over the entirety of Eternia for the first time in weeks. Prime runs in the opposite direction and towards the tower bell, crossing through the warning tape and slipping inside the precarious building like a rat chased out.

"Fuck!" Mara curses, soaked from head to toe, making quick work of herself as she stands up, barely avoiding tripping with Kurr's body to run towards the building too.

She makes quick work of the tape, pushing the door of the tower with her left shoulder, rushing inside. The building smells strongly like new paint and meral, the rain falling heavily over the roofs, making the inside of the walls feel claustrophobic, warm and heavy with humidity.

Mara turns to every corner carefully, checking the empty rooms before pointing to the circular stairs, narrowing her eyes at the darkness there. Her soaked boots make a sucking noise over the marble tiles so she steps carefully as she scans the room, teeth grinding tightly.

"My father always said perfection is the only thing that matters, and it was one of the few things he was actually right about" Prime says somewhere above her head, shooting another missing bullet blindly at her that ends up crashing against one of the windows, shattering the glass in pieces. He is not even trying to actually hit her, he is just having fun hunting her for it. Taunting her towards him. "That's why he beat by mother to a pulp every day, and when she was gone, he made his goal to perfected me"

"Don't you understand? That's why your mother left. To escape the violence of your father" Mara says, climbing up the precarious stairs. Prime chuckles, walking out of the shadows just a few feet away from her. He is looking at her mockingly, condescending, almost like a professor disappointed with a student that doesn't understand the lesson.

"Detective," he says, dragging the words as he shakes his head from side to side. "You should know by now, already. *Nobody* leaves Eternia, and certainly not the weak link my mother was." He smiles, teeth stained with his own blood, his eyes psychotic. A shiver runs down Mara's spine at the sight of it. "Actually, given you like snooping around the woods so much, you might actually find her bones somewhere around, if the animals didn't got to it first. Don't expect the skull, though, dad made a number out of it."

Mara's breathe stops on her lungs, dread and realization falling over her. She feels like puking, acid boiling on the start of her stomach and the bottom of her throat, tears stinging on her eyes. Prime must see all of this running in her eyes because his smirk grows and he shoots again, this time scratching Mara's shoulder painfully, almost missing her neck by a single hair.

Mara grunts, angry and barely in shock, unloading her own gun thrice. Prime throws himself against the walls to avoid being hit. He shoots again, without success, and runs the last steps towards the top of the tower. Mara chases behind him, biting in her tongue with force. She can't give herself the luxury of dwell on his words, not for know.

The top of the tower is much less empty than the rest, long plastics hanging from the glasses windows, barely covering from the freezing rain slipping inside. It's starting to rain heavier, lightning and thunder ringing like the huge bells resting over the floor of the tower, exploding so close to the building it making it shake completely.

The floor is slippery so Mara scrunches lightly, scanning the dark place sharply. Her hair sticks to her face and the back of her neck with humidity. She can't hear well with the sound of the rain, barely catching the sound of the downstairs doors opening and closing again. Maybe Serenia has come back from rushing people away.

Mara circles the corner of the room, scanning the back of the bells. They are humongous, two or three heads taller than her, shining bright in cooper and polished until it looks like mirror. Mara sees the shadow reflected on it before she hears it but doesn't move quickly enough.

The bullet catches her on the angle of the shoulder, barely missing bone and arteries, coming from the other side and crashing against the bell with a loud bang. Mara yowls, loosing her foot and stumbling to the floor. The pain is excruciating, burning like the very flames of hell, skin and muscle screaming in agony. She hears the steps approaching her, slow and contemplating, and tries to swing her own weapong to the side but Prime kicks it away, slamming the handle of his own against the back of her head, already tender by the previous hit. Mara groans again, vision misting with pain.

"Adora just needed to act as it was expected of her" Prime says against grinded teeth, tangling his hand around her hair and pulling. Mara grunts, struggling against the grab, managing to hit him on the back of the knee hard. Prime yowls and yells in anger, rising his feet and digging his heel on Mara's wounded shoulder until she stops fighting, crying in pain.

Prime clicks his tongue against his teeth, pulling from Mara's hair as he drags her towards the center of the room, throwing her over hard wood. He climbs over her, smacking his own gun over the opposite wall, wrapping his hands instead around her base of her neck, holding her down.

"She burnt with her sins in the end and she deserved it, just as the bitch she was fucking deserved what she got too," he closes his hands around Mara's neck, digging his elbow purposefully over the wound. Mara trashes around, ankles slipping on the wet floor as she tries to get him off, pressing her hand against his cheek and pushing his face away, smearing blood over his face and hair.

Prime shakes her over the ground again, pinning her down with a harsh blown. "I will make of this town what it always should have

been. A purified place, free of the impurity you and your kind have brought to this place," he presses down, cutting Mara's oxigen. She gasps, clawing at the empty floor, trying to find anything to defend herself without luck. "I will hunt, *every single one of them* off this town until everyone is what it should."

Mara feels the blood drain of her head, dizzy and lightheaded as the oxigen stops from arriving to her brain, Prime's hands still firmly pressed against the base of her throat. He is not speaking anymore, grunting like a animal only as he tries to choke her out.

Mara is starting to inmmensely feel out, heart pumping like crazy inside her chest as it tries to compensate the chaos, dark spots clouding her vision either by the lack of air or the blood still pooling off the wound in her shoulder. Everything hurts. Her skin, her muscles, her chest, even her bones are screaming. Absently and almost out of reality anymore, Mara wonders if this is how Catrina felt and it only manages to enrage her more.

There is a rush of extremely cold breeze behind Prime's back, the plastic sheets flopping over the open holes of the windows. The wood of the floor cracks under new weight, thunder breaking the sky in pieces, hiding the sound of steps before everything quiets down and the voice rises.

"Hey, Prime"

Prime raises his head in time just as the baseball bat swings, hitting him on the face violently. He gets flung to the side, rolling over the floor and against the body of the bell. Mara gasps as the breath returns to her lungs in a rush, rolling away from him and on her knees to the other side, raising her head lightly from the floor to see.

Glimmer is holding the white bat like a dangerous weapon, both hands wrapped around the handle, the white paint over the bat's wood stained in a splash of red from where it crashed against Prime's nose and broke it again. She is panting heavily, soaked for the rain from head to toe, her bomb lilac and turquoise jacket

barely covering her at all. But nothing of that matters right now because the expression on her face is something else. Cold as ice as holds the weapon high above her eyes, staring down at Prime as he struggles to stand up again with such ire she seems to have torn him into pieces inside her mind a hundred times now.

Prime swings to Glimmer's direction, filled with fury, gushing blood from his nose like a fountain, one of his eyes narrowed, almost shit close where the tip of the bat catched it violently. He bares his teeth, stomping on the floor and pulling off his hair.

"I'm going to kill you!" he screams. Yells. Howls. Kicking the heavily hard copper of the bell until it vibrates completely. "I'm going to fucking will you both!"

Mara gasps, wanting to stand up but falling again, Glimmer doesn't waver on her position. That's when the rest walk out of the shadows of the staircase. They are all here, some of them carrying baseball bat's, others heavy sticks of steel. Their faces mirror Glimmer. Firm and unmoving, cold against the rain that makes them look even more dangerous. They are young and they are angry, all of them. Bow, Mermista, Hawk, Lonnie, Perfuma. And in the back, the hazelnut shade of Adam Grey's now cut short hair, staring at Prime as someone would stare a fly on their food. Or maybe, even, a prey.

Prime stares at them all like he couldn't believe his eyes, gurgling in blood and still laughing around it as if he couldn't believe the scene before his very eyes. He raises his arms and stretches them to the sides, taunting the group and a loud cackle.

"What? Are you the justice team or something now? Am I supposed to be scared?" Prime lowers his arms and makes an intimidating motion towards them, challenging them to actually do it, actually expecting them not to. What are you going to do? Kill me? Is that what you are going to do, wonder boy? You don't have the fucking balls"

Mara's eyes are locked on Adam's cold profile so she misses when Bow moves forward first, sharp and quick as an arrow and just as lethal. Prime doesn't see him either because he barely has time to flinch or even grimace in surprise before the length Bow's own bat hits him in the face fully, sending him stumbling back over the floor.

Mara gasps in surprise, resting her weight on her hands and knees as she stares at the scene. Prime rolls to the side and spits on the floor, saliva, blood and what looks frightening enough like a few teeth. His eyes snap to the friends, running them over like daggers, brutal and violent, straightening up and then scrunching as if he were to charge over them.

Mara watches as the group starts walking towards him, slow and contemplating, and she tries to exclaim a warning, yell them to walk away because she knows how dangerous people like this can be, but her throat gives away and with it her voice, strained and still in pain from Prime's attack. Perfuma and Hawk separate from the group and rush next to her, steading her on the floor with their hands over her back and upper arms, Perfuma pressing a torn piece of her long dress against the wound of Mara's shoulder. But also, somehow, pinning her down into place, incapable of move away as the rest, still in complete silence, circle Prime.

Prime tries to make an escape through the side of the room but Mermista and Lonnie's intercept him, pushing a scaffold from the wall so it blocks his way, the heavily filled paint cans rolling and spilling open into the floor, almost knocking over Prime's legs and making him stumble backwards, closer to the open windows.

Glimmer lets go of her weapon, dropping it loudly into the floor, and marches directly to Prime, knocking him out with a harsh slap on the face. Prime tethers back, frighteningly closer to the open edge, grinding his bloody teeth. He stretches a hand quickly and tries to get a hold from Glimmer's hair to pull himself towards her. Bow pushes him away harshly, growling, so instead, Prime holds himself from the frame of the window, running his eyes over all of them before smiling deviously.

"So this is where your moral standard lies? Do you think *this* will make you feel better about what happened to your little friend?" He laughs, enjoying the furious expression that crosses the people in front of them. Prime licks his teeth, smudging red there, even beaten and scrunched over slightly, his muscles tense and his head is held straight. He doesn't think he is in the wrong. He is proud of what he has done, and that, is the scariest thing of them all. "You are not better than me"

There is a moment of charged silence that crosses everyone in the room where even the rain seems to lay suspended on time, waiting. Bow, Mermista, Lonnie, even Perfuma and Hawk next to Mara seem to be tense. Glimmer opens and closes her hands to her sides, the right one stained in blood where it hit against Prime's skin. There are errand tear tracks made on her damp cheeks but she remains stoic as she regards him, not even recoiling at his words or the horrifying look on his face.

"We know what you did. You tried to own her like a piece of meat you could take whenever you wanted. And when you couldn't you attacked her, like you attacked the person she loved." She gasps for breath but doesn't stop, fire burning in her dark eyes and it's at that moment that Mara realizes that, whatever they've come to do here, they've come to make Prime stop. "You are cruel and evil. *You* are a *monster* "

A thunder breaks in the sky, followed by another and one more, so close to the tower that every single hair in Mara's arms and scalp stands on point. Rain whips heavily on Bow's face when he speaks too, making his eyes look deep like black holes and endless constellations.

"We are cowards, and we will live with that forever. But we are *nothing* like you. And you? You will live what you have left of life knowing that"

Prime's face is terrible as Bow says every single one of the words, falling from the clear disdain and cruelness on his face to something much more angrier, sticky as venom, and completely

honest, the true reach of his actual feelings showing clearly on his face. Mara can't hear their voices anymore over the ripple of the thunder and rain around them but she sees their meaning clear as eau over Prime's pulped out face as it shifts and contorts impossible so in anger.

Prime moves suddenly, convulsing in sudden rage, violent and almost out of his mind, growling, grunting and gasping, hitting himself, the window and the floor and everything in between with the outburst as he throws his arms forward seemingly to rush towards Bow and Glimmer. It's violent and uncaring. Terrifying and stupid because the wet wood of the window barely even restored at all cracks and breaks under his weight and years of rot, making him tether over the window's edge and backwards.

He manages to hold himself from the frame at the same time a hand shoots forward from the shadows behind Bow and Glimmer, lightly wrapping around his shirt and holding him from the edge. Adam's blue eyes bore themselves on Prime's pale and bloodshot ones, staring down at him like one would stare, not even a pest or worse, but something completely unworthy to even stare at. Something monstrous and disgusting. Something that killed someone he loved.

Adam's upper lip recoils over his gums, teeth flashing under the lighting's silver light. His hand curls around Prime's bloodied shirt, pulling him closer to his face just enough to spit the words directly on his face.

"I told you to stay away from my sister"

What happens next, nobody will ever know for sure. Maybe the frame gave away under the water and years of poor care. Maybe Prime's grip failed and he simply couldn't hold himself to the wood anymore. Maybe the rotten floor just crumbled below his feet, too quick for anyone to ever see it coming or stop it.

Maybe, just maybe, Adam let go.

The friends will never speak about it out loud, holding it inside their chests until their graves. In fact, nobody will ever even wonder about what happened. Things are like this. Suddenly, when all evil has been casted away, there is no need to talk about it anymore.

Mara blinks and then Prime is gone, quick and easy, easier than it should. If she focuses on her own dizziness, the heavy rain and the throbbing pain of her shoulder, she can almost drown out the sound of bone cracking against the asphalt of the street below the tower bell. If she closes her eyes tight enough, she can ignore the way her chest lifts with something too close to relief, the tight knot that had made its home there losing.

Instead, Mara can finally lean back against the floor, send a quick mourn above and hope they are, at last, at peace.

Halloween Night

1985

An hour before midnight

"Don't leave"

"I have to"

"Why? Why can't you just… stay with me?"

"Because I have to. You know I have"

"You always say that"

""I'm sorry. Please, I don't want to fight again, I just can't stay, not tonight"

"Yes. I know"

"Please look at me"

"..."

"It'll get better. I'll make them leave you alone. And I'll see you tomorrow, alright? And every single day after that"

"...alright"

"I love you. So much"

"I know"

The dawn of the next day

November 7th, 1985

The club house

People's capacity to move on is surprising sometimes. One day, everything is whispered, rushed words passed back and forth between people until it gets all swept under the carpet. One day there are people swiping blood from the fountain marble and bagging two bodies of bad people and the next, the square is full again. One day, there are harsh words against love, and the next, there are flowers.

The Major gets fired. Among other things Mara still needs to say, his corruption on the election, deviation of resources and complicity with the disappearance of the corpse of the sheriff's wife are enough reasons to take him out and sent to justice in the next town. It's not very hard, if people are honest. He was kind of pathetic to begin with.

Kurr's murder and Prime's dead are whole other thing. Prime's actions and confession, the reveal of his attempt of assault, Adora's and Catra's murder, their love, it all comes up, bubbling like boiling lava and spikling beyond the very limits of the Town. It doesn't take much for the story to travel beyond Eternia, which doesn't please the First Ones at all, but they deserve it. Anything, whatever if that means they get to change, even if only to please

the eye of the rest of the Etheria. After all, the world *is* a better place out there. Eternia will have to change.

But for that, Mara must make something right first.

Besides the events of the last day, the club is buzzing with people, having breakfast and talking a mile per hour with each other. Things are still fresh in many people's minds and the brutality of it all will take a while to truly be forgotten.

When Mara walks in, whoever, everything goes deadly silent, even the clank of forks and glasses quieting down. That's good, it's better like this, full of people that can watch. In a way, it feels good to know people will speak about this.

Mara makes her way through the tables full of food and clean white carpets until she reaches the furthest window, the one that is floor to high roof showered with warm sunlight where the biggest, most expensive spot is reserved. There is only one table there and it's full of people who look rich enough to be disgusting and who also quiet down when Mara approaches.

Weaver is sitting on the head of the table, elegantly drinking from a cup of tea, not even raising her eyes when Mara approaches the table. There is a moment of charged silence after which the rest of the table finally gets into motion, men and women standing up quickly and making their way to other tables, nodding in recognition at Mara as they walk past her. She couldn't care less, though, it has never been the approval of these people what she seemed for.

"Mrs, Weaver," Mara greets, resting her free hand over her hip. Her wounded shoulder is heavily bandaged and resting in a fabric cast, slowly beginning the process of healing. Doctor Bright-Moon had insisted for her to rest a little bit longer than a day but there were some things that just couldn't wait.

Weaver lowers down her cup of tea and cleans her mouth with a napkin after which she finally looks up, regarding Mara's presence

with a small smile.

"Detective," she signals at one of the chairs next to her with her palm, "please, take a seat"

Mara does so, never once taking her eyes away from the woman. Weaver keeps smiling at her tight and collected, both of them doing a good job ignoring the silence of the club around them only broken by the errand plate and cup passed back and forth.

"You've done such excellent work, detective. You should be proud of yourself." Weaver says, resting her hands over the pure white tablecloth.

"Well, I wouldn't have been able to do it without the help of my partner and the good will of the good people of this town," Mara says, just as tightly. "And without Adora, of course."

"Of course, that poor girl. Such a waste," Weaver says, still smiling broadly. "What an awful thing to happen, isn't it?"

"Indeed. Luckily, the truth always, *always,* comes to light." Mara says back, returning the smile. Weaver's eyes darken slightly but she doesn't break her pose, leaning back on her high chair. Her red dress covers just enough of her collarbones, the tight black curtain of hair falling at either side of her face and chest. She is a beautiful woman, all dark, rich skin and gorgeous eyes, and yet, the darkness living inside her is too great to look past by.

"And the Major? What will happen now with our administration?"

"He will be sent to Etheria's law to receive what he deserves as well as the sheriff's department. Only time will tell what's next, it's not like they were doing something at all, outside covering murders" Mara states, loud enought that the entire club house can hear her. "I have understood that Micah Bright-Moon will step on his shoes for now and then will run a true, honest election," Mara says, tapping her fingers over the table. "I trust, however, that the town will want to keep him in charge. He is a good man"

"Of course he is. I've known him since we were young, actually, we were pretty close before he met his… wife," Weaver's nose wrinkles as she speaks, an obvious give away before she relaxes again, eyes sparkling with a new thought. "I've seen his daughter, Glimmer. She is a very promising young woman too."

Mara bites into her tongue, still staring at her even when Weaver resumes her drink, slowly slipping from the cup. Purposely. Mara waits until she is done to speak again.

"Just as promising as Catrina was, of course."

"Of course," Weaver agrees between her teeth, "But you, the burdens a mother can carry with her children are sometimes too great," Weaver sighs, locking her hands in front of her. She acts as if she was extremely tired, dropping her shoulders lightly and shaking her head. "But it's all in the past now. I've forgiven her for everything now."

Mara's nails dig in the tablecloth as Weaver speaks, almost tearing the fabric with the pull.

"I haven't gotten the opportunity to thank you, detective, for revealing what Prime Kurr did. Also such a shame"

"I'm just doing my job," Mara says, biting into the inner side of her cheek. "However, Prime won't be charged post-mortem for Catrina's dead"

Weaver stops halfway as she pushes part of her hair over her shoulders, dragging her eyes back to Mara.

"And why is that?"

"Because Prime Kurr didn't kill Catrina" Mara snaps, leaning over the table until she is facing Weaver completely. "You did"

It shouldn't come as a surprise. It was all there, for years. The hidden bruises, carefully calculated so they would hide easily on clothes. The lack of interest in a child's well being. Old clothes, a

locked room in the attic. Harsh, violent words and phrases. It's all there, placed to the eyes of the people of the town. They knew of course, but nobody did anything. But what others didn't want to see, Mara saw clearly. It was in Adora's demeanor, in the rasp of her voice when she begged for justice, in the way she had tried to wrap herself around her to shield her even a little, until it was too much and, suddenly, in a blink, both of them were gone. That's how life is sometimes, one day we are here and the next, we are gone. That's why we try to make things good for us and the people we love every day, even if the world is against us.

Weaver's expression doesn't change. She is an abuser but she is also manipulative and lacks empathy for anything but for herself, and she is a damn good actor too, she has done this her entire life after all.

"Detective, please," Weaver says, high and sweet, almost scolding her. "You are talking nonsense now."

Mara has grown tired of being talked like that inside this godforsaken town.

"You know, I almost believed you hadn't done it. I mean, I knew you were a piece of shit from the first moment I saw you, but you almost fooled me," Mara says, all decency thrown out of the window. She can hear the faint gasp of some guests behind her. "It was very smart, asking for Kurr not only to rule it as an accident when we found her body but to make him order Oscar to cremate her. I guess he owed it to you after you helped him get promoted as sheriff after a very generous payment to the town hall."

Weaver slams her hand over the table, finally losing her posture, making the glass twinkle together and fall, spilling white wine and tea over the surface.

"Detective, this is outrageous. I wasn't on my house that night, I was at-"

"A dinner with Hordak, Prime and Kurr? Yeah, I don't think so," Mara interrupts her, almost smiling. "Hordak is talking, Mrs. Weaver and you never were there. And I think he will do anything to reduce his punishment, especially, uncover you."

Weaver clicks her teeth together, fisting the fabric on her hands. Mara doesn't let her speak again. "I know you planned for Adora to be with Prime alongside Kurr. I guess you expected to act as a mentor for her after her mother was gone, but it didn't work all like you wanted." Mara chews on the words. "Catrina was truly a stone on every single of your plans, wasn't she? She not only kept Prime away, she kept *you* away from Adora. And what's even worse of it all, Adora fell in love with her."

Mara pulls a torn piece of paper from the front pocket of her jacket, placing it over the table. It's wrinkled and ripped without care but the bubbly handwriting inside is still slightly visible.

"I payed you a visit the other day, but you weren't there, so I *looked* around for a while. You are very good cleaning, Mrs. Weaver, but I guess throwing out the fireplace ashes and trash can be forgotten for anyone."

Mara then pulls out her recorder again, resting it next to the pieces of paper and flipping it on once more. Adora's voice, tired but firm, fills the room one more time, a haunting ghost of what could have been slipping inside the town's bones with her truth.

"I sent Catra a note on Halloween night," Adora's voice says, *"I climbed up her window and left it on the frame. I knew it was dangerous because her mother was at home that night, but she wasn't speaking to me. I was so worried."*

"I asked her to see me at the treehouse. I waited there for a while. I thought she wasn't going come, but she did"

"We fought. It was horrible, we had never fought like that before. But I was so scared Prime was going to hurt her for defending

me, and I loved her so much. I don’t think you understand how it was that night. It was so much”

“Catra kept saying she heard things outside the treehouse. She was frantic that someone could be watching us that night. I went to look around but I found nothing, just a small fallen tree on the edge of the road and forest animals.”

“I had to leave. I left her that night even after everything, Itold her that I would see her in the morning and left. I should have stayed. If I had known it was the last time, I would have stayed until the end with her, I would have died with her. I should have come back”

The tape runs out and so it's the sound. The room of the club house is so quiet even the tiniest of the pins falling on the floor could be hear right now.

"You were there, you followed them," Mara continues. She is on heavy painkillers and her shoulder throbs with the pain of the shoot, but the blood inside her veins boils hotter than anything else. "I saw your car the first day, quite a bump it had"

"I had a little accident on the road"

"Yeah. Was it too dark you didn't saw the tree or you were just too drunk to even notice it?" That manages to bring an angry scowl out of Weaver.

Mara's pleased smile dies down immediately, replaced by a sour stare. "You are pathetic, you shouldn't even be given the title of mother at all. You put your plans for Adora first as if you possessed any of them to begin with and when you found out about them, you just couldn't take it."

Weaver remains impassive, scowling as she runs her red tongue over white teeth, not even a glimpse or remorse running through her face.

"Tell me what happened," Mara asks, sharply. When the silence just stretches she slams her good hand over the table, knocking the last of the glasses into the ground, shattering is small pieces. "Tell me!"

October 31th, 1985

Halloween

11.00 pm

Catra makes her way inside the house, climbing over the backyard tree and into the roof, easily slipping inside the attic through the open door. It's easy, as easy as breathing, she has done it a hundred times and she has great strength and elasticity, Catra knows exactly what to do.

She is dizzy, still flustered from her night in the woods. Her hair is ruffled, barely held down on the thick braid Adora had done before they parted ways, and her cheeks are bright red, eyes glimmering with the shadow of Adora's touch on her back and waist, her mouth on Catra's pulse and the corner of her lips and her anger in her veins. The way Adora kissed her may have as well trip her into a mild heart attack, all teeth and tongue and desperate lips against the sturdy wall of their tree house.

Catra almost forgot she was angry. Almost.

The fight after had been as fired up as the kisses had been. Harsh words against biting kisses, yells and accusations against hairs pulled and shirts disheveled. Catra was still wearing Adora's pink sweater out of sheer spite, lavender perfume clinging to her skin like rain to leaves.

The fight still doesn't leave Catra's body, but the passion of it doesn't either. Right now, all Catra wants to do is fall into her bed and sleep. Shower can wait, just for the sheer narcissistic instinct to cling into Adora's smell a little longer.

Catra jumps off the frame and, uncharacteristically, trips with the bare floor, stumbling hard into the ground. She groans, annoyed and mildly confused, feeling with the pads of her fingers the bare woods, gone all her blankets and the old mattress Adora secretly helped her to drag all the way up here years ago.

The sound of paper wrinkling makes her raise her head, locking eyes for the first time with the eerie presence in the attic, sitting in Catra's precariously chair with her legs crossed and her long, red dress wrapped around her.

" Treehouse at nine?" *Weaver's voice reads out loud, and it's with the worst sense of dread that Catra realizes she forgot to bring Adora's note with her before leaving,* " I'm sorry, let me explain. I *love* you, A"

Weaver drags the last sentences before she lowers down the paper, folding it slowly, movement purposeful as she grips the opposite sides and rips it in half and then again and again, throwing them into the floor of the attic. Catra watches the tiny pieces of the paper fall sadly, Adora's round, bold letters peeking through the torn pieces.

Catra's heart is hammering inside her chest, pounding on the inside of her ears and making her dizzy. She wants to puke and scream in fear, recoil and throw herself off the fucking window if she needs to. But she freezes instead, barely even managing to raise into her feet, pressing her back against the wall. She feels like she is being run over for a wave of electricity, locking every single of her nerves and muscles into place. It's one thing that Weaver berates - verbally and physically - for all the things the town day about her, for just being herself. It's another thing the witch knows who it is, another thing for her to knows about Adora.

"You've done nothing but embarrass me your entire life. How could I ever have a thing like you?" Weaver says, loud and hurtful, digging inside Catra's heart like they always do, even when she covers the flinch with a sour face.

This time, though, Catra does flinch, pulling from the sleeve of Adora's sweater in anxiety. Weaver follows the movement, her eyes narrowing and pupils shrinking at the sight of the cloth. It's obvious it's not Catra's, not even the light blue jeans. Weaver's eyes focus on Catra's chest, digging in it until Catra squirms. He hand moves on it's own, wrapping her palm over the golden locket there, unsuccessfully hiding it away from Weaver's raged stare.

"You've always been a disappointment, Catrina, but I had you for someone smarter than this," Weaver stands up, approaching Catra's tense body. Weaver sizes her by the wrist pulling her off the wall painfully, almost making her trip and fall into the ground again.

Catra shakes herself off her frozen state, pulling from Weaver's grip, groaning when the strength of the hold makes the fragile bones of her wrist complain in pain.

" Let go of me!" Catra yells, clawing at Weaver's perfectly manicured hand with her nails. Weaver shakes her like a ragdoll, dragging her in the attic towards the small trapdoor on the floor.

"I know what you did. You are a disgrace" Weaver hisses, towering over Catra menacingly.

"I said let go!"

***"** I saw you. How dare you bring Adora into your shame?" She growls. Catra stares at her, momentarily stopping her struggle. All the blood drains from her face, sickly pale as realization washes over her, like the echo of muted footsteps over dry leaves she heard as Adora pressed her against the walls and bit gently on her jaw.*

"You followed me," Catra mutters, shaky. Weaver's darkened eyes dig into hers, her upper lip retracting over her lip. For a second, Catra braces for the hit - wouldn't be the first - but it never comes, tethering over the edge of the door.

Weaver pushes her down the attic stairs. Catra feels herself suspended in the air, sauntering down for a second too long before she crashes against the floor. She definitely has a sprained wrist but she is lucky she doesn't break her neck or her skull, but all the air inside her lungs comes out with the hit, leaving her wheezing and gasping at the floor in pain.

Catra blinks away the tears from her eyes, rolling over her tummy to crawl at the floor, fighting to reach the start of the stairs. She feels like in a fucking horror movie, chased by a monster as hear Weaver climb down the stairs too, following her across the second floor of the house slowly, almost enjoying Catra's desperate tries to leave.

Catra manages to grip the rail of the stairs, pushing herself up as she starts the hurried, torturous way down. Her chest is struggling, screaming with pain where the air is fighting to reach the inside of her lungs.

Catra reaches for the back pocket of her jeans, grasping her inhaler to take a deep breath out of it and then another, barely helping her tame down the pain of her chest, but enough to help her manage her way down the stairs.

Weaver follows her up close, barely even straining herself to reach Catra at all. She leans against the bottom of the stairs, staring as Catra makes it to the door, yanking off the doorknob just to find it shut close tightly.

Catra yells, frustrated, hitting the tinted glass with her palm with no use before turning around, facing Weaver and her mocking stare.

"What angers you more, Weaver?" Catra wheezes, biting on each of the words, rage overtaking her own sense of self preservation. "That it is Adora, or that Adora choose me *and not all the sick fucking plans you were making for her?"*

Weaver snarls, walking to Catra and grasping her from the back of the neck, dragging her from the hair again, this time towards the living room, brightly illuminated by the chandelier on the roof. There is an empty bottle of wine and a halfway drank glass over the table, not a strange sight in the house, Catra can smell the rancid share of alcohol on Weaver's mouth when she leans towards the girl.

"Insolent child. I've come to expect such disgraceful behavior from you, but I won't allow you to drag Adora down as well" Weaver's voice echoes inside the room, making even the glass of the windows shake. Absently, Catra wonders if the neighbors can hear the screaming, she wonders if any of them care. "A brilliant future awaits for her. When Prime becomes Major, she will have everything, and once she does she will need someone to guide her through it, someone that treats her like a daughter"

Catra gasps against the grip, spitting to Weaver's face as she bares her teeth at her. She is scared as shit, but the anger boils deeper at the ring of Adora's name on Weaver's mouth. As if the woman Catra loves were nothing else but a toy to be traded for something 'bigger', and not her own person.

"And who will that be? You? You couldn't even take care of your own daughter" Catra sizzles, her own words stinging in the back of her tongue. It hurts, knowing your mother doesn't love you, that she is capable of hurting you like this, it hurts.

"You've been a nuisance for me from the moment you were born. I will not allow you to jeopardize Adora's future for a stupid tantrum like this"

If Catra wasn't sure of Adora's words for her, they would cut her inside like a sharpened blade, leaving her bleeding out. If she didn't know Adora's night terrors of becoming something she is not, of being turned into what Weaver, and Prime, and the First One's want of her, Catra would tether on her own resolve and hesitate, be unsure of herself and Adora's love. She had done it, just a few hours ago, after their fight in the gym and later in the

treehouse. As long as they lived in that town, around these people, that fear would never go away, but Catra held herself to Adora's words against her skin. It's the only thing she has right now, inside the spider-like grip of this woman.

“You’ll only manage to hurt her. After everything the town says about you already. Why would Adora want to throw away her future for someone like you?”

That makes it for Catra to snap out of it. She stretches her hand and digs her nails in Weaver's neck, dragging down purposely and painfully, ripping expensive silk and drawing angry red lines and blood on the pale neck there. Weaver yowls in rage and pain letting go from Catra just enough for her to stumble back lightly, violently cleaning her tearful eyes with the back of her hand

“What they say about me? Do you have any idea what the assholes you seek say behind your back once you are gone?” Catra screams at the top of her lungs, straightening her back. She smirks at Weaver's stunned, ragged face, mocking her even if she is out of breath. “Sharon Weaver. She had nothing until she managed to tangle her husband. That's *the only reason she is what she is, she has what she has. He didn’t even love her. She only managed to kept him at her side for the baby, nothing else”*

“Be quiet, you brat!"

"The society and the power you so much seek sees you as nothing! And they'll turn their backs on you when you run out of things you can cling onto to remain important"

Weaver slaps Catra on the face, making her lose her precarious balance. She trips with the table and falls into the hard floor, knocking the wine on her way down. It spills over the wood like blood, staining the rich brown into a deeper shade of red, splashing over the hem of Weaver's dress.

Weaver sneers as Catra rasps for breath, her lungs closing suddenly with the scare and the pain. Out of the corner of her

eye, Catra sees Weaver lean towards the floor, taking something and straightening again with the little object in her hands. Wheezing and completely exhausted Catra looks at her from behind her tears, catching sight of her blue inhaler on Weaver's hand as the witch throws it into the lighted fireplace. Catra whimpers as she looks at the hard plastic melting and the fragile medicine bottle snapping in pieces under the pressure of the heat.

Catra's side is fired up from where she fell over the table and her wrist is screaming, but nothing of that compares to the pain of her chest and throat and the desperation in her head at the sight of the inhaler snapping into pieces.

"Look at you, you can't even fucking breath," Weaver spats, "I won't let you take away everything I've worked on so hard."

Catra leans against the seat of the couch to stand up, stumbling over her own feet as she makes her way through the living room and towards the back door of the kitchen. Weaver doesn't even try to stop her, staring at her as she tumbles with everything around her.

The kitchen door is miraculously unlocked and Catra manages to swing it open, rushing into the backyard and towards the woods. Maybe, just maybe, she is able to reach the treehouse she would make it. Adora is long gone already, probably safes tucked inside her bed, unaware of everything

"Run away! Is the only thing you have ever been good at!" Catra hears Weaver yell behind her, there, out in the open.

Catra stumbles into the woods, her mother's steps following her close behind. What happens in the woods takes place as it is. Hands on throat and the biting cold water of the river. And then it 's over.

Mara leans over the table and tugs down the fabric of the red dress and the heavy pearls of her necklace, revealing the skin below. Halfway healed scratches live in there, deep and ragged by desperate, broken nails, red as the fabric of the killer's dress and the blood of the one that is already gone, from the angle of the shoulder to the start of the collarbones, undeniable and dark. The cord of the necklace gives away, the shimmering beads scattering all over the table and floor, rolling one after the other, no longer perfect.

Mara leans back on her seat, her hand closed into a tight fist, frustrated by Weaver's deadly silence. She won't say anything, even if she knows she is done for, taking the truth of that horrible night with her. In fact, she leans back over her chair too, chewing on her silence for a second longer before she speaks, in a whisper, to Mara, barely audible above the space between them.

"You are never going to be able to prove that," Weaver says and her tone is condescending, the kind of voice of someone that knows perfectly well what she has done and she is going to be able to get away with it. "A torn piece of paper is not enough to accuse me of anything, which by the way, I'll talk about breaking into my property with the proper authorities after our brunch, and poor Adora's words aren't specific enough to accuse me of being there or not at all. I'm afraid none of this will be enough"

"In that, we agree Mrs. Weaver," Mara says suddenly, cutting Weaver's confidence plainly in two. She leans towards her bag, grasping the expensive red file from it and resting it over the table simply. Weaver's face goes through a hundred emotions at once, marble mask of a face cracking in the edges and limits under the sight of the almost inoffensive looking file.

Mara grasps the corners of the file and opens it, clearing her throat to start reading. Weaver shoots forward then, stretching her hand over the table like a disembodied claw grasping the tablecloth, almost snatching the paper away until Mara leans backwards, away from her touch.

“Stop this,” Weaver hisses, looking around her swiftly, but her secrecy is in vain, everyone is already blatantly looking and hearing.

“This is a copy of the last will and testament of Sebastián Martínez,” Mara read outloud, high and strong, “on which he declares that, in case of his dead, all his possessions including the mansion located in Eternia with all what is inside, the brand new car and the entirety of his fortune, is to be inherited completely to his only daughter, Catrina María Martínez when she turns the legal adult age of eighteen years old. Until she turns of age, not a single coin of the inheritance shall be touched or used by a third person in which case they would have to pay back the entirety of the expenses to the inherited.”

Mara lowers the thick file back into the table, full of terms and a long list of even more expensive belongings, long lost at the hands of a pin abusive woman that had no right to call herself mother in the first place. Mara pushes the file towards Weaver, though the latter doesn’t even touch it, and pulls a second file from her bag, also placing it in front of her. This time, the one with the condescending tone is Mara herself.

“You changed Catrina’s last name to yours and made her a second birth certificate so she wouldn’t be legally recognized as your late husband’s daughter,” Mara explains out loud, like talking to a little kid that knows exactly what they have done, “And last year, when his testament arrived and was opened for Catrina’s eighteen birthday, you asked Hordak to hide it and got made an illegal succession of rights that made *you* the sole executed of all his assets. You had already spent most of the money during thirteen years anyway,” Mara points at the curly, tight signature at the bottom of the fake succession, smiling lightly. “This is *your* signature after all, right?”

Weaver stares down at the paper and then to Mara, fury burning behind her dark eyes. She opens her mouth but Mara shuts her right up again. “Please don’t bother to deny it Mrs. Weaver, Hordak sold you out pretty quickly. He told us everything, and I’m

sure the nice detectives waiting outside will also find, pretty quickly, the original testament inside the house. Any smart person committing fraud would have gotten rid of it, but narcissistic people such as you just can't help yourself. Which, by the way, reminds me to let you know that you should also clean the back of the fireplace. Little pieces of the inhaler may have escaped your cleaning there."

Weaver slams her hands on the table, standing up in a rush. Her mask has broken completely now, rage and hatred clear on every single one of her factions. "This is outrageous! Nobody here will ever believe such a ridiculous invention!"

She looks around her, expecting, her back straight. She is waiting for anyone to stand up and defend her, to claim the absurdity if it all and maybe even yell at Mara, or kick her out. But there is nobody there that will speak for her or cover her, not anymore. In fact, the expression of the guests inside the expensive house club is that of raw disgust. They are looking at her as something less, something unworthy and nasty, their noses held up and wrinkled, some of them even with their backs towards her, fully and completely shutting her out of the things she had given most importance to. Power.

Suddenly, one woman stands up, so white her skin looks almost red on the cheeks and neck. Weaver smiles broadly, clearly relieved to which she thinks is an attempt to defend her. Turns out, it is the complete opposite.

"She was the one that asked me to ban Catrina from the Prom," Miss Darling says loudly, looking at Mara when she speaks but peeking at Weaver with clear disgust, "I don't know if she knew about the plans of that evil boy, but thanks goodness Catrina went anyway, she was such a smart student,"

"The top of her class I heard!" joins another.

"Poor creature! She and Adora had such a promising future"

“It’s monstrous what they’ve done to them! Monstrous!”

“And to steal the inheritance! What an absolute lack of shame!”

“We’ve all known Sebastián was only with her for the baby. I guess she never thought he would try to make sure she didn’t get a single coin!”

“He knew very well what kind of person she was!”

“Such a good man too”

“Monstrous I say!”

One by one, all the voices inside the club start to rise along their owners, loud and high, echoing inside the clubhouse until almost everyone in there is either talking, nodding along or pointing accusatory at Weaver. One more person stands up, an older woman that looks as expensive as she stands, with rich skin and thick curls around her face that make her look crowned and taller than anyone else. Everything in her screams social position and money and, with a shiver, Mara realizes this is Hope's grandmother, looking at Mara with a heavy expression before speaking.

"I live in the Mansion in front of her," she says, quieting everybody else. Mara knew it was a possibility, Mara had spent long evenings in that house with Hope, but after everything that happened she thought she had maybe moved out too. But the glimmer in the woman's eyes when she looks at Mara, tells her she remembers her. And her words, as now, have always carried an important weight with them. "I saw her that night arrive at the house. Her headlight was broken and she stumbled when she walked out. She has always been an abuser and a drinker, and anyone that says they ignored that is just lying."

A murmur runs quickly through the people but Mara doesn't pay attention to it. Her eyes are locked with the woman's as she speaks, purposely. Because there is something Weaver can't beat

and that is the veracity of someone respectable that wants to mend things.

"I knew that girl. I saw grow up outside of that house and blow off like a candle when she stepped back in. She gifted me tulips when my husband died and I saw her fall in love, even if she never said it. It was written in her face." The woman takes a breath, blinking quickly, and Mara knows then that this is not only about Catrina anymore. "I heard her scream that night. There have always been yells from that house but this was different, it scared me. I called the sheriff but he told me to not worry about it and I- I didn't."

The old woman holds Mara's gaze for a second longer and then drops to the floor, age and years and memories reaching her finally. "I should have tried harder, done better. I'm sorry."

Mara exhales, almost out of breath and searches for the woman's gaze until she looks at her again, giving her a swift, understanding nod and a gentle smile. Then she turns back to Weaver, who is cornered between the window glass and the harsh, accusatory look of the people around them.

The doors of the house club open once more, Serenia and other detectives from Etheria walking in and towards the table, ready to take Weaver off. Mara wraps her hand around the woman and yanks her forward, even with the shoulder rest on, though the latter doesn't present resistance at all. Her eyes, instead, are wide as plates, staring around her as she quickly realizes that she has lost everything and nobody is going to help her anymore.

Mara leans towards her and speaks in a low voice, the true extent of her anger shining through her words.

"You are going to pay the rest of your life for what you did to her," Mara says between her teeth, smiling slightly when Weaver snaps her eyes at her. "But most important of all, you are going to *live* every single day of your life knowing that you didn't win. You ruin

people but no matter what you did to them to keep them apart, you lost."

Mara hands her to Serenia and the rest, standing there as she watches ber get dragged away, publicly humiliated. She almost thinks the people around them is going to start to boo on her way, though the heavy stares are just as satisfactory.

Weaver trips with her dress on her way and then starts yelling, lashing towards Serenia and the others and then Mara, shouting at the top of her lungs harsh words and even crueler sentences. But nobody listens to her anymore, and nobody will ever again.

Evening at the square

The stage is exactly the same as the one Hordak used in his speech, but the background is different.

By starters, the tower bell is heavily secured, high pieces of wood blocking the doors and windows. It's been cleaned up already but nobody really has a want to wander around it, at least not for now.

There is something else, at the fountain. The rain has cleaned the blood and the crushed petals and now, where first was a small altar, now there is a sea of flowers, overflowing the fountain and even the clear water inside. White and yellows and tender pinks, placed by the people of the town as they walk by. It's a sight to see, not even for the crowns of flowers hanging from the fountain columns, but for the photograph, tapped together after Prime's attack and placed carefully above the bed of flowers.

It's beautiful. Late, but beautiful.

Mara stands in front of the stage, staring down at the town. Most people are here, either out of curiosity or to gossip, le because they truly care. It's been quite a week for the town, after all.

Glimmer, Bow and their friends are standing in the side, closer to the flowers, arranging them carefully as they add more. They still look exhausted and the sadness will always love inside their eyes, but their shoulders are less tense and, at least, they are smiling to each other and to the fountain. Absently, Mara can see Perfuma slightly bumping with Lonnie, both of them blushing a light shade of pink at the touch. It's quick and a little bit nervous, with still swift glances around them to see if anyone has seen them, but it's honest. And even if someone does watch them, nobody says anything. It's good.

Mara clears her throat, facing the crowd. She waits until most of the chattering has quieted down to speak.

"Last night, the bodies of Sheriff Kurr and his son Prime, were taken into Eternia's local mortuary and then delivered to Etheria's custody. Post mortem charges will be raised against them for the murder of Adora Grey. The remains of Silvia Kurr have been located on the woods and will also be added to the post mortem charges. The sheriff department has been officially closed and defunded and is the wait of their own trail under charges of corruption, covering of murder and negligence," Mara wets her bottom lips, taking a deep breath. "This morning, Sharon Weaver was disposed to Etheria's squadron for falsification of official documents, theft and, most important of it all, the planned homicide of Catrina Weaver. She will be sent to Beast Island for a lifetime sentence."

A murmur of agreement rushes around the crowd, nodding to each other and Mara with pleased expressions. It bothers Mara deeply, it has been bothering her the entire day. She drags her eyes to the sides but Glimmer is already looking to the crowd too, wrinkling her nose before turning to Mara, her stare heavy, charged with unspoken words between both of them.

"There is something else," Mara says to the microphone, voice echoing on the square. Glimmer's eyes and her friends snap back to Mara, expecting, as if she already knew what Mara is going to say. Maybe she does. "There is another guilty on this"

A murmur raises again and someone in the crowd asks loudly. "Who?"

Mara doesn't even bother to look for the source of the voice, staring at one of the random neighbors. "You"

"Me?!" They ask, squeaky with surprise and indignation.

"Yes you" Mara says before turning to someone else, randomly, pointing at them too and then to the next and next. "And you. And you. And you." The crowd's voices are high now with confusion and indignation to which Mara just leans forwards over the microphone, frowning deeply.

"I want to make something very clear. All of you are as guilty of what happened as Prime, and Kurr and Weaver. Because you knew. You knew a girl was being abused by her mother and you did nothing. You knew a girl was being harassed by a boy, and you did nothing," she snaps, strongly. The murmur dies down immediately and instead of looking at each other proudly, the crowd looks ashamed, shifting uncomfortably in their feet and avoiding Mara's sharp gaze. "Because, instead of being cruel and indifferent to two people that loved each other more than anything, you could have been kind, and for that, you are guilty too."

Mara turns her eyes to Glimmer, who holds her gaze. Her cheeks are pale and her eyes red rimmed, mirroring Bow's next to her, and her friends behind. Infinitesimally small, Glimmer gives Mara a nod.

"So, instead of palming each other's backs because bad people paid for what they did, change. Be gentle with each other, understanding, respectful. Accept others even if you don't understand them, and show the kindness and bravery you wished other people would show for you. And make of that change Catra and Adora's legacy. Not victims or mártires for Eternia, but as two girls that loved each other and fought to be together. And even if

they are gone, build from that a better place, the place they deserved, for you and for the people you love.”

Mara takes a breath, letting the tears stuck in her eyes flow.

“That’s how you honor their memory. That’s how you’ll honor their love.”

November 8th, 1985

The cemetery

It’s a quiet funeral.

Their gravestones are placed next to the other, dark granite against the fresh moss of the cemetery. Their ashes are together, carefully placed into the ground. There are seeds scattered over the ground, in time, they will break and be born and a pine tree will grow from it, tall towards the sky, sibling of one that once held a treehouse and a sacred space. This one, instead, will shelter their story with its shadow, and warm the change their love will bring with the sunlight dancing through its leaves. It will be good.

There are only just a couple of people here, all of them surrounding the graves in a tight circle.. Glimmer and Bow are holding hands next to each other, Glimmer resting her head over Bow's shoulder, him cradling her close. Mermista and Hawk are next to Perfuma and Lonnie, embracing each other into a close hug. Angella and Micah are on the opposite side of them, standing quietly behind Adam, whose face is barely seen as he stares at the stones in the ground.

Mara has given them space, standing several feet behind them. The air is warm and clear and the cemetery is calm. Somehow, even with the sadness of it all, the air around the friends and the family feels lighter, like a weight that has been lifted from her shoulders.

At some point, the group starts to separate. The friends make their way over the grass, murmuring softly to each other. Angela and Micah stay behind, saying something to Adam before giving him a small hug and starting to walk back to the road too.

Glimmer raises her eyes to Mara, wrinkling her nose. She gives a swift look to her friends and separates from them, walking towards Mara until she is right in front of her.

"Detective"

"Hello Glimmer," Mara says, softly. "It was very beautiful what you did for them at the fountain."

Glimmer's nose wrinkles again but her shoulders relax slightly, nodding with a deep sigh. She knows Mara's words are honest. "Yeah, well, thank you for not snitching on us about that night."

Mara looks Glimmer meaningfully until the latter looks at her again. "You saved my life, Glimmer. You, Bow, Adam and your friends," Mara says, softly and honest. "What you went through was pretty scary and traumatizing, and you were very brave. Everything that came with it, in the end, had to happen one way or the other."

Mara softens her voice even more, smiling tiny and reassuring, nodding at the twin stones at Glimmer's back. "All of you should be very proud of yourselves. And I'm sure they would be proud of you."

Glimmer follows her eyes towards the graves, sighing deeply. There is some kind of sadness nested inside her eyes that will probably always live there. “We owe it to them,” she says, voice breaking with unshed tears. “We are family”

She finally tears her eyes away and back to Mara, taking an object from her purse, barely hidden by the ruffles of her black dress. She sorbs her nose, pushing back some treacherous tears before handing it to Mara with a firm hand.

"I still don't trust you, and didn't agree with this," Glimmer says, basically chewing on the words before sighing, placing the object on Mara's good hand, "but here, we want you to keep this"

It's the school's annuary, red cover and golden letters and all those things that make it a little bit less of a couple of photographs and a little bit more of a collection of memories. It is dated from that year and smells freshly printed, probably just taken from the rest to be delivered into Mara's care.

"It's so you don't forget us," Glimmer explains, still a bit strained, "And so you always remember what you did for them"

Mara states at it for a few seconds, her small smile melting into something much more sadder. She doesn't open it, can't really do much with one hand, but wraps her hand around it carefully, bringing it close to her chest with a tender stare.

"Thank you, Glimmer"

Glimmer nods, thoughtful, turning on her ankles, saying a quick goodbye before returning to Bow's side. Just as the first time Mara saw them, they walk together towards their cars, speaking in low voices. There won't be milkshakes and pom poms this time, replaced by black clothes and tearful cheeks, but they'll remind together and, eventually, they'll create the town they deserved to live and grow into.

Mara makes her way to Adam's side, standing next to him and following his gaze to the ground. He doesn't make a comment on her presence, barely standing there with his hands inside the pockets of his suit trousers and his face blank. Short hair looks good on him but it makes him look older, or maybe that is the perpetual melancholy etched in there for the rest of his life.

"You buried them next to each other," Mara says softly, staring at the smooth, beautiful stones. Adam huffs, without bite, shrugging lightly.

"Yeah. I- I figured they would have wanted to be together," he says, as if it wasn't such a big deal, as if it wasn't the last symbol of love he could ever do for his sister. Mara raises her eyes from the stone and towards Adam, her heart hammering painfully in regret and guilt.

"I'm sorry, Adam"

"It wasn't your fault," he says immediately, following the golden swirls of his sister's name over the stone. "Adora was dead the moment Catra died. I just- I wish I could have done more. I wish I could have honored them when they were here."

Mara knows how hard this is, fighting what one knows and changing for love. How difficult it is to live with guilt and regret and the perpetual thought of *What if* , so she doesn't try to persuade him otherwise. She doesn't say that Adora loved him too and that he did the best he could even if it was late. That confronting his sister's abuser was probably one of the hardest things a loved one of someone that has been violently taken from the world could ever do. She doesn't tell him that doing those for both of them, this patch of green and golden sky and dark stone, is a proof of love itself and that it is worth a thousand times more than any void word of consolation. Those are things that Adam will come to understand on his own, with time, and will be able to make peace with, just as he did with his parents before. Life goes on.

"I believe things will be better now, for others, thanks to them," Mara says instead, carefully. Adam huffs a tired chuckle but nods in agreement, brushing his hand over the smooth surface.

"I know they will. I just wish Eternia's salvation hadn't come at the cost of their lives," Adam confesses, biting in his inner cheek to keep himself at bay. "But, if they are going to become the heart of this, then I'm glad it is to make this damn world a better place."

Mara mediates on his words, letting silence surround them for a while. After the heavy rain, it has become a truly beautiful day.

"What are you going to do now?"

"Go to college, like everyone else, and get the fuck out of this place for a while," Adam straightens up, finally looking at Mara. His eyes are heavy but at peace. "Bow got the basketball scholarship, as he should. He is going to be a great surgeon very soon. And I heard Glimmer said she is going to take on psychology and social work. I think they will be fine too"

"I agree," Mara says with a smile. "Did you finish fixing your parents's car after all?"

Adam chuckles at the sky now, shaking his head. "No. I just- I guess in the end I understood the best thing I could do was let it go. For them too"

Mara feels her eyes sting at his words but holds it in, nodding in understanding. "I wish you luck then, Adam"

Adam turns towards her and offers her his hand, shaking it once, firm and grateful. "Thank you, Detective Grayskull, for what you did for them." Adam blinks, tears gathering in his blue, blue eyes. "You brought them peace"

After that he leaves, walking slowly through the rest of the cemetery, his face still towards the sky. He is walking towards his parents' own resting place, maybe to say hello, maybe to say goodbye.

Mara remains next to the girls' gravestones, calm and in silence. The dry leaves of the trees ruffle behind her as someone else starts to make her way towards Mara, calling her in a sweet, tender voice.

"Mara, dearie," Razz calls, approaching her way quicker for her age.

She is wearing a plain black dress, so much different from her usual bright pinks and blues, but there is a splash of color on her arms where she is holding a bouquet of bright sunflowers, the petals so yellow they almost look like suns when Razz finally reaches the twin gravestones and places them over their warm surface.

"For my girls," Razz whispers as an explanation or just a simple fact, caressing the stone with her wrinkled fingers lovingly.

Mara smiles candidly at the woman, wrapping her arms immediately around her old, bent over frame when Razz tip toes to embrace her into a kind hug, running Mara's back with her long fingers. Mara sighs, sinking in the hug, relaxing relieved finally and for the first time probably since she left this town over twenty years ago.

"Oh, I almost forgot it," Razz exclaims suddenly, parting from Mara just so she can reach inside the patched up pocket of her dress, taking out a folded piece of paper and handing it to her. "A few months ago, a very nice lady came to the diner. She came to visit her grandmother but she was looking for you," she explains, smiling.

Mara blinks, staring at the paper before opening it quickly. Inside, in bright black ink there is Hope's number, scribbled carefully. Below the numbers there is a small note, almost quiet even in the paper.

I'm still missing all about you

Mara exhales around a sob, heart losing free and pouring on the ground with the sudden strike of happiness, sadness chased off finally. Razz must feel it in her body because she cradles Mara softly, rocking her from side to side with a gentle voice.

"You did good, dearie," she says against the silence of the cemetery, "You did good."

When we die, our bodies will be scattered in the heavens as two constellations... And no one will have known happiness like ours.

– **Carmen Maria Machado** , *In the Dream House*

Chapter End Notes

Don't be sad because they are gone, be happy because above anything else they loved each other.

Again thank you so much for reading, for traveling this journey with me and for being there for them too. I'll see you all tomorrow at 1 am CT for our Matinée.

Did you find out what the truth was? Let me know in the comments below. Until tomorrow, love you all. Be good ♡

Matinée

Chapter Notes

I regret nothing

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Matinée

But love is impossible and it goes on

despite the impossible.

— *Bright Dead Things,* **Ada Limon**

November 9th, 1985

Mara walks the last steps of the dinner's second floor, sighing. There are a lot of sounds coming from the other side, cheerful 80s music, muffled chattering and laughter and the characteristic wound of plates clicking, forks and spoons and glasses. It sounds a little bit like Mara's childhood and that brings a smile to her face immediately.

She enters the room swiftly, taking in the delicious smells that surround her. Some people raise their dads as she walks past, nodding in greeting towards her before going on with their breakfast. It’s a kind image inside the dinner and warm as a candle. Razz is somewhere behind the counter of the kitchen, passing warm pies and hot chocolate one after the other, with the occasional ice cream soda going in and around. Kyle, the boy who helped Mara with the final recording, is helping her, almost tripping with his own shoes as he delivers the food, nervous but quick. The rest of the cheerleaders and basketball team are also there, with the exception of Glimmer and her friends, helping with empty plates and laughing lightheartedly with Kyle and not at him.

A warm scene indeed.

Mara takes on everything one last time. Her things are inside the car already, reports and archives done and delivered. She just needs to say goodbye and deliver one more thing and then she’ll be gone.

Serenia is sitting in one of the tables, the one next to the window where Adora and Catra once sat, talking cheerfully with Oscar, finally out of his laboratory coat and into much more comfortable clothes. Serenia's cheeks are rosy and Oscar is laughing goodhearted, brushing his hand just slightly against Serenia's. Mara smiles at the image, approaching them carefully. Serenia's face brightens when she sees Mara, waving at her.

"Everything ready?" Serenia asks, standing up from the blue seat. Mara nods, raising her arms so she can wrap Serenia into a gentle hug, patting her in the back.

"Yes, just need my obligatory hug and then I'll be gone," Mara says, parting from Serenia so she can squeeze her shoulders, peeking at the papers scattered on the table. "What are you watching?"

"Oh! Razz was showing us pictures of her travels around the world!" Serenia explains cheerfully, handing the old pictures to Mara. They are a considerable bunch, from the frozen forests of Snows to the high rocks of Drill and the beautiful blue and purple corals on Salineas. There are a few of Razz herself, younger, riding horses, sitting on the pilot seat of old time airplanes, jumping from high cliffs into calm sea, sitting on the porches of different houses. There is a beautiful house in the last photograph, of a kind yellow with green leaves hanging from the balcony and the porch, tinted arched windows and eggshell steps. The street is vibrant and long, circled by evergreen trees with the tall, red bridge of San Francisco behind. It's a good life, a collection of memories well preserved and golden.

Mara smiles at the photographs, leaving them back over the table with a kind brush of her fingers. She turns eyes Oscar with a knowing smirk, asking Serenia in a teasing voice, already knowing the answer.

"Are you sure you want to stay a little longer?"

Serenia blushes a deeper shade of red, nodding. "Yeah, um, actually Oscar and I have tickets for the movies in half an hour. I just wanted to say goodbye first"

"Well, goodbye then," Mara says with a smile, hugging her once more.

"Are you sure you are going to be fine?" Serena questions her once more, resting her cheek over her good shoulder.

"Of course I will. I've been working on this for twenty years, a break will do me good."

"And… are you going to look for her?" Serenia asks, very gently. Mara nods, a little bit more brightened up, this time the one blushing.

"Yes. I think it's time"

"Then I wish you all the luck of this world," Serenia hugs her once more, tight and honest, placing a swift kiss on Mara's cheeks before letting go. Mara then turns towards Oscar, offering him her hand.

"Oscar," Mara starts her goodbye with a lighthearted smile, "Take very good care of her, remember I'm a detective."

Oscar chuckles, surprised and a little bit nervous but honest and kind before surging forward, enveloping Mara's tall frame entirely inside a huge bear hug, careful enough to not bother her injured shoulder but almost crushing the life out of her.

"Thank you so much Mara," Oscar says next to her ear, almost out of breath. "For everything you've done, seriously, thank you."

Mara blinks, a little bit thrown off and confused, but returns the embrace, patting Oscar's shoulders lightly a few times. She eyes Serenia but she only shrugs, flushed and smiling, so Mara doesn't question it further.

After, Serenia stretches towards Oscar and takes his hand, lacing their fingers together. She gives Mara one last wave before following him towards the door of the dinner. Mara watches them go with a tender smile, happy for them. She is so glad that, after all the darkness they had gone through these last days, they had managed to find each other after all. Serenia has not only been her partner in work but she has also been a wonderful friend, a rock for Mara when she had barely arrived to her new place after Eternia, a shoulder to cry on and a back to lean into when they started their business together, hard working and satisfied for their work. Just as Mara, after twenty years Serenia deserves to find her happiness.

Oscar opens the door for Serenia, gallantly leading her out with a clumsy bow. Serenia laughs, walking out first, crossing paths with a short girl with pink dyed hair held on two buns over her head. She smiles at Serenia and then at Oscar, waving at him as he walks inside.

"Good morning, Doctor Coleman," she sings-songs sweetly.

"Good morning, Fluterina," Oscar greets her back with a second thought, smiling broadly before following Serenia to the parking lot.

Mara blinks, taken aback, gaping in surprise as her mind overruns and then comes to a stop completely. She walks towards the girl absently, body moving automatically, interfering in her walk across the dinner with a hand barely stretched in front of her, Mara's eyes running from the door of the dinner to the girl, who is looking at her with curiosity.

"Excuse me, did you call Oscar, the mortician, Coleman?" Mara asks, her voice trembling slightly as her mind fights to form a coherent thought. "Like- like Bow Coleman?”

“Oh? Oh, yes sure!" Fluterina exclaims, good-natured. "He is Bow’s older brother!”

Mara blinks, then blinks again. “What?”

“Well, yeah! They are a big family. Seven brothers nonetheless, though only Bow and Oscar are still living here! George Coleman, their father, adopted them all. He was a good man, I think he moved a few years ago with his coworker Lance to open a library in San Francisco," Fluterina explains in a breath, almost as excited to talk about her neighbors as to have some of Razz's ice cream, which she keep eyeing behind Mara every once in a while. Mara however, is still frozen in place, her hand hovering over the girl's shoulder as if she didn't quite know what to do with herself.

"Seven brothers and… a sister?" Mara inquiries, slowly. This time, it's the girl the one that looks confused, looking at Mara up and down with curiosity.

"Um, no? They are just brothers. The whole town knows them so I'm sure we would know if there had ever been a sister!"

Fluterina stares at Mara, seemingly waiting for her to say or ask something else. When she doesn't Fluterina just shrugs, tippy tapping around Mara and towards the dinner's counter without a second thought.

Mara's mind is already a thousand miles away, fragments and parts of the last days playing around her head like recordings, echoing inside her mind and memory as songs ringing from an old, dusty radio.

Doctor Brightmoon, she is so cold. Why is she so cold?

My little sister has a really bad cold , I was wondering if you could give her a look

Angella agreed, easy and without a thought, following him alongside Glimmer inside the home. They hadn't questioned it, hadn't acted surprised. It was a reaction so natural Mara hadn't even spared a second thought about it.

They are just brothers. The whole town knows them so I'm sure we would know if there had ever been a sister.

George Coleman. I think he moved a few years ago with his coworker Lance to open a library in San Francisco.

Mara snaps her head back to the table where Razz's photographs are still scattered over the surface, the bright red of a bridge popping among them all.

My grandchild is just recently moving into one of my houses, Razz's voice echoes in Mara's memories, happy and cheerfully, a second thought pulled on a moment of sincerity.

I didn't know you had a grandchild, Razz.

Which grandchild?

Mara trips with her feet, stumbling back slightly. A few consumers stare at her with curiosity but she doesn't see them, looking instead towards the counter of the dinner where Razz is gently teaching Kyle how to serve the portions. She must feel Mara's gaze because Razz raised her eyes, locking their gazes together. Razz's expression is already knowing, a kind of understanding falling over her old factions at whatever she sees in Mara's own face. Razz doesn't say anything but she smiles, nodding at Mara kindly, sweetly. All knowing, too knowing. Almost- almost proud.

We always talked about getting out. Travel. Move to San Francisco together.

Mara moves as if in a dream, barely missing tripping with her own feet and other tables and customers as she makes her way out. The warm breeze of autumn hits her in the face when she walks into the asphalt, head spinning and breath rushing, her heartbeat

hammering inside her eardrums as she looks at the woods, rows and rows of trees full of secrets.

All their voices are there, echoing, ringing, twinkling, loud and honest and determined. The voices of people that love. Glimmer. Bow, Angella, Micah. Mermista, Perfuma, Lonnie. Oscar. Razz. Adam.

Nobody ever leaves Eternia alive, you should know that

Weaver is the monster here, not Catra

My mother is a hairdresser. People are always talking about Catra

Adora is pretty and she smells like lavenders

If you are not beaten up or dead, nobody will do anything to protect you

Prime was harassing Adora

We knew something was going on

Do you understand detective? All of us, we did nothing.

Did Catrina ever talk about bruises or hits?

I wouldn't be able to tell that to you even if she did

I don't care. If someone kills me, if the town talks about me. I don't care

In a way we are all their killers

Adora is my sister, I will always be ready to do whatever is needed for her to be safe

They deserve a good ending, Mara dearie

I just want to be with her

We owned them that

I figured they would have wanted to be together

Mara runs her hand through her hair and laughs out loud, tears gathering on her eyes and spilling free. She knows how she must look right now, loose hair and crying and, sincerely, kind of hysterical, weeping at the woods in front of her and the blue, blue sky and the autumn breeze and the sun above her head.

A new thought occurs to her out of nowhere, leaving her breathless. She lowers her hand and starts roaming on the inside of her jacket's left pocket, looking for the last objects she was meant to deliver today after she forgot at the cemetery. She searches and searches and searches, looking inside posible rips of her jacket and the corner of the pocket, turning it inside out and back again. Then she looks inside the other and the inner ones and back to the left pocket again, but there is no luck.

The twin golden lockets are not there anymore.

Mara didn't register it at the time. There was chaos and everything was frantic but the quick frames of time are etched in her memory, fragments of what happened even if it did so quickly, things Mara saw out of the corner of her eye and then forgot. Until now.

November 5th, 1985

Midnight

People are screaming.

Someone crashes against Mara's left side so hard it makes her fall alongside other people against the ground painfully. The person is tall, almost as tall as Mara, wearing a long black coat with the hood pulled on. The person is on the square from the very beginning, watching Prime and his father in silence, bright eyes

flashing with every scene, every scream, every truth spilling free, and then, watching Mara.

Like this, the person is almost invisible among the crowd, among the chaos and the screaming and the panic of Kurr's murder. Like this, Mara doesn't even notice when the person walks directly towards her, blue eyes like gems shining as sharp silver, and crashes with her on purpose, tumbling them both into the ground.

And as Mara barely manages to avoid getting stomped over, she also barely feels the tug on her jacket as the person slips their hand inside Mara's pocket, wraps it around the lockets and stands again, getting lost in the crowd in a matter of seconds. The smells around are crazy. Metal, electricity, blood. But Mara catches the trail of the person's smell before they are gone.

Bleach.

Bleach and lavender perfume

Mara rushes towards her car, halfway laughing, halfway mad, halfway hysterical, opening the door in a quick swing and slipping inside, turning the car on and speeding away with a cackle.

She doesn't even know where she is going. Maybe to the square and its fountain and its flowers on the floor. Maybe to a white house with a red door. Maybe to the woods, where a new pine tree will begin to grow from cold ashes. Maybe away, past the limits of the town, through serpent concrete paths and bright blue sky, voices of memories as a loud echo.

She almost doesn't even notice Razz looking at her through the window with the biggest smile. Today, her dress is yellow. Today, her dress has sunflowers on it.

“This is crazy, if they figure it out, they'll kill us both for good”

“I know”

“Aren't you afraid?”

“Of course I am. I'm scared to death”

"And you still want to do this?"

"Yes"

“But-“

"I love you more than I fear them,” a shaky breath, lips against a slightly feverish forehead, "I'm not their hero, or their savior, or their toy. Maybe in another world, but not on this one,” blankets tucked gently around a trembling frame, shared kisses on the corner of gentle mouths. “On this one, I'm yours. Everything I am and I've been and I will ever be, I'm yours, completely"

Mara is driving slightly like a maniac, ignoring any sign on the empty road that crosses the limits of the town. Her breath is coming in quick puffs as she searches blindly on her bag, carelessly thrown over the empty copilot’s seat.

She manages to pull out her recording with the one tape she kept to herself, switching it on with quick fingers. Adora’s voice spills inside the cozy car, the words and sentence of the statement she insisted on given Mara before they went back to her house jumping up and down, mixing with the fragments of the last days inside Mara’s memory, telling a story that was there from the very beginning, in plain sight just for Mara to see.

Like a secret.

Like a promise.

"I would have rather died with her a thousand times than let her go through it on her own..."

"... I should've gone back"

"Have you ever loved someone madly?..."

Halloween Night

A few minutes past midnight

The air is unusually chilly tonight. She hadn't noticed it all, but then again, she had spent most of her time outside wrapped around the warm skin of the person she loved the most. Around her angry words that cut like incandescent steel, and the feverish sweat of her hands and lips, and the boiling lava of her voice against her neck as she brought her lover into a white fire with curled quick fingers and words pressed against her ear. The mere thought makes her hand twitch and her spine to shiver, guilt and love and the shadow of pleasure washing over her completely.

Even inside the love, it had been a horrible night, charged with the thunder of fear and accusatory words and hidden, swift kisses on the back of necks. And she knew, inside of her, she knew she was a coward.

But even if it was just at night that she could wrap her arms around her frame and kiss her angry mouth, knowing she was safe from them made everything else worth it. Even if it was fucked up. Even if every night she had to part from her side and leave to put on a show with the rest of the town, being someone she wasn't, putting on a smile. It was worth it, it was a job she had tasked herself to do. She knew this.

And yet, and yet, here she is, tripping through the branches of woods she knows as well as herself, walking a path at night she has walked through a hundred times before.

Here she is.

She came back.

She calls her name, echoing across the woods, squinting her eyes at the darkness. She jumps a few talk rocks, circling the pond where, on a warm, sunny summer day, she secretly taught her love how to swim.

Suddenly, in front of her, she can hear the sound of sticks breaking and the unmistakable crack of dry leaves under a weight. The steps are slightly sluggish, heavy and slow, but they approach the place she is standing in without changing paths.

She calls her name again, hesitant, waits for one second longer and then the berry bushes right in front her part in the middle. Her love emerges from behind them, stumbling against the fallen trunks, one hand pressed tight against her chest, the other stretched towards her.

"No!" She rushes forward, catching the love of her life on her arms at the same time her knees give up and she falls towards the ground. She cradles her head with her hand, pushing from her love's back with the other so she is sitting up and not on her back. "I got you, I got you. Don't worry"

Her love gasps, clawing at her hands in desperation. Her eyes are big, pupils dilated, a river of tears falling from her eyelashes and into her freckled cheeks. She is soaked from head to toe and trembling like a leaf, her hands smudged in mud, nails broken in splinters, her sneakers, jeans and the sweater she had wrapped around her just a few minutes before, coated in water, mud and moss, as if she had crawled her way out of the river.

" -can't-" her love struggles, closing her eyes in frustration. "I can't- breathe-"

"It's okay, let me see" she is trying not to panic, fumbling with the pockets of her love's jeans, increasingly alarmed. "Where is your inhaler?"

Her love shakes her head, wheezing painfully. She is almost limp on her arms, exhausted to the bone and cold as the dead herself.

Her usually bright cheeks are frighteningly pale and her lip slightly blue, all those signs Adora has learned to identify and always wished she hadn't to.

"Fuck!" She exclaims when she comes empty handed, shifting her love's weight on her arms so she can reach for the inner pocket of her own red jacket. She searches on it until she grasps what she's looking for, her love's spare inhaler that the silver eyed always, always *, carries with her.*

She places the small end of the inhaler on her love's lips and presses down, letting the medicine enter her body is a rush. Her love clings to her hands and the medicine, taking several ragged breaths until the air finally makes its way inside her lungs, cold and fresh and miraculously.

She rocks her love gently, there over the mushed moss and the cold woods, waiting frantically until she hears her chest give away some of the tension inside and open. She slips her arm under her love's knees, supporting her back with the other and she stands up, carrying her up and rushing over the paths of the woods towards their treehouse.

Climbing up is a whole thing of its own, but her love is now awake enough to grab the steps and impulse herself up, she is behind helping her up and inside the warm little house.

She pushes her love gently over the makeshift bed, stretching for her backpack and pouring all the content into the floor until the epinephrine shot she is looking for rolls towards her knees almost too slowly. Her love is still a scary tone of pale and her eyes are sunk, grabbing at her chest with every painful breath she takes. She unwraps the shoot and digs the needle without a second thought over her love's tight, tossing it aside once the epinephrine tube is completely empty. She cradles her love's cold face inside her palms, rubbing circles on her cheeks.

"You are okay, you are okay." She keeps whispering, for her love and for herself. She feels like crying but holds it back, her lip

trembling uncontrollably still. She crawls behind her love, helping her move until she is sitting between her legs, her love's back against her front. She wraps her arms around her arms and places her hands over her chest, pressing oh so very gently. "Feel my chest, can you feel me?" Her love gasps, nodding slowly. Her breath is slightly less forceful now, the tension of her body is losing, her grip on her hands, relaxing just a little. She presses her mouth against the curve of her ear, placing a loving kiss there. "Breathe with me"

Her love nestles her head closer to the angle of her neck, pressing her lips over her pulse point, gentle enough that helps her anchor into reality. She releases a shaky breath, hiding her face partially over her love's soaked curls.

"That's it, that's it. You are doing great. Just breathe with me, mi sol *, with me."*

They stay like this for a while more, the moon lower on the sky, the woods quiet. Her love's breathing regulates but her chest is still struggling, her entire body sore. The mind of the silver eyed is rising with thoughts as she runs her fingers over the purple bruises blooming on the back of her love's neck and wrists, heart hammering with something much more dangerous than worry. Something nasty and furious. But she doesn't dare to voice any of it, not right now. Instead she gathers the love of her life in her arms and whispers to her softly

"I'm going to take you with Angella, alright?" Her love hesitates for a second and then nods, still deadly silent. "Okay, hold tight."

She helps her move, wrapping her love's arms and legs over her shoulders and waist, her head resting against her shoulder. She is strong, stronger than any person gives her credit for, she can carry her love down and across the entire forest and town if she needs to.

She wraps her jacket over her love's trembling shoulder and kisses her forehead one more time before going down.

"Alright, let's go, sol *"*

Mara gives a turn around around the road, eyes firm on the scenery in front of her. The tape stretches and then comes to an end only for Mara to let go of the wheel enough so she can rewind it and start it again.

The bent green, blue and purple trees all around her start to think out, opening into a wider space as the street that leads to the square comes into view. Here, the trees have already started to change colors, to pinks and reds and oranges, making the town start to look like a sunset, held for a second inside a painting's frame.

Mara's car goes around the fountain, where gentle petals are still floating over the water. There is a group of people sitting on the bench in front of the fountain. They are laughing, chatting with each other at high, cheerful speed, sharing back and forth soda bottles and bags of popcorn. Their cheerleader and basketball team uniforms are not there today, changed instead for denim pants, skirts, cheerful earrings and colorful bomb jackets.

They turn their eyes towards Mara when her car passes by, staring at her through the lowered glass. But their gazes are not tight right now, or stone cold, or sad. In fact, they are smiling. And when Mara exhales, eyes full of questions and mind full of answers.

On the car's radio, 'Goo goo muck' starts to blast, loud and morbidly cheerful, filling the space between them.

Glimmer huffs silently, something devious inside of the corner of her mouth, raising her bottle of soda towards Mara. And then, she smiles.

"We all knew about it"

"That's what we do, we protect each other"

"We owe it to them"

November 1st, 1985

2.00 am

"So, what are we doing here exactly?" Mermista asks, wrapping her hands around the warm mug of hot chocolate Micah had given to everyone.

They are all here, all gathered around the small table in front of the chimney, each with a mug on their hands, a calm silence broken only by the crack of the fire every once in a while.

Glimmer stands up from her seat, walking in front of the fire with a decided expression in her face. She rests her hands on either side of her hips, raising her chin with a fired up decision.

"This is a best friends squad meeting," she says firmly, nodding almost to herself.

"This is madness," Bow says back to her, his head resting on his open palms. He looks exhausted, deep bags below his eyes, and his knee is bouncing quickly with anxiety. "Absolutely madness and I'm pretty sure it is illegal in a lot of ways."

"It's definitely illegal," Glimmer agrees. "But -"

"But? Glimmer if they catch any of us we are going to end in jail," Mermista states from her seat, lowering her mug with a loud tud.

Silence falls between the friends once more, heavy until Glimmer lowers her hands down, pinching her nose before waving her other hand towards the closed door that leads to the bedrooms' corridor of her house.

"Guys, look at them. They are going to die in this town anyway, it will eat them alive," she says, low, tense, honest. Her words cut deep inside everyone's hearts because they are true, and that is

the scariest thing of them all. "We can abandon them to die or we can help them decide how"

The group shares a look, eyebrows frowned in worry, and also, realization of the weight Glimmer's words bring with them. After all, they are all here sitting because it almost happened. Because it was so, so close it was a mere miracle it hadn't happened at all. They are all sitting here, glitter still on their hairs from the Halloween party, because they almost dressed for a funeral.

The door of the room opens and closes softly, the click of the doorknob alerting everybody inside the dark room. She *walks inside with tired steps, running a hand over her absolutely exhausted face. Her blue eyes are rimmed in red, bloodshot and worn out after hours of desperation and crying. Her hazelnut hair is loose, hanging at either side of her face like waterfalls, partially hiding her face among the shadows of the fire. She is barefoot as she walks over the soft carpet of the room, her shoulders dropped forwards slightly, but her spine remains straight as she walks towards the couches her friends are sitting in. She drops over one of the empty seats, the one Glimmer had just stood from, close to the fireplace, deflating almost as quickly as she sits.*

There is a very heavy weight on her shoulders, all her friends can see it clearly, but she still holds herself above, almost drowning, but just enough so she can still breathe. She *doesn't know how much longer she will be able to take it. Today, tonight, it was too much. Tonight, she learnt how much it's enough.*

"How is she?" Lonnie asks in front of her, voice soft. She *releases her breath, looking up from her palms. Her eyes are pulled down, swimming in sadness and worry. And anger, pure, raw and unfiltered anger.*

"She fell asleep. Her fever lowered down a little." Her voice is as raw as her eyes. Rasp and worn out. There are scratches on her knuckles and splinters on her palms from where she climbed down the treacherous steps of their little spot on the world, walking all the way across the woods towards the house.

Glimmer gulps, wetting her suddenly dry mouth as she scrunches next to her, placing a hesitant hand over hers, balled in tight fists over her knees.

"My mom said… she said-"

"She could have died," She *finishes for Glimmer, snapping her eyes to the dancing fire. Her lips, usually kind and gentle, are retracted over her gums, baring her teeth like a predator about to jump. "She should be dead."*

Glimmer exhales because it is one thing hearing about it and another completely different living it. Instead Glimmer shares a swift look with everyone in the room, worrying her lip with her front teeth.

She *clicks her tongue against the roof of her mouth, turning her eyes back to Glimmer's dark ones. "Did you explain them?"*

"Yes," Glimmer says, nodding. She hesitates, looking swiftly towards the rest. "We… think it's very dangerous"

"It is," she *agrees, this time tearing her eyes from her friend's to look at the rest. "This is my plan, all of it,"* she *says out loud, determined, firm, the kind of strong voice of leader and lovers and people blinded by something much more powerful than love. "You know me, I'm the planner. But for it to work, I'm going to need you, all of you."*

They all share a look, from her blue and silver eyes to the eyes of the rest, black and green and blue and everything in between. Finally, as a collective sigh or a rush of fresh air, the demeanor of the group changes, lifts, sharpens. It's hard saying no when you see the blooming purple flower on her *love's neck.*

Bow stretches towards her, *rubbing her tense back with his hand.* She *melts a little bit under his kind touch, her lip bobbling with the pinch of tears on the corner of her eyes and the back of her throat. Bow hums, nodding at her for them all.*

"What do you need us to do?" he asks, gently.

"A lot," she *confesses, eyes even sadder, voice breaking in pieces.*

Lonnie stands up too, followed by Mermista, and Perfuma on the back and all the others, surrounding her in a small circle. She *smells like sandalwood and pine and sweat, all that carefully constructed barrier she had built around herself in the last hours crumbling into pieces around her. She breaks into small parts, tears pooling from her eyes and sobs tearing from her mouth like they have never done before, at least not in front of them.*

Another pair of arms stretch from the warm shadows, cradling her *face between his palms. They share the same sun freckles and hazelnut hair. They share the same eyes.*

"We will make them be sorry," he says to her, hands trembling ever so slightly, voice never wavering.

"I don't just want them to be sorry," she *says between her teeth, venom pouring out of her as tsunamis. "I want them to pay"*

"She is so cold, why is she so cold?"

The water is freezing

Black nailpolish and delicate fingers

November 3rd, 1985

Bow parks the car on the far end of the road, walking out of it alongside the other two. They've been deadly silent the entire trip, but now that they are actually here, there is some kind of electricity running between the trio as they make their way across the woods and into the slippery lands that limit the river.

"Are you sure they are coming now?" Glimmer asks in a whisper, tucking her jacket closer to herself. Bow nods, confident, evading tree branches after tree branches.

"She called from her house. They are on their way here right now, we need to hurry"

"Alright, alright," Glimmer mutters, barely missing tripping at all. "Just making sure, I don't want to sedate her before time. She will never let me hear the end of it"

"I can hear you," a voice calls after her, frown evident even feet behind Glimmer.

"That's the point"

They make it to the hem of the river just as the moon reached its highest point, illuminating poorly and sinister the misted woods. The river is calmer here, but when Bow kneels to touch the water he has to take away his hand immediately, hissing.

"It's freezing," he whispers to them, standing up and shifting on his feet. "I don't like this"

"We don't have a choice. We are already here," Glimmer says, handing Bow the medical bag as she roams for the needle and medicine she is looking for, already charged and ready.

The third one is unusually quiet, staring at the darkness of the woods opposite to them, her hair done in a loopy braid, the pink of her sweater almost too bright under the dim light of the night. There is the echo of a shout on the woods around them, followed by another and another, the loudest of them all a voice the three of them now we'll, alerting them of the other group's impeding arrival.

"Stay still," Glimmer whispers to her between her teeth, rolling the wool sleeves of the sweater to reveal her arms. She doesn't speak as Glimmer digs the needle quickly on the muscle there, the cool

sedative running through her muscles and body almost frighteningly quickly.

Glimmer makes quick work of the latex gloves and needle, throwing them inside bag again and putting it around her shoulder. Bow walks forward just enough to catch their friend between his arms as her knees buckle, saving her from hitting the ground.

Between Bow and Glimmer, they help her make her way inside the freezing cold water, Glimmer cursing the entire time as they lay her over on her back over the surface of the moss and water. Glimmer is extremely pale, running her fingertips over her pulse point, gradually slowing down, and her chest, scanning her trembling breathing.

"Get out," she says between grinded teeth, her entire body locking in a shiver.

"You temperature is going to drop a lot"

"I know"

"Mom will be here soon"

"Alright," her voice is far away now, barely a thread, coming just slightly scared at the end before she drifts away. "Take care of her, please"

Her eyes go from narrowed to closed, floating over the icing water like a leaf to the wind, almost insignificantly against the volume of the water. Glimmer hesitates inside the river, suddenly panicking. From an instant to the other all of this looks and feels terrifyingly real. She grasps the hem of her sleeve between her fingers, horrified to having to let go and leave her like that, cold and alone.

"Glim, we need to go," Bow urges her, delicately but firmly undoing her grasp from the fabric with his fingers, pulling from Glimmer's arm as she guides her out. Still, Glimmer catches him

throwing swift looks behind him, the trembling of his body nothing related to the cold of the night.

They make quick work of their footprints, covering them in the same mud from the river and moss. There is movement in the bushes in front of them, too close to them, barely a few minutes away. Bow wraps his arms around Glimmer's as another calling shout rips the night, pulling her inside the security of the trees no without sending one last lingering look at the river below them.

Extremely dangerous indeed.

"I'll help you cover her"

"I'm so sorry, I've got you know"

"I'll need you to help me hold her, detective"

"We are going home"

If you ask, she will be quiet about it. But the truth is, Angella Bright-Moon has never heard something as horrid as the pained howls of a girl she has met since she was a toodler, all gap in teeth and poofs of hazelnut hair, tearing her throat and lungs apart in cries.

She *is screaming, howling, crawling at the ground behind them. And somehow, Angella knows that the pain pouring with the shouts is not a lie, it's a damp crashing free from years and years of hiding, and fear and pain and lost. Somehow, doctor Bright-Moon knows this is, pretty much, very real.*

But Angella can't do anything about it right now because she is on a mission, and that is, to make good of her wrongs and compensate somehow all the years she has been a coward, hidding behind excuses and the clinic door the bruises of the girl she now holds in her hands, her curls soaked, her skin cold. The reality of it all makes Angella loose her breathe for a moment.

Micah kneels on the ground next to her, hiding with his frame and jacket the girl's face as he gently nudges his wife back to reality. He knows just how hard all of this is, how real it seems, how wrong they were for thinking things would be better off quiet, waiting for them to wear out. The thing about abuse is, it doesn't wear out, it doesn't get bored. It stays with you until you put a stop to it, until you rise above or until it drowns you down. Or maybe, just in some occasions, until someone else is there to defend you.

Behind them, the detective keeps struggling with her, *digging her knees in the ground to keep a hold of her fighting body, almost pinning her on the ground. Angella takes the distraction as what it is, rushing on her work. She runs her hand over the girl's face in front of her, running her fingers quickly over her pulse point. It's there, faint and a little bit slow but there.*

Angella opens her coat and swiftly takes the new needle with the sedative's agonist inside, embedding it on her upper arm. The sedative wasn't too much, just enough to keep her body still from everyone else's sight. Micah does quick work of the used needle, wrapping his jacket over her face in time to hide the sudden jolt of her chest as her pulse starts to stabilize.

Angella's ears are ringing with the screaming and she can feel herself trembling from head to toe, but she stays firmly on the ground, cradling the girl's head over her lap and she waits for Oscar to arrive. Angella is running circles over the girl's cheek under Micah's jacket so she can feel when tears start to run out over them, warm and sad, an answer to the screams of the person this girl loves.

The lights of Oscar's car makes Angella sigh in relief just for her heart to jolt in panic as the characteristic red and blue lights of the sheriff's car come into view from the opposite side. Micah's hand rests over Angella's shoulder squeezing softly.

"I'll stay, you go with them," he says, nodding to the detective. Angella nods, releases a shaky breath before passing the girl's

head to Micah's hands, who holds her with just as much care as his wife.

The next minutes are a rush of movement. Kurr and the detective are yelling at each other, Micah and Oscar rush towards the car, wrapping the girl inside a dark, heavy blanket before pulling her inside the back of the mortuary's car. Angella sees them out of the corner of her eye as she wraps her arms around the other girl's frame, pulling her close into a sideways embrace and making a show of calming her down too.

She is trembling too, badly, her teeth clicking together with the violence of her body's shakes. She digs her fingers over Angella's sides, her voice trembling and breaking as she tries and fails to speak.

"It's alright, it's alright," Angella whispers next to her ear, because she can't help it, because these are kids, because she saw them grow together. "Everything is going to be alright."

There is another car parked at the other edge of the woods, an empty white beaten up pick-up

She storms out of the building, walking in long steps across the yard

Mara knocks, quick and loud. Oscar opens the door with a sigh

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November 4th, 1985

4.30 am

"What are you doing here?" Oscar says, alarmed, wrapping his hand around her forearm and pulling her inside the house quickly.

She *pulls down the hood of her jacket, shaking her ponytail free from it. Her eyes are tired and her body sore but she looks unyielding over the little spot on the carpet she is standing on.*

"I want to see her," she *says, not demanding, but it's very close.*

"Weaver and Kurr just left you know that?" Oscar says in a strained voice, looking sharply to the window until he is sure nobody is else is out there before turning towards her, eyebrows raised. "This is very risky and you know it. Someone could have seen you," Oscar reprimands her, running his hand over his hair.

"I know," she admits, her eyes softening, pleading. The tip of her ears are red with the cold of the morning and the autumn breeze and she looks two steps closer to falling asleep. "Please"

Oscar holds her blue gaze for one second more and then gives up, surrendering to the sadness he sees in there. "Alright, alright. But don't be so careless anymore. You know what is at stake right now."

They walk together upstairs, following the path of the long corridors until the last door, the one that leads to the main guest's bedroom with the window that looks towards the yard and one of the last chimneys that remain from the original construction. Still, the entire house is warm and smells slightly like cookies and home-made food, all the curtains of the windows pulled closed, the corridors illuminated by the soft golden light of the chandeliers.

The door opens and closes just as they get near. Bow walks out of the bedroom with a sigh, wearing a red apron slightly stained with flour. His expression brightens when he sees her standing there, opening his arms to her and wrapping her into a soft embrace that she returns kindly.

"Hey you," Brow greets her, rubbing her back lovingly.

"Bow," she says as recognition, resting her forehead over his shoulder before parting slightly, dragging her blue eyes to the

closed door with a heavy frown etched in her face. "Is she-?"

"She is awake and restless," Bow assures her with a tiny smile, chuckling as he shakes his head a little. "Actually, I think she's been waiting for you" Bow adds before his smile falls a little, rubbing the back of his neck with his hand. "Her fever picked up again, so take it easy"

Her dark eyebrows just deepen over her face, casting shadows over her face. "I-"

"We already called, Angella," Oscar says, trying to look as reassuring as he can when her eyes turn towards him. Oscar gives her a kind smile, nodding. "She'll be on her way on an hour"

The shadows clear from her face a little, though there is still a mist casted over her factions. Still, her voice is as kind as it always is, biting down in her lip with a grateful expression. "Thank you, guys"

Bow squeezes her shoulder gently before opening the door, pushing the heavy wood slightly. "Go on then"

She *smiles before peeking inside the room hesitantly, taking in the fire on the chimney and the bed close to the window. Her love is sitting on the bed, surrounded by as many blankets and pillows as there can possibly be in the house. Her face is slightly flushed and her eyes are bright and big as moons as she stares back at her, actually taken by surprise.*

Before her love can say anything at all, she *move forward as if by sheer impulse, stumbling on the carpet before almost throwing herself completely towards her, half of her legs still dangling from the bed, her torso over the mattress. Her love catches her inside her arms with a small huff, cradling her head against the angle of her neck, her arms around her shoulders and back.* She *wraps her own hand against her waist over the warm shirt she is wearing, pulling her closer in almost a desperate embrace.*

"Hey," her love says in a hoarse whisper, pressing her warm mouth against the cold skin of her pulse point. "You shouldn't have come"

"I love you," she *says instead, cradling her deeper.*

Bow and Oscar stare at them from their spot in the door until then. Oscar nudges Bow a little and makes a small movement with his head towards the corridor, walking away with his brother and closing the door behind.

—

" … I've been and I will ever be, I'm yours, completely"

Bow hears the muffled voices before he knocks on the door softly to let know of his presence, opening it just a slit and looking inside. His friend is sitting cross legged over the bed across her love, holding her freckled hands against hers. She *is looking at her drowsily, eyes locked on her nose and eyes and entire face like one would look the most beautiful painting.*

Looking towards Bow is heavy, but she does in the end, the corners of her lips pulled down, already guessing what he is about to say.

"Razz called," Bow tells them, almost regretting doing it at all at the sad expressions on her faces. "The detective had a beef with Kurr and she is on her way here"

"You need to go," her love says to her, running her fingers through the soft strands of her hazelnut hair, her nails picking on the hairband of her ponytail and pulling it down, letting the curtains of wavy hair fall around her sun kissed face. She never liked it when she *held her hair so up and straight, after all.*

She *shakes her head, the now free, long strands of hair brushing her collarbones when she leans forward, kissing her love swiftly and mourning on the mouth.*

They kiss dearly for a few seconds until she *has to part away between a sudden fit of sad chuckles, propping a tiny kiss over her love's freckled nose.*

"You taste like chicken noodles," she *say, in mirth*

"Gross," her love says, wrinkling her nose annoyed in that way she *always finds so adorable, and then rolling her sea glass eyes. "Bow made me soup"*

"I did," Bow says from the other side of the door where he hid away when they started kissing. She *blushes when she realizes but her love just chuckles, pointing loosely at the empty plate on the table next to the bed.*

"And cookies"

"Best in town," Bow adds from the corridor, making both of them laugh.

"Hmm," she *hums, running her lips through her love's face, merely a feather brush of her mouth against her skin. "I'll be back soon"*

Her love grimaces at the words, gripping the blankets around her tightly with her fingers. "I know I can't change your mind about what 's happening today, but be careful."

"I will "

"Don't hit yourself on the head"

"Can't promise that," she *jokes, gaining a painful pinch in the side.* She *leans her forehead against her love's, breathing the orange of her perfume. "Almost there"*

"Alright"

"Alright"

"I'm sorry, guys, but we really need to hurry up," Bow says, apologetic but urgent. "Oscar is getting things ready at the mortuary. I think the detectives should see you walk out of there"

"Coming," she detangles painfully slowly from her love's arms, climbing down the bed and jogging quickly towards Bow and the door. "Let's make good of those theater years then"

She looks back just enough to share one last longing stare between her and her love and then they are gone.

"My sister has a cold"

"I'm the only doctor in Eternia"

"Why are you so afraid that I tell you exactly what she is?"

"I work at the Mayor's office. Lots of paperwork and documents"

"I never defended her. Never in in front on anyone"

"I found something a year ago"

"Who was defending her then?"

November 4th, 1985

4.30 pm

" *You still have a bit of a fever," Angella says, shaking the thermometer and saving it back inside her medical bag. "But your lungs sound better. How is the pain?"*

"Manageable"

"Very well. You still need to take painkillers but I think the worst has already happened." Angella says in a gentle voice, placing an

errand curl from behind the girl's ear.

She is so big right now. Angella still remembers her the day she was born, when Angella was a freshly graduated from the medical college. Her father carried her the entire time, sitting on the small couch of the nursery room until the day turned into night. She was so tiny and she almost didn't cry, wrapping her infinitesimally small hand around her father's finger. It was only them that time, because there wasn't a need to even mention that woman in her life anymore, and it was like that for dear years that ended too fast. And Angella saw her through it all, small and toothless, and tall and beautiful. A baby, a little toddler, three years old, six years, ten, fifteen, seventeen, now.

That's why she is doing this. Angella owes it to that little baby, to that cheerful child and closed up teen, and loving adult. For every bruise and scratch and hit she patched up in silence and all the others this girl and the one she loves had to tend on their own. She owes it because Angella is a mother too, and she has a daughter, this could be her daughter, and they've talked and they've heard the horrible words of the town and once Angela asked the kids to stay apart from it all but all of that is gone now because these children deserve a better world.

And she is looking at Angella as if she knew exactly what was going on through her head, her pretty face serious in thought. Gently, almost unsure and hesitant, the girl places her hand over Angella's and squeezes, once and reassuring. There is a kind of gentleness with which she carries herself always, the kind that can't be stripped no matter the abuse or the defamation or the pain. A gentle kindness that it's there simply for the fact that this girl is good.

There is a knock on the door after which Micah enters slowly, smiling at both of them. The girl perks up at the sight of him, her hands trembling just a little.

"Is she okay?" she asks, almost snapping her teeth with how tight she grips them. Micah raises a calming hand in front of him,

shushing her gently.

“She is home. I talked with Adam on the phone, she is alright and getting the rest ready,” he assures her, voice slightly strained. “But things are very, very tense in the town. Everyone will be hyper focused on her right now, we need to be very careful right now.”

The girl flops back into her pillow, nudging the bandage around her wrist until Angella pulls her hand away softly.

“That absolute idiot,” the girl whispers between her teeth, looking through the closed window. The incident in the club house had taken everyone by surprise, and yet, everyone understood why it had happened. It had been as brave as stupid and the girl knew this, because her eyes were soft under all the worry and the evident angry, cleaning treacherous tears with the back of her hand every once in a while. “Why did she even do that?”

Angella and Micah share a knowing look, a silent conversation going back and forth between them. Micah gets closer, shifting with the things on his hands. There is nervousness in his entire demeanor about something Angella already knows why. It's the kind that comes with knowing something for a long time and not doing anything about it at all.

"Kiddo?" Micah says to the girl, taking a seat on the chair in front of the bed. The girl's shoulders tense at his tone, tight like a violin cord about to snap. There is sadness on Micah's face but also, just as with Angella, deep regret. He places an expensive looking red file over the blanket between them, pushing it gently towards the girl's freckled hands. "I need to talk to you about something."

“I loved her” “I know”

“He was angry at the drinks?”

"You are a fucking pig! I know what you tried to do!”

Green pills scattered across the concrete. Rohypnol

Prime has a can of beer in his hand, by his sly smirk, Mara supposes it was Adam's at some point.

"I've told you to stop drinking from my things"

Prime looks a bit dizzy in his feet as he stumbles on the road

"Find out and whoever did this to them, make them pay. Or I will"

November 4th, 1985

Pre-game party

Adam stands alone in the empty kitchen, opening a single can of beer. The music is loud, echoing around the three stores and making the windows tremble. Most of the seniors are in the living room, dancing or passing out drunk in one of the couches, or maybe even sneaking out to one of the rooms in the higher levels.

Adam doesn't care, to be honest, doesn't even who's house is this. The team announced the party and he followed because he needed to be here and nothing else.

He can hear the loud laughter of Prime's followers in the other rooms, drowning out the music and the chattering. The sound makes Adam want to crawl his eyes out of his skull and scream but he can't right now.

Instead, he is gridding a green pill with the bottom of a glass until the hard surface breaks into pieces and then into fine powder, gathering the entirety of it with a small paper and promptly and without remorse, throwing it inside the beer can. He shakes it, carefully of not spilling anything, until he cannot longer see the powder floating on the drink. He then takes the paper and the glass and throws it into the trash bin. One attempt it's enough, he is not taking any chances.

Adam sighs and raises his eyes towards the window. His reflection returns the gaze, blank and unworried. He knows he should feel bad about this, at least, a tiny bit guilty but he can't as much as he tries to find it within himself to feel any kind of remorse at all.

He already lost his parents. He is about to lose his sister in order to save her. All because of hate and ignorance and malice. All because of cowardice.

So no, Adam Grey won't find it in himself to feel guilty. Quite the contrary, he will do it for the joy of it. And if that makes him a villain, if that makes him the same, he will take the title with pride as long as they are safe.

Adam clicks his tongue against the roof of his mouth and grasps the open beer, promptly walking out of the kitchen and back into the party room.

It doesn't even take him two minutes to appear.

"Adam," Prime says, standing from the expensive couch he is sitting on, open legged and proud. The rest of his followers are all around him, none allowed to sit next to him. They are pathetic.

Prime approaches Adam, throwing his arm around his shoulders with a wide, reptilian smile, opening his palms as a preacher. Or a killer. "I heard what happened today at the club. I'm sure things will be back in order in no time"

"I´m sure they will," Adam agrees, biting into his own tongue. Prime's smile only widens, eyeing the beer in Adam's hand.

""Helping yourself with a drink? I'll help you with it. The Captain of our team should be on his five senses for now," he says, and then, like an expected omen, takes the drink right off from Adam's hand, swirling the liquid lazily. His breath already smells strongly like alcohol. Adam's heart gives a jump. "I hope we get to be on better terms soon enough, Adam. For our own sake." Prime stops, chews on the words, smiles, spills them off. "And of your sister"

For the fraction of a second, Adam wonders how much he could get away if he ripped Prime's jaw off his skull.

For Prime's luck, a member of the team rushes inside the room, all winded up and breathless. He scans the place until her spots Adam, walking towards him with an alarmed expression.

"Adam, you need to go home quickly," the boy says, out of breath, "I just heard from the neighbors outside, that detective detained your sister and took her away."

Adam is not surprised. But Prime's sickening green eyes are digging on the side of his face so he pushes through it, shifting his face into a grimace and a furious scowl and hopes it's enough to fool Prime. Adam's sister has always been the best actor between both.

"Where?" Adam growls, balling his hands into fists.

"Nobody knows! Just go home, quick!"

Adam shakes Prime's arm off his shoulders and stomps across the room in wide, alarmed steps. Behind him, he hears Prime turn to his followers with a matching snarl.

"You two, my car. Now," Prime says, not bothering to stay and see them scramble like rats towards the door and the street.

Prime follows Adam out close behind, but this time Adam doesn't say anything. Like this, Adam can see Prime raise his arm and take a long gulp of Adam's beer can.

Adam walks among the shadows of the outside trees and, where nobody can see him, smiles.

Good.

"Catra was the one that kept him away from Adora"

As Mara makes her way to the woods, a red car speeds out beside her in the opposite direction, almost crashing with her.

"She was stabbed, Adam"

At Adora's house, Bow is standing next to his car, an anxious stare on his face. A red car.

"At least it's lucky the body was legally reclaimed, I'm always receiving Jane and John Does"

"I don't care if they kill me"

"I was so fucking drunk, I didn't even enjoyed killing her"

November 4th, 1985

The treehouse

"The fucker tried to fucking stab me," she *says, dragging his limp body off the platform of the treehouse and pushing him promptly into the ground.*

Prime falls with a dry crunch, barely even moving at the harsh hit. His face is all purple and red after she broke his nose early, but other than that, he is completely out of it.

Adam stands next to his limp body, nudging him with his foot. Nothing. Not even a sound or a movement. The next day, Prime will wake up with a very bad headache and a lot of pain, but he won't remember anything. It would be funny, but just the thought that this is how his sister would have been that Prom Night if love hadn't saved her makes Adam want to kill him right now very badly.

"I should have broken his face sooner," she says, cleaning the blood from her nose where Prime managed to throw her a hit.

"Please stay still," Bow urges her, bandaging her upper arm where the hunting knife had actually cut her. The sleeve of her sweater is already coated in blood. "You are going to need stitches at home. You know she is going to really kill you when she finds out you actually got hurt, right?"

She *grimaces, shivering slightly, but waves her hand, dismissing her own wound away before hopping off the tree too. Bow follows her, rushing through woods to help his brother lower down the wheelbarrow from the car into the ground.*

"Actually, it's not a bad idea," Adam mutters, kicking Prime's drugged up ass on the shin. She stares at him so he shrugs, grasping the handle of the hunting knife, dripping red with his sister's blood. Hate pours slick and poisonous on his blood.

Behind them, Bow makes a disgruntled sound, almost dropping the black bag he is helping Oscar carry up towards the treehouse. "Please don't tell me you are thinking what I think you are thinking"

"I'm afraid he is and he is right," she says, already pulling off her sweater, leaving her in only her white undershirt, stained in spots of red. She brings her hand towards the necklace around her neck and hesitates, just for a second, before pulling from the chain, carefully tucking the golden locket inside the sweater. "I'm sorry Bow but we need to do this."

She hands the clothes, her locket and the knife back to Bow with a serious stare, leaving no doubt that she is complete, frighteningly serious. Bow takes them, gulping loudly before turning to his brother and the decoy body they had brought from the mortuary, sharing one heavy look with Oscar before getting into motion.

They struggle a little as they dress the body with the stained clothes, clipping the necklaces in place. Bow wrinkles his nose, holding the knife tightly in his hand. He feels sick to even be contemplating this, not only for the obvious, but because the

weapon is very clearly freshly coated on his friend's blood. With this thought in mind, Bow grinds his teeth and swings the knife down.

" I'm sorry random person I'm stabbing," he says in a whisper, closing his eyes and drinking his nose as he pulls out the knife, throwing it onto the floor as if it had burnt him.

"Help me put her face down," Oscar urges him, rolling the body so her face is hidden by the mass of hair. Oscar grimaces lightly, pointing out the obvious. "This is really morbid"

"It is," Bow agrees, gently placing the golden locket next to the body's neck. His eyebrows scrunch in pain, sighing. "But it's worth it"

On the ground, she and Adam are dragging Prime's passed out body several feet away from the treehouse, dropping him over the moss like any other drunk asshole. Adam coats his shirt and hands lightly with fuel, just enough to make him reek of it, as Bow and Oscar make their way down the tree. They hand the knife back to her which she immediately throws to the ground next to Prime, scowling gravely.

Soon enough, Oscar will rush, take the car and leave back to the house, covering as many tracks as he can. But the other three will remain here, hidden among the trees as they watch how the red fire consumes the entire tree. How Kurr arrives after the first call of the fire, thinking he is the first, finding Prime's passed out body in the ground. They'll watch as Kurr shakes him awake and slaps him across the face. Hard. Screaming the whole time, dangling the knife and pointing at the fire with fury. He won't even worry to check if there is anyone alive inside at all. And just as she planned, when Prime wakes up, he will think he did it all on his own and he will rejoice in the horror of it all. Because he is a monster. Because she *provoked him. Because she knew this was the only way.*

For these few seconds, though, as Bow finishes throwing fuel inside the treehouse, she stares up at the last safe spot in the world, a package of photographs safely tucked inside the pocket of her coat.

"Are you sure about this?" Adam asks one more time, handing her a box of matches. She takes it, staring at Prime's limp body and then at the place she loved.

"Yes." Without a second thought, she lights one of the matches, the golden of the tiny fire dancing inside her eyes, turning sapphires to rubies.

"I'm already dead," she says and tosses the fire inside the house.

"They loved each other and we - we saw how happy they looked"

Micah places a bouquet of sunflowers enveloped in black paper over the edge of the fountain, joining the rest

"She loved sunflowers! And she was kind!"

"I help my mother, she is a hairdresser"

Razz places the sunflowers over the warm surface of the gravestones. "For my girls"

It smells like bleach. Lavender and bleach.

November 5th, 1985

The Bright-Moon's house

"Please stop moving"

"It burns!"

"Of course it does, it's bleach" Perfuma scowls her, pulling lightly from her earlobe. Her plastic gloves are coated in bleach as she rinses them on the faucet, leaning towards the basket next to her right after so she can start preparing the honey blonde dye.

Her friend squirms over the plastic chair in front of the bathroom's mirror, tugging from the newly short strands, still slightly soaked after the rinse. She pouts at herself on the reflection, panic clear on her face as she inspects the pale wheat color that her hair has taken.

"Are you sure this is going to actually work?

Perfuma slaps her hand off her hair, newly changed gloves mixing quickly the dye. They've been sitting here for the last four hours and Perfuma's eye is starting to twitch. From the corner of the door's frame, Glimmer's head peeks out, smiling broadly. Behind her, the pulled curtains tell them dawn is just about to start.

"How are you two doing here?" Glimmer asks, shit eating grin. She already knew this was going to be the hardest task.

She *squirms on her seat again, pouting somehow even more. "Glimmer, I'm going to go bald"*

Perfuma drops the plate with dye on the counter, closing her hands around her face, barely managing to take a shaky, contained exhale. Perfuma can hear Glimmer almost bent and cackling with laughter at the door and a small whimpering on the plastic seat.

"You know what? I'm just going to take a deep breath and retouch my roots too. Why not?"

"We know what you did, Prime"

Mara can't hear their voices anymore over the ripple of the thunder and rain around them

"You will live what you have left of life knowing that"

November 5th, 1985

Midnight. The Bell's Tower

The rain slams against the building like a goddess releasing her mighty fury against a mortal world.

Glimmer is soaked from head to toe, her shirt hair sticking to the base of her neck. This wasn't in the plan, they hadn't even talked about it, not thrown it in the conversation like a sideways thought. The end of this was supposed to be different, just as fair, but different. And yet, and yet *.*

It happened because the group of friends walked on them. Glimmer forgot to knock and when they walked inside, both of them were already in each other's arms, on the spot in front of the chimney. Stitches and bandages. Bruises and scratches. And neither Glimmer, nor any of them had ever seen two people holding each other with such love and desperation, ever.

That's why it happened.

Detective Grayskull is several feet behind them, held by Perfuma and Hawk. Glimmer considers the words inside her head, weighs them as she throws a swift look to the detective and then back at Prime. She is already, they are all already here. And if Glimmer is to make something, is to be sure that Prime doesn't leave this world without knowing he lost.

"Do you feel dizzy, Prime?" Glimmer asks and she knows it's wrong, but just once, it feels good to make abusers pay. "Maybe sleepy. Or even, I don't know, drunk?"

Prime's pupils shrink. He looks like a pulp, beaten out and bloody as realization starts to sink slowly on his system. And still, he has the nerve to look offended instead of regretful or guilty. He will

never feel anything else but the right to own other people's lives. Glimmer leans closer, breathing hard

"Do you want to know the truth, Prime? Do you?". Glimmer whispers to him between her teeth. The words are in the tip of her tongue, crashing against each other on its urgency to come out. "Then I'll say it to you."

Glimmer speaks, Prime attacks her, the frame of the window gives up.

Adam let's go.

Mara parks the car in the road that leads outside the town. She stays still, holding the wheel between her hands until they hurt, until she obligates herself to let go from the faux leather and drop them back into her lap.

The record had long ago ended again, the sound of Eternia drowned behind the tall crowns of the trees at her back, submerging the inside of the car into silence.

Mara blinks then blinks again. Her eyes feel dry yet she knows there are tears running down her face.

As if underwater or in the middle of a dream, Mara stretches towards the shelve of the car and opens it, pulling from it a folded piece of paper. It arrived at her office in the dawn of November 2nd, a single page letter without a return address but Eternia Town.

Make takes a shaky breathe, counting inside her head. She already knows the content of the letter by memory, bold black letters scattered in the center. At first, she thought it was a threat. Now, she knows it was a cry for help.

Mara clicks her teeth and unfolds the paper again.

"Thank you, for what you did for them"

"Why are you here, Grayskull?"

"You brought them peace"

On the night of Halloween

"This letter arrived at my office"

October 31th

"Is it supposed to be a threat?"

Catrina Weaver is going to die

"Why would anyone send this?"

November 1st, 1985

4.00 am. Razz's Diner's

She is exhausted.

Her shoulders ache, her arms are screaming with pain, her chest feels tight and sore. Her eyes are tender with inflammation, red rimmed and bloodshot after staying the entire night up and crying most of it too.

She sits on their usual table, resting her forehead over her palm. She is so tired.

"Here is your milkshake, dearie," Razz says, rubbing her back with her old, wrinkled hand, placing the drink in front of her before sitting on the other side of the table. The diner is completely empty at this hour, the curtains pulled shut and the door sign turned to closed. "Caramel with a hint of coffee, just as you like."

"Thank you, Razz," she says, smiling lightly. Not even the sugary drink seems to be able to pick her up, dread knotting in her belly painfully.

"Are you okay, darling?"

"Yeah. Just- a lot on my head," she shrugs, rubbing the back of her head with her hand.

She is a planner, she plans, yes, and yet inside all of these plans and secrecy and thoughts, she doesn't seem to be able to reach a solution she likes. To reach what she desperately wants. A little.bit of justice for all these pain.

She roams her eyes around the pictures Razz is showing her, focusing on an older one. Razz is standing in front of the diner, a little bit younger than now, her arm wrapped around a young hair, soft dark skin, even darker, wavy hair and silver eyes. They are smiling, the girl with a gal in her teeth and something when she looks at this picture tells her there is something similar about them both. Something not spoken with words but beyond.

"Who's that? The girl in the photo?" She asks, posting softly at the photograph. Razz's eyes go wide with recognition and gleam, smiling from esr to ear.

"Oh, that's Mara deary!"

"The one you always talk about?"

"Yes!" Razz nods, beaming with happiness. "She used to live in town but left when she was a teenager, about twenty years ago. She was your age when it happened." There is something else of that story Razz doesn't say, something private yes but also something that speaks of painful memories mixed with happy ones. She doesn't push the matter but can see the way Razz's shoulders deflate and then pick up again, smiling once more. "I believe she is a private detective now. She sends me letters all the time."

Her heart gives a jump, clarity suddenly illuminating her foggy, tired mind.

"A detective"

"Yes. But the good kind, the kind that makes the right thing," Razz states, sure and also proud.

Her heart is hammering inside her eardrums, Razz's words running free in her mind. She can still feel the ghost of cold lips over her own mouth and the ragged struggle of a chest trying to breathe and, suddenly, every single piece of the puzzle falls into place.

"Now, let me talk to you all about the wood ceilings, dearie"

"I just want to be with her"

November 1st, 1985

1.30 am. Bright-Moon's House

She *locks the window and slips back into the small bed, curling around her love's drowsy form.* She *can hear the muted echo of Angella and Glimmer talking downstairs and the unmistakable smell of Micah's hot chocolate traveling under the closed door.* She *presses her forehead against her love's, feeling the slow drum of her pulse point against her fingers. Her love is still very cold and*

her breathing is ragged and slow but she has calmed down, her hand coming up to curl against the neck of her *shirt.*

"How do you feel?" She *asks in a whisper, running the pads of her fingers down her cheeks. Her love groans low in her throat, burying the side of her face deeper in the pillows.*

"Like dead"

"Please don't say that"

They remain quiet for the whisper of a second, just their heartbeats drumming at the same rhythm, noses pressed together, lips ghosting over each other's cheeks.

"I mean it, though," her love says, tiny, sad. So sad, she *wants to pull from her own hair and scream and cry with her because it's not fair. "One day she is actually going to kill me and nobody on this fucking useless town is going to do anything about it"*

She *wants to deny it, tell her it's not going to be like that, that it will get better. But she can't, the blooming red and purple bruises like rotten blossoms around her love's neck are proof enough of that.* She *wants to promise her they'll be together on this, they'll get over the threats and the hate and the ignorance, but she can't.*

There is a certain kind of vulnerability that comes with knowing that, as much as you want, you aren't able to protect the person you love. It's something that tastes like rabid anger, bittersweet desperation and numbing love, pooling in the back of our tongues as copper and tugging from the strings of our heart until the constant rythm that keeps it beating strains itself and can't go on anymore.

It's a despair equal to the amount of love stored inside your ribcage and the bottom of your belly and the blood of your veins, boiling like lava and burning like ice mountains and rivers of desire and pain and devotion, where your heart is no longer a simple organ anymore, where it has torn its own way out of your body

and crawled in the ground, beaten and bleeded until it was found and cradle inside someone else's chest. It's holding a dagger, a sword, an arrow against your own chest and throat and sliding them clean open with your own hand, red and dark and light as a feather, dying on their arms again and again and again just for the stolen second where you can see their eyes over yours, cradling your skin against their nails and your dying soul against their mouth.

This is how she *loves* her *. This is how they love each other. It's an old love, old as life itself, older than the stones in the ground and trees that brush the sky, older than the sea and the stars and the moon itself, stardust fusing and parting and reaching towards each other time after time until they don't know where one ends and the other starts and it doesn't matter anymore because she is her and her is she, alive and breathing or beaten up and weak, or death and rotten. It's her mouth against her pulse point and her hands against her heat and her nose against closed eyelids, and her voice against there hair and her ears across her heart. It's two bodies turned into ashes and returned to the sky together. It's dying and waking up again every day. It's her. It's them.*

Knowledge and ignorance and wisdom and realization that if one dies, the other follows and… there

… an answer

"But what if she does?" She says, a thread if a voice among the shadows that shelter them.

"What?"

"What if she does kill you?"

"Have you heard anything I- uff," her love complains, voice muffled when she *crawls over her, pressing their foreheads together tightly.*

"Listen to me," she insists, tangling their fingers together, staring at her love's sea glass eyes until she is sure her attention is

completely focused in her. "What if she had done it? What if you had actually…?" she says, struggling to even speak the word, so she doesn't say it. Her love's eyebrows frown in thought, raising then to her forehead when she comprehends the meaning of her words.

"But-"

"You'd be free," she *says, the tiniest thread of desperation shining through her words. Still, it's enough for her love to hear because her incredulous stare melts into something much more softer.* She *brushes her thumb over the bruise in her love's cheekbone, scrunching her eyebrows is a silent plea. "You could get out of here, never look back. She wouldn't hurt you anymore. You'd be free."*

"What about you?" Her love asks then, squeaky vokce edging in the same desperation as she grips tightly her shirt between her fingers, as if the touch alone could keep them together forever.

"I'd leave. Grab my things and leave too"

"Prime is not going to let you go," her sea glass eyes mist with the rush of warm, angry tears, baring her teeth around the words. "He is obsessed with you. I'm, fuck, I'm scared he's going to do something to you"

"Then I'll go with you," she *says, and her love knows, with a terrified shiver, exactly what she means, "I would go anywhere with you"* she *whispers, brushing the tip of her nose with her love's, covered by the secrecy the night brings with it. Her love smiles, tiny and tired, her eyebrows knitting together in swift hesitation.*

"Really?" she asks in an equal whisper, scooting closer to her. "You have everything here and I have nothing to give you"

"I don't need any of it," she answers, tapping the surface of her love's locket with her fingers. "I want to do what we said. Know the world, go wherever we want. We'll call the shots"

Her love giggles, good-hearted, heart full. It's cold tonight but she doesn't mind it, neither of them do.

"I'm poor" her love whispers, a blush tinting her cheeks, but honest. She is nervous, she can feel it in the palm of her hand as it runs down the creases of her love's back.

"I'm poorer," she whispers back, smirking. Her love snorts, just as she predicted, poking her in the ribs and the forehead.

"Liar," her love complains, but she laughs anyway. She *catches her hand between hers, bringing it up so she can rest her love's palm over her cheek, sighing at the shared warmth of her skins.*

"I want to hold your hand without anyone talking behind our backs," she confesses, locking her eyes with her love's, bright and smart and just a bit scared. "I just want to be with you."

Her love bites on her bottom lip, hiding her face in the angle between her neck and shoulder, blankets want and rumpled around them. "Promise?"

She smiles at her, even though she can not see her, burying her face over the soft curls of her hair, placing a phantom kiss there. The soft tune of Belinda Carlisle's 'Heaven is a place on earth' echoes from the radio somewhere behind their backs, filling the small space with hopeful music.

"I promise"

Mara knows she should be furious but she can't bring herself to feel anger at all. There is just something cool and refreshing running in her veins, lighting her from the inside out, making her cry and laugh on her car seat in the middle of the empty road.

Her bag on the copilot's seat tethers and falls suddenly, the contents inside of it spilling over the seat. A heavy book falls from inside the bag, perfectly square and tall, the golden and purple colors of the highschool almost too bright under the autumn

sunlight that peeks from outside the car. Mara looks at the annuary laying still for a few seconds before stretching towards the seat, grabbing the heavy book between her hands. She runs her fingers over the cover gently and opens it, looking inside.

It's the average highschool annuary book, filled with photographs from classes, basketball matches, the night of the prom, heartfelt quotes and many other important moments from the school's years, followed by rows and rows of professionally looking school pictures from the classmates.

They are on the same page, both of them, separated by just a few rows. *She* is in the very first picture of the road, her long hazelnut hair braided carefully off her face, falling over her shoulder gently. There are small baby hairs around her temples, curling softly over the tip of her ears. Her face is clean from makeup beside the lightless hint of mascara over her eyelashes and sweet pink in her lips, making her sun kissed skin and the moles scattered over her cheeks to pop even more. She is smiling, honest and sweet, and when Mara looks closer she can see her gaze is slightly unfocused, as if she was watching something beyond the camera.

Her love is two rows below, right in the middle of the page. Her curls are thick, gently placed so it almost looks like an ethereal halo around her pretty face, freckles dusted by the slightest shadow of a blush. Someone has knitted tiny braids on the sides of her hair, sticking the tiniest of yellow flowers in there, almost like an afterthought, like a gentle caress done minutes, moments before the picture was taken. Her smile is also there but it's softer, more secretive, as if the soft curl of the corners of her mouth held all the mysteries to ever exist. Her eyes sparkle in sea glass, blatantly focused in somehow behind her sight.

Mara stares at the pictures until her eyes pinch from not blinking, taking a ragged breath. She wets her bottom lip and turns the page, taking a look on the other side. Something slides loose from inside the book, almost falling from the page it's carefully stocked

into. Mara catches it before it can saunter into the floor of the car, turning the thick, bright around so she can see the other side.

It 's a photograph.

One last photograph.

It doesn’t belong to the annuary, someone placed it there, as a wordless explanation or goodbye letter or, maybe even, a thank you.

In the photograph, there is a group standing in front of a lighted fireplace, everyone’s arms thrown around each other into a gentle, joyful embrace. It’s Christmas Night, if the decorations over the chimney and the huge tree on the side have anything to say about it, and the air around the image is kind and loving.

They are all there, all of them, every single one. Some of them are smiling at the camera or caught in the middle of a laugh. All of them, except the two people in the middle. Unlike the others, they are staring at each other, kind smiles stretched around their faces, flushed with a lovely blush. They are young, they are happy, they are in love.

They are together.

“We are family”

Christmas Eve, 1983

The Grey House

The sweet ring of the door echoes inside the house, almost as cheerfully as the music coming from the recorder in the living room. The house is bursting with life, golden lights illuminating both the outside and the inside of the house, the smells of hot wine, pine and homemade cookies filling every single room. There is laughter coming from the living room and the kitchen, plates

and glasses clinking with each other as the kids accommodate the table for dinner.

Marlena twirls towards the door when the doorbell rings again, the golden locket around her neck twinkling under the chandelier's light, jumping on her feet as she gets close and swings it open. She smiles broadly at the two young girls she sees standing on the porch. They are covered from head to toe in snow, their noses and ears red even under the thick knitted hats and big scarfs, matching each other almost unconsciously. They have always been like this , gravitating around each other as suns.

"Girls! Did you get it?" Marlena asks, moving aside to let them in. Both of them slip inside the warmth corridor quickly, shivering as they take off their huge coats and hang them behind the door. "Why didn't you just walk in? You are trembling!"

"Sorry mom, we forgot our keys!" Her daughter explains, breathless from the run under the snow or from long minutes of honest laughter across their trip to the store.

Marlena's other girl shakes her head, snowflakes coming off her pretty curls as starlight. She reaches inside the pockets of her leather jacket over the hanger and pulls out a big can, handing it to Marlena with a huge smile on her face.

"Last can of cranberries in the entire store", she announces proudly, beaming with happiness. Marlena adores this girl, ever since she met her for the first time when she was barely a little duckling in the winter woods all the way to now. Marlena loves her because this girl is good and kind above anything. She loves her for the way her daughter looks at her when they are home, when they are safe, with her whole chest open and free and sincere, honest love clear for everyone to see. And she loves her for the way she looks at her daughter right back, like the moon calling for the stars.

"Excellent!" Marlena cheers, taking the can with an excited jump. "Dessert is saved!

"She managed it to get it all on her own, snatched it right below Mrs. Darling's nose," Marlena's daughter explains, her blue and silver eyes shimmering with mirth at the recent memory.

"Really? What did she say?"

"She wished me a very happy Christmas, of course," the girl says, nodding with a smirk. Marlena knows that is definitely not what it happen, she is used to her sense of sarcasm, but by the happy curl of her mouth she understands that, at least for tonight, it is not that bad.

"Very well! You two get warm again and come into the living room. Dinner is almost ready," Marlena instructs them, lovingly pinching their cheeks before rushing back inside the kitchen. Randor is already there too, carefully following each and every single one of Razz's instructions to bake the perfect butter cookies.

Back on the corridor, both girls pull out their winter boots and slightly damp jackets, staying only in their wool socks and soft knitted sweaters. Before they can even walk towards the living room, she *wraps her arms around her love's waist and pulls her back, pressing their chest together swiftly.*

"What-?"

"Mistletoe," she *explains, pointing above their heads. There, hanging from one of the beams of the ceiling, is a small green branch, white fruits sprouting from it like pearls with a red ribbon tied sweetly around the end.*

Her love's eyebrows rise over her forehead, rolling her eyes before a cheeky, all knowing smirk spreads into her mouth, looking back at her with a knowing look.

"Did you hang that all by yourself just so you would trap me here?" her love asks, flashing her teeth with a smile.

"Yep," she *confesses, not a single drop of regret or shame in her voice.*

Instead, she *runs her hands over the creases and dips of her love's back above her white sweater, fingers brushing over the soft skin of the back of her neck until she is cradling her love's jaw between her palms.* She *pulls from her face gently, slow enough that her love has space and time enough to pull away if she wants. She doesn't. Her love lets her guide her towards her pink mouth into a sweet kiss, gentle and slow enough that makes her love's spine melt and her fingers to tingle, wrapping her own hands around hazelnut cold hair, brushing it away from* her *pink flushed face as they press against each other tightly, so tightly one starts and the other ends at the same point.*

"We are in your parent's house," her love mutters against her red kissed mouth, lips meeting and parting again and again until the cold is completely melted from their bodies by the warmth of their embrace.

"And? They adore you," she *whispers back, shrugging into her love's arms, "wouldn't be the first time they catch us kissing"*

"Ugh, please don't remind me of that," her love groans, wrinkling her nose. She *uses the momentary distraction to dip her nose into her love's neck, kissing on the column of warm, freckled skin she finds there. "I don't want another 'talk' like that time."*

"Mmm," she *hums, already forgetting what they were talking about to raise her head and kiss her love again, running her thumbs over her pulse point so she can feel the fluttering jump of her heart between her fingers.*

They are so woven into the strings of each other that they don't hear him walking down the stars next to them and round towards the kitchen, squealing loudly when he catches them kissing.

"Oh! Ew! Do you mind?!" Adam all but yells, making a show of covering his eyes and grimacing. "There are younglings present!"

Both of them snort against each other's lips, parting just so they can cover their mouths and muffle a laugh. Her love turns her head towards Adam, smirking at him all sharp canines and mirth.

"Who? You?"

"Haha, very funny, kitty"

"Don't worry Adam. One of these days a Christmas Miracle may actually give you a partner too," her love bites back, biting back a squeaky when she *ignores them both and leans to kiss on the angle of her jaw tenderly.*

Adam makes a fake gagging motion and flips her off. "You know I fucking hate you, right?"

"Likewise"

"Don't fight," she *whines, half inside the joke, half serious, "it's Christmas."*

"That 's right. So stop smooching in the corridor already and come to the living room, everyone is waiting for you," Adam says, pointing at both of them lighthearted but sharply.

She *pulls her tongue out to her brother but follows him inside the warmth room, resting her hand over her love's back to guide her with them.*

The living room is cozy and full of laughter and music. Mermista, Sea Hawk, Lonnie and Perfuma are chatting happily in the corner nearest to the window, biting into roasted nuts and sugary cookies, laughing about something as Mermista holds Hawk as far away from the fire as she can.

Kyle and Rogelio are helping Adam and Oscar to place plates around the huge table in the middle of the dining room, discussing an incoming baseball game and the last band concert they like and are planning to drive to Salineas to watch together.

Razz, Marlena and Randor walk out of the kitchen carrying several pots filled with turkey, mashed potatoes, coquito, ajiaco, rice with gandules, congrí, pozole, tamales, cakes, buñuelos and even a huge bowl filled to the brim with churros coated in cinnamon and sugar.

Glimmer and Bow are cozy next to the chimney, their faces brightening when they see them coming inside. Glimmer waves her arm at them, resting her hands over her hips with a devious grin.

"What took you guys so long? I'm starving!" Glimmer scowls them. She is wearing the ugliest sweater ever seen by human kind, bright pink with lilac sleeves and a huge golden Christmas tree in the middle.

"We were doing stuff, Sparkles-"

"We were kissing," she *says at the same time, beaming with pride. Her love snaps her eyes back to her, clearly alarmed and fuming as she lonches her in the side painfully. "Ouch!"*

"Ah, so the mistletoe worked, uh?" Bow adds, smiling from ear to ear.

Her love's eyes go wide, staring at the three of them with something much like betrayal shinning on her face. "You-"

"Aw, we all know you have a soft spot, there is no need to hide it," Glimmer teases her, knowing damn well what she is doing.

"Yes? I'm not the one that made her way into my *D&D party with the rest of her friends because she wanted to be a pretty druid," she fight back, sea glass eyes full of mirth. Glimmer gapes, huffing.*

"Oh, yeah? Say that to yourself, rogue magicat all stealth no charisma"

"Listen, you-"

"Alright, alright, that's enough," Bow stops them with a chuckle, wrapping his hands nervously around Glimmer's shoulders and bringing her back a little.

"Imagine what would everyone say if the school knew you are actually friends with the cheerleaders," Glimmer keeps saying.

"I'm not the one that was jealous for years"

"Ha! Are you joking? You were sulking for months! You know what? I think I might actually tell everyone you called me friend the other day at the last game"

"Don't you fucking dare, everyone knows we hate each other and we are keeping it like that. All of you with your pompous skirts and shorts stay away from me at school, I have a reputation. I don't want to be seen with cheerleaders"

"Hey, I'm a cheerleader too," she *says with a pout*

"Obviously not you, dumbass," her love tolls her eyes at the same time Glimmer points out.

"My aunt knitted you that sweater"

"And she definitely knows to difference from good to bad style. What are you even wearing?"

"It's ugly sweater season!"

"It looks like an unicorn puked on your chest"

"Okay!" She *intervenes too, wrapping her arms around her love's waist and dragging her slightly away. "Let's keep the rivalry for the table game"*

"Ridícula"

"개새끼"

"Time to eat!" Razz announces cheerfully from the table, saving the day. Bow drags Glimmer across the carpet, still mumbling something under her breath.

Before anyone can take a seat, she *jumps on her feet, excitedly looking around her until she finds what she is looking for. A new, just opened gift from Adam resting over the couch. The Christmas paper is still stuck to the new camera as* she *makes her way towards it, taking it swiftly between her hands.*

"Wait, wait! Let's take a photograph first!" She calls for them, waving happily.

"You are not letting go of that thing from now on, are you?" her love asks with a lighthearted huff, crossing her arms over her chest.

"Nope," she answers her happily, winking at her.

New chattering starts to rise again as the entire house starts to scramble in front of the fireplace, some errand elbows in bellies and stepped in feet as they accommodate around each other. Marlena walks besides her love and smiles at her, leaning to press a motherly kiss on her forehead. Random follows his wife, pinching the girl's cheek cheerfully. Razz follows, because there won't be a day Razz lets go of the opportunity to hug her, making a point of brushing her freckles and calling her pretty. It makes her love smile, it makes her heart soar.

She *opens the camera and starts preparing it, impatience and joy running across her entire face as she trinkets with the little buttons until it comes as she wants.*

"Alright, here we go!" She announces, rushing to the middle, immediately wrapping her arms around her love's waist.

She can smell her mom's perfume behind her and her father's strong cologne when he hugs Marlena. Adam is next to her, *elbowing her swiftly and with mirth in the ribs before throwing his arm around Bow's and Glimmer's shoulders. Glimmer throws them*

a smile from her place, devious yes, but also honest and kind. As much as they fought in the past, and as much as they annoy each other now, they are friends, they love each other, even if nobody else outside these walls knows it.

The little countdown of the camera is ticking, but in those small seconds, those stolen fragments of time, life is perfect.

She *looks down, towards the girl she loves, resting her hands over her waist. Under the golden light of the fire and the chandelier above their heads, her love looks ethereal, golden like an angel with the light crowning her soft curls and cradling her cheeks, making her freckles look like painted starlight over gold. Her love looks back at her and, for the split of a second, he can see herself on the reflection of her sea glass amber and turquoise eyes.* She *can see her own eyes, blue and silver, and the curve of her own mouth as she smiles. Inside her eyes, she can see all the love beating in her chest reflected equally, cradled and cared for and returned. Fully.*

"I love you," her love says, whispered and honest and kind.

The flash goes off.

San Francisco

December 23th, 1985

Sunset

Mara parks the car on the concrete road, right in front of the opened bakery. It smells beautifully even though they are still inside, like oranges and caramel and warmth, the smell rolling across the entire neighborhood.

It's a peaceful street. Huge purple, blue and deep green trees are lined on the sidewalks and the middle of the road, separating the stores and restaurants from the houses on the opposite side. There are golden Christmas lights wrapped around the trees,

making the sidewalk shimmer alongside the gentle light of the sunset. Live music fills the air from where it rolls off the traditional pizza restaurant just a few stores below. From her stop inside the car, Mara can see people dancing joyfully over the street, all kinds of couples wrapped into a peaceful embrace.

Children are running in and around, carrying pretty bags with gifts and candies, laughing joyfully among each other. Mara sees two women walking out of the store behind the kids, holding hands and smiling at their children A school is nearby and a park beyond that, where most of them run off to play in the swings before going back home for dinner. Beyond the lines of trees, the red of the bridge can be seen among leaves and branches, framing the golden sphere of the sun as it makes its way below the blue, blue sea.

"Gonna get us some bread for the trip, I won't be long," Mara's companion says with a sweet smile, opening the door of the car and skipping inside the bakery with a sprint in her step. Her cream colored dress matches the light blue of her hijab, a cloud of gentleness walking over the sidewalk and inside the warm establishment.

Mara looks at her go with a smile on her face, heart fluttering in her chest. She then walks outside her car too, leaning against the closed door and taking in the beautiful neighbor she is in. The houses in front of her are gorgeous, tall and old, with tinted glasses and low metal front yard's doors, and yet, all of them are different from each other, vivid colors oh so different to the dead whites from other towns. Neighbors talk with neighbors here, leaning over the bushes of their porches to share a cup of warm drink or food, smiling always.

Life is good here, joyful and patient. It's a good place to live in, a good place to be safe.

A prussian blue Mustang drives around the corner of the street and stops in front of the house at the opposite side of Mara's car, the engine coming to a stop with a low rumble. The pilot's door

opens and just a few seconds later a young woman steps out, balancing the tiniest pine tree ever seen with an almost comically huge pot on it. She is laughing, smiling bright and crystal clear against the light of the evening.

Her hair is shorter. Barely brushing her shoulders, free of her usual tight ponytail, falling in gentle waves of dyed honey blonde, a nice change of her natural hazelnut bronze. She is wearing sneakers and a white t-shirt tucked inside a rose, long skirt. There is a scar in the side of her biceps, still pink and raised, but she doesn't hide it. It's a proof, a mark she carries proud, that she survived it. And she looks different, softer, happier. But her eyes are the same, crystal blue and almond shaped.

The young woman walks around the front of the car, towards the copilot's door, opening it with her free hand and a chivalrous smirk. Though, there is no lie in the expression in her face, soft and open. The gaze of someone that is completely, utterly in love.

"Seriously 'Dora, did you have to pick the biggest plant in the market?" a second voice echoes softly in the empty street as the owner of the enamored look in the young woman's face hops out of her seat. "We already have one tree in the house"

Mara never got to see her like this, but watching her now, watching her now around *her,* it makes sense. It makes sense why they would risk it all to be with each other. Together.

"Oh, please, Cat, you love it as much as I do. We can't never have enough Christmas trees. And it's going to look amazing in the living room," she says, blonde hair swinging softly in the breeze.

Her love rolls her eyes, closing the door with a muted hit. She is a little bit shorter, just a few inches, hair cut very, very short, curling behind her ears in gentle waves below the white handkerchief tied around her head. She is wearing high waisted denim pants and, most sticking of it all, a knitted baby-pink sweater, extremely soft

and new looking, a tender contrast to the dark of her freckled skin.

Their necklaces match, golden hearts hanging gently from delicate chains.

"Yeah, I'm sure it will look awesome next to the two chairs and the coffee table made of a carton box we have"

"We'll buy new ones" she reassures her, wrapping her arm around her neck and shoulders, pulling her closer.

"Hmm. Yeah, I guess we will." The young woman wraps her hands around the other's waist, closes her eyes and leans forward, pressing their lips together in a tender kiss, there, in the middle of the street, where nobody will judge them or hurt them for loving each other. Not anymore.

They are free.

"Come on then, I'm hungry and it's your turn to cook. George and Lance can't feed us forever."

"I'll do my best," she says, chuckling as she opens the metal door that leads to their porch.

Suddenly, the purple door of the neighbor's house opens and two heads peek from the inside. The first is a tall, *tall* woman with short white hair and black lipstick. She looks like the definition of a rockstar, muscular and beautiful with the kindest face possible, a smile stretched in her lips at the sight of the couple. The second person is shorter, brown skin scattered with patches of vitiligo, hair dyed soft purple and held on slave buns over her head. She is wearing a jumper stained in oil and holding several mechanical tools in her arms. She is smiling too.

"Lizzi! Alex! Hi!" The first woman greets them loudly, waving excitedly with her arm.

"Hi Scorpia! Hi Entrapta!" Answers back happily the girl with the blonde hair at the same time her love mutters.

"Ugh, don't call me Lizzie"

"Getting things set for Christmas?" Scorpia asks, eyeing curiously the pine tree held in the blond's hands.

"Yeah, we just got this little guy ready to be pampered. Right, baby?"

"Yeah, yeah, whatever. I'm just letting you enjoy yourself." Her love says with a shrug, crossing her arms over her chest. The blonde wiggles her dark eyebrows at her, smirking.

"Didn't you choose this one especially for its perfectly triangle form and pretty little branches?" She fights back, making small quotation marks in the air with her free hand. Her love snap her head towards her, baring her teeth.

"I'm going to divorce you"

"Sure, sure." She dismisses it softly, pressing a kiss on her forehead where the short curls wrap gently over her skin. Then she looks back at their neighbors, grinning brightly. "Hey, would you guys like to come have dinner with us on Christmas? We are already one door away"

Scorpia's face brightens immediately, nodding in excitement. "We would love to! My Christmas turkey is too much for both anyway!"

"Oh, I can help you fix your Christmas lights!" Adds Entrapta, suddenly completely interested in the conversation, her eyes flaring in almost maniac joy below her round glasses. "I've found a method to make them ten times brighter with almost no room for shortcuts and fires!"

"Um, maybe not. I would really like to keep my house intact, Entrapta," the short haired girl says, rolling her eyes without a

bite, fondness clear even below her words. Entrapta shrugs, not at all, and squirms back into the house, loud sounds of pipes clicking together and steam coming off the open door.

"Oh, boy. I think I better go look and keep an eye on her," Scorpia says, running her hand over her neck. "But I'll see you tomorrow then!"

"Yeah! You are going to love Lizz's pie," she adds, squeezing her loves shoulders gently, "My grandmother taught her everything she knows"

"Of course she did. You couldn't stop burning things" her love huffs with mirth, waving the other two goodbye too. "See you tomorrow then, dofuses"

"By, Lizzie!"

"Ugh, bye"

Scorpia closes the door behind her, leaving the couple alone on their porch. The blonde girl leans to leave the little pine on the ground, standing up so she can wrap both of her arms around her waist, pulling her from the low of her back into another breathless kiss, all pink lips and tongue against teeth. Her love parts from her, panting and blushing furiously, pulling from the honey strands of hair playfully.

"Alexandra," her love whispers around a squeaky laugh. She smiles too, running her lips over her forehead tenderly.

"Elizabeth"

"Pff, dummy," her love rolls her eyes, parting from her to open the door of their house and walk straight in, calling sweetly from the inside. "Melog! We are home, kitty!" A soft meow is interrupted to a bit of a turmoil, followed by the characteristicly excited barks of a puppy. Even from the inside of the house, the fond exasperation of her love's voice is evident. "We are home too, Swift Wind"

This is the last time Mara is ever going to see them. But she knows they'll be fine, in this little yellow house tucked below green vines. They'll be happy here and love here and, eventually, they'll grow old together here too. Mara can see it inside her mind, these two young girls´s entire lives together. The newly opened flower shop at the corner of the block. The job as primary teacher in the school near the park. Dancing around the living room under fairy lights and the golden shadows of the sunset. Photographs hung on the window frames. White dresses bought from the thrift store and the made up wedding on the roof of the house, barefoot and laughing.

And many years into the future, another trip like this, hopping off the car, holding a little stuffed unicorn, her love carrying a baby in over her chest and neck, their baby hair honey, their life soft. Adoption papers and love and a better world. Friends, lovers, wives, mothers.

"Got it!" A voice calls behind Mara, happy. She turn in time so see Hope's face, bright with joy and pink with happiness, carrying the bag of freshly baked bread in her hands.

Mara doesn't say anything, she just smiles, and something in that must tell Hope something because her grin softens as she leans towards Mara, kissing her sweetly in the mouth before slipping back inside the car. Mara looks back to the yellow house, sighing deeply.

The blonde girl leans down to pick up her little tree, hair golden under the sunlight, as golden as the heart in her chest, and starts walking towards the porch, face sweet. Suddenly, she stops in her tracks up the door and turns her face back, towards Mara, locking her gaze with hers. She is not surprised to see her there. There is a small, soft smile on her face.

"Hey, *sol* ! You are not getting out of cooking! Come help, dummy!"

"Coming, *mi amor* !"

Before the young woman hops over the steps of the house and into the rest of her life, she looks back one more time.

Mara gives her a recognizing nod.

Adora nods back.

I can’t tell you the day that I fell in love with you because there wasn’t a single day that I didn’t. You have the purest parts of my heart, and I’m certain that in every alternate universe, I’m always, always in love with you

– *Addicted After All* , **Krista&Becca Ritchie**

Chapter End Notes

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See? I told you to be patient ♡ As Jack Black interpreting R.L. Stine once said "every story ever told can be broken down into three parts. The beginning, the middle, and the TWIST"

Thank you so, SO much to everyone that went into this journey with me, to all of those that saw the meaning of this story and understood it and accepted it even before you knew the truth. Thank you for your theories (and congratulations to those that almost, ALMOST got it) and for your support. I managed what I wanted and I couldn't have done it without all of you.

And to those that were mean with me for "tagging wrong" if you are reading this, I hope you feel ashamed of yourself :D

Last but not least, huge thank you to Madi, who helped me bring logistics with the core plot of the story, without them, this story wouldn't have existed at all.

I hope I'll see you all in future projects. Until then, happy winter. And be good ♡

"Dedicated to all the souls we couldn't save and who deserved a kind ending"

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